

# **NATIONALLY CONSISTENT COLLECTION OF DATA ON SCHOOL STUDENTS WITH DISABILITY (NCCD): AN INSTITUTIONAL ETHNOGRAPHY OF STUDENT FUNDING**

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students with disability; institutional ethnography; Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability (NCCD); education policy; education funding; teacher work; student data; new public management

# Abstract

This institutional ethnography (IE) explores how the everyday work and lives of school staff and policymakers are reshaped by the introduction of the Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability (NCCD). The NCCD is an inaugural Australian Government funding policy for school students with disability that requires all teachers in Australian schools to collect evidence of the educational adjustments they provide for students with disability. This evidence is used to determine a level of educational support for federal government purposes.

An IE inquiry traces how things happen across multiple institutional sites. This inquiry investigated and mapped how the NCCD flowed between schools, regional officers, the head office of the Education Authority, and ultimately the federal government. The research was conducted in the Australian state of Queensland and included ethnographic data collection in the form of interviews and conversations, collection of school-based texts and documents, observations, and field notes. Data was collected from four teachers, twelve school-based leaders or specialists, ten support officers from regional and head office, and three leaders from the head office of the Education Authority. The textual authority of key documents that contributed to and maintained processes across and within locations are identified. This breadth of data collection allowed for empirically based mapping of the work that occurred across various institutional levels.

By making the frontline work of teachers, school leaders and policymakers visible, it became clear that there was a significant disjuncture between official NCCD accounts of policy flows and teachers' work. At the school level, considerable time was spent collecting evidence and documenting educational

adjustments. The research demonstrate that this work is high stakes for schools, because it is tied to funding for students with disability. At all levels across the institution, there was significant angst about “getting the data right”, that was connected to audit processes and funding outcomes. These concerns created an intense focus on the data collection for NCCD, which orchestrated work and relationships across the institution.

In effect, an inordinate amount of time and energy was consumed by documentation requirement of the NCCD. Daily work was prioritised and oriented towards document. While the findings show the NCCD has met its goals of producing data for funding purposes, and national reporting commitments to the OECD, it raises significant questions about how the NCCD shapes the nature of schooling that students with disability experience. This thesis offers a critical insight into how the focus on evidence is reshaping education practice in schools, and in regional and head offices that support them. Participant accounts presented across the chapters serves as a timely reminder that policies such as the NCCD have powerful effects on what happens in schools, orienting work, relationships and practices. Given this research was borne out of a deep concern for the education of students with disability, and the educators who dedicate their lives to this work, this thesis offers empirical evidence to support attention of how the NCCD has unleashed significant work in schools; and whether this provides genuine improvements to the education of students with disability.

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# List of Abbreviations

|              |                                                                              |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| AC           | Australian Curriculum                                                        |
| ACARA        | Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority                                |
| ADS          | Australian Disability Strategy 2021 – 2031                                   |
| AEA          | Australian Education Act 2017                                                |
| AG           | Australian Government                                                        |
| APSTs        | Australian Professional Standards for Teachers                               |
| CoD          | Category of Disability                                                       |
| DDA          | Disability Discrimination Act, 1992                                          |
| DSE          | Disability Standards for Education, 2005                                     |
| EA           | Education Authority                                                          |
| EAP          | Education Adjustment Program                                                 |
| ES           | Education sector                                                             |
| ESA          | Education Services Australia                                                 |
| HPS          | Hillside Primary School                                                      |
| ICSEA        | Index of Community Socio-educational Advantage                               |
| IE           | Institutional ethnography                                                    |
| IEer         | Institutional ethnographer                                                   |
| IEP          | Individualised Education Plan                                                |
| LoA          | Level of Adjustment                                                          |
| LoA document | Level of Adjustment Provided to the Student (NCCD text)                      |
| JWG          | Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability |
| MSSD         | More Support for Students with Disabilities                                  |

|          |                                                                                                       |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NAP      | National Assessment Program                                                                           |
| NAPLAN   | National Assessment Program – Literacy and Numeracy,                                                  |
| NCCD     | Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with<br>Disability                        |
| NCCD SLT | Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with<br>Disability school leadership team |
| NCEC     | National Catholic Education Commission                                                                |
| NDIS     | National Disability Insurance Scheme                                                                  |
| NDS      | National Disability Strategy 2010 – 2020                                                              |
| NRSA     | National School Reform Agreement                                                                      |
| NRSB     | National School Resourcing Board                                                                      |
| NSIT     | National School Improvement Tool                                                                      |
| OECD     | Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development                                                 |
| PAT-M    | Progressive Achievement Test in Mathematics                                                           |
| PAT-R    | Progressive Achievement Test in Reading                                                               |
| PPS      | Parkside Primary School                                                                               |
| PwC      | PricewaterhouseCoopers                                                                                |
| QCAA     | Queensland Curriculum and Assessment Authority                                                        |
| QDTP     | Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice                                                              |
| QUT      | Queensland University of Technology                                                                   |
| SST      | Student Support Team                                                                                  |
| SWD      | Student/s with disability                                                                             |
| UN CRPD  | United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities<br>2006                          |

# Definitions

**Education sectors** have the responsibility of providing education to school-age students. In Australia, there are two education sectors – government and non-government. The government sector provides free public education and is the responsibility of the respective state or territory Department of Education. The non-government education sector has two components, Catholic Education, and Independent Schools (private schools).

**Education Authority** For the purpose of this thesis an Education Authority is defined as a system of schools in Australia. For example, Catholic schools and some Independent schools have their own respective education authorities.

**Regional office** is an administrative branch of the Education Authority. Regional office personnel provide professional services to schools, such as professional development, professional mentoring school-based staff, advice on education policy and procedures, and so on.

**Ruling relations** are objectified forms of consciousness and organisation, that are established externally to people and places, creating and reliant on textual realities which are actions that are observable across multiple sites, meaning they occur translocally (DeVault, 2012; DeVault & McCoy, 2002; Smith, 2005).

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I commenced my journey, like many, with, “I have an idea but not sure what to do with it”. Jill introduced me to institutional ethnography (IE), and I was captured by it, the approach resonated. But even more importantly, as I met more people who were equally interested in IE, I felt I found my tribe, my ‘peeps’. So, to my peeps, thank you for sharing your knowledge, your insights, and your time with me. The lessons learnt have been invaluable. Nerida, you have graciously taken me by the hand and walked with me through this IE journey with such wisdom, patience, knowledge, and care. THANK YOU.

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# Chapter 1: Introduction

---

## 1.1 BACKGROUND

In Australia, like many western countries, it is expected that students with disability will attend their local primary or secondary school *on the same basis* with similarly aged peers (Commonwealth of Australia, 2005, p. 9). This means a student with disability is intended to have the same opportunities and choices as students without disability and that barriers to access and participation are minimised (Commonwealth of Australia, 2005; United Nations, 2006). There are clear legislative contexts and specific guidance for schooling for Australian students with disability in the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (DDA) and the Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE), flanked by the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities 2006 (UN CRPD). These international and federal legislative obligations form the basis on which educational policies are developed, including the inaugural federal policy, the Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability (NCCD).

The research presented in this thesis demonstrates how this legislative and policy context shapes the everyday world of schooling for the teachers and staff who serve students with disability. This research project took the qualitative sociological approach of institutional ethnography (IE) to understand how the daily actions of teachers, school leaders and education policymakers were organised by the requirements of the NCCD. Specifically, the project has made visible the connected “actualities” (Smith, 2003, p. 61) of those at the frontline of the NCCD implementation through the various decision-making junctures of the NCCD within the non-government education sector. The purpose of an IE inquiry is to explore how



power operates through a detailed examination of “institutional work processes by following a chain of action, typically organised around and through a set of documents” (DeVault & McCoy, 2006, p. 21). This inquiry approach incorporates peoples’ stories of their experiences from which the researcher begins to “identify some of the translocal relations, discourses or institutional work processes that are shaping the informants’ everyday work” (DeVault & McCoy, 2006, p. 21). An IE inquiry is about understanding how things happen and in so doing, makes work that would often be hidden visible. By making the actual everyday practices of those at the frontline of institutional processes visible, their work can truly be appreciated.

Chapter One is an introduction to the context of the research inquiry, how the project came to be activated and the inquiry context. This is followed by an outline of the aims of the project and the questions that were explored. An explanation of some key terminology is also offered. The chapter concludes with an outline of the thesis.

### **1.1.1 A conversation about on the same basis activated a research inquiry**

As I sat with, Nick, a principal of a primary school in Queensland Australia, in my capacity as a senior policy officer to discuss the pending enrolment of Ben, a youngster who was about to start school, we came to discuss the phrase, on the same basis, and what it really means. Nick was preparing for a meeting with Samantha, Ben’s mother. Samantha was trying to enrol her son into his first year of school and had approached a few schools near their home. When Samantha called Nick’s school to make an enrolment appointment, she told the school secretary that Ben had a disability and had been told by other schools that he would receive the same level of resources as the other children in his class, the phrase used was, on the same basis. Samantha took this to mean that the other schools would provide Ben with exactly

the same resources as his peers, nothing additional. Samantha told the school secretary she had felt discouraged by these schools, which is not surprising as she had experienced “gatekeeping” (Poed et al., 2020, p. 766), a subtle form of discrimination used to discourage the enrolment of students with disability. Samantha wanted Ben to get the educational support he needed, but as he had not started school yet, she was unsure of what this additional support looked like.

Both Nick and I were challenged by what we had heard; first, the fact that Samantha felt compelled to tell the school secretary that she had been discouraged from enrolling her son at schools closer to their home before he had even commenced any form of schooling; and second, that this had occurred at all. Samantha’s negative experiences challenged our own beliefs about what the phrase on the same basis, from the Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE), means and how it gets used. Nick and I both agreed that our understanding of the phrase, on the same basis, was that each and every student is entitled to be resourced so that they have full access to and can participate in all classroom learning activities and any extra-curricular activities (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2012; Australian Ministerial Council for Education Employment Training and Youth Affairs, 2008; Commonwealth of Australia, 2005). We also agreed that if barriers to learning and participation were to be minimised Ben and/or his teachers required additional resourcing.

As our discussion continued, we noticed how official language, the “institution talk” (Smith & Griffith, 2022, p. 73), can be used to include or exclude students with disability from attending their local school, and had been used in this circumstance. The subtle and not so subtle, talk of on the same basis was used by the other schools to exclude Ben. Samantha described her experience as both frustrating

and disheartening; she walked away from these encounters with the belief that her son, was not entitled to receive additional support for his learning. Nick proceeded to enrol Ben and identify what additional resources would be needed to minimise any potential barriers to Ben's learning. Nick's goal was to ensure Ben could access and participate in all aspects of schooling, from his first day at school.

As Nick and I discussed how the school could make provision for Ben's needs, our conversation turned to educational policies for students with disability. As the principal of a school in Queensland, Australia, Nick was very familiar with the well-established Queensland educational policy process for identifying students with disability, the Education Adjustment Program (EAP), which provided additional funding in all Queensland schools for eligible students with disability (Queensland Department of Education, 2019b). Over many years, Queensland schools have used this additional funding to employ teacher assistants, learning support teachers and other specialist staff, as well as purchase resources such as customised desks and chairs, as well as digital or assistive technologies (Carrington et al., 2012; Cologon, 2019). Identifying what additional resources were required to minimise barriers to learning for students with disability was not new work for the principal. However, concurrent to the state-based funding mechanisms for students with disability was also a newly introduced national policy, the NCCD.

As Nick worked with Ben's mother to identify his educational needs, Nick also had to work with his school team to navigate these two policy processes, the established EAP system and the newly introduced NCCD. As a senior policy officer, I became intrigued as to how these policy systems would interact, how school staff would traverse them both and what this might look like in actuality for teachers in the classroom. The NCCD was a new way of approaching education for students

with disability, which sparked a brief national conversation about educational provision (see Chapter Four for a detailed discussion). While these important policy and practical discussions were shaping thinking and understanding, Nick was trying to work through what this all meant for teachers in his school and for the students with whom they work. Nick was one of many principals grappling with the day-to-day implications of unclear new policies. This research project makes a contribution to new knowledge about how the everyday work happened to implement an inaugural national funding policy, this inquiry was timely and is important.

### **1.1.2 Research standpoint: Embodied experiences are a way of knowing**

In seeking to understand the social organisation of knowledge, consideration must be given to how the everyday lives of people are coordinated by institutional texts. For example, the texts associated with the NCCD model, have the power to organise actions in the same way across multiple locations (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Deveau, 2009). As I reflect on my own awareness of this phenomenon and how I became interested in people's perceptions about the educational needs of students with disability, I am taken back to a moment when I was a part-time undergraduate psychology student, many years ago. I commenced this study program after having completed my degree in education and was working full-time, as a special education teacher. My journey into special education was probably motivated by my experience of living with a family member with disability. It was not typical, in that era, for a child with a developmental disability to be living with their family (Ashman & Elkins, 1990). So, my provocation into this area of education was almost certainly because I had played with, eaten with, and shared my life with people with disability my entire life. It was very natural to me to share my everyday with people with disability. But more importantly, by adulthood I was insatiably curious about

learning in general (which is a motivation for ongoing personal learning) and specifically, learning differences. So, here I was, bright-eyed, and full of enthusiasm for the course about developmental disorders (the course name should have been an alert for me), only to find that my family, and I, had been othered (Slee, 2011) by a textbook, which was reinforced by the lecturer! I was told that we (my brothers and I) were less likely to be, well, almost anything, because we (yes, all seven of us, parents included) were different, disordered, and dysfunctional because one of us had a disability. I did not know this. I was shocked to hear this. I rejected this assumption; this was not my embodied experience. However, I had no way of knowing what my fellow students believed. It was in this instant I became acutely conscious of the power of texts and institutions, and official accounts (D. E. Smith, 1990a). The experience created dissonance.

That moment stayed with me, and profoundly influenced my personal standpoint and career, as a teacher, a school administrator, a senior policy officer, and has informed my work as a novice researcher. In all my roles (professional and personal) I have tried to grapple with the complexity of how official discourses, policies, and societal events shape how disability is conceptualised broadly, but more specifically, how students with disability are resourced so that each student has full access to their learning entitlement. As a researcher and an educator, the acquisition of a comprehensive understanding of how the power of texts and institutional practices has never been more important. So, I am back to that moment in the lecture theatre, the dilemma I experienced that day was that the official account from the lecturer and my embodied experiences were vastly at odds, there was a disjuncture or as Luken and Vaughan (2003) describe “lines of fault” (p. 110). Throughout my everyday work life, I have experienced disjunctures between institutional and

embodied ways of knowing multiple times, where my experiences of the everyday were at odds with the official accounts.

Institutional ethnography provides a suite of inquiry tools to explore the tensions and dilemmas created when such a disjuncture occurs, to understand “how the world comes about for us and how it is organised so that it happens to us as it does in our experience” (D. E. Smith, 1990a, p. 27). In my conversation with Nick, as we planned to meet with Samantha to finalise Ben’s enrolment, we experienced a disjuncture between the policy (a text) and the lived experience. The principals of the previous schools had made decisions about Ben, not based on any real experience of educating Ben, but quite possibly they too had heard the same official accounts of disability that I had heard all those years ago. To exclude Ben, the principals used institutional objectifying language of on the same basis from legislation designed to protect Ben and other children with disability.

The NCCD is a national mechanism for data collection about students with disability (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017). As a senior policy officer for an Education Authority, I talked with principals and learning support teachers about the data collection requirements of NCCD and heard many more experiences of disjuncture. What has also become apparent was the power of these new policy texts in mediating and coordinating both my work and the work of my colleagues across a multitude of locations. Even though there seemed to be similarities in how work was coordinated, the texts of NCCD are complex and people understand them in different ways; this meant how this policy was understood and the dilemmas that were experienced could differ with each context.

Throughout the doctoral journey, I drew on these multiple standpoints, that of educator, policy professional, sister, daughter; to explore the inter-workings of the those involved in bringing the NCCD to life. Institutional ethnography adopts an ontological stance in which the world is understood as “being produced and brought into being through the social practices of people” (Frampton et al., 2006, p. 34) and acknowledges how knowledge is “mutually produced through interactions between the researchers and the people they learn from” (Frampton et al., 2006, p. 31). Hence as I came together with the many educators who generously took part in this study, we brought together our personal and professional subject positions and developed new consciousness through language. Reid (2017) writes that this process “acknowledges not only the internal relation between peoples’ objectivity and subjectivity, including that of the researcher” (p.32). As a researcher, my personal and professional knowledge and consciousness was therefore challenged throughout the process as new ways of being and doing were revealed to me. For example, through the research, I reflected on the extent to which the datafication of education had shaped my own professional work. My reflexive process (described in section 2.3.1) was therefore an important aspect of being cognisant of my own standpoint and biases and to develop new understandings about how work was coordinated under the NCCD.

### **1.1.3 Resourcing students with disability**

Many students with disability require and benefit from adjustments to remove barriers to learning and extra-curricular activities (Conway & Walker, 2017; Cumming et al., 2013; Gargiulo & Metcalf, 2017; C. A. Tomlinson, 2017). Adjustments or educational supports, such as using speech to text software to address literacy learning or speech language disorder, are typically associated with additional

funding. The mechanism for how this funding is determined and distributed is complex and has been contentious in Australia and internationally (Rix et al., 2013; Van Vondren et al., 2017). Additional educational funding for students with disability is typically distributed through local educational policies that use funding formulae contingent on student data (Ainscow et al., 2012; Gonski et al., 2011; Sigafos et al., 2012). This data is often collected and managed locally at schools.

Successful implementation of educational funding policies is reliant on the local work of teachers (Grant et al., 2016). To explain the term *work* I draw on Canadian sociologist, Dorothy Smith's (2005) definition of work to be "anything done by people that takes time and effort, that they mean to do, that is done under definite conditions and with whatever means and tools, and that they have to think about" (pp151-152). For teachers' work, this means, collecting and managing student data occurs across locations (at home and at school), and includes work during school hours but also the extra hours at home which is often at night or early morning.

As an educator, a policy officer and more recently a researcher, I have experienced the tension and dilemmas in my own work, and the work of teachers, that have been created by the macro educational policy requirements for students with disability and the micro policy work that occurs to meet these policy expectations. My professional history has given me an appreciation of how vexing, multi-faceted and complex funding for students with disability can be. The educational, social, and political intricacies attached to questions of identification for resource distribution also influence how people think about disability, funding, and education. The provocation of equity, who gets what, who is treated in what way, and who can do what, and the associated debates about resource distribution activates



opinions and create dilemmas (Ainscow et al., 2012). These dilemmas experienced at the personal level have broader implications for tracing how power works in schools, for and against students with disability, which is why this study is critical for creating positive change for people like Ben, Samantha, Nick, and Ben's teachers.

## **1.2 INQUIRY CONTEXT**

Since 2015, Nick and every other school principal in Queensland, Australia have navigated two identification systems of school students with disability. As previously noted, the EAP in Queensland was a well-established funding policy. The NCCD was an inaugural national policy that commenced with a gradual introduction in 2011. By 2015 it was mandatory for every school in Australia to apply the NCCD model to identify students with disability.

Negotiating dual identification systems, often for the same students, was complex especially when the same policy was interpreted or used differently. For example, the DSE is an institutional text, a policy, designed to ensure additional resources are provided to remove barriers to learning for students with disability. This was not Samantha's initial experience of this institutional text. She was presented with a disjuncture, "different versions of reality – knowing something from a ruling versus an experiential perspective" (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 48). While policy texts guided Nick's next steps in terms of Ben's school enrolment, the same policy texts had also been used to exclude Ben by colleagues at other schools. This thesis foregrounds the everyday; people's embodied experience of implementing policy texts and the disjunctures presented when this differs from official accounts.

### **1.2.1 Some definitions**

Language has the capacity to structure and organise how people think (Smith, 1999). This brief section introduces some key terms and definitions used in this

thesis, with more detailed explanations of institutional ethnographic (IE) concepts in Chapter Two.

First, terms such as *students with special needs*, *students with special educational needs*, *students with additional needs*, and *student/s with disability* are widely used in the special education and inclusive education literature. The term *students or student with disability* is used in this thesis. A student with disability is a young person for whom educational adjustments are provided to minimise barriers to learning to address the functional impact of disability. These educational adjustments are often accounted for through resource provision, such as personnel resources (teacher, teacher assistant, specialist staff), material resources (hearing aids, modifications to school buildings such as ramps, acoustic attenuation), and financial resources that are tracked through budget allocations and/or specific payments for services (OECD, 2008).

Second, an IE inquiry strives to understand “work processes and the social relations shaping them” (Luken, 2021, p. 6). Unlike in traditional sociologies, “social relations” from an IE perspective understands “people’s activities as coordinated in actually temporally concerted sequences or courses of action” (Smith, 1987, p. 183). This includes recognising how work processes are organised, how the work comes in, what precedes the specific actions, and the organisation that follows (Smith, 1987, 1999). Understanding the social relations makes meaning of how people’s every day activities are textually coordinated.

The *institution* in an IE inquiry, is not a physical location but rather is “discovered in motion” (Smith, 2005, p. 235); meaning people’s actions across sites and locations, and at particular times of the day. It is common in many forms of qualitative research for the unit of analysis to be bounded by a school or an

Education Authority, in this inquiry, the institution refers to the apparatus of education. This inquiry investigated the *social relations* to understand the power relations of the NCCD, a specific function within education, beyond an individual school setting (Smith, 2005). This inquiry about the NCCD was not bounded by physical locations, but rather by people's actions as they brought the institutional processes of the NCCD into being. This means that the institution encompassed a wide range of people including those working in schools, education authorities, consultants working on NCCD delivery.

In making visible people's *everyday/everynight work*, Smith (1997, p. 45) this refers work that occurs at any time of the day or night. This work is often invisible, meaning that people are not always aware of all the work they do to make things happen. All forms of work are important, "from its extraordinary invisibility to visibility" (Smith, 2003, p. 63). It is easier to account for paid work. However, making visible the hidden work, which is often unpaid, contributes to building new understandings of how things *actually happen* (Smith, 2005). Ultimately all forms of work matter and contribute to how things happen.

### **1.2.2 School education in Australia**

The Australian school education system is a complex arrangement, regulated and funded through two levels of government – federal and state/territory. Constitutionally, the Australian federal government has responsibility for funding school education, directly and indirectly (Keating & Klatt, 2013). However, responsibility for the provision of schooling sits with each state and territory government (Chakraborty & Blackburn, 2013; Keating & Klatt, 2013). This division of authority between the two levels of government remains an essential element of

the Australian Government system and has significance for the NCCD implementation.

Over recent decades, the Australian Government has used legislation and policy to shape educational provision for all school-age students, including students with disability (Keating & Klatt, 2013; Lingard, 2000; Lupton & Hayes, 2021). The NCCD is one example of the increased federalisation of Australian education policy. In 2008, the state and territory government Ministers of Education agreed to a national approach for identifying students with disability; and that this approach would be tethered to funding of school students with disability (Ralston et al., 2019). While state and territory governments have the responsibility for schooling, the outcome of this agreement assured federal funding for students with disability.

The push for increased federal influence in Australian school education began with a review of schooling in the 1970s, commissioned by the then Labor Australian Government (Lingard, 2000). Specific recommendations from the *Karmel Report 1973*, were made about funding and educational provision for children with disability (children because very few were attending school and therefore not students), and increasing special education teacher education (Karmel et al., 1973). The far-reaching impact of this review is discussed in Chapter Four.

The Australian school system is comprised of two separate education sectors – government and non-government schools. Government schools provide free education to school-age children and are administered by the state and territory governments. The non-government sector, which includes Catholic schools and independent Schools, is predominantly funded directly by the Australian Government (alongside school fees paid by families). Non-government schools are afforded a level of autonomous governance (Kenway, 2013). While most Catholic

schools are part of a diocesan based Catholic education system, many standalone Catholic schools operate independently. These schools operate under the auspices of a Catholic religious congregation, such as the Sisters of Mercy. Other independent schools generally operate under the direction of a governing body such as a school board.

In this set of arrangements state and territory governments are tasked with the provisions of additional resources (e.g., targeted funding and services) for students with disability across all education sectors. The NCCD is a federal policy that is being implemented by state and territory educational jurisdictions, this has added complexity.

### **1.2.3 Educational policy for school students with disability**

Because the federal government is not constitutionally responsible for school education, this meant “all Australian jurisdictions [state and territory governments] have detailed and complex procedures for identifying eligibility criteria and the provision of support required” (Forlin et al., 2013, p. 5).

Each government defined their own criteria to determine additional funding for students with disability. This meant there was no national consistency of funding eligibility criteria for students with disability, nor was there similarity in how funding was distributed. These inconsistencies have made it extremely difficult to have comparisons about students with disability across educational jurisdictions (Forlin et al., 2013). Consequently, there has been no national data about students with disability.

Initially, the two purposes of the NCCD model were first to improve planning, and second, to create a mechanism for allocating Australian Government funding for students with disability (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to

Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2016; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). In 2018, reporting on national data for students with disability became a third purpose (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). Since the introduction of the NCCD, some state and territory governments have dismantled long-serving systems that activated additional funding for students with disability, supported by policies that had been established over many years (Chaney et al., 2020). By standardising eligibility criteria for students with disability, Australian teachers are expected to collect evidence of the educational adjustments they provide for students with disability using the same criteria (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017, 2018). The NCCD support materials provide guidance about what evidence needs to be collected and curated for the NCCD. Teachers' everyday/everynight work is being organised to meet the requirements of the NCCD. Yet, how teachers were expected to do this work was not clear. The everyday work of the NCCD occurs mostly in classrooms and schools, however, as a senior policy officer, it was my experience that policy officer work was also being organised by the requirements of the NCCD requirements, both at school and at the regional office.

### **1.3 ESTABLISHING THE PROBLEMATIC**

An IE inquiry seeks to make visible the social organisation of knowledge by considering how daily activities are coordinated by institutional texts and the associated power of texts to mediate actions across sites (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Deveau, 2009). The *problematic*, is a technical term that guides the IE inquiry (Smith, 1987) and provides a starting place for the project (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). The problematic "is property of the social organisation of the everyday world"

(Smith, 1987, p. 91). The researcher uses the problematic to guide and focus the inquiry, questions are generated for the purpose of exploring how the everyday are “knitted into the extended social relations of a contemporary capitalist economy” (Smith, 1987, p. 110). The researcher utilises the problematic to discover how peoples’ lives are connected beyond their everyday actualities.

The context of this inquiry was associated with how people were implementing the requirements of the inaugural NCCD policy. The centrality of teachers was significant, as they were expected to assess and categorise students to determine the level of educational adjustment provided (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2015, 2018). These judgements were essentially to quantify educational adjustments provided to the student to address the functional impact of disability (Chaney et al., 2020). This was new work for teachers, school leaders and education policy officers.

The entry point to an IE inquiry or the problematic defines “how the researcher will take up the inquiry from a standpoint in the everyday world” (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 48). The disjuncture “between knowing something from a ruling versus an experiential perspective” provides the impetus to explore further, and is taken up from a particular lens or standpoint (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 48). It is through this standpoint that the inquiry begins and evolves, but it is not the final destination (Griffith & Smith, 2005). Alongside standpoint is the problematic, which G. W. Smith (1990) asserts commences with “actual experiences of actual individuals”(p. 631). The problematic for this study was a series of conversations and realisations about how teacher’s work with students with disability and how a new resourcing model reframe and coordinate this work. My entry into

this inquiry is deeply seeded in my personal experiences, as well as my professional experiences as a teacher, a school leader and more recently a policy officer.

### **1.3.1 Beginning with peoples' experiences**

Institutional ethnographic research is iterative and dialogic, and often begins with a personal experience of dissonance (Smith, 2005). For example, when the policy says one thing, but the experience is different, such as when Samantha went to enrol Ben in school. Nick knew the enrolment policy should mean that Ben could be enrolled in the first school his mother approached, but this did not happen. As Nick began to explore what additional resources would be needed for Ben, he was guided by the official NCCD texts. These institutional texts coordinated his work processes, they had textual power (Smith, 2010; Turner, 2001, 2006). As Nick moved through the NCCD documents the workflow could be traced. By mapping how institutional texts coordinate people's NCCD work the lived reality of their embodied experiences becomes visible.

Beginning with people's actualities, is much like pulling a thread to reveal the next steps, by following where the thread leads (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). By examining the role NCCD texts had in coordinating work processes and the everyday/everynight work, the *ruling relations* (Smith, 1997, p. 3) were made visible. This term, ruling relations, incorporates the operation of textual power and examines the role texts have in coordinating people's actions (Smith, 1997). For example, once the enrolment form was completed, this permitted Ben to attend school, the enrolment form then activated a series of actions. The text (enrolment form) had the textual power to socially organise people's doings across and between locations (Smith, 1997); at home, Ben's mother got school supplies ready for him (uniforms, school bag) and at school, his teacher planned a transition program in



preparation for Ben's arrival and began recording adjustments as outlined by the official NCCD texts. This textual chain orchestrated people's everyday lives through sequences of actions (Smith, 2005). Once Ben entered school, the NCCD policy requirements were activated by his teacher.

Understanding how texts of the NCCD were activated required knowledge of the everyday work of teachers, as well as school leaders, particularly in terms of planning learning sequences and educational adjustments. Actions arising from planning decisions were generally guided by school-based curriculum planning templates, as well as formal curriculum documents and other school endorsed (institutional) texts. In other words, their actions were authorised by institutional texts, which coordinated their daily work (Smith, 1997). By making visible how things happen and how sequences of actions are activated, the temporality of the social relations can become known (Smith, 1999, 2005). For example, an IE inquiry can help explain how early morning curriculum planning meetings with colleagues about additional support for Ben, can spark chains of events that lead to work done by teachers in the evening.

The official policy texts of the NCCD emphasise the crucial role of teachers when making decisions about the level of educational support provided to the student (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). The aim of institutional ethnographic research is to understand the social organisation of knowledge and power as it is enacted through institutional practices (Smith, 2005, 2010). Understanding the operation of textually mediated power relations of the NCCD texts and how this coordinated people's work across and between local sites was an aim of this inquiry, in other words, the ruling relations (Smith, 1997) (Smith, 1997, p. 3). The findings in this

study begin from the disjuncture between the official texts of the NCCD and the everyday actualities and show how the NCCD coordinated the work of teachers, school leaders and education policy officers.

### **1.3.2 Research questions**

The purpose of this inquiry was to understand the embodied experiences of people implementing an inaugural national education funding policy for students with disability. The research design sought to consider how the everyday lives of people were shaped by relations of rule operating as part of the NCCD model implementation.

The broad research question was therefore:

How is the work of people in school systems coordinated by the Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability (NCCD)?

Smith (1987) introduced the term problematic in an IE inquiry to direct attention to questions that can guide the exploration of the everyday actualities of peoples' lives.

Additional, research questions (RQ) that guided this inquiry were:

- Whose everyday work was coordinated by the NCCD and how did this happen?
- What activities did people attend to within the workflow processes from the Education Authority (macro) to the classroom (micro) and vice versa?
- What institutional practices emerged (ruling relations) and how were these maintained across settings (translocally)?

Discovering the work of the NCCD policy, as it happened, was achieved through an investigation of institutional processes in response to the research questions. This

research, therefore, generated important new knowledge about the extent to which the policy intent has been realised.

#### **1.4 SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY**

This research project is the first major study that provides evidence about how the NCCD, as an inaugural federal national policy, was implemented. There is very little known about how the NCCD is influencing education sectors, at a macro institutional level (Smith, 2006). At the micro level, there has been a dearth of research that investigates the frontline work associated with NCCD requirements and implementation. The findings presented throughout this thesis explore “the dichotomy of [the] micro and macro” (Diamond, 2006 p. 61), by beginning from the standpoint of frontline workers such as teachers, and then moving on to school leaders and policymakers.

This is not only of significance because the NCCD policy implementation work occurs across Australian schools, but also because the work being undertaken by teachers and school leaders – such as making decisions about the level of adjustment provided to students directly impacts additional funding. Previously, decisions about student eligibility for funding were made away from the school, often by policy officers with disability expertise. Therefore, understanding how local decisions and choices are made, and how these inform what happens for students with disability is of national significance. However, returning to the circumstances of Samantha, a mother seeking support for her son Ben as he commenced schooling; and Nick, the principal wondering how to do this within the new policy framework this research is of significance to the many Australian families and students around the country who simply seek the right to a fair education, on the same basis as their peers.

### **1.4.1 Research contribution**

The findings presented throughout this thesis provide an important and significant contribution to national and international literature across multiple fields of educational policy for students with disability, teachers' work, and school leadership. First, this thesis provides insights into how processes of a national policy intended to inform funding and planning for students with disability were being activated by those at the frontline (Ozga, 1999). There is limited scholarly literature about the NCCD, despite it having now been in place for several years. How this far-reaching policy has worked to achieve the policy goals of funding and planning for students with disability remains under-researched and under-theorised. The findings presented in this thesis contribute to a fledgling corpus of knowledge about the NCCD.

Second, while this thesis contributes to understanding teachers' work in the context of a new policy, the inquiry was anchored in how things happened, and the organisation of institutional processes as experienced by those at the frontline implementing the NCCD (DeVault, 2008b). Official and unofficial NCCD policy documents that have the textual power to connect how things happen across locations are explored. Findings from this investigation contribute to the broader national and international educational institutional ethnographic literature. This inquiry will also broadly contribute to this growing corpus of IE literature, and specifically IEs conducted in the field of education.

## **1.5 THESIS OUTLINE**

In Chapter One I have introduced the context in which this research inquiry was situated, as well as the scope and purpose of the research project. A brief description of school education in Australia was necessary to outline the complexity

in which the NCCD was introduced. Appendix A: The development of the NCCD model is a detailed outline of the development of the NCCD model, this also includes some additional background information. In this chapter, IE was introduced as the research approach, and the research problematic was described.

Chapter Two introduces institutional ethnography as a method of inquiry and describes the research problematic. The research approach is discussed in detail in Chapter Three, which outlines the research design and ethical considerations.

Chapter Four, the literature review, is an introduction to policies and legislation that are influential to this inquiry, and an analysis of the influence of these policies. Without delving into this background, it is difficult to comprehend the complexity of this policy landscape. In this chapter a detailed introduction to the NCCD is offered to complement the comprehensive outline in Appendix A: The development of the NCCD model. Included in this literature review is a discussion of the sociology of disability and the educational provision for students with disability in Australia.

The analysis chapters commence with Chapter Five, beginning with school leaders. As in all IE inquiries there is an entry point to the investigation, and for this project the entry point was the classroom teachers, from which the inquiry unfolded; teachers as the first informants guided the next person with whom to have a conversation, who then introduced the next informant and so on (Smith, 2005). Although the inquiry commenced with conversations with classroom teachers, it became evident in mapping the relations of rule that teachers' NCCD work and social interactions were frequently authorised (and often mandated by school leaders). This outcome was not unexpected and easily accommodated because institutional ethnographic research is rarely ordered with distinct stages, there is a lot of work back and forth (McCoy, 2006). In addition, (Rankin, 2017b) suggests IE

research should not be presented as a narrative of “the researcher’s journey through the research” but that it should instead provide “an account of the institution and how it works”(p. 9).

Chapter Six provides an analysis of conversations and texts provided by the teachers and a teacher assistant. Chapter Seven presents an analysis of the NCCD work generated from the perspective of the Education Authority. This chapter also outlines the work of policy officers and their significant contribution to the implementation of the NCCD.

The final two chapters focus on the discussion and findings. Chapter Eight offers a detailed discussion of core findings, moving from the local work of the NCCD to consider the broader transnational influences. Chapter Nine, the concluding chapter, provides a summary and recommendations, including insights for both policy and further research agendas.



# Chapter 2: Introducing Institutional Ethnography

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## 2.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter provides a detailed orientation to institutional ethnography (IE), the method of inquiry that guided this research. Institutional ethnography is a critical inquiry approach, developed by Canadian sociologist, Dorothy Smith, that seeks to make visible how the everyday of people's lives (actualities) are "organised and determined by social processes that extend outside the scope of the everyday world and are not discoverable within it" (Smith, 1987, p. 152). This was a logical fit for my doctoral research project because I wanted to understand the embodied experiences of frontline workers, and how their experiences were put together in relation to the work of the NCCD (Smith, 2005). Following Smith, it was apparent that understanding how the organisation of knowledge impacted social relations, in other words how people's activities were actioned in the similar ways across locations, how the work of the NCCD actually happened reveals the operation of textual power (Smith, 2005). This requires the researcher to look beyond the official implementation processes and texts of the NCCD policy to see how work unfolds in the everyday.

This chapter presents an outline of IE as a research approach, and the design of this study. The sociological and theoretical work of Dorothy Smith, who pioneered the development of IE is discussed, and an explanation of IE research tools, as applied in a schooling context, is offered. The method of inquiry is discussed in Chapter Three.



## 2.2 INSTITUTIONAL ETHNOGRAPHY AS A RESEARCH APPROACH

Institutional ethnography is an alternative sociology, as Smith explained in a 2018 interview, that was first conceived after reading Marx and joining the women's movement, in the 1970s; she was searching for a sociology that “would start with actual people, their work, and the conditions of their lives” (Kearney et al., 2018, p. 294). In other words, IE is a sociology that avoids making people the object of the inquiry but rather seeks to examine their experiences (Smith, 2005). Over time Smith's conceptualisation of ruling relations considered how knowledge is socially organised and how textual technologies, language and experiences coordinate the actualities of people's daily activities as they are experienced in the everyday/everynight (Smith, 1997, 2005). It was from this focus on the entities and processes of people, that the social ontology of IE emerged (McCoy, 2021). An IE inquiry is posited within the actualities of peoples' everyday.

This research project provides a detailed investigation of people's experiential accounts of their own work with the NCCD policy, to make visible the institutional order that initiated and maintained the conditions of their work (McCoy, 2006). Smith (2005) defines work as being an intentional action, which is undertaken in an actual place under defined conditions and with specified resources, and it takes time. The work of the NCCD is intentional, taking time, energy, and resources to complete.

Through piecing together people's individual accounts, their embodied experiences, the researcher can show how knowledge is socially organised (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Kearney et al., 2018). Smith (2005) calls this “ruling relations – that extraordinary yet ordinary complex of relations that are textually mediated, that connect us across space and time and organise our everyday lives –

the corporations, government bureaucracies, academic and professional discourses, mass media, and the complex relations that interconnect them” (p. 10). Ruling relations are distinctive objectified forms of consciousness and social organisation, that occur translocally, meaning they occur across multiple locations and are not associated with a particular person or place (Smith, 2005). Ruling relations have the capacity (textual power) to coordinate people’s actions. In an IE inquiry, texts are defined as materials or artefacts that can be replicated or reproduced such as print, film or digital formats (Smith, 2005). Educators use a variety of official texts, such as curriculum planning templates and forms, as well as the mandated curriculum. Teachers produce the design and development of unofficial texts to suit their local contexts and needs.

An IE inquiry is “ground[ed] in experience from which discoveries are to be made” (Smith, 2005, p. 8). Hence, an IE inquiry begins from the embodied actualities of people’s lives and the interplay of texts (Griffith & Smith, 2005; Smith, 1999). For example, imagine Ben’s classroom teacher who scheduled a meeting before school with his mother, Samantha, to discuss his learning needs. To be prepared for the meeting, and to get to school on time, the teacher needs to plan her own morning at home to ensure her young children are ready to leave the house early, as well as ensure she is ready for what needs to be done when she gets to school to guarantee the meeting runs to time and achieves the purpose. Equally so, Samantha is doing the same in her own home, organising her own family so that she too is on time and prepared for the meeting. While scheduling a parent/teacher meeting before school seems easy enough, there is a lot of invisible work that must occur to make this meeting happen. The embodied actualities of both the parent and the teacher are complex, multilayered, and yet connected, as they attend to their own

respective familial and professional responsibilities. Institutional ethnographies begin by investigating the actualities of these kinds of embodied experiences, which are often invisible in objectified accounts of work and life. The IE sociological approach is agentic, deliberately iterative, and flexibly responsive to the everyday experiences of people's daily lives and work, to make visible what is often not known (Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012; Hak, 1998). The approach is really concerned with understanding how people's daily actions are organised and coordinated, the ruling relations.

As a sociological approach, IE is not aligned with a specific theoretical base or specific way of knowing (Smith, 1987). However, there is a distinctive starting point and analytical intent which is to ensure that the subject of the inquiry is kept in the everyday (Kearney et al., 2018). Ontologically, IE seeks to understand "knowledge that represents the social as it happens" (Smith, 1999, p. 97). The epistemological shift in IE is located in the disjuncture or line of fault that emerges when there is a mismatch between official accounts (official knowledge or accounts) and the everyday, as it is actually experienced by people (everyday knowledge or accounts) (Collins, 1992; DeVault, 2006; Smith, 1999, 2005). There are three fundamental assumptions underpinning IE; first, people are experts in how their own lives are lived; second, actions are located in sites throughout society and finally, these actions are shaped by translocal forces or ruling relations (Deveau, 2009). These assumptions guide the analytical process.

While IE inquiries begin in the everyday, the analytic aim is to understand how the actualities are connected by a wider set of power relations, organised by texts to make visible how actions hook up into (Smith, 2005) relations of rule which are "fragmented, textually mediated and subject to rapid change" (Spina & Comber, 2021, p. 253). Understanding how texts are connected to, or hook into, rules in an

educational context is challenging due to the speed in which policy (the rules) evolves.

By making ruling relations visible, the organisational structures (e.g., administrative, managerial, professional and discourse) that organise, coordinate and regulate the embodied activities (actions) of people are revealed (Smith, 1999, 2005). For example, similar actions, such as teachers recording the educational adjustments, they provide for students with disability to access the curriculum on the same basis as their peers. Smith (2005) argues that these kinds of actions are “textually coordinated” because they occur as people act on key institutional texts, such as templates for recording teaching adjustments. These doings occur in vastly different places, with the everyday work of people orchestrated by institutional texts.

Smith (1987) defines *institutional and/or institution* not as a single entity or organisation, nor a physical structure, but rather as clusters of ruling relations organised around specific functions, such as education, health care, municipal planning, and the like. It is a complex “ruling apparatus” (Smith, 1987, p. 160). The institution in this research project is the apparatus of schooling, specifically as it applies the coordination of people’s work in relation to the NCCD.

### **2.2.1 The ontology of institutional ethnography**

Institutional ethnography “has an explicit ontology that focuses researchers’ attention on the materiality of people’s lives and the socially organised practices of coordination that shape the conditions that people encounter” (McCoy, 2021, p. 35). This means, how people’s activities are organised and the “material conditions of those activities” (D. E. Smith, 1990b, p. 6), what is materially present and how this shapes people’s actions across time and place. McCoy (2021) describes this as “thereness of coordinated activity” (p.36). Smith (1990b, 2016) draws on Marx and

Engel's *The German Ideology* conception of materialism to ground IE in people's actual activities and what is materially there rather than ideas about people and what they do. Smith has argued that an important distinction between IE and traditional sociological approaches is that IE does not seek to categorise discourse and nor does it make social processes the object of the inquiry, but rather IE seeks to understand how knowledge is socially organised (Kearney et al., 2018; Smith, 1987). The intention of an IE inquiry is to make visible people's everyday/everynight actions to understand how social relations are organised translocally (Smith, 1987, 2003, 2005). As an activist scholar, Smith proposed that an IE approach is used to understand how people's lives are organised, to explore how things happen so that improvements can be made to the "existing textually-mediated social relations and, ultimately the lives of people" (Luken, 2021, p. 6). These actions contribute to or produce institutional processes.

By knowing how knowledge is socially organised, Smith suggests that this makes it possible for people to understand the organisation of the everyday (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). As Smith developed her ideas about IE, she explored Bakhtin's ideas of discourse and Foucault's conceptualisation of discourse to consider how people's actions both produce and are produced by language (DeVault & McCoy, 2006; McCoy, 2021; Smith, 2005; Stanley, 2018). Bakhtin's concept of discourse as a model of social processes aligns with IE, specifically, interactions with texts (dialogism) and diversity of views expressed through language (heteroglossia) (Stanley, 2018). In particular, Smith (2005) engaged with Bakhtin's theorisation of the relationship between utterance and speech. Drawing on Bakhtin, Smith (2005) explained that 'language is an ongoing and developing complex within which people's intentions are realised in utterances; at the same time, each utterance both

reproduces and elaborates language” (p.65). Dialogue, Smith (2005) contends, is a “form of coordinating in language” (p.65). Bakhtin’s notion of dialogism was thus important for Smith because it provided a frame for considering how people’s everyday doings were coordinated, through language, without “construction abstractions that isolate them conceptually” (Smith, 2005, p. 68). Importantly, Smith also worked with Bakhtin’s (1986) concept of speech genres. For Bakhtin (1986), “each separate utterance is individual, of course, but each sphere in which language is used develops its own relatively stable types of utterances. These may be called speech genres” (p. 60). Bakhtin described primary speech genres are primarily written, and somewhat more removed from direct experience. This distinction, between speech based experiences in the everyday world, and speech that is mediated by texts is important, because it built a foundation for Smith’s analytic focus on how the everyday is coordinated through relations of rule, and the conceptual practice of power.

Smith’s work also built on Marx’s notion of consciousness which had been developed prior to the explosion of neoliberal rationalities, and which “identified with individuals and what goes on in their heads” (Smith, 2005, p. 14). Smith sought to develop a method of inquiry that would explicate the organisation of the social.

However, while Bakhtin offers a model for deep interrogation of discourse as way to examine the social processes, IE defines discourse as a way to examine the social processes, IE defines discourse more broadly, which means it does become the object of the inquiry per se (Smith, 2005). Institutional ethnography is not focused on analysing the content of the discourse, rather it is through discourse that the social relations and organisation of people’s doings are revealed.

Institutional ethnography also shares Foucault's interest in texts, power, and governance. The point of divergence from this shared interest is the location of power, Foucault locates power within the relations that exist between individuals as a way of changing people's conduct (O'Farrell, 2005). In contrast, IE explores power by examining how institutions rule through modern technologies and the capacity of texts (Smith, 1987). Foucault's conception of discourse was on ways of organising forms of knowledge, to "formulate and recognise objects of knowledge in distinctive ways" (Smith, 2005, p. 127). Foucault (1969/2002) described a discourse as "a group of statements in so far as they belong to the same discursive formation" (p.121). He described discursive formations as practices that "systematically form the objects of which they speak" (Foucault, 1969/2002, p. 54). As discourses produce knowledge that appears across institutions, groups of people, such as students with disability, belong to the same discursive formation. These discourses, or *systems of representation* (Hall, 2001), therefore, produce power/knowledge depending on who has authority.

Smith and Griffith (2022) built on, and expanded Foucault's notion of discourse, (and Bakhtinian notions of primary and secondary speech genres) to distinguish specialised language used by people, including in texts, which coordinates the everyday. In an IE, texts have a particular role in promulgating particular discourses, and in organising and coordinating people's actions. This textual mediation is used to explain how people's experiences are shaped (texts are defined in more detail in section 2.3.3). Smith and Griffith (2022) explain:

For institutional ethnography, discourse refers to translocal relations coordinating the practices of definite individuals talking, writing, reading, watching and so forth, in particular places at particular times. Participants create texts for other participants to read; they read what others have

written and take them into account in their own work. People are active in participating in discourse, and their participation reproduces and changes it...We stress again: discourse is an organisation of relations among actual people engaged and active in local settings – offices, conferences, workshops, classrooms, homes – whose activities, our work, are textually coordinated (p. 34).

To explain translocal relations in people's lives and how this is organised, institutional ethnographers draw on tools that help to explicate *institutional power* (Smith, 2005, p. 194) and governance (Deveau, 2009). A significant point of difference is that for an IE inquiry the products of research are not traditional case studies in which power and governance are interrogated per se, but rather it is like pulling a thread in ball of yarn to follow the social organisation of knowledge across settings and amongst individuals, to piece together how things happen (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Griffith & Smith, 2005; Smith, 2008). The IE researcher needs to stand back from the informant's individual accounts of their experiences to follow the thread of how things happen, to discover similar doings across locations and informants.

The purpose of an IE inquiry is to “create knowledge for us, and not as a power over or against us” (Smith, 2005, p. 133). With this challenge in mind, institutional ethnographers are reminded that tools used in this method of inquiry are designed to explore the textual realities of people's everyday, and in so doing, avoid categorical approaches that move the person from subject to object (Kearney et al., 2018; Smith, 1987). The following section is a discussion of the IE tools used to create knowledge about the social organisation of how things happen.

## **2.3 A TOOLKIT FOR AN INSTITUTIONAL ETHNOGRAPHY INQUIRY**

The tools used in an IE inquiry allow for deep exploration of how things happen or operate translocally and how texts maintain their capacity or power to



mediate and coordinate daily actions (Darville, 2014; Turner, 2001). These IE tools explore the social relations that coordinate people's actions (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). The following section outlines key aspects of the IE toolkit.

### **2.3.1 Standpoint, and an insider's perspective**

As discussed above, an IE inquiry is grounded in people's embodied experiences and is typically activated from the standpoint of the researcher, who firstly identifies something they would like to understand better (Smith, 1997, 2005). Standpoint is located in people's actualities and perspectives. It draws on the principle that people are experts in their own lives. An IE inquiry is an agentic analytical endeavour that evolves by gathering people's stories and experiences and to explore the emergence of patterns and concepts, to work out how things are happening (Smith, 1997, 2008). It is through the active engagement of informants that the researcher can see how their lives are organised to create knowledge about how things happen beyond individual experiences (DeVault & McCoy, 2006). It is through this information that the researcher seeks to make visible the social organisation of knowledge.

Institutional ethnography inquiries are activated from the standpoint of the researcher, who may also have the benefit of *insider* experiences or knowledge (Eastwood, 2006, p. 171). For example, for this inquiry, I have drawn on my experience as a teacher, a policy officer, and a school leader. These professional roles have provided me with insights and insider knowledge about teachers' work and bureaucratic processes (Eastwood, 2006). As Griffith (1998) described, being an insider gives a deeper understanding of both context and the knowledge that is being created, having insider knowledge is not an obstacle in the production of quality research. It is the researcher's opinions, experiences and shared understandings of the

work being investigated, which add richness to the emerging story (Grahame, 1998; Smith, 2005; Stahl, 2021). However, the insider standpoint of the researcher demands reflexive practices, such as journaling reflections and/or critical discussions with supervisors and colleagues, to ensure they recognise their own “entry into the social relations” of which they are describing (D. E. Smith, 1990a, p. 147). For example, the researcher makes sense of accounts and in so doing selects threads to follow, “working as both agent and observer” (Stahl, 2021, p. 120). The researcher’s “standpoint anchors the research in relevancies of a particular group, the idea is to consider how the perspectives from different locations illuminate the relevant social relations while keeping in mind the questions” (DeVault & McCoy, 2006, p. 32). The insider standpoint contribution to an IE inquiry ensure threads are followed up and connections are made, drawing on a deep understanding of the everyday.

As previously described, my personal and professional history led me to an interest in understanding how the work of those at the frontline of the NCCD policy implementation was coordinated and mediated. Entering into a complex inquiry by beginning with those at the frontline, it is important to remain cognisant that it was my understanding or interpretation of the conversations with informants that took specific ideas forward for further interrogation (Deveau, 2009; Grahame, 1998; Griffith, 1998). As the researcher, it is also necessary to move beyond individual experiences to examine the operation of textually mediated power translocally. This is achieved by reflecting on each conversation to add the detail to a visual representation (map), which was frequently revisited and updated (see Appendix B: Maps in progress). It is expected that individual differences would emerge (and they did) but an IE investigation is focused on explicating the social relations as they are shaped by the embodied actualities that are coordinating people’s everyday work

translocally, making visible the “everyday activities and their positioning within sequences of actions” which are replicated over time and in multiple locations (DeVault & McCoy, 2002, p. 753). Insider knowledge provides a richness to the inquiry that helps to move it forward.

### **2.3.2 Social relations and social organisation**

A cornerstone of IE is the belief that the “world is invariably social and that the only way we can be in the world is as social beings” (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 27). It is from people’s social activities and how these are coordinated by external factors that the social relations are revealed. Social relations are the interplay between the everyday actions or the embodied experiences of people and how these are textually coordinated translocally (Campbell, 1998; Griffith & Smith, 2005; D. E. Smith, 1990b). These actions are activated and maintained through conversations, documents, and other types of texts, and are connected to sequences of actions.

### **2.3.3 Textually coordinated actions and ruling relations**

A central premise of IE is that in a post-industrial society people’s experiences are routinely organised, connected to and shaped by “text-based forms of knowledge” (Deveau, 2009, p. 9). This textual knowledge comes in various formats, but essentially texts communicate information via words, numbers, or images. Types of texts include printed documents, electronic documents, government forms and reports, audio-visual materials (Smith, 2006a), as well as digital technologies that communicate information such as health monitoring (Small et al., 2021). Texts coordinate people’s activities in local settings, as well as across organisations and institutions, they are replicable and carry authority, and hook up people’s doings (Smith, 2001). For example, birthday cards do not carry authority, but national funding policies do. The textual power of a national funding policy is activated and

replicated across multiple locations in similar ways, it has the authority to organise people's doings. The texts of the funding policy hooks into the work of institutional actors, such as the school principal, the classroom teacher, a specialist teacher, parents/carers, and the student who each have a specific role that is part of a sequence of actions (Smith, 2005; Turner, 2006). These textually based sequences of actions may therefore occur in similar ways across locations.

Textually coordinated actions transcend local settings, such as schools, education authorities and national borders. Despite local contextual differences, textually coordinated actions are temporal, meaning they are replicated over time and across locations (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). For example, when implementing a new educational policy one of the procedural steps is to officially launch the policy. This often occurs at professional meetings, such as the quarterly principal meeting. This action of launching the policy is coordinated by a communication plan, but occurs in various ways, across multiple settings, time and time again, at every principal meeting across the region. The policy launch then activates chains or sequences of actions that hook into how the principal organises their everyday doings, as well as teachers, parents/carers, and other members of the school community.

Ruling relations occur when texts coordinate people's actions in specific ways, IE is interested in the "active ways in which texts organise [these] relations" (D. E. Smith, 1990b). D. E. Smith (1990b) argues texts offer "access to the ontological ground of institutional processes which organise, govern and regulate the kind of society in which we live" (p.122). These actions are connected to each other like a chain that extends back and forward, over time and across locations (McCoy, 2021). Institutional ethnography shows that people's everyday doings are textually

coordinated, but often coordinated from *outside* the everyday through wider power relations.

#### **2.3.4 Line of fault or disjuncture**

Experience is a way of knowing. The epistemological shift between ways of knowing something experientially and knowing something objectively or ideologically creates cognitive dissonance (Deveau, 2009). In IE, a fault line or disjuncture is described as emerging from the contradictions between versions of “knowing something from a ruling versus an experiential perspective” (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 48). It is through making the disjuncture visible that an understanding of the ruling relations occurs (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Smith, 2005). This bifurcated consciousness, or two ways of knowing something, can emerge as people become immersed in one aspect of their professional work which is contrary to official accounts of how things happen which can result in a line of fault or disjuncture (Campbell, 1998; Smith, 1987). For those at the frontline of the NCCD policy implementation differences between official accounts of the NCCD and the unofficial experiences of people in their everyday emerged.

The NCCD was established to standardise eligibility criteria for funding for students with disability. This standardisation covers all Australian schools but does not account for contextual differences arising from local policies, geographical locations, size of the school and so on. Nor do the official NCCD policy texts consider jurisdictional differences of implementation, this poses the potential for confusion as teachers move from one school to another. It is by bringing this dissonance to the fore that gaps are revealed between the policy intent, the institutional claims and the everyday practices, the lived realities, as they actually happen.

## **2.4 INSITUTIONAL ETHNOGRAPHY AS A RIGOROUS RESEARCH APPROACH**

Institutional ethnography is an established qualitative research approach used by researchers predominantly from Canada, the United Kingdom, and Australia, in the fields of nursing, education, social work, governance and municipal planning (Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012; Comber, 2012; Daniel, 2008; Spina, 2020; Turner, 2001). Institutional ethnography is an agile research approach, suitable for researching complex social issues (Talbot, 2020). The analytic intent is to notice and describe; and to make connections beyond the local, to follow a thread. Barron (2022) argues that institutional ethnography “provides a unifying ontology for the sociology of quantification and studies or rankings and metrics (p. 1). While situated in higher education, rather than schooling, Barron’s work resonates with my research because it demonstrates how numbers and quantification have reshaped relations between people, and now coordinate a great deal of work in education settings.

Institutional ethnography has been used to successfully explore the complex relations of educational policy both nationally and internationally. For example, Gerrard and Farrell (2013) were interested in the textual sequences that coordinated the production of curriculum policy and implementation. Talbot (2016) explored the relationship between teachers collecting evidence of their professional learning and teacher practices. Nichols and Griffith (2009) traced the relationships between the everyday lives of teachers and parents to explore curriculum policy and educational governance in Canada using an IE lens. Daniel (2008) traced how funding policy of students with disability was implemented in Ontario, Canada. Gallagher (2016) investigated Australian primary school teachers’ curriculum planning practices for students with disability. Comber (2012) sought to understand the ways in which the Australian National Assessment Program Literacy and Numeracy (NAPLAN)

reorganised teachers' work. Kerr (2014) and Spina (2020), in separate studies, investigated the impact of data-driven accountability and governance on teachers' work, in Canada and in Australia respectively.

Ethnographic research is an established approach used to explore and interrogate policy implementation (Bacchi, 2009; Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016; Heimans et al., 2015). An IE approach to understanding how policy is implemented avoids attempts to categorise or theorise people's experiences because it is focused on revealing a practical account of people's actions to discover how work is coordinated across different locations (Rankin, 2015; Smith, 1999). For example, van Leent and Spina (2022) used IE to explore primary teachers' representations of genders and sexualities in primary school, showing how heteronormative ideological codes operate, framed by the power of a national curriculum.

In an era of neoliberalism and globalisation Denzin (2016) suggests new qualitative research methods and paradigms are needed to explore social life to give agency and voice to those impacted, and to explore ways to make a more socially just society. The activist approach of an IE inquiry provides this opportunity (Wilson & Pence, 2006). Moreover, with the increasing globalisation of education and focus on the knowledge economy, IE provides a way to understand the "ruling practices of a knowledge-based economy" (Deveau, 2016, p. 312). An IE research approach can be used to understand, from the perspectives of those at the frontline, complex policy implementation such as that of the NCCD.

I return to my earlier accounts (see Chapter One), of my younger self in the lecture theatre being confronted by a disjuncture in which my own thinking was challenged by my lecture's official account of disability. I also reflect on my experience of sitting with a principal at the point of enrolment of a young child with

disability. These kinds of lived experiences shape my standpoint, which cannot be separated from this inquiry. It is through these embodied experiences that I have come to appreciate the complexities of work for those charged with the responsibility of implementing the NCCD. My standpoint was the entry point for this inquiry, but it is their voices that guide it. Consequently, a deeper understanding of how the everyday work of the NCCD is coordinated has become known, in other words, visible.

The lens of IE aligns with my personal ontology, the complexity of teachers' and school leaders' work is not always visible. Teachers, school leaders and policy officers are finding new ways to undertake their existing daily work as well as responding to new demands and expectations. Through valuing their expert knowledge of their own work, I was provided with the opportunity to share and learn from their embodied experiential accounts of how things happen. This was important in constructing a detailed sketch of how the NCCD works in practice.

## **2.5 CONCLUSION**

In this chapter, I have outlined theoretical underpinnings of IE and explained how this is an appropriate approach to understand how the NCCD policy is being implemented by people who are responsible for making it happen. This chapter outlined the core concepts of the IE inquiry approach and explained tools used in the research project. It established three fundamental principles of IE: that people are experts in how their own lives are lived, that actions are located in sites and that these actions are shaped by ruling relations. This theoretical foundation made IE a legitimate and appropriate choice for this research. The next chapter provides a detailed outline of the method of inquiry for this research project, including details of participants, data collection and data analysis process.





# Chapter 3: Method of Inquiry

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## 3.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter commences by highlighting the intentional use of the phrase “method of inquiry” rather than “methodology” which denotes a prescribed way of undertaking research and is often framed by specific research protocols (Smith, 2005). As a method of inquiry, IE, “is designed to create an alternative to the objectified subject of knowledge of established social scientific discourse” (Smith, 2005, p. 10). There is no one way to conduct an IE inquiry, yet integral to the approach is the understanding how the everyday/everynight is organised, to explore the ruling relations beyond direct experience (D. E. Smith, 1990a). An IE inquiry seeks to discover how daily activities are coordinated across settings and time by following a thread to see where it leads.

Another unique aspect of IE is the use of the term “informants” rather than participants. Traditional research projects use the term participants to describe those who was part of the inquiry, whereas the deliberate language choice of informants acknowledges the active role people have in guiding an IE inquiry (Smith, 1987). An IE inquiry is co-constructed by the informants, as the actualities of people’s lives are shared through the conversations that occur (Smith, 1987). Informants take an active role in guiding the inquiry.

An IE research project cannot be fully planned out in advance due to the iterative nature of the approach, in which the researcher must follow textual threads and, in so doing, they can often go back to go forwards (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; DeVault, 2012; Smith, 2005). The inquiry is dialogic and begins with a conversation between the researcher and the informant/s about their daily work to understand how

things happen in their local context, and across sites, translocally (DeVault, 2012; Smith, 2005; Turner, 2001). This iterative inquiry method requires the researcher to analyse conversations as they progress to determine the next step, meaning, the next conversation or what texts and/or institutional talk needs to be investigated (DeVault, 2012). These metaphorical threads guide and connect the researcher to the next informant, who then directs the researcher to the next step and so on.

In summary, this chapter provides an outline of the completed research project, including information about the informants and the processes of data collection. Section 3.4 details the method used for analysing the data sets. Ethics is discussed in the last section.

### **3.2 INFORMANTS AND RESEARCH SITES**

An IE investigation begins with the researcher, it is from their standpoint that the entry point to the inquiry is identified (Smith, 2005). In my work as a senior policy officer, I was working with schools to understand the recently introduced national education funding policy for school students with disability. I was interested to understand how this new policy was changing their everyday work, particularly classroom teachers. Therefore, it was practical and methodologically appropriate to begin the research with classroom teachers teaching students with disability; this was the entry point into this inquiry (Smith, 1987). Through these initial conversations with classroom teachers they identified additional informants, as well as the texts that were guiding their daily NCCD work.

The researcher follows the thread to see where it leads, who to talk to next, what texts to collate and so on (Creswell, 2020; Smith, 2005). Snowball sampling has the advantage of continuing to seek informants until saturation is reached (Creswell, 2020). Saturation levels are reached when there are no new people

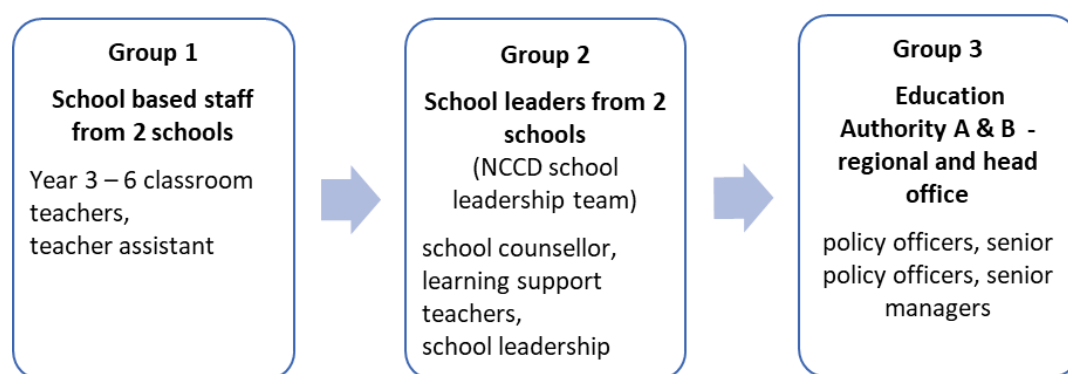
identified or when conversations offer no additional information. Insights from each informant about their lived experiences contribute to understanding how knowledge is socially organised and the institutional processes, the ruling relations, that coordinate daily activities across locations (Smith, 1999, 2002). The IE researcher zigzags between data collection and immediate data analysis, whilst following threads offered by each informant to make decisions about next steps, including what data to collect next.

Locating informants for this research project began with a research application to education (school) authorities in Queensland, Australia. An Education Authority has responsibility for schools, which is explained in more detail in Chapter Four. The research application involved submitting a detailed application form alongside the university approved ethics application. One Education Authority approved my research application within weeks whereas, after many months, the other Education Authority requested that I withdraw my research application. When I asked for feedback about their concerns with the project, I was told that they did not want me to talk with teachers about the NCCD because it was too contentious, although they were interested in the project outcomes (Field Note 3, November 7, 2018). Consequently, I only had approval from one Education Authority to approach schools, which meant all school-based informants were from the same Education Authority. The Education Authority ethics approval also included approval to approach policy officers in the regional and head offices.

Identifying informants began with compiling a list of over twenty primary schools, with the intention of sending emails to the first three schools on the list, then the next three and so on until three schools were secured. The initial email was sent to the principals' generic school email account (not their personal work email). In

this first round of emails, all three principals responded positively. During an initial meeting with each principal, I provided a brief explanation of IE and the inquiry approach which included following an inquiry thread as it is presented through conversations with informants. I shared that the focus of the inquiry was to understand the work of the NCCD, so I would be asking informants about their NCCD work, specifically the documents that organised and guided their work, and who they worked with. Furthermore, the snowball sampling approach meant that classroom teachers would identify additional school staff, such as the school counsellor, the learning support teacher and school leaders, as well as policy officers from the Education Authority. Figure 3.1 is a visual representation of the snowball sampling sequence.

**Figure 3.1** *Informants*



During this initial meeting with the principals, I also explained that I was seeking approval to approach volunteer classroom teachers of students in years three to six (children aged from approximately eight years to eleven years). In Queensland, there are seven years of compulsory primary education, commencing with prep through to year six. Teachers of years three to six were selected because of the developmental age of the students, and the increased likelihood of identifying classroom teachers with at least one student with disability in their class that was

included in the NCCD count. This also meant that the school would have detailed documentation about these students, and they would be known to school personnel. It is important to note, that this project was not seeking information about specific students, but rather retained a focus on the work involved in implementing the NCCD.

The principals all agreed to facilitate my approach to their respective school staff. However, within days of meeting one principal there was an unexpected departure of the learning support teacher from the school. The principal requested that I delay meeting with school staff for a few weeks as this sudden disruption had a significant impact on the school community. During this time, I continued to work with the remaining two schools. The next correspondence was an email to the principal of the schools that included an information pack about the project which included the participant information form outlining the aims of the project and the process, a copy of the university ethics approval certificate, a copy of the ethics approval from the Education Authority and the participant consent form.

Shortly after my initial meetings in these schools, both principals contacted me to say they had identified two classroom teachers in their school who were ready to commence interviews and provided days/times that would suit the school for this to occur. Although both principals agreed to my request, and teachers were keen to be involved, I also needed certainty that there was broader agreement from school staff so that additional people could be approached. The principals assured me the research proposal was shared with all school staff, there was a general interest in the project and agreement for a range of staff to be involved, and that seeking participation from other potential informants as my research progressed would not be an issue. During the initial interview phase with the two primary schools, it was

decided a third school site was not required. The classroom teachers, in these schools, provided a rich and detailed account of their experiences, which launched the next phase of the inquiry.

The first group of informants (see Figure 3.1, Group 1) were classroom teachers and a teacher assistant from two Queensland metropolitan primary schools. Members of Group 1 identified other informants from their respective schools who had worked with them on the NCCD (see Figure 3.1, Group 2). Similarly, members of Group 2 named informants from the regional office of the Education Authority (see Figure 3.1, Group 3) who had collaborated with them as they undertook their NCCD work. These policy officers identified colleagues, including senior policy officers and managers who they had worked with from the Education Authority. Snowball sampling enables the researcher to analyse the data provided by informants to identify the next person with whom to have a conversation by the way they talked about their work and how it happened (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Creswell, 2020). In total there were twenty-seven informants, thirteen informants from the two schools, and the remaining fourteen informants came from two education authorities. The two schools, Hillside Primary School (HPS) and Parkside Primary School (PPS), and all informants have a pseudonym, with professional roles generically named.

Every Australian school is allocated an Index of Community Socio-educational Advantage (ICSEA) value by the Australian Curriculum, Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA) that identifies the socio-educational advantage or disadvantage of every school and is used to make comparisons between schools (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020a). The ICSEA value is determined by a range of factors including the student's family backgrounds (parents' education, parents' occupations), the geographical location of the school

and the proportion of Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander students attending the school, as well as the NAPLAN results for students in Years Three, Five, Seven and Nine (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020a). The average ICSEA value is 1000, the higher the value, the higher the socio-educational advantage, the lower the value the lower the advantage. The ICSEA values for each school are published on each school's profile page of the My School website, which contains accountability data about every Australian school (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020b). The ICSEA value is only relevant as a blunt comparison of the two schools in terms of educational advantage or disadvantage.

### **3.2.1 Hillside Primary School**

Hillside Primary School (HPS) is a coeducational primary school located in a middle-class area in a major metropolitan city in Queensland, Australia. At the time of data collection, 2018, the ICSEA value was between 1120 and 1130, which was just above the national average of 1000 in terms of educational advantage (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020b). In 2018, there were approximately 330 students enrolled, of which, almost 10% of students were from a language background other than English and 1% of students identified as being Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander. There was a full-time equivalent teaching staff of 25, and more than 11 full-time equivalent non-teaching staff, such as teacher assistants, school office staff, school maintenance staff and so on (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020b).

I had conversations with eight informants from HPS, commencing with classroom teachers Robert and Olivia. They both suggested I also meet with teacher assistant, Chloe, and members of the Student Support Team (SST). The SST



included the school principal, Jennifer; the curriculum lead teacher, Debra; two learning support teachers, Fiona, and Karen; and the school counsellor, Natalie.

Robert was an experienced classroom teacher and had previously been a principal of another school for several years. Robert was in his third year at HPS. Robert joined the staff as the Assistant Principal, he then moved to a full-time classroom teaching role. At the time of our conversation, he was in his second year of classroom teaching at the school. Olivia was a mid-career teacher and had been working at HPS since graduating five years earlier. Olivia had taught a variety of year levels. Chloe, a teacher assistant, had been a member of the school staff for many years (so many in fact, nobody really knew how long, not even Chloe herself!). She was well known to all the teaching staff. During her employment at the school, Chloe had undertaken a broad range of duties, including working directly with students in classrooms, working in the school library, and administrative tasks in the school office.

The purpose of the SST is to provide a collaborative forum for problem solving issues relating to student learning needs and wellbeing, and to provide strategic direction to assist teachers to meet additional learning needs of specific students (Tancredi et al., 2020). The curriculum lead teacher, Debra, was an integral member of the SST, and had been in a range of teaching roles at the school, including more than ten years as a classroom teacher at HPS. Debra was in her second year as the curriculum lead teacher, but just prior to this role she was a learning support teacher for the previous school year. Karen, another member of the SST, was a part-time learning support teacher. Karen had also been a classroom teacher in the school for some years before commencing as a learning support teacher. Karen's learning support teacher role was specifically focused on prep to year three, with a particular

focus on literacy development. Karen worked with classroom teachers to develop literacy programs, as well as delivering intensive literacy intervention programs with small groups of students. At the time of my conversation with Karen, she was working across two primary schools in the same role of literacy/learning support. Fiona, the full-time learning support, was also a member of the SST at HPS. Although this was Fiona's first year at the school, she was an experienced learning support teacher with primary and secondary school experience. Natalie, an experienced school counsellor, also worked across other school sites, working at HPS two days per week. Natalie had been working at HPS for the last four years. The final member of the SST was Jennifer, the principal. This was Jennifer's second year as principal at HPS, she had previously been a principal of another school within the Education Authority.

### **3.2.2 Parkside Primary School**

Parkside Primary School (PPS) is a coeducational primary school located in a middle-class area of a major metropolitan city in Queensland, Australia. In 2018, the ICSEA value was between 1000 and 1100, which was close to the national average of 1000 (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020b). At the time of data collection, there were approximately 360 students enrolled, of which, almost 30% of students were from a language background other than English and approximately 2% of students identified as being Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander. The school had a full-time equivalent teaching staff of 23, and the full-time equivalent for non-teaching staff of almost 10 (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020b).

From PPS, I had conversations with seven informants, commencing with classroom teachers Sophie and Emily. Sophie was a mid-career teacher, but this was

her first year in both the school and with the Education Authority. Emily was an experienced classroom teacher who had been on the staff of PPS for more than ten years. They suggested that I also meet with members of the SST, which included the school principal, Margaret; the curriculum lead teacher, Jodie; the learning support teacher, Rebecca; and the school counsellor, Linda. At PPS, I also met with Sarah, the assistant principal.

Jodie, the curriculum lead teacher, worked part-time in this role and had done so for the last three years. Prior to taking on this role, Jodie had been a classroom teacher at PPS. Although Rebecca was the newly appointed learning support teacher, she too had been on staff for more than ten years as a classroom teacher. Rebecca had started in this position a few weeks before our first conversation. Being new to the role of learning support teacher she was keen to explore study options to gain additional qualifications relevant to learning support/disability. Linda was an experienced school counsellor, she worked at PPS for two days per week and in another school for three days per week. In many schools within the Education Authority, specialist role holders, such as the school counsellor or learning support teacher worked across two schools and were, therefore, members of the SST in more than one school. Linda had been working at PPS for the last two years. Margaret was an experienced principal and had been in this role at PPS for more than five years. Sarah, the assistant principal, was new to the role in 2018, but had been on the school staff as a classroom teacher for many years. Although Sarah was not a member of the SST, she was responsible for scheduling professional learning for the school staff and that included ensuring there was training provided about the NCCD policy requirements.

Informants at both schools had multiple connections with policy officers from the Education Authority. I approached each of these policy officers to meet with me to talk about their work implementing the NCCD.

### **3.2.3 Education Authorities**

By following the thread, I spoke with informants from two education authorities (see Chapter Seven). For the most part, informants came from the one Education Authority (Education Authority A), which is a large organisation, employing thousands of teachers, with multiple regional office locations as well as the head office. Senior managers and policy officers based at head office had specific policy development portfolios, whereas senior managers based at regional office had supervisory responsibilities for school principals. Other regionally based policy officers worked directly with school staff but had no line management responsibilities. These policy officers had specific expertise in the areas of student wellbeing or inclusive education practices, they provided advice to principals and mentored school counsellors or learning support teachers. The policy officers had moved out of school-based roles into these advisory positions. At the time of the conversations, all informants had worked in their respective professional roles for more than two years, and for some, as many as fifteen years.

I met with five policy officers, Maria, Donna, Judith, Michelle, and David, and six senior managers, Sharon, Julie, Wendy, Joanne, Sandra, and John. Both Sandra and John had specific responsibilities for the supervision and mentoring of principals within their school cluster, which was a group of schools often based on geographical areas. Sandra and John met with their cluster groups at least once per term and with each individual principal as often as required. Prior to being promoted to senior managers, Sandra and John had been school principals for many years. The

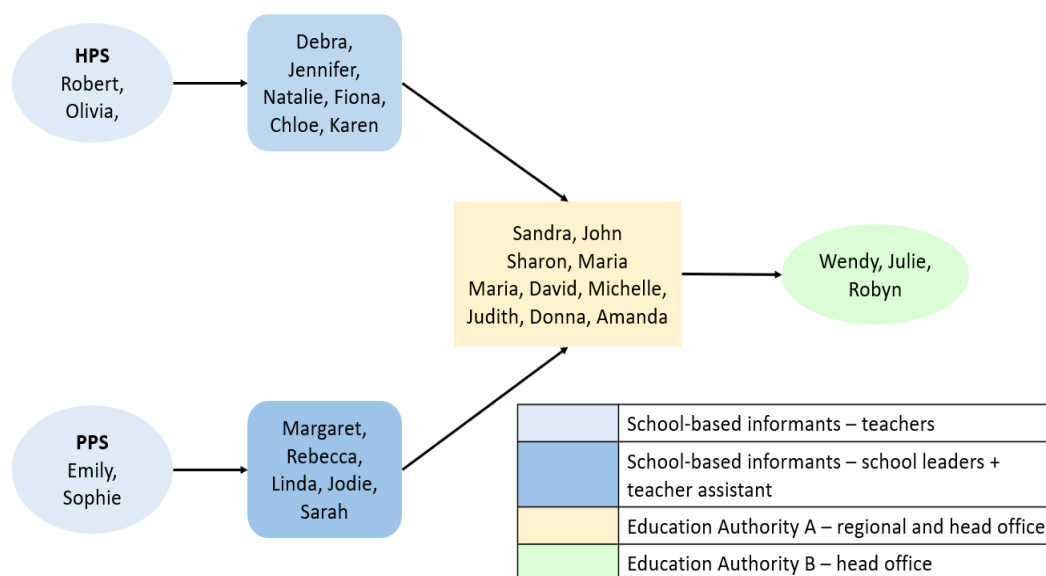
other four senior managers, Sharon, Julie, Wendy, and Joanne had specific responsibilities associated with policy development and implementation. While they worked closely with colleagues who were more connected to schools, their roles were removed from the everyday actualities of schooling.

Additionally, I met with three informants who were based in the head office with state-wide roles and responsibilities connected to the implementation of the NCCD. Robyn and Julie worked in the head office of Education Authority B. Their work was connected to Education Authority A through a collaborative state-wide rollout of professional learning about the NCCD in their respective education authorities. This was a deliberate partnership. How this was organised is discussed in Chapter Seven.

### **3.2.4 Summary of informants and research sites**

The snowball sampling approach produced a sequence of conversations with informants (Creswell, 2020; Smith, 2005). The informants were connected to each other, as shown in Figure 3.2 below, a visual representation of the network of informants. During my first conversation with each classroom teachers, they directed me to members of their respective school teams, who then introduced me to the informants from the Education Authority, who then nominated additional informants from the school authority. Once the conversations moved from the school sites to the Education Authority, it was noted that informants from both schools had identified many of the same informants.

**Figure 3.2** *Network of informants*



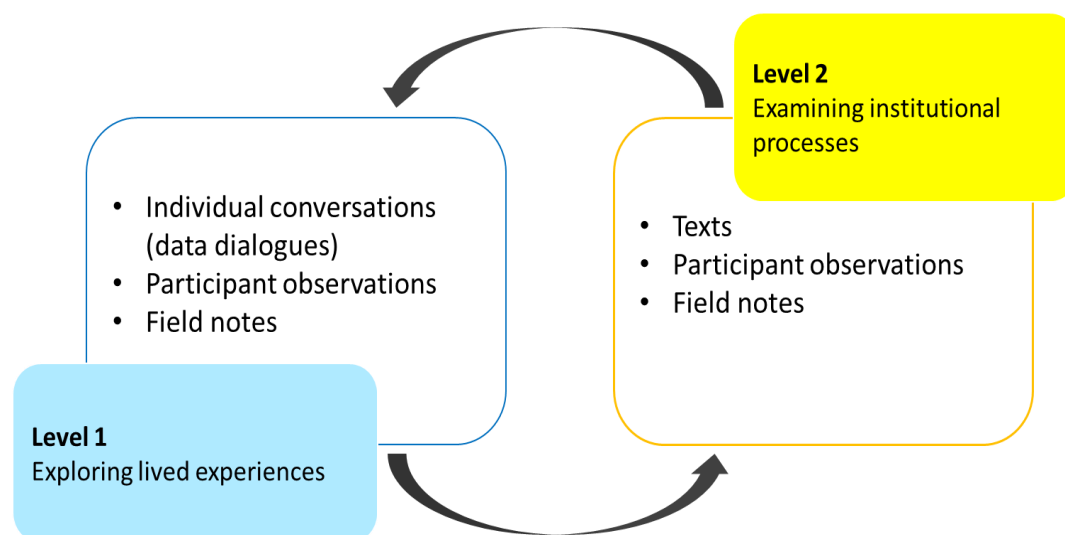
The entry point of this inquiry began with the classroom teachers. These initial entry-level conversations about people’s everyday experiences are explained in their local settings, which is where the analytic work begins (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). With each conversation, it is important to listen to details that describe how things are organised, to encourage the informant to share how knowledge is socially organised (Campbell, 2006). Understanding how the work of the NCCD came to each informant, what they did because of it and how the work of the NCCD moved to the next informant are the sequences of actions that underpin this inquiry. The details of these sequences of actions are discussed in the analysis chapters, Chapters Five, Six and Seven.

### 3.3 DATA COLLECTION

Campbell and Gregor (2004) explain there are two distinctive phases of an IE inquiry; first, learning about the lived everyday/everynight actualities of each informant; and second, mapping the operation of the ruling relations to explicate how it all works. These phases, while distinctive, are not necessarily sequential yet are

inextricably connected (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). The cyclical nature of these two phases is visually presented in Figure 3.3. Each phase has a distinctive focus, in phase one, this is the data dialogues and for phase two, it is the texts.

**Figure 3.3** *Data gathering in an institutional ethnographic inquiry*



The research cycle is designed to uncover the complexity of the informants' own lived experiences, before shifting attention to examining the institutional processes that shape and coordinate these experiences, however, these levels of data collection often occur concurrently and inform each other (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; DeVault, 2012). The researcher needs to move seamlessly across and between each level of the data collection, as it happens.

### 3.3.1 Data collection begins with conversations

Institutional ethnography is about understanding how things happen; the actions or practices that produce what gets done (Turner, 2001). This begins with conversations or *data dialogues* (Smith, 2005, p. 223) with informants talking about their day-to-day actions and the texts that inform their work. The challenge is to keep conversations grounded in the informant's everyday work, whilst avoiding generalisations, and uncovering the work that may be invisible to them (Dalmer,

2021). Smith (2005) describes that IE research is much more than an interview, and that there will inevitably be dialogues between the researcher and the informants, as well as between the researcher and the interview transcripts. With every conversation the researcher needs to be ready for the “detective work...to discover the missing organisational details of how the setting works” (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 60). During the conversations, informants share stories about their everyday activities and provide clues about how their actions are organised. Through their talk, informants discuss texts they use as part of their everyday actions. Beyond data dialogues, other forms of data collection include participant observation and the maintenance of the researcher’s field notes (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Diamond, 2006). The cyclical nature of the data collection presented in Figure 3.3 shows data collection is activated by a data dialogue but the movement between the levels is fluid.

### ***Data collection process***

Data from HPS were collected during several school visits. Specifically, an individual interview with each school-based informant, as well as an observation of a reflection and planning meeting about the NCCD with the school leadership team and an observation of a curriculum planning session with the year level team facilitated by the curriculum lead teacher. For PPS, data collection was similar; an initial conversation with each informant and a follow-up conversation eight to ten weeks later. At PPS, observations included a year level curriculum planning session facilitated by the curriculum lead teacher. Year level curriculum planning, in both schools, involved all teachers of the same year level meeting together to plan the learning program for the class; for example, the year three teachers met to plan the English program and learning sequences for the following term.



Through each conversation and observation, informants provided documents they used as part of their everyday NCCD work. After each conversation field notes were recorded, these notes included my observations of the conversation and notable remarks made during each conversation. These field notes also included drawing diagrams to visually represent what was heard (see Appendix B: Maps in progress). Importantly, conversations with supervisors, and reflexive practice included a frequent return to empirical data. That is, thinking and talking through mapping was always focussed on texts that were activated, and that coordinated action.

The school-based informants directed me to policy officers from the regional office who had worked with them. The initial interviews with policy officers occurred simultaneously to conversations with school-based informants. An additional conversation was held with some policy officers between twelve and twenty weeks after the first conversation. The first group of policy officers then directed me to senior policy officers and managers. Like the school-based information, conversations with the policy officers and senior managers were fluid and continued until saturation level was reached, whereby no new information or people were identified (Creswell, 2020; Pole & Morrison, 2003). The cycle of data gathering, conversations, gathering texts, participant observation and writing field notes, and ongoing analysis, was replicated in each location.

### *Conversations are interviews and data*

In an IE inquiry, conversations/interviews or data dialogues are the lynchpin of data collection yet tethered to texts. The dialogic dynamic produced in the exchange between informants and researcher collaboratively produces knowledge that is shaped by, and to, the conversation (Smith, 2005). Conversations guide the inquiry, building knowledge of the problematic through understanding the social organisation

of people across locations to produce and maintain institutional processes (Griffith, 1998; McCoy, 2006). The challenge is to keep the institutional processes in view, particularly when there is a lot of data to consider.

Having insider knowledge can assist with preparation for these conversations, it can also make maintaining the analytic intent challenging. The researcher is not assessing the accuracy of the informant's account, they are seeking to identify how things happen, and to recognise disjunctures between the lived actualities and official accounts (Rankin, 2017a; Smith, 2005). As part of her fieldwork involving nurses in situ, Bisaillon developed a scaffold to avoid “researcher drift into conceptual or ideological talk during interviews” (Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012, p. 23). This scaffold, presented in Table 3.1 below, details the purpose and focus of the conversation in terms of both analytic concept and analytic intent. The italicised words in each of the columns are notable actions to keep in the forefront, to avoid researcher drift, during the conversation. In preparing for each conversation, the scaffold was annotated, and kept as field notes which contributed to analysis of the data.

**Table 3.1** *Characteristics of interviews using institutional ethnography*

| Analytic concept                                                                                                                                                                              | Analytic intent                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Inquire</i> from a perspective rooted in the activities of standpoint informants. This position is maintained throughout the inquiry that explicates how organisations work.               | <i>Learn</i> about the issues, tensions, and contradictions that people experience in their lives (problematic).                                 |
| <i>Examine</i> work practices and processes in organisational and bureaucratic setting in such a way that the researcher “think[s] organisationally” (Smith in DeVault & McCoy, 2004, p.758). | <i>Orient</i> towards features of social life that link standpoint informant activities to activities occurring more broadly (social relations). |

*Investigate* the material, empirically observable events of people's lives.

*Listen* to people's "stories" of what practices and activities they engage in (Diamond in DeVault and McCoy, 2004, p. 756).

*Uncover* the research problematic over time through the researcher's immersion in the field.

*Be* attentive to how informants describe the events of their lives. Listen for how people use institutional language and official or authoritative reasoning to explain events. People's accounts might actually be dissonant from what they experience and know.

*Study* features operating across multiple sites and explore how these are connected through circulating texts and documents.

*Find* out about how texts organise what informants say and do (discursive organisation).

*Focus* on how an informant's social location informs her/his knowing and consider what the person can say from this position.

*Develop* understandings about how institutions function because this provides about social organisation and power or ruling relations.

*Cultivate* understandings about the organisation of institutional places from informants and texts. Researcher follows up on analytic clues of thread gathered in one interview or observational setting to the other.

*Acquire* understandings about how people use texts. Informants talk about people's work practices, and the researcher prepares to dialogue with and/or observe extra-local informants in later stages of fieldwork.

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(Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012, p. 24)

A semi-structured interview schedule was used to minimise the potential influence of insider work knowledge because familiarity with the institutional discourse may influence the evolving conversation (DeVault & McCoy, 2006; Griffith, 1998; Smith, 2005). The interview schedule assisted with staying focused on understanding institutional processes through the informant's everyday actions to "get a clear

account of how things go together to make up what the informant might consider standard practice” (Campbell & Gregor, 2004, p. 77). Drawing on a semi-structured conversation/interview schedule developed by Ng et al. (2013) a prototype to stimulate conversation ideas about the work, whilst maintaining the analytic intent was developed (see Appendix C: Semi-structured interview scaffold). This schedule guided the conversation and kept in-check preconceptions that could have inadvertently influenced the flow of the conversation (Creswell, 2020; Hatton & Smith, 1995; Pole & Morrison, 2003; Smith, 2005). The schedule was used with annotations that built on previous conversations and provided important ideas to explore with subsequent informants.

The schedule was also important in helping me to avoid *institutional capture* (Smith, 2005, p. 156), when informants’ language was subsumed by conceptual practices and institutional discourse, and everyday doings and experiences were hard to reach. My professional knowledge and experience made me aware of how easily I could fall into the use of abstracted language and institutional talk. As Nilsen (2021) suggests, one way of drawing people away from the conceptual practices of power is to ask “stupid questions”(p. 368). The questions posed by Nilsen (2021) are strikingly similar to the questions I posed when talking with people in my research: “What does that mean? Can you explain how that works? Can you show me? What do you think about it? and so on” (p. 368). A keen awareness of the need to get behind institutional language during the interviews was important in gathering data that kept people and the institution in view.

Subsequent interviews were heavily shaped by what was discussed in the initial interviews with teachers. Identifying sequences of textually mediated action meant that the focus in interviews was on following empirical chains of textually mediated

action. For example, in the teacher interviews (see Chapter Six), it was apparent that professional learning delivered by school leaders was an important activity that authorised teacher actions. For this reason, I subsequently talked with those leaders who developed and delivered the professional learning about how the texts used to create the professional development were generated (see Chapter Five). Here I heard school leaders talk about the demands from education authorities to deliver information to teachers, after which I talked with people in the Education Authority about how these demands were generated. The process of *indexing* (Rankin, 2017b, p. 7) (see section 3.4.2), and mapping were key in ensuring interviews followed textually authorised action and slowly abolished a picture of conceptual practices of power.

### *Texts as data*

Texts carry messages. Texts take many forms, they are official and unofficial documents that communicate messages through reports, infographics, digital technologies, emails, notes, templates, diagrams, and conversations (Small et al., 2021; Smith, 2005). Unique to IE, texts are used to explore the complex and varied social relations that are revealed through *act-text-act sequences* (Smith, 2005, p. 67), specifically how texts enter into, organise and coordinate people's everyday/everynight activities (Smith, 1999; Smith & Turner, 2014). Texts can be an outcome of a course of action, but also produce actions as seen in Figure 3.4, they are part of an ongoing activity.

**Figure 3.4** *Textual sequence*



(Smith, 2005, p. 67).

In an IE inquiry, texts are not analysed in abstraction, but rather how texts frame what gets done and how it happens, what is organised because of texts (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; DeVault, 2006; Smith, 2005). As informants describe their daily happenings texts are identified, as well as textual connections and their capacity to organise (D. E. Smith, 1990b). Some texts have more authority than others, and in some instances can be understood as a *boss text* (DeVault et al., 2014, p. 177), which carries institutional discourses or ideological codes. Smith (1993) describes an ideological code as “a schema that replicates its organization in multiple and various sites...[to] generate the same order in widely different settings or talk or writing – legislative, social, scientific, popular writing, administrative, television advertising and whatever” (pp. 51-52). These texts carry authority in that they have the power to discursively construct institutional facts that sanction specific actions (DeVault et al., 2014). An IE inquiry seeks to reveal and understand how texts mediate the everyday.

Texts were collected during and after conversations. As informants talked about their work, they either produced texts they were using as they talked about it, located the text shortly afterwards, and some in instances texts were received as part of follow up email communications initiated by informants, as they thought the documents might be useful. The email exchange with the informant provided additional information about how specific documents are used in their work and the value placed on them (only useful documents were emailed). Texts shown at the time of the conversation were mostly printed versions of documents stored on the school intranet or on personal computers. Other types of texts included formal and informal email communications, large wall size posters with student data, testing results of

online assessments, curriculum planning templates and a vast array of student record-keeping documents.

### *Participant observations and field notes*

Other data collection included participant observations and field notes.

Participant observations provide the opportunity “to be where things are happening...to notice, and then describe in field notes, what people (including the researcher) are doing, and where and with what they are doing it” (McCoy, 2021, p. 42). A protocol of participant observations and field notes established by Diamond (2006) was used to record observations, which included noting personal reflections as soon as possible after each conversation or observation. Diamond’s (2006) narrative style lends itself to detailed descriptions of what people are doing and the context.

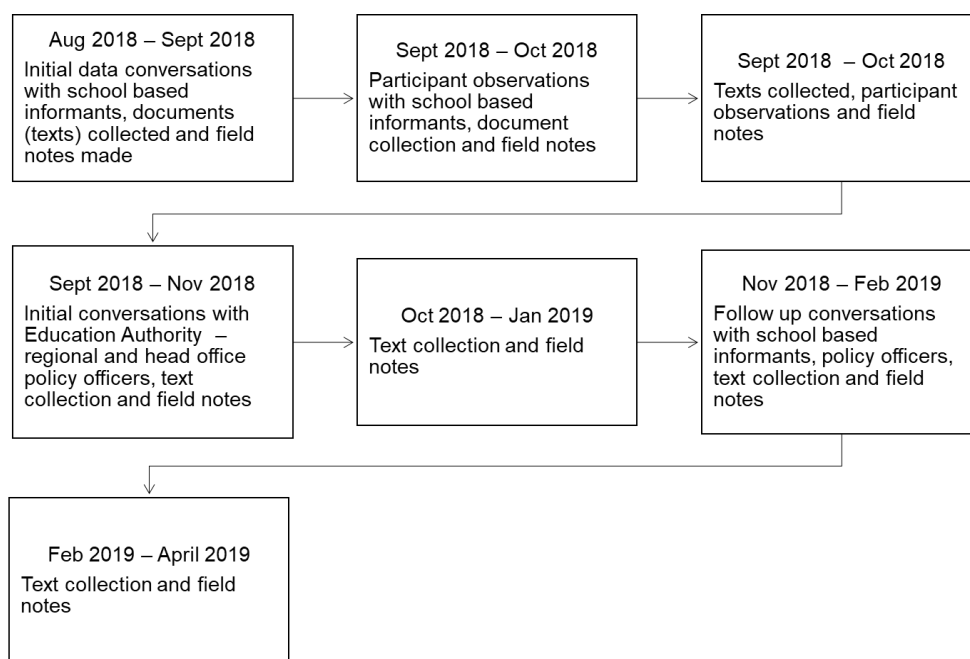
The participant observations included school meetings in which NCCD procedures were discussed, professional development sessions and curriculum planning sessions. After each conversation, I made reflection notes of what I observed and heard. These notes were either made before leaving the site of the meeting, or shortly afterwards. These protocols for field notes were applied consistently throughout the data collection. By recording reflections in real time, data analysis begins as it happens, as the data sets are collected (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). Included in the field notes, were ideas to explore at the next conversation, and reflections of how people’s everyday actions occur translocally or across other sites, actions noticed in more than one location.

### **3.3.2 Summary of data collection process**

The beginning or entry point for this inquiry was the conversations with the classroom teachers and progressed using snowball sampling until a saturation level

was reached (Kerr, 2015). While Figure 3.5 represents data collection as a linear process, this was not the case, it was complex, shaped by conversations (data dialogues) and texts, supported by participant observations and field notes. Data collection occurs concurrent to data analysis.

**Figure 3.5** *Summary of data collection process*



The visual map presented in Figure 3.5 shows the fluidity of the data collection process, moving between informants, curating artefacts, participant observations and maintaining field notes to better understand how their work happened.

### 3.4 ANALYSIS

To make the institutional organisation visible, the IE researcher needs to be attuned to the minutiae of the everyday while keeping an eye to the bigger picture (Pence, 2021). An institutional ethnographer (IEer) is required to search for, describe, and come to an understanding of the connections between experiences across institutional sites to reveal the social organisation (Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012; DeVault & McCoy, 2006). Moreover, people's daily actions may be organised in ways that they may not even be aware of, or even, without their conscious



knowledge (Deveau, 2009). The analytic process means the researcher makes connections between actions, and time and place to map out how things happen.

Despite being “fundamentally an analytic project...[IE] researchers tend not to use formal analytic strategies such as interpretative coding” to analyse the data (DeVault & McCoy, 2002, p. 768). Instead, the researcher must trace how texts are activated and how people’s actions are coordinated or mediated by the text to understand how knowledge is socially organised, in other words, the social relations (Pence, 2001). Institutional ethnographic analyses maps texts that are activated so as to explicate ruling relations.

In this inquiry, data analysed were the accounts of those working to implement the NCCD policy, this encompassed the texts they produced, responded to and used, and their everyday activities to reveal the social relations of the practical application of a complex policy assemblage (Ball et al., 2012; Griffith & Smith, 2014b; Singh et al., 2014). While other ethnographic approaches would treat this data as the object of interest, an IE inquiry uses this data to understand the social relations, the data is not the object of the inquiry (Campbell, 1998). These data are used to discover how people’s actions are similarly organised across multiple sites, to reveal the connections between, and coordination of processes and activities (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Kerr, 2015; Smith, 2005).

### **3.4.1 Conversations and texts**

All conversations (or data dialogues, as Smith (2005) describes) were audio recorded and later personally transcribed, this allowed for active analysis from the outset. As the conversations were transcribed, talk of specific official and unofficial texts that were mentioned by more than one informant was noted for further investigation (Turner, 2001). A first step in analysis was to discover which texts were

used by people in their everyday work. It was important to be mindful that it was not always the first text identified that carried the most authority or were ultimately the most powerful (Bisaillon & Rankin, 2012; Turner, 2001).

Dominant texts or boss texts have the capacity to initiate people's doings and are often connected to other texts, however, it is what gets attended to or ignored that frames what institutional practices are produced and textually maintained (Kerr, 2015; Smith, 2005; Smith, 2014). A boss text can be an official or unofficial text and take a variety of textual forms, such as a procedure, a report, or a variety of digital formats. Part of the analytic work was, therefore, to keep all potential texts and work in view, before beginning to put together an analysis of how these texts worked together to form the relations of rule.

### **3.4.2 Mapping the social**

Data analysis is iterative and begins even before transcriptions of the conversations, as the researcher makes field notes and reflects on what has been observed. Analysis continues throughout the transcription process, with annotations highlighting documents or repeated ideas and the like, as well as notations of how the informant talked about key documents, their experiences and actions undertaken because of, or to produce texts. In other words, how these texts seemed to be organising the informant's everyday work of the NCCD.

During transcription analytic notes were recorded about prosody of speech – rhythm, tone, intonation. This approach to analysis follows the work of Ochs (1979) who argues that the actual labour of transcription is central to the analytic process. Once the transcription was completed, the transcripts, field notes, analytic notes and annotated documents were organised into electronic tables using the processes of indexing (Rankin, 2017b). Insight into how people's actions are coordinated by texts,

or textually mediated actions, is obtained through how informants describe the texts they use (Kerr, 2015; Smith, 2005). D. E. Smith (1990b) describes this as investigating texts in motion, where a key goal is to track the sequences of action associated with the text. Smith (cited by DeVault and McCoy, 2006) proposed indexing as a means of organising data (p. 39). Rankin (2017b) writes that:

the practice of indexing is a way to discover linked practices going on in society. It is a strategy that can be used to stay grounded in IE's core materiality as opposed to developing themes and categories that are abstracted from the data and that leave the particularities behind. Indexing is a tool that can be used to cross-reference across work processes, people, and settings. It is a useful strategy to begin the preliminary work with the data (p. 6).

The tables created during this process included relevant demographic data, such as school, year level, as well as a column that listed the NCCD work identified by each informant, such as creating templates to record educational adjustments and creating records of evidence for these adjustments. The tables had a column to record key documents that were used or discussed by informants. These were also annotated to indicate whether the document was provided as part of the data set at the time of the conversation, received by email from the informant or located on a public website. Other annotations included how the text was produced and the text flow, where it went once the informant had completed their work, as well as identifying if there were any intersections of texts (Ng et al., 2013). Tracing sequences of actions, alongside the analytic notes, field notes, and annotations provide a descriptive adjunct to the transcriptions and collated texts.

A further analytic task was to map how texts coordinated other texts, so as to explicate the “inter-textual hierarchy” (Smith, 2005, p. 186). A text’s position in a textual hierarchy is not attributed to whether the text was official or unofficial, but rather, by considering how it was activated and used to organise activity. This analytic work revealed the authority or power of the text to coordinate and replicate a course of action translocally.

A line of fault or disjuncture refers to when “one’s experiential knowledge bumps up against the textual realities that are meant to manage it” (Nichols & Griffith, 2009, p. 244). The disjuncture identifies the artificial realities of institutional textual practices and the actualities of the informants’ work as mediated by texts and the ruling relations (Collins, 1992; DeVault & McCoy, 2006; Kerr, 2015; Smith, 2005). Through creating visual representations of the everyday actions of people, and the texts that mediated their everyday work, it was possible to explicate ruling relations and the operation of textual power (Collins, 1992; DeVault & McCoy, 2006; Smith, 2005). The visual representation or social cartography often resembles a subway map with nodes and interchanges, brings clarity and understanding of the interactions and sequences of action (Pence, 2001; Smith, 2005; Turner, 2006). Mapping these interactions and intersections enables the researcher to stand back and create an empirically rigorous analysis of how things happen.

The outcome of mapping interactions and intersections into a visual representation, means “rather than theory building: the analysis is...usable, in the way that a map can be used” (DeVault, 2006, p. 294). The map informs an understanding about how ruling relations organise work, as shown by Turner (2001) who mapped the use, and creation of texts in real time to make visible the disjuncture between the lived experience and official accounts. By mapping how knowledge is

organised and how texts are activated it becomes apparent which texts have authority to maintain institutional practices (Kerr, 2015). Once texts are identified, understanding how they are activated to maintain institutional order is the next analytic step.

### *Accountability circuits*

An accountability circuit captures what people actually do, and how this is made institutionally accountable, through measures such as reports or specific procedures that may include the collection of data or record-keeping (Smith, 2005). Sequences of text and action within an accountability circuit direct actions to both those working at the frontline and their managers to make compliance visible (DeVault, 2021). Texts are activated through act-text-act sequences that produce accountability circuits that are designed to maintain institutional order (Smith, 2005). Kerr (2015) poses three analytic questions to trace the act-text-act sequence:

- Who activates the text?
- What actions are required?
- What happens next?

Recording responses to these questions revealed the work of the NCCD, and the associated accountability circuits of the work. The accountability circuits revealed how people's actions were brought into alignment with institutional goals and expectations, but also disclosed contradictions with people's own experiences to expose the disjuncture or fault line (Kerr, 2015; Smith, 2005). As the informants talked about the texts they used, asking probing questions (see Appendix C: Semi-structured interview scaffold) revealed the textual sequences. In undertaking textual analysis, including explicating textual chains, I was cognisant of the importance of attending to my own positions as researcher. Murray (2022) suggests attending to

“reader interpretation. Both the researcher as a reader, and the specific users of texts under analysis, need to be taken seriously as active readers of texts, reading differently depending on who they are and where they are situated” (p. 55). Issues of researcher reflexivity are described below and in section 3.3.1.

### **3.5 ETHICS**

As with any research that is predicated on conversations or interviews as sources of data, asymmetries of power must be considered (Creswell, 2020; Pole & Morrison, 2003). Therefore, transparency throughout the data collection process was paramount to minimise any potential power asymmetry between the informants and myself as researcher. At the time of commencing this research project, I was on study leave from a senior policy officer role in an Education Authority where I had responsibilities for managing regional programs for students with disability. Except for the principals, the school-based staff were unknown to me and some of the informants from the regional office had been colleagues. I did not experience a direct conflict of interest with any of the informants, as I had no authority over their work, or decision-making capacity in relation to their employment. However, it was imperative that informants had confidence in the integrity of the research and be guaranteed confidentiality of their involvement. Plans were made to address any perceived conflict of interest and all informants were advised of the procedure during the participant consent process, and at any time informants could withdraw from the project. Confidential options were provided should anyone need to raise concerns about my conduct in the research project.

Researcher reflexivity was also a crucial element of the ethical research design. As described above in section 2.3.1, there are affordances associated with being something of an insider to research. Rankin (2017b) suggests that it is appropriate to

“follow your hunches and to begin to formulate problematic(s) that lead to discoveries” (p. 8). However, she also notes that insider knowledge and hunches must still be framed by a focus on using empirical evidence to map how ruling relations are organised and coordinated. The process of indexing is a way of connecting work activities as “a way to organise one’s data around empirical happenings” (Rankin, 2017b, p. 6). Talking with my supervisory team about data and indexing was an important strategy to ensure ethical research that followed the empirical evidence collected.

As part of the informed consent process, all informants were informed of the inquiry process, which included the anticipated time demands. By explaining the process, informants were told that in an IE inquiry it is not a researcher’s role to assess the accuracy of their accounts of what they do, as they are experts of their own lives, but rather to explore their lived experiences which may require focusing on specific points during the conversation to clarify the details (Smith, 2005). There was full disclosure of the data gathering process; conversations would be digitally recorded, and that I would be making intermittent notes throughout the conversation, and the collection of documents that they were willing to share.

Ethics approvals from the Queensland University of Technology (QUT) and the Education Authority were sought and obtained prior to commencing the research. The research complied with the requirements set out by QUT and was granted ethical approval through a Human Research Ethics Application process (Ethics approval number: 1800000564) (see Appendix D: Ethics approval certificate). As described above, gatekeeper clearance was provided by the Education Authority, to approach principals of each school, through an additional ethics approval process (Ethics approval number: 334). Details of these approvals were included in the initial email

to the principal (see section 3.2). This research was deemed to be low risk to informants, with the most foreseeable risk likely to be discomfort (Australian National Health and Medical Research Council (NHMRC), 2018). I remained cognisant of the values and guidelines set out in the *National Statement of Ethical Conduct in Human Research* (NHMRC, 2018), and upheld the four principles of: research merit and integrity; justice; beneficence and respect. With every episode of data collection, informants were reminded participation was voluntary, they could withdraw at any time, and this would not jeopardise their professional standing or employment. Additionally, it was reiterated that confidentiality would be maintained in relation to all conversations and documents provided. Informant were reminded that should they require counselling, as result of their participation, this was freely available through the university.

All data is de-identified; the names of informants, references to staff members, students, locations, or actions that could possibly alert the reader to their identity is replaced with a pseudonym. The decision to use generic nomenclature for the Education Authority was intentional and designed to protect both individual and institutional reputations. All data is securely stored as per QUT requirements, including artefacts collected, and transcriptions of conversations.

### **3.6 CONCLUSION**

This chapter provides an outline of the method of inquiry undertaken for this research project commencing with recruitment of informants and data analysis. The final sections of this chapter discuss the ethics application and the limitations of the project. In addition to outlining the inquiry method, fundamental concepts of IE were discussed through the analysis section, in terms of their practical application (see section 3.4). The data analysis of an IE inquiry seeks to be usable; to contribute to a



deeper understanding of the work of those implementing the NCCD to reveal how translocal doings are coordinated by institutional texts (DeVault, 2006; Kerr, 2015; Nichols & Griffith, 2009). The analytic devices employed throughout the data analysis are explained in detail. The literature review is presented in the next chapter.

# Chapter 4: Literature Review

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## 4.1 INTRODUCTION

In assembling this chapter, it became evident that very little has been written in the scholarly literature on the NCCD funding model, and the work of educators in schools and in policy roles. So, this literature review provides a sense of how and why the NCCD was proposed; and how it fits within disability and funding scholarship.

The NCCD model reflects complex intersections of Australian schooling history for students with disability and social values (Liasidou, 2015), and political messages and government and governance (Ball & Junemann, 2011; Singh et al., 2014). This literature review delves into how these intersections operate to organise the work of those at the frontline of this policy implementation. The chapter commences with a discussion of the sociology of disability, and then presents a brief history of schooling in Australia. The policies and legislative frameworks connected to the NCCD are analysed, followed by an explanation of the NCCD model. A descriptive account of the national and international legislation, policies and agreements that are pertinent to the development of NCCD is available in Appendix E: NCCD Legislative and policy landscape. This leads to the final section, understanding some of the work that is part of the NCCD.

## 4.2 A SOCIOLOGY OF DISABILITY

Government policies are value-laden and are an aggregation of people's experiences over time, with values reflected in the language used (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). Returning to that moment in the lecture theatre, an undergraduate psychology course; this is where I truly realised how disability is framed in official discourse (as

portrayed by my lecturer), and how different this was to my own embodied life experiences. I also realised that the words used in the lecture were like the framing of government policy and would likely be used to inform beliefs and expectations about disability for my peers. These undergraduate students were future employers, employees, parents, and colleagues, and there was no way of knowing to what extent the account offered on that day (after all it was in a textbook and the lecturer was talking about it), was accepted and internalised as authoritative knowledge. Had this authoritative knowledge become *facts* (Oliver, 1990, p. 81)? Would these facts inform the values and beliefs of future professionals, or were some similarly challenged by what they had heard?

In this section, I examine the sociology of disability to explore “hidden assumptions and ideologies...so deeply embedded...they become facts” (Oliver, 1990, p. 81). These facts are a window into contemporary social values, as the language of facts typically become the official disability discourse (Florian & McLaughlin, 2008; S. Tomlinson, 2017; Walton, 2015). Social policies about disability are typically laden with dominant discourses and social constructs that are shaped by historical, institutional, and organisational contexts, as well as emotional dimensions that involve expectations about an idealised person (Allan, 2010; Oliver, 1990). For example, an idealised person is rarely someone with reduced mobility or someone who uses a white cane due to low vision (Oliver, 1990). People’s expectations about disability are reflected in their talk and the language used to describe a person living with disability.

Values and beliefs are contextually situated social constructs that shape public discourse and education policies, especially programs designed to address the educational needs of students with disability (Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016; Ehrich et al.,

2011; Florian, 2008; Walton, 2015). Social constructs that are interwoven throughout history, include classification systems used to categorise students and identify additional educational provisions made (Florian & McLaughlin, 2008; Liasidou, 2015; Walton, 2015). Historical conceptualisations of disability are reflected in what people say, the social practices of how people with disability are treated and what becomes enshrined in policy. The following section examines how concepts of disability have emerged over time.

#### **4.2.1 Disability conceptions over time**

The history of disability is a complex and long story that should be considered alongside contemporary policies and social practices (S. Tomlinson, 2017). Disability discourses reflect “deep power structures and inferences about the status of people with disabilities in society” (Yuill et al., 2010, p. 15). Moore and Slee (2020) offer a thematic summary of dominant disability discourses (see Table 4.1) and suggest these discourses are not linear, meaning that you do not move from one paradigm to the next in an orderly way, and some can occur concurrently. In other words, they are not neatly chronological. The summary provides an explanation of disability discourse, and a corresponding social response. For example, the disability discourse of fear and loathing, meant people with disability were perceived as defective which led to ridicule of the individual or even genocide. These discourses, for the most part, render people with disability as passive and powerless, with the exception of the human rights approach (Yuill et al., 2010). These discourses have shaped how disability is conceptualised.

To better understand how disability is discursively constructed within the scholarly literature these broad models of disability are often used as a reference point as they reflect how society views people with disability. Education policy and

practice is shaped by these discourses and can be seen as an exercise of power. When key stakeholders (such as politicians and senior education bureaucrats) subscribe to particular world views and norms, these form the basis of policies they seek to implement. Numerous models have been put forward to explain how disability has been understood; and how governments have strategized to manage people with disability. For instance, early religious views saw disability as an act of God or karma inflicted on a person and their family or community as penance for sin. This is broadly known as the religious or moral model of disability. However there have been dominant models of disability that remain relevant to contemporary Australian education: the medical and social (human rights) models. The key tenets of these models are provided in Table 4.1 (see below).

**Table 4.1** *Summary of disability discourses*

| Disability discourse | Explanation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Responses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fear and loathing    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Disability is seen as an abhorrent defect. Impairments are often explained in religious terms, as God's punishment for the sins of the parents. Disabled people are accordingly characterised as representing danger.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Genocide.</li> <li>Eugenics.</li> <li>Institutionalisation.</li> <li>Segregation.</li> <li>Ridicule.</li> <li>Ignorance.</li> <li>Isolation and hiding.</li> </ul>                                                               |
| Pity and charity     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Disability is perceived as a personal tragedy and disabled people are seen as being in need of charity.</li> </ul>                                                                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Institutionalisation.</li> <li>Begging as an acceptable social role.</li> <li>Expectation of individual heroism to overcome impairments.</li> <li>Segregated schooling.</li> <li>Sheltered workshops.</li> <li>Shame.</li> </ul> |
| Medical              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Disability is seen as a consequence of defective or disordered individual</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>There is a requirement for expert diagnosis, intervention and</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                         |

|                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                | pathology. This results from genetic disorder, accident or disease.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | treatment with a view to cure, rehabilitation or normalisation.                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| [Human] Rights | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Disability is a measure of the barriers generated from the social response. In other words, disability is the burden people must carry, the barriers they will encounter because of society's inability to deal with difference. This is the social model of disability (Oliver 1990).</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Changes to architectural, legislative, political, economic, social and cultural structures and relations of society in order to enable people to assume their rights of citizenship and participation.</li> </ul> |

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(Moore & Slee, 2020, p. 268)

Australian legislation and educational policy are couched in the human rights discourse, yet actions, attitudes, values, and beliefs are not always reflective of a human rights approach.

#### 4.2.2 Sociological models of disability

The dominant disability discourses in education are associated with the medical model and the social model (human rights) of disability. The medical model represents disability as the result of biological flaws within the individuals with disability that require medical treatment or rehabilitation. In educational contexts, taking this approach would be adopting the view that autistic students should attend specialist schools that are developed to treat and rehabilitate specific characteristics associated with a diagnosis because autistic students are not able to fit in to a regular classroom. For this reason, the medical model is often aligned with special education (Haegele & Hodge, 2016; S. Tomlinson, 2017; van Kraayenoord, 2006). These views are critiqued as being ableist as they create barriers and institutional forms of discrimination that reinforce false facts about disability (Oliver & Barnes, 2012; Thomas, 2004), using deficit discourses to stigmatise and skew how an individual is

perceived (Haegele & Hodge, 2016; Slee, 2011; S. Tomlinson, 2017). Many education systems maintain segregated education in the form of specialist schools for students with disability.

An alternative construction to the medical model is a human rights approach to disability (the social model) which considers disability to be a social construct and people are disabled because of inadequate responses to difference (Jenkinson, 1996; Oliver, 1990; Thomas, 2004). The social model introduced nearly fifty years ago, by Mike Oliver and fellow disability rights activists, Vic Finkelstein and Paul Hunt, rejected the medical model and associated notions of disability as a personal tragedy to be overcome and proposed an alternative way to conceptualise disability within a rights based framework (Humpage, 2007; Oliver, 2013; Thomas, 2004). A core principle of the social model is that disability is a consequence of ableist attitudes and social structures which create barriers to access and participation in everyday life which could be minimised if a person-centred approach was adopted (Connors & Stalker, 2006; Oliver, 2013). Taking a person-centred approach means viewing disability as being a consequence of barriers created in the social environment and therefore, the source of disability (Shakespeare & Watson, 2001; Thomas, 2004). Proponents of the social model consider societal attitudes about disability to be a source of oppression and discrimination, rendering the disability.

Scholars debate the merits and limitations of the social model. One of the main criticisms of the social model is that it does not adequately consider peoples' unique circumstances, and that it assumes disability is always the consequence of ableism (Owens, 2015). In other words, some of the barriers people with disability experience cannot be attributed to a social attitude but instead to their own specific condition which is not a social construct. For example, a deaf person not hearing a

platform change at a busy metropolitan railway station is not because of ableist attitudes but a consequence of their hearing loss (Owens, 2015; Shakespeare & Watson, 2001). People experience disability in unique ways that cannot always be causally linked to the environment, as outlined in the social model. The social relational model offers an alternative to the social model, by acknowledging people can experience disability regardless of the environment (Reindal, 2008; Thomas, 2004). The social relational model does not accept that disability is always the result of inadequacies found in the social setting.

Educational policies for students with disability, like the NCCD, are tethered to these models of disability. For example, the policy of inclusive education, where all students attend school together (as opposed to specialist schools for students with disability), occurred as education departments sought to move away from a medical model. The trajectory of inclusive education policy and schooling in Australia is further outlined in the sections that follow. However, an important conceptual point is that in practice there are often policy contradictions (Moore & Slee, 2020). For example, education departments can have an inclusive education policy yet continue to tacitly support and maintain segregated educational programs for students with disability that are entrenched in the medical model of disability. Tensions exist between policy and actions, this is a reminder that the values and beliefs that underpin social and institutional practices are not always synchronised with policy (Mavropoulou et al., 2021). The dominant disability discourses have evolved over time, in a non-linear way, as evidenced in policy contradictions and people's actions. This next section argues that schooling in Australia, especially educational provision for students with disability reflects the relationships between sociological models of disability and education policy.



### 4.3 SCHOOLING FOR CHILDREN WITH DISABILITY IN AUSTRALIA

This brief historical account of Australian schooling is based on western perspectives and does not talk to the long-standing education traditions of First Nations Australians. While examples are mostly drawn from Queensland, the context of the inquiry, Riddell et al. (2016) assert that disability discourses and themes relating to education for students with disability are mirrored throughout western countries, despite differences in culture, local contexts, and histories. Understanding this journey to education for children with disability provides some insights into why educational reform for students with disability was necessary (Forlin et al., 2013; Moss, 2003). The launch of the inaugural national NCCD policy was a significant education reform, which is contextualised by historical educational provision for students with disability.

In 1901, six former self-governing British colonies united to form the Commonwealth of Australia, to become a federated nation. The constitution of this new nation gave responsibility for primary schooling to the newly established state and territory governments, as it had been when they were British colonies (Barcan, 1980). In Queensland, at the time of federation, state funded education was not available for children who were considered *backward* or *mentally retarded* (also labelled as *imbeciles*, *feeble minded*, weak minded), *deaf-dumb*, *blind* or *crippled* (Barcan, 1980; Queensland Department of Education, 2019a). People with disability were feared and loathed (see Table 4.1), these negative attitudes isolated children and prevented them from attending school and participating in society. Yet, also in 1901, the Queensland Blind, Deaf and Dumb Institution, a charity, appointed a head teacher to run the residential school program for deaf or blind children (Queensland

Department of Education, 2019a). The institution was located on the outskirts of Brisbane, near a prison. This physical location is a reminder of how people with disability were not valued by society, nevertheless this move to appoint a teacher represented something of a conceptual shift as some children with disability were now able to have an education.

Through the early part of the twentieth century schooling for most Queensland children was transformed with an expanded curriculum (e.g., vocational studies was included in 1907), minimal learning outcomes were established for every year level and secondary education was added raising the school leaving age from 12 to 14 years of age (Queensland Department of Education, 2019a). This contrasted with educational options for children with disability, only deaf or blind children were allowed to attend school at the residential facility, for which the state had no responsibility. By 1924, education was made compulsory for deaf children, yet it was not until 1931 that the state assumed responsibility for the program (Queensland Department of Education, 2019a). Segregated education was available for children with specific medical conditions (i.e., deaf, blind) in line with a medical view of disability.

Through the mid-twentieth century children deemed educable were provided state funded schooling, whereas ineducable or backward children were under the care of the Department of Health (Forlin, 2006; Loreman et al., 2005; Queensland Department of Education, 2019a). Children were placed into specialist medical facilities, administered by charities, where medical staff developed treatment plans that matched specific diagnoses (Slee, 2011; S. Tomlinson, 2017). Meanwhile, students without disability had their school leaving age raised to 15 years and were provided with new syllabuses in primary and secondary schools, and remote learning

was offered to geographically isolated children (Queensland Department of Education, 2019a). Flexible and innovative solutions were offered to ensure access and meet the learning needs of many students, but not students with disability. Schooling for children with disability remained segregated, often in residential facilities, reflecting a medical model.

In 1984, the Queensland Department of Education agreed to take responsibility for educating all school-age children, activating a gradual deconstruction of long-established arrangements with charities that were providing education for students with disability (Swan, 1988). In 1986, the Queensland Government took over the administration of special education schools and finally in 1988 all residential educational facilities were closed (Queensland Department of Education, 2019a; Swan, 1988). Schooling for students with disability was in transition. Students moved from special schools and residential facilities to segregated classes located in primary or secondary schools and others to special schools that were closer to their homes. However, a categorical approach to school placement, which was based on the type of disability continued.

Since the 1980s, spurred on by the International Year of Disabled People in 1981, disability activists and scholars challenged ideas that pathologized individuals, where they were positioned as defective or disordered. Instead, advocacy for the recognition of individual rights was evolving (Barnes, 2020; Forlin, 2006; Shakespeare & Watson, 2001). By now, special education was also under scrutiny, particularly the efficacy of using a diagnosis to determine educational options (Cologon, 2013; Lyons & Cassebohm, 2012; Norwich, 2008). The slow movement towards inclusive education had begun. An inclusive school is the local school, where children with disability learn alongside their peers, where diversity and

difference are expected and accepted, this requires barriers to access and participation in all aspects of school life to be removed (Florian, 2014; Harpur, 2012). Yet, presently, schooling options for students with disability are confusing, special education programs (that are primarily predicated on a medical model of disability), and inclusive education programs (that operate using the social model of disability) are contradictory but do co-exist. Scholars, such as Saggars and Carrington (2021), Mills et al. (2017) and Moore and Slee (2020), argue inclusive education is a measure of educational equity, a concept that dominates contemporary educational policies, yet practices are not that clear cut. It was in this context, of a changing philosophy about the educational provision for students with disability, that the NCCD came into being in 2016.

#### **4.4 AUSTRALIAN SCHOOL FUNDING POLICY**

The Australian Government has no responsibility for schooling yet maintains fiscal authority due to complex constitutional arrangements whereby state and territory governments administer school education; therefore, funding is used as a lever for educational reforms such as the NCCD (Keating & Klatt, 2013; Kenway, 2013; Lingard, 2000). This division between the two levels of government is significant, as it produces a “complex interplay between legislation and policy” (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009, p. 21). The rise of globalised education policy and the increasing significance of the role that the Organisation for Economic Co-operation Development (OECD) has in Australian education policymaking and governance must be acknowledged (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009; Sellar & Lingard, 2013). These global and national political and policy structures mean that Australian education policy is a mediated or negotiated settlement that responds to federal and international education reform agendas.

Australian school education is regulated and governed by two levels of government, the federal and state or territory governments; the schooling system has two separate education sectors, government, and non-government schools; and within the non-government sector, education authorities administer schools. Government (state or public schools) are administered by the respective state or territory education departments. Non-government schools are Catholic schools administered by dioceses or independent schools that operate autonomously and are accountable to the school community through a school board (Kenway, 2013; Lupton & Hayes, 2021). State and territory education departments have jurisdictional governance over non-government schools, which means they must comply with state and territory government policies. To ensure and maintain federal government funding, all Australian schools must adhere to federal government regulatory requirements.

In recent decades, the rise of cooperative federalism and increased regulatory requirements by the federal government focused on performance and accountability in Australian school education has led to a series of government funded initiatives, such as the Disadvantaged Schools Program (1970s), Building the Education Revolution (2000s), National Partnership programs (2010s) and more recently National School Reform Agreements (2020s) (Chakraborty & Blackburn, 2013; Lingard, 2000; Lupton & Hayes, 2021). Federal government policies and funded initiatives have accountability requirements, yet the Australian Government has no direct responsibility for schooling.

Public policy is intended to serve people. Education funding policy is intended to allocate funds and can be seen as having two distinctive policy intents. First, to ameliorate educational disadvantage, such as social circumstances and

geographic location through redistributive policies, or second, just to allocate funding, a distributive policy, without attempting to remit disadvantage (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). Whether educational policy is distributive or redistributive is symbolically important because policy can be used to allocate resources (distributive) or steer public opinion and affirm certain values (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). As several key funding policies indicate, Australian educational policy has traditionally had a redistributive approach (Mills et al., 2017), which is highlighted in the discussion about the *Karmel Report 1973* and the *Gonksi Review* in this next section.

### ***The Karmel Report 1973***

Lingard (2000) suggests the push for federalism through funding, such as the NCCD, commenced with the release of the *Karmel Report 1973* commissioned by the Whitlam Labor Government. The Australian Schools Commission was elevated from “think tank” to an administrative organisation to manage the outcomes of the *Karmel Report 1973*, marking a substantial shift in federal-state government relations (Barcan, 1980; Walker, 1978). Recommendations were made on school funding, initial teacher education, school facilities and the education of disadvantaged students, including students with disability (Keeves, 1978; Lingard, 2000). The *Karmel Report 1973*, brought into sharp focus systemic inequities and state differences in educational provision for school students, including students with disability (Barcan, 1980; Karmel et al., 1973; Keeves, 1978). On behalf of the federal government, the Australian Schools Commission determined federal educational priorities and managed funding for programs and initiatives (Selby-Smith, 1978). The *Karmel Report 1973* introduced needs-based funding to remediate educational

disadvantage, with a specific focus on improving educational provision for students with disability and funding to train special education teachers.

The Whitlam Labor government systematised school funding arrangements for government and non-government schools and a needs-based funding regimen was introduced (Lingard, 2000). The federal government was actively involved in schooling, with increasing authority (due to funding arrangements), yet little responsibility to provide educational services. Consequent to the *Karmel Report 1973*, federal government funding policies for schools have continued as a series of negotiations and settlements attached to each new grant program, which are often ideologically driven by the political agenda of the government of the day (Crittendon, 1978; Gonski et al., 2011; Lingard, 2000). These negotiations are generally made with the education sectors, government, and non-government schools, with the potential of each funding agreement to vary across sectors and across states or territories. This means there was little consistency in terms of the negotiated funding package.

### ***Gonski Review (2011, 2017)***

Consistency in funding was a priority when in 2010, the Gillard Labor Australian Government commissioned businessman, David Gonski to chair the *Review of Funding for Schooling*, Gonski Review (Joseph, 2017; Kenway, 2013). Deloitte Access Economics, commissioned by the Review of Funding for Schooling Panel, reported on an optimal funding architecture and the relationship between funding and educational outcomes, which informed the Gonski Report recommendations (Deloitte Access Economics, 2011; Gonski et al., 2011). The Gonski Review occurred within a context of globalised education policy (Kenway, 2013) and as a member nation of the OECD, the Australian Government is

committed to policy and educational reform that aligns with the OECD reform agenda (Ball et al., 2017; Ozga, 2020; Sellar & Lingard, 2013). Gonski drew heavily upon multiple OECD sources of data and reports to inform the final report and recommendations. For example, Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) results, an OECD assessment program, were used to add a sense of urgency that something must be done to turn around Australian school student results on PISA (Gonski et al., 2011). A policy problem was created about assessment regimens that required urgent attention (Bacchi, 2009). The Global Education Reform Movement (GERM) was now apparent in Australian education policy (Sahlberg, 2016; Sellar & Lingard, 2013). Gonski aligned school funding issues with international assessment programs, and it was through this data that policy success would be measured.

Gonski called for substantial restructuring of federal government funding of Australian schools, informed by three principles: first, reforms would provide the capacity to compare achievement data with OECD data, second, all reforms need to ensure Australian schooling is globally competitive, and finally, all school-age children must have access to a quality education (Gonski et al., 2011; Keating & Klatt, 2013; Kenway, 2013). The Gonski funding model recommended base funding for primary and secondary students, with an additional loading for identified educational disadvantage, of which disability was one (Joseph, 2017). Gonski also noted that “it was not possible to provide an indicative estimate of the loading [without reliable data on students with disability] (Gonski et al., 2011, p. 257). An endorsement of the fledgeling national NCCD model, whilst highlighting the variable approaches to funding mechanisms across states and territories for students with disability.



The political maelstrom to implement the Gonski recommendations is a separate research undertaking. Essentially, the Rudd, then Gillard, then Rudd Labor Governments, followed by the Abbot Liberal National Government, all used whatever legislative power available to make inroads on the Gonski plan, which ultimately led to a series of funding agreements and promises unique to each state and territory government (Joseph, 2017; Keating & Klatt, 2013; Kenway, 2013). The Gonski model had partial implementation, but more significantly, it was broken down into so many subparts making it hardly recognisable, adding new complexity to the school funding system (Joseph, 2017; Keating & Klatt, 2013; McCollow, 2015). The funding model had been hijacked by politics.

The Turnbull Liberal National Government revisited the Gonski model in 2017 to guarantee that by 2023 all Australian schools will be funded using the Gonski model and earlier agreements with state and territory governments will be replaced (Alberici et al., 2017). Simultaneous to the Gonski model funding debate, the development of the NCCD funding model continued, with an expectation that students with disability would be funded according to the level of adjustment.

In summary, the *Karmel Report*, under the auspices of the Labor Australian Government, was the first significant review of education funding in Australia's history. Recommendations from the *Karmel Report* led a redistributive policy, whereby target funds were directed towards reducing educational disadvantage. The next substantial review, the Gonski Review, was undertaken by an Australian businessman on behalf of the Australian Government. This represented a significant shift in how policy work gets done, with an eye to globalised education policy and educational reform.

Because of the complex political arrangements described above, many Australian educational reform initiatives are incentivised with supplementary targeted funding attached to accountability agreements (Wilkinson et al., 2018). For example, the National Partnership Program was a series of federally funded education reform initiatives open to both education sectors - government and non-government. National Partnership Program initiatives require state and territory education departments to select output areas and submit a proposed implementation plan to the federal government for approval (PhillipsKPA, 2015). In 2012, the federal government announced the More Support for Students with Disabilities (MSSD) National Partnership Program to improve educational access and outcomes for students with disability (PhillipsKPA, 2015). The MSSD was a three-year program, from 2012 – 2014, and was implemented concurrent to the development of the NCCD funding model. Initially the MSSD output areas were not directly linked to NCCD policy development, although there was obvious overlap, as can be seen in the original output areas listed in Table 4.2. In 2014, NCCD was an addition to the menu of outputs for MSSD.

**Table 4.2** *MSSD output descriptions*

| Outputs                             | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    Assistive technology provision | Providing assistive technology (e.g., computer software, low vision aids, communication tools) to support the teaching and participation of students with disability.                                         |
| 2    Assistive technology training  | Providing training for teachers to strengthen their skills in the use of assistive technology in the classroom.                                                                                               |
| 3    Support centres                | Developing support centres which serve as a centre of expertise in the educational needs of students with disability and provide expert support to a group of other schools that may not have this expertise. |

|    |                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4  | Health/allied health        | Schools coordinating with health/allied health or other professionals to strengthen schools' support for students with disability.                                                                                        |
| 5  | Special education training  | Providing training for pre-service and/or practicing teachers to build their skills in special education.                                                                                                                 |
| 6  | DSE 2005 training           | Providing training for all school staff to improve understanding of their obligations under the Disability Standards for Education 2005 and how to meet those obligations.                                                |
| 7  | School leadership           | Supporting school principals and/or school leadership teams to strengthen teachers' ability to assist students with disability.                                                                                           |
| 8  | Adapting curriculum         | Supporting school staff to assess the current learning level of students with disability, adapt the teaching curriculum to suit their current level of ability and report on student progress against adapted curriculum. |
| 9  | Modifying lesson plans      | Supporting teachers to develop or modify lesson plans to suit the needs of students with disability.                                                                                                                      |
| 10 | Team teaching               | Supporting teachers to meet the needs of students with disability through collaborative teaching practices (aka team teaching).                                                                                           |
| 11 | Paraprofessionals           | Engaging paraprofessionals (aka teacher's aides) to strengthen their skills in supporting students with disability.                                                                                                       |
| 12 | Student transitions         | Providing additional support for students with disability to transition effectively between stages of schooling and/or from school into further education, training, or employment.                                       |
| 13 | Supporting NCCD (2014 only) | Supporting schools with the implementation of the Nationally Consistent Collection of Data for Students with Disability.                                                                                                  |

Meeting the NCCD requirements was situated within the MSSD national partnership agenda, not just output 13, but also more subtly in outputs 1, 2, 5, 8, 9 and 10 in terms of planning educational adjustments; output 6 ensuring educators understand obligations outlined in the DSE; and output 7 in terms of the role of school leadership. Establishing consultation and collaborative practices was supported by outputs 3, 4, 10, 11 and 12. When output 13 became an option, state and territory governments amended the MSSD implementation plans to include the

NCCD (PhillipsKPA, 2015). Output area 5, special education training is a curious inclusion, as a signatory to UN CRPD the Australian Government has made a commitment to inclusive education practices (see section 4.6.2). This is yet another example of contradictions of policy; whereby official conceptions of disability and models of educational provision for students with disability are at odds.

#### 4.4.1 Funding to ameliorate disadvantage

Schools require adequate funding to make certain of education provision for all students. However, many students with disability require additional funding and resources to facilitate their full access and participation in learning. How this is achieved is tied to policies about educational provision and more broadly, how disability is conceptualised. How to support students with disability (see sections 4.2 and 4.3) and how to best fund these supports (Liasidou, 2015; S. Tomlinson, 2017; Walton, 2015) are key questions considered when determining a funding model for students with disability. Sigafoos et al. (2012) identified five broad funding approaches for students with disability discussed in the literature (see Table 4.3). However, they note that no actual funding model is as clearcut as suggested in the taxonomy; most funding models are a hybrid version of more than one approach.

**Table 4.3** *Funding approaches for students with disability*

| Type          | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Discretionary | Additional funding is provided, or a certain budgetary percentage for discretionary purposes by allocating a set percentage of the school’s overall budget, for example, 20% of the school budget allocated to support for students with disability. |
| Categorical   | A set amount of additional funding for each student with an identified disability. Funds are specifically targeted to meet the needs of students with an identified disability.                                                                      |
| Voucher       | Parents receive vouchers to pay for specific educational needs of their child. Often used to increase school participation among economically disadvantaged children.                                                                                |

|              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Census based | Funding is based on the number of student and weighted by variables such as socioeconomic status or characteristics of the disability. This type of funding model aims to simplify the overall funding mechanism and are intended to remove financial incentives for overidentifying students which are presumed to occur in a categorical model. |
| Cost based   | Funds are allocated on first estimating the actual costs of providing additional educational support. This approach includes features of the categorical and census-based approaches in that total funding amount is based on the number of students. This model aims to provide an empirical basis for funding allocation.                       |

(Sigafos et al., 2012, pp. 20 - 28)

Applying this classification, the NCCD can be categorised as being primarily a resource-cost model, which draws on cost-based description outlined in Table 4.3. Students with disability are funded by the *Schooling Resource Standard* (SRS) which is based on school census data to provide a per-student base amount with additional loadings for specific student characteristics or categories (this is discussed in more detail in Appendix A: The development of the NCCD model) (Australian Department of Parliamentary Services, 2013). The funding methodology is a base amount plus loadings for specific disadvantages, of which disability is one. However, the loadings calculations are currently under review as recommended by the *2019 National School Resourcing Board Review of the loading for students with disability* (Chaney et al., 2020). PricewaterhouseCoopers (PwC) were awarded the Australian Government contract to undertake the review of disability loadings, which is expected to be finalised in 2022.

#### 4.4.2 NCCD is a complex governance arrangement

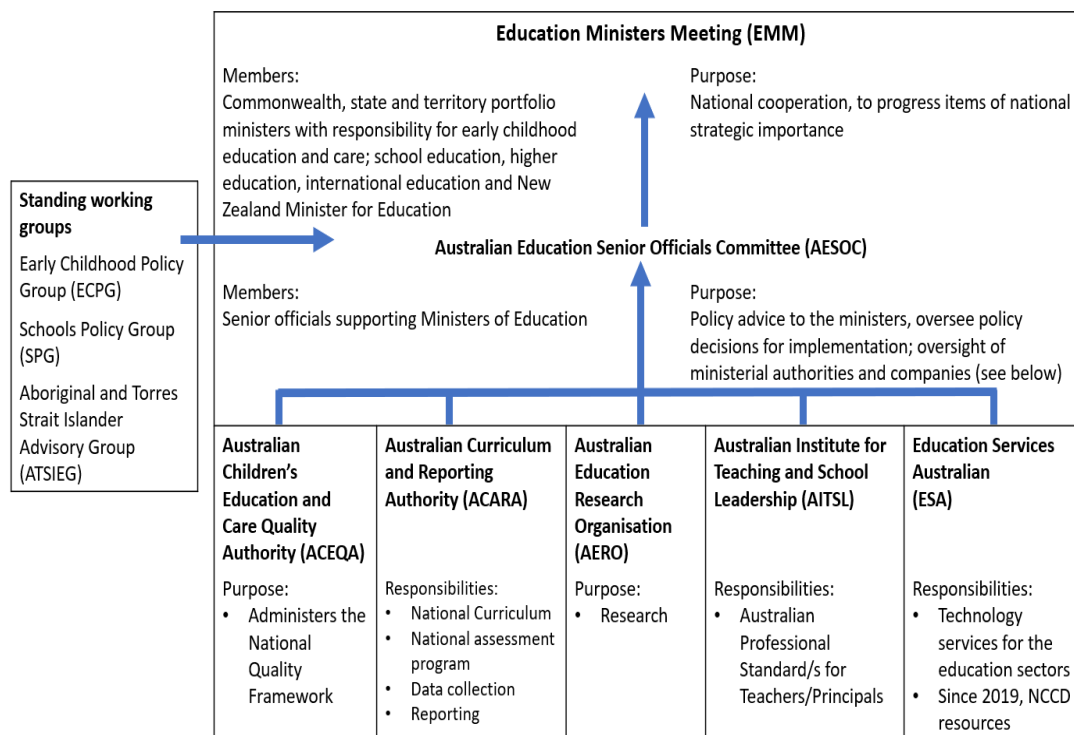
The governance arrangements for the NCCD are complex, it has become the concern of multiple agencies, committees, and organisations. Traditionally intergovernmental negotiations were managed through layers of committees providing advice through governance structures that involve the Commonwealth and

all state and territory governments. From 1992, this structure was under the stewardship of the Council of Australian Governments (COAG), but in May 2020 was replaced under the Morrison Liberal National Government as “a new architecture for federal and state relations...to reduce bureaucracy and red tape” (Australian Department of Prime Minister and Cabinet, 2021, p. 33). The new architecture meant the Education Council Education (COAG) became the Ministers Meeting (EMM) earmarked as the forum for collaboration and joint decision-making (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021b). The EMM is chaired by the Commonwealth Minister for Education, and members include state and territory government ministers with responsibilities for early childhood education and care, school education, higher education (although this is federal government responsibility) and international education (see Figure 4.1 below); the New Zealand Education Minister is a non-decision making member (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021c). The EMM is supported by the Australian Education Senior Officials Committee (AESOC) who have oversight of the five ministerial authorities and companies, as well as standing working groups (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021a). The standing working groups all report to AESOC. The new architecture for Commonwealth and state relations are complex, as represented in in Figure 4.1.

Since 2020, NCCD operational matters and decisions have become the responsibility of ministerial authorities and quasi-autonomous government agencies, as well as the standing working groups (see Figure 4.1) (Rose, 1996). For example, decisions about the NCCD Guidelines (which are updated annually) are managed through the Schools Policy Group (SPG), student with disability data is managed and

published on the Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA) data reporting portal.

**Figure 4.1** *Architecture of Commonwealth and state relations*



(compiled from information available at Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment 20021a, 2021b, 2021c).

NCCD support materials are managed by Education Services Australia (ESA) and are located on a dedicated website. Curriculum planning advice about students with disability is under the remit of ACARA. Under this new architecture no single agency has oversight of the NCCD, highlighting the complexity of policy arrangements, and the potential for decisions to be made in one context that may not be always consistent with the original stated intent, which is discussed in this next section.

## 4.5 SITUATING THE NCCD

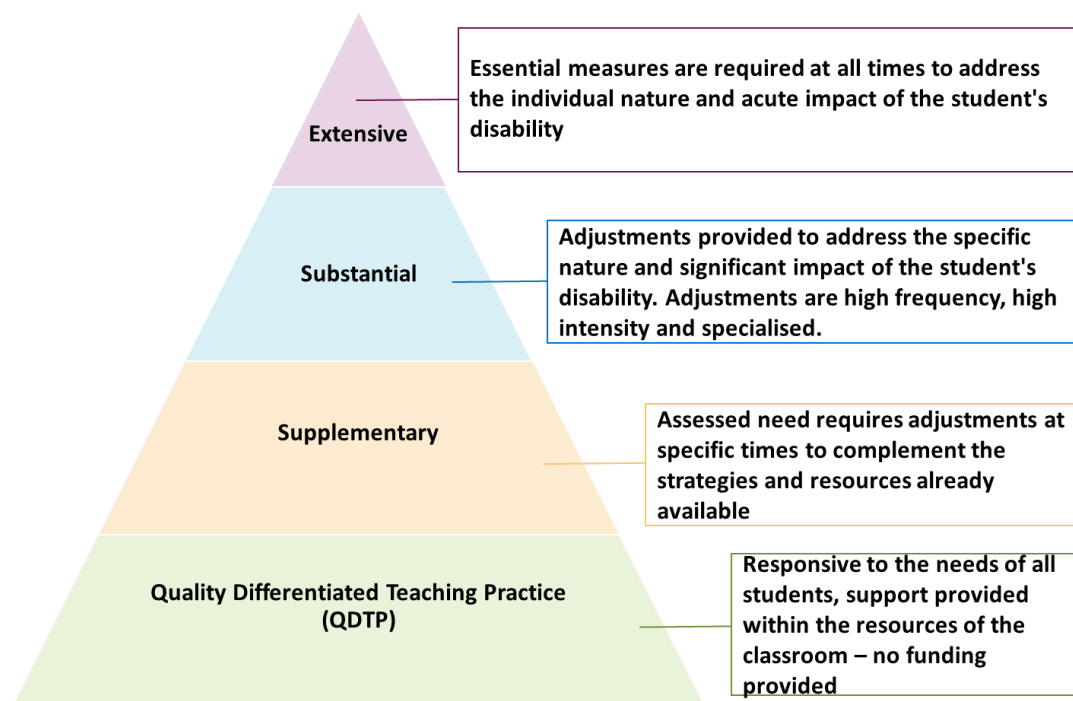
The purpose of the NCCD is threefold, first, to collect prevalence data about school students with disability to inform Australian Government funding for schools, second, a mechanism for national reporting about Australian schools and finally, to support policy development and future planning (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). While the broader legislative context of the NCCD is discussed in section 4.6, the NCCD model is specifically underpinned by two legislative frameworks, the DDA and the DSE. These legislations have informed the policy development, and NCCD resources and tools.

As an annual data collection, the NCCD is a component of the Australian Government (AG) School Census which is used to calculate school funding from the federal government to state and territory governments and provide data to inform education policies (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021g). The AG School Census date is always the first Friday of August for all Australian schools. Through the census collection, the NCCD information is aggregated under four broad categories of disability (CoD) and four levels of adjustment (LoA). The disability categories of cognitive, sensory, social-emotional, and physical correspond with definition of disability in the DDA (see Appendix F; Definition of disability). The four LoAs - Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice (QDTP), supplementary, substantial, and extensive determine the funding amount paid. This funding amount is a graduated payment commensurate with the student's level of educational need, as determined by the LoA. The shape of the triangle in Figure 4.2 represents the proportion of students at each of the levels, with most



students expected to be at the QDTP level, and the least students at the extensive level.

**Figure 4.2** *NCCD Levels of Adjustment*



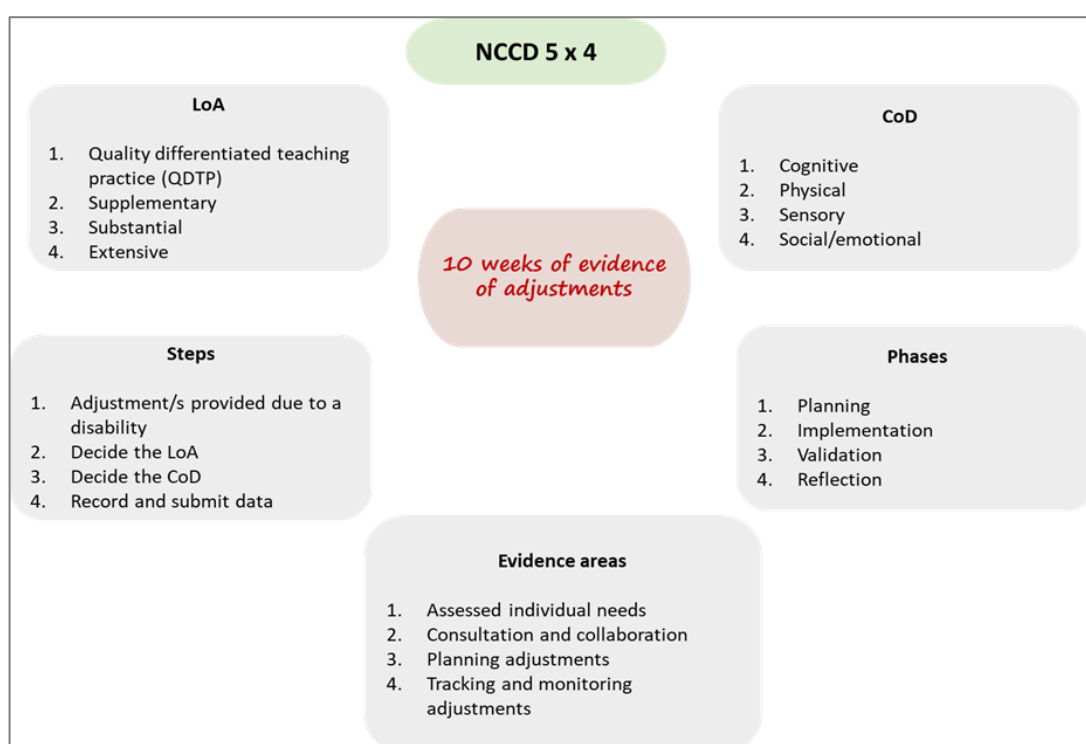
(Education Council Joint Working Group, 2017)

As students' educational needs become more complex, the funding amount is commensurate with the level of educational need; students at the QDTP level are unfunded with graduated funding amounts paid for the other three levels dependent on the intensity, frequency, and specialisation of the educational adjustments provided (e.g., physical settings, specialist personnel) (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). For example, students who require intensive educational support throughout the day are at the highest level of support, extensive, and receive the maximum payment. Whereas students with learning needs that can be accommodated by the classroom teacher without drawing upon additional school resources are likely to be at the QDTP level and receive no funding. Figure 4.2 above provides a brief

explanation of the levels, for a more detailed explanation of each level see Appendix G: NCCD Levels of Adjustment descriptors.

The decision-making process for the NCCD is presented as a flowchart (see Appendix H: NCCD model diagram 2016 - 2018<sup>1</sup>) with four sequential steps. To use this NCCD model diagram, an understanding of the DDA definition of disability and legal obligations as outlined in the DSE is highly desirable (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018, p. 10). The mandatory evidentiary requirements of the NCCD are framed by the obligations of the DSE (see Figure 4.3 below).

**Figure 4.3** *Components of NCCD implementation*



The NCCD has five core components presented in Figure 4.3. Within each component there are four aspects. For example, there are four steps in the decision-

<sup>1</sup> The decision-making process of the Model Diagram 2016 – 2018 is current. The 2016 – 2018 version, which is the model used for the data collection phase of this study, has slightly different footnotes to the current diagram.

making process: four LoAs and four CoDs. The figure below is a snapshot of each of the five components of the NCCD and draws attention to the minimum requirement of 10-weeks of evidence of education adjustments. The four phases of the NCCD were introduced in 2019 and have provided a structure for schools to use when planning the implementation of the NCCD (Education Services Australia, 2019). While the actions within each of the phases were not new, this structure promoted new ways to organise and describe the work of the NCCD.

The NCCD is intended to be a nationally consistent mechanism to identify and fund students with disability. However, even after many years of the NCCD implementation some state and territory governments, such as Queensland, have maintained existing funding arrangements and processes for state government funding of students with disability. Having parallel funding processes for identifying students with disability has meant schools have been required to manage dual processes, this has allowed national inconsistencies and misunderstandings to continue (Forlin et al., 2013). For example, the categorical approach of EAP, is aligned with a special education model of educational provisions. This stands in contrasts to inclusive education models of schooling that are aligned with the social model of disability. This next section provides a rationalisation for the NCCD.

#### **4.5.1 Why was a national model needed?**

The federally legislated definition of disability was not carried over into funding state and territory government policies for Australian school students with disability; not all students with disability were eligible for additional resources even when there was evidence of educational needs due to disability (Forlin et al., 2013). Forlin et al. (2013) were commissioned by the federal Department of Education, Employment and Workplace Relations to report on Australia's capacity to provide

education for students with disability in comparison to international counterparts, as well as to examine Australian and international policy aimed at improving learning outcomes for students with disability. This section draws on the government school sector analysis in the report, which became the basis for further reform. Each state and territory government had their own educational policies and funding mechanism for students with disability, these lacked cohesion and alignment, making it impossible to make direct comparisons of student data and levels of educational needs (Forlin et al., 2013). There was no obvious way of knowing the number of Australian school students with disability, or where they were located, making it difficult to plan for national resource distribution.

The separate state and territory funding policies meant there was no certainty that funding or support for a student with disability would be maintained should they change school. There was no mutual recognition of eligibility for additional funding beyond education sector boundaries. For example, a student with disability meets the eligibility criteria for additional funding in the state of Victoria, Australia but should that same student relocate to the Northern Territory, they may no longer meet the eligibility criteria for funding. Also, if a student with disability transferred from a government school to a non-government school, in Queensland, funding provided for the student in the government school does not move with the student, and nor does the documentation completed to access this funding. The incoming school is often required to complete new documentation to apply for funding, which is not guaranteed, and nor is there certainty it would be of equal monetary value (Forlin et al., 2013). This was challenging to navigate, for families and schools alike. The NCCD was expected to standardise eligibility criteria and processes for the identification of students with disability across educational jurisdictions to enable

national funding and planning (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2019). The NCCD provides the opportunity for consistent eligibility criteria and approach to accessing additional funding.

***NCCD policy development was a public-private partnership***

All aspects of the NCCD policy development and implementation have occurred through public-private partnerships, for the most part between the Australian Government and PwC. Hood (1995) suggests Australia's engagement with new public management (NPM) practices, which focus on improving the efficiency of the public sector, to the increasing global influence of the OECD. Indeed, the partnership between the federal government and PwC in both policy development and delivery is an illustration of the move from policy making that was largely state-centric to a non-hierarchical governance structure. Instead, this new structure could be described as a "heterarchy" because it does not follow traditional administrative structures, but rather, is "an organisational form somewhere between hierarchy and network that draws upon diverse horizontal and vertical links [and] that permits[s] different elements of the policy process to cooperate and/or compete" (Ball & Junemann, 2012, p. 138). This is not to suggest the partnership with PwC represents wholesale change in Australian policy making. However, it certainly fits the kind of political and structural transformation that Rose (1996) has described as the "de-governmentalisation of the state" (p.56). As Ball (2016) argues "repopulating" policy making and implementation with organisations such as PwC "give[s] primacy and legitimacy to the role of business or enterprise or philanthropy in the solution of 'wicked' social problems"(p.560). In so doing the authority, responsibilities, decisions, and work that occurs within the policy network has been rebalanced with a new field of non-state actors. The manoeuvres around how the

education of students with disability should be resourced have changed with the introduction of the NCCD.

## **4.6 POLICY CONTEXT FOR THE NCCD**

The NCCD interacts with a range of policies, which contribute to a complex policy landscape. It is a connected policy, that sits within, and builds upon national and international education policies, legislation, and disability policy work, all of which have historical attachments and are culturally contextual (Ball et al., 2017; Koyama & Varenne, 2012; Lingard & Sellar, 2013; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). The NCCD is a confluence of historical and contemporary disability discourses and educational policies. Understanding the policy background of NCCD provides insights into the existing organisational arrangements that have and continue to shape the everyday work of those at the frontline, where this policy is activated. This next section identifies key legislative frameworks and policies that are connected to and have influenced the design and implementation of the NCCD policy requirements.

### **4.6.1 National legislation and obligations**

#### ***Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (DDA)***

It is unlawful to discriminate against a person with disability in Australia, either directly (e.g., harassment and victimisation) or indirectly (e.g., subtly exclude the parent of a child with disability to avoid the child with disability). The DDA applies to all states and territories of the Commonwealth of Australia. This legislation outlines legal requirements in relation to the treatment of people with disability and defines disability for the purposes of applying the legislation (see Appendix F: Definition of disability). The DDA uses a [human] rights perspective to define disability, which is explained in Table 4.1 (Dempsey, 2003). The DDA

definition of disability underpins the NCCD (see Appendix F: Definition of Disability).

The DDA requires *reasonable adjustments* (Commonwealth of Australia, 1992, p. 8) to be made to ensure access and participation of people with disability across a range of settings, including schools (Handley, 2010; Lindsay, 2007). In the context of schooling, a reasonable adjustment means adjustments are provided to facilitate students with disability to participate in all aspects of schooling, meaning adjustments are made to instructional strategies, the environment and assessment to facilitate access to and participation in learning programs (Cumming et al., 2013). Reasonable adjustments are intended to enable students with disability to participate in learning programs and school activities on the same basis as students without disability (Commonwealth of Australia, 2005). Decisions about adjustments made for students with disability inform the NCCD level of adjustment, which activates funding.

### ***Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE)***

In the earlier sections, and across the thesis, the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD are explored. The collection of evidence by teachers to address the evidentiary requirements is a cornerstone of the NCCD. I note here that the DSE underpins many of these requirements, which are assessing student learning needs, provision of educational adjustments, tracking and monitoring educational adjustments, and consultation and collaboration (Australian Education Council, 2019a; Commonwealth of Australia, 2005).

The DSE provides guidance about the legal expectations outlined in the DDA in relation to students with disability. When these expectations are not met and are therefore challenged through legal proceedings the outcomes have clarified the intent

of the legislation, particularly in specific contexts such as schooling (Dempsey, 2003; Lindsay, 2007). The consequence of these challenges has led to an improved understanding of obligations. The DSE were drafted to assist schools to understand obligations under the DDA; however, they had not been enforced. The *2002 Senate Inquiry: Education of students with disabilities* stated that there was a necessity for “an agreed set of national standards setting out the equity entitlements of students with disabilities...to bring into force the Disability Standards for Education 2002...to take the necessary legislative action to put the education standards beyond legal challenge” (Australian Senate Standing Committee on Education Employment and Workplace Relations, 2002, p. 118). The draft Standards remained unenforceable until legislated in 2005.

The DSE provides schools and educational jurisdictions clarity about their obligations and responsibilities in relation to students with disability under the DDA. The DSE outlines responsibilities in terms of managing victimisation and harassment and other forms of discrimination, as well as enrolment, consultation and collaboration, and the provision of reasonable adjustments (Cumming et al., 2013). The DSE is applicable to education authorities, as well as individuals employed in a school.

Every five years, the DSE are reviewed. The findings of the first review, in 2010, noted the issue of funding variability for students with disability across state and territory governments as being confusing and also led to inconsistent levels of educational support for students (Australian Disability Standards for Education Review Team, 2012). While there were common disability categories funded across state and territory governments (e.g., autism (ASD)), but there were also disability categories unique to the state or territory. For example, the disability category of deaf



blind, was a funded category only in New South Wales; whereas the Northern Territory was the only jurisdiction that funded the disability category of severe behaviour, and the disability category of chronic health issues was funded only in South Australia. Table 4.4 (below) identifies the funded disability categories for each state and territory educational jurisdiction (as at 2017), note the different disability categories, and the slightly different or inconsistent terminology used for each of these funded categories.

**Table 4.4** *Funded disability categories for Australian school-age students - January 2017*

|                                | ASD | DB | H | HI | ID                                                                      | LD | PI | SB | SED | SLI | VI |
|--------------------------------|-----|----|---|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|----|----|-----|-----|----|
| Australian Capital Territory   | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    |    |    |     |     | ✓  |
| New South Wales                | ✓   | ✓  |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    | ✓  |    | ✓   |     | ✓  |
| Northern Territory             | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       | ✓  |    | ✓  |     |     | ✓  |
| Queensland                     | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    | ✓  |    | ✓ * | ✓   | ✓  |
| South Australia                | ✓   |    | ✓ | ✓  | ✓                                                                       | ✓  | ✓  |    |     |     | ✓  |
| Tasmania                       | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    | ✓  |    | ✓   |     | ✓  |
| Victoria                       | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    | ✓  |    | ✓   | ✓   | ✓  |
| Western Australia              | ✓   |    |   | ✓  | ✓                                                                       |    |    |    |     |     | ✓  |
| ASD – Autism Spectrum Disorder |     |    |   |    | PI – Physical Impairment                                                |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| DB – Deaf Blind                |     |    |   |    | SB – Severe Behaviour                                                   |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| H – Chronic Health             |     |    |   |    | SED – Social Emotional Disorder<br>(includes psychiatric/mental health) |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| HI – Hearing Impairment        |     |    |   |    | SLI - Speech Language Impairment                                        |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| ID – Intellectual Disability   |     |    |   |    | VI – Vision Impairment                                                  |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| LD – Learning Disability       |     |    |   |    |                                                                         |    |    |    |     |     |    |
| *non-government schools only   |     |    |   |    |                                                                         |    |    |    |     |     |    |

While some disability categories were consistent across all states and territories, such as Autism Spectrum Disorder, hearing impairment, intellectual

disability, and vision impairment, eligibility criteria for additional funding was not the same and nor was the funding amount (Forlin et al., 2013). A student may be eligible for funding in one state but not in another, despite the disability not changing. A nationally consistent approach to identifying and assessing students with disability for funding purposes was recommended (Urbis, 2015). Linking the necessity for a nationally consistent approach to identifying students to the DSE review is notable, especially as the “primary purpose of the Standards is to clarify, and make more explicit, the obligations of education and training providers under the DDA” (Commonwealth Attorney-General, 2005, p. 1). The textual connections between the DSE and the DDA are well established and have enabled the development of a national approach to identifying students with disability.

Of course, not all of a teacher’s work is directly mediated by major policy texts such as the DSE or DDA. However, major legislations, policies and institutional texts create regulatory frames that are “established from positions of power in the institutional regime, control facticity; they control and are specified as the categories and concepts that come into play at the front line of building institutional realities” (Smith, 2005, p. 191). As this thesis shows, the reach of some texts is greater than teachers might imagine and occurs through act-text-act sequences.

As a text, the DSE produced a regulatory frame (Smith, 1999) for states and territories, and which culminated in the development of the NCCD . Educators are required to ensure students with disability have access to education, it is a legal obligation outlined in the DSE. The language of the DSE obligations, key phrases, such as on the same basis, reasonable adjustments, and consultation and

collaboration, are often used when describing some of the work teachers do when considering the educational needs of students with disability in their class.

#### 4.6.2 NCCD location in a complex policy landscape

The NCCD is a redistributive funding policy; this means funding is provided to ameliorate potential disadvantage arising from disability (Mills et al., 2017; Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). Policies are important because they address an identified need and are always a series of settlements which attempt to reconcile dilemmas that are invoked (Ball, 1994). Policy settlements are outcomes of negotiations, which when done well, facilitate voices to be heard of those for whom the policy is intended (Rinne & Ozga, 2011; Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). The NCCD policy has particular significance for those working at the frontline of educational services, as this policy can only be achieved through their work.

The connections of the NCCD policy, how the official texts are hooked up with each other in formal ways (Smith, 2005), are presented in the Table 4.5 below. The planning, validation and reflection phases focus on what school leaders need to do to implement the model (de Bruin et al., 2020). The implementation phase of the NCCD is a good example of how each policy texts interact with each other, and how each of the components are connected. Policies within each component of the NCCD, the official texts, coordinate specific activities of the NCCD.

**Table 4.5** *NCCD components and official texts*

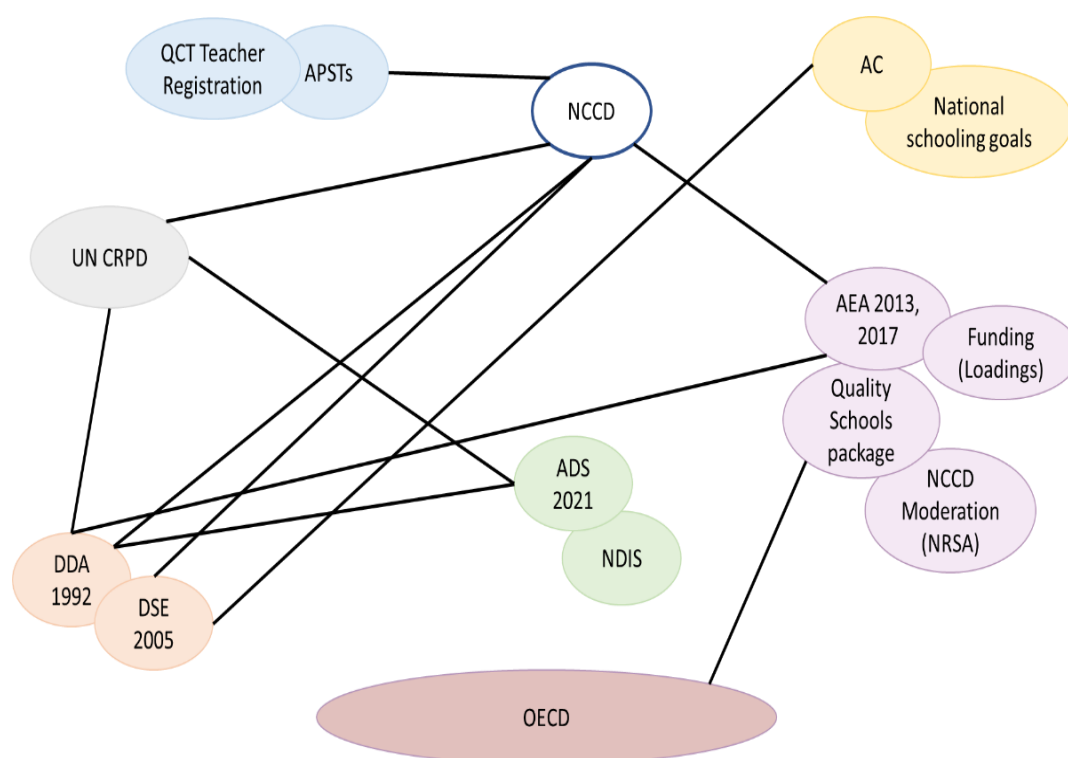
| NCCD subcomponent            | Official texts (see section 4.5)                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Level of Adjustment (LoA)    | Australian Curriculum (AC)<br>National goals of schooling<br>Australian Professional Standards for Teachers (APSTs) |
| Category of Disability (CoD) | Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (DDA)                                                                            |
| NCCD Evidence areas          | Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE)                                                                       |

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NCCD Steps        | Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (DDA)<br>Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE)                                                                                                                                                                           |
| NCCD 4 Phases     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 1. Planning       | National School Improvement Tool (NSIT) or equivalent                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 2. Implementation | Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (DDA)<br>Disability Standards for Education 2005 (DSE)<br>Australian Curriculum (AC)<br>National goals of schooling<br>Australian Professional Standards for teachers (APSTs)<br>Australian Professional Standard for Principals |
| 3. Validation     | Australian Education Act 2017 (AEA)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 4. Reflection     | National School Improvement Tool (NSIT) or equivalent                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

Furthermore, in piecing this together, what becomes more apparent is “the systematisation of the federal government’s involvement in schooling” (Lingard, 2000, p. 26). The Australian Government has implemented education policy in such a way that brings about educational reform that situates them to manage and negotiate how each state and territory educational jurisdiction will be accountable for funding received.

A visual representation of how the NCCD is connected to national and international policies present in Figure 4.4 below. The overlapping or clustered policies are directly connected to each other, and the black lines show the connections between these clusters. Note the OECD is indirectly connected through a range of key national policies, this is discussed in more detail later in this chapter.

**Figure 4.4** *Connecting policies of the NCCD*



Understanding how policies connect to the NCCD makes existing organisational arrangements more visible. The policy assemblage is complex and multi-layered, but nonetheless shapes the current field of practice (Apple, 2004; Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). Figure 4.4 maps the intertextuality of NCCD, how this organises the daily work of those at the frontline of this policy implementation is discussed in Chapters Five, Six, Seven and Eight.

#### **4.7 STUDENT DATA – A GLOBAL PUSH**

How school students with disability are identified is complicated, tied to conceptualisations of disability, funding mechanisms and driven by policies. From a pragmatic perspective it is necessary to know who is eligible for additional funding. As a member state of the OECD, Australia has committed to contributing data to the OECD global reporting on students with disability (Ebersold & Evans, 2008; OECD, 2008). Having a common reporting framework for member nations is necessary to be

able to make valid data comparisons. The OECD have moved away from the tri-partite model of disability, difficulty and disadvantage to embrace the classification framework proposed by the *European Agency for Development of Special Needs Education* (Brussina, 2020). Having shared terminology and language across the OECD and the European Commission (sponsor of the European Framework) enables comparisons for global policy analysis (Brussina, 2020; European Agency for Special Needs and Inclusive Education, 2016). As already discussed, the OECD have noted the opportunity for data capture about students with disability on the ACARA My School website.

How the OECD extrapolates the data sets produced by the NCCD is not yet clear. However, the NCCD is linked to global education policy through the OECD's expectations of member nations to provide data on students with disability, not just in terms of prevalence but also in relation to assessment and educational outcomes (Brussina, 2020). Data capture about assessment and educational outcomes has been flagged in the Australian Disability Strategy 2021 – 2031 (ADS) as an outcome measure (see Appendix E: NCCD legislative and policy landscape). The NCCD policy has national and global implications that are not necessarily visible to policy actors at the frontline (Ball et al., 2017). The NCCD is a policy designed for funding, which will report on student numbers and has the potential to provide data for transnational evaluation.

Australia, as a member nation of the OECD, is obligated to commit to a range of global economic initiatives outlined by the OECD, and submit to data collection on numerous social issues, such as education (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009). The Australian Government publish high level data about school education on the My School website managed by ACARA. Collecting and publishing school data about

students with disability on the My School website was identified for future releases of the website, thereby meeting obligations to report on national data about students with disability (Zanderigo et al., 2012). The influence of global educational policy is evident, with the intent that the NCCD would meet OECD member obligations. High level national data about students with disability is updated annually and published on the My School website.

#### **4.8 CONCLUSION**

The NCCD is a connected policy that is hooked into federalism, international census data and resources approaches, and transnational evaluation. This chapter has presented a discussion about the sociology of disability and how this has contextualised schooling for Australian students with disability. The policies and legislative frameworks connected to the NCCD were introduced and some of the work required to implement the NCCD model was discussed. This chapter has shown that the devolution of responsibility for the NCCD policy design, development, implementation and evaluation through public-private partnerships arrangements, has enabled the federal government to “steer” this inaugural national educational policy reform “from a distance” (Kickert, 1995, p. 135). The NCCD policy assemblage presented demonstrates the multiplicity of ideas, dynamics, contestations, and societal provocations (Liasidou, 2015). The quantification of students with disability for the purposes of a resource allocation draws on ideological assumptions that having nationally consistent “data holds the elusive promises of addressing educational concerns” (R. Smith, 2016, p. 2). The NCCD is a funding model, intended to standardise how students with disability are identified and funded. In achieving these outcomes, the Australian Government is also able to meet obligations to the OECD to provide national data about students with disability.

This research, was therefore, timely. By understanding how this frontline work happens, thereby making visible unintended consequences of this new policy work. By mapping how frontline work is textually organised new understandings have emerged that can inform how school leaders and education policymakers continue to progress the work of the NCCD requirements. The next three chapters present the analysis of data collection followed by the final two chapters, a discussion of findings and finally, a concluding chapter. In Chapter Five, the work of the school leaders is presented, followed by teachers and teacher assistants in Chapter Six. The analysis of the work of policy officers is described in Chapter Seven.





# Chapter 5: School Leadership of the NCCD

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## 5.1 INTRODUCTION

The orientation of how the NCCD happens at school has organised the data analysis chapters. The first data analysis chapter, Chapter Five, is an analysis of the experiences of those leading the NCCD implementation at school. While, Chapter Six is predominantly about the work of classroom teachers and Chapter Seven, the final analysis chapter, is focused on the work of policy officers.

This chapter presents an analysis of the experiential accounts of school leaders leading the NCCD in two primary schools. In both schools, the team leading the NCCD consist of the learning support teacher, school counsellor, curriculum lead teacher, the assistant principal, and the principal. For clarity, going forward, this team will be referred to as the NCCD school leadership team (NCCD SLT) not to be confused with the SST. The SSTs were mostly the same people, however, in both schools the NCCD SLT was a new group introduced, whilst maintaining the purpose of the SST. Despite there being a formal team notionally leading the NCCD, the day-to-day administrative responsibilities of the NCCD and the ongoing classroom teacher support fell largely to the learning support teacher and to a lesser extent the school counsellor, in both schools. Given this was similar across sites, this suggests that leadership of the NCCD implementation was translocal (Smith, 2005). What was made visible almost immediately, was that while the learning support teacher's work in each school was analogous, the workflow or sequences of actions in each school were remarkably similar.

The NCCD SLT at Hillside Primary School (HPS) (see Table 5.1 below), was led by the principal, Jennifer, with experienced learning support teachers, Karen, and Fiona. Each learning support teacher was allocated specific areas of focus, Karen worked in early years

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literacy development and intervention, whilst Fiona maintained oversight across the school, ensuring programs were in place for students with disability and learning difficulties. Fiona, while an experienced learning support teacher, was new to HPS and was learning school systems and processes at the time of our conversation. The curriculum lead teacher, Debra, was very familiar with the NCCD due to her previous role as the learning support teacher at HPS through 2016 and 2017. School counsellor, Natalie, and learning support teachers, Karen worked across two schools, HPS and one other. Their experience of the NCCD across two schools meant that ideas were shared with staff in both locations, as they were in the NCCD SLTs in both schools.

Leading the team in PPS (PPS) was the principal, Margaret (see Table 5.1 below). The NCCD SLT had undergone several changes over the year. Rebecca, the learning support teacher, joined the NCCD SLT at the beginning of Term Two in April 2018. The previous learning support teacher had left the school mid-way through the first term. Although Rebecca was familiar with the school, having been a classroom teacher for more than ten years at PPS, this was the first time she had taken on a learning support teacher role. Other disruptions to the school team included extended leave for the school counsellor, Linda, who was present for some of the NCCD activities, but not all. Other members of the NCCD SLT team included the curriculum lead teacher, Jodie, and the assistant principal, Sarah. Both Jodie and Sarah had undertaken work to support classroom teachers with the requirements of the NCCD. This work had mostly been done when the school was between learning support teachers. In many ways, as I listened to the informants from PPS, I was taken back to my own time when I worked in schools, despite the best of plans, disruptions to teams, and therefore how work occurs, are inevitable. Managing disruptions to staffing and supporting teachers due to these disruptions was raised by Margaret particularly, but also Jodie, Rebecca, and

Sarah during our conversations, this issue seemed to be a key factor in how they prioritised and organised their work.

**Table 5.1** *NCCD school leadership team informants*

|                          | Hillside Primary School<br>(HPS) | Parkside Primary School<br>(PPS) |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Learning support teacher | Fiona<br>Karen                   | Rebecca                          |
| School counsellor        | Natalie                          | Linda                            |
| Curriculum lead teacher  | Debra                            | Jodie                            |
| Assistant principal      |                                  | Sarah                            |
| Principal                | Jennifer                         | Margaret                         |

In the early analytic stages, the data dialogues focused on nuanced influences of what was happening locally and extra-locally in the school, such as staff disruption or staff working across multiple school sites (Darville, 2014; Smith, 2005). They talked about how work was organised and prioritised. The extra-local work in schools of those working in more than one location, shaped which NCCD texts they shared with staff at HPS and how they were used, which organised how they worked with teachers. Teachers also talked about how working across locations was hooked up into their work at each school (see section 6.2).

The work of the NCCD SLT was socially organised by official and unofficial NCCD texts, understanding which texts people operationalised, and how the work comes to them and where it goes reveals sequences of actions; the workflow (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Griffith & Smith, 2005). An institutional ethnographic text can take many formats, but what is common amongst all formats is that it communicates information. Texts include such things as teacher-generated documents, templates, spreadsheets, policies or even conversations (discourse) (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Griffith & Smith, 2005). Relations of rule are revealed through understanding how texts organise daily actions, thereby bringing

the textual power into analytic focus (Smith, 2005). The NCCD has official texts designed to support the policy implementation and unofficial texts that were generated locally to meet local emerging needs.

The NCCD is a complex layering of social and educational policy (see Chapter Four). Implementation of the NCCD requirements is reliant on intricate relationships between those at the frontline, the school, and the Education Authority. School leaders, classroom teachers, teacher assistants, as well as the Education Authority policy officers co-exist in this policy space and are mutually reliant on each other. It was, therefore, necessary to begin with understanding the context and how the NCCD was experienced locally, at school. Questions about how the work entered the lives of teachers placed the NCCD SLT at the forefront of how this work happened at school.

By commencing each conversation with a discussion about their role, members of the NCCD SLT shared experiential accounts about their work with the NCCD. Their descriptive accounts made the work and workflow of the NCCD visible. They talked about how work came to them and how their everyday work or actions included the production of new texts which were coordinated by the NCCD policy requirements (Wagner, 2014). By following these sequences of actions, the structure of the relationships between these informants and the teachers at their respective schools, as well as policy officers from the Education Authority, were made visible.

## **5.2 PROFESSIONAL LEARNING**

At the beginning of the 2018 school year, both schools undertook a range of activities to prepare teaching staff for the upcoming work of the NCCD. For example, the NCCD SLT arranged whole staff professional learning sessions and ongoing individual mentoring support for classroom teachers. Although not unexpected, both schools relied on the Education Authority to guide the professional learning work, and the NCCD SLTs took direction from

their local policy officer, who was actively engaged in additional school activities through the year. The work of the policy officers is discussed in more detail in Chapter Seven. What is significant for the NCCD SLT, is that they handed over the leadership of whole staff activities to the policy officers; this included facilitating several whole staff professional learning sessions, mentoring specific teachers, and offering bespoke question and answer sessions during regular after school meetings with classroom teachers. While previously policy officers may have been involved, the extent of the devolution of responsibility to the policy officer was not something that had happened before. The professional learning program offered by the policy officers seemed to have been developed by regional office personnel, with an emphasis on ensuring key messages were consistent across school sites, with some capacity to customise or contextualise limited content. The Education Authority expected schools to offer a professional learning session about the NCCD to teachers at the beginning of the school year. The significance of these professional learning sessions is explored further in Chapter Five.

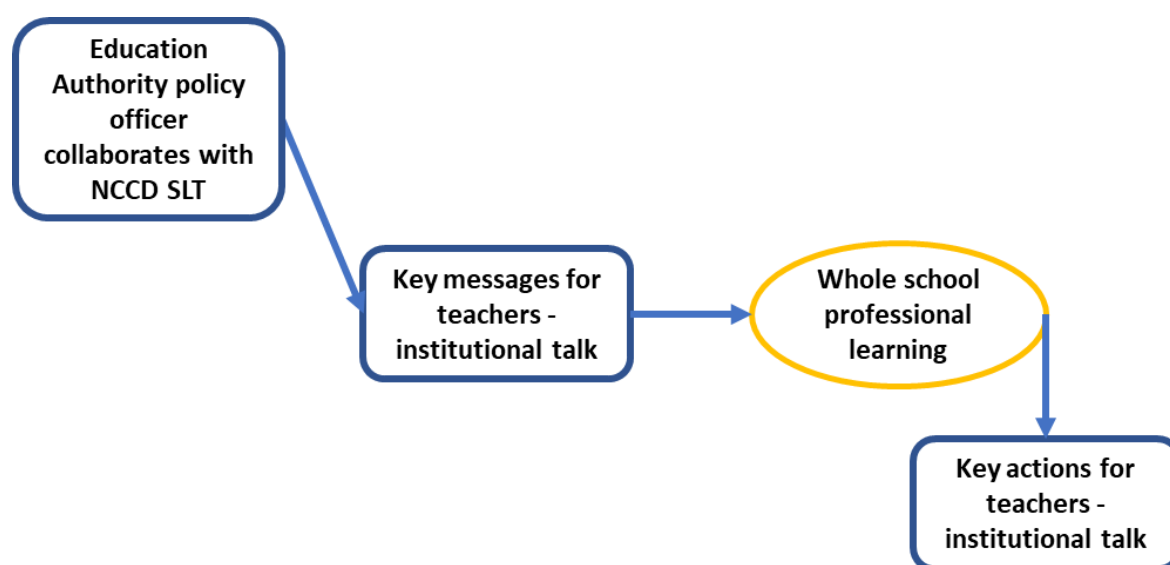
Strict adherence to the Education Authority's direction for professional learning for all staff was particularly evident when HPS scheduled whole staff training about the NCCD during the professional learning days that are seen as valuable and highly sought-after time with staff. In Australia, the school year begins at the end of January and finishes mid-December, it is standard practice for professional learning days to occur the week before students commence the school year. Throughout the school year, there are additional mandatory professional learning days equating to one day for each of the four school terms. At the beginning of the school year, HPS scheduled a NCCD professional learning session during these mandatory staff days, the content was the responsibility of the policy officer, and the process for the session was a collaboration with members of the NCCD SLT. The principal, Jennifer, requested the policy officer facilitate this session:

we actually did have a meeting with our policy officer, and she was going to come in and do some PD [professional development] with our staff and we had a process organised. And then she was unable to support us with that. And we pretty much had to run it ourselves (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 9, 2018).

Although the school team “pretty much had to run it” the content for the professional learning session remained the same, as it had originally been planned by the policy officer. This guaranteed the Education Authority’s key messages about the NCCD were shared. The institutional talk about the NCCD was emerging and being reinforced by policy officers as they presented to schools during the professional learning days and beyond (Darville, 2014). Interestingly, despite the policy officer suddenly not being available on the day there was a level of confidence with content to proceed with the presentation.

Key messages from the NCCD professional learning were picked up by the NCCD SLT and actioned in ways that coordinated the work of classroom teachers. Institutional key messages are ideological codes that seek to manage ideas within textually mediated discourses that are pushed into circulation (Smith, 1999). While ideological codes appear to be formally open, they operate in ways that close debate, for example, the NCCD key messages remained unchanged regardless of context or who facilitated the session (Smith, 1999). Ideological codes coordinate actions, and mediate language used to share and describe work, “the local sequences of the social act...the dialogue between the discourse and local actualities” (Smith, 1999, p. 129). Figure 5.1 maps the interaction between discourse and sequences of actions mediated by the ideological codes of the NCCD key messages activated and maintained by the NCCD SLT in both schools.

**Figure 5.1** *Sequences of actions for the NCCD school leadership team*



The professional learning acted to ensure classroom teachers understood the requirements of the NCCD, what was expected and their required actions. What was not visible to the teachers, was the collaboration between the school team and the Education Authority policy officers to deliver the professional learning session. The principal said they “had a process organised” and the Education Authority provided the content (ideological code). Despite the messages being prepared by the policy officers, the visibility of institutional mandate was not immediately apparent, teachers talked of the NCCD requirements as being a school process.

A key message from the professional learning was the necessity for classroom teachers to have accurate student information. This meant keeping records of educational adjustments provided to students with disability in their class. Just like the NCCD SLT, teachers were made aware of a minimum evidentiary threshold, and without sufficient evidence there would be negative funding consequences for the school. The institutional discourse regulated the NCCD work at schools and was focused on collecting sufficient evidence to count students in the NCCD to maintain funding.

Smith (1999) explains how institutional discourse mediates actions, “the relations of text-mediated discourse are themselves actual as activities and the ordering of



activities...always in the time they occurred in and during the time they perdured” (p. 75).

The everyday work of the NCCD SLT was hooked into the institutional discourse about evidence and funding for students with disability, framed by texts that carry authority, such as the ideological codes of the professional learning program (Darville, 2014; Grant et al., 2017). The emerging institutional discourse had the power to coordinate the actions of the NCCD SLT and sequences of actions in similar ways across sites (Smith, 1999). How this discourse coordinated the work of classroom teachers is considered in Chapter Six and for policy officers, Chapter Seven.

### **5.2.1 How did professional learning lead to talk of funding?**

The Education Authority ensured the NCCD SLT, and classroom teachers were informed of the issues of student funding, and the outcome that was contingent upon their work. Margaret, the principal of PPS, foregrounded how funding for students with disability was now hooked into their everyday and introduced a level of accountability for teachers:

Yes, I also, and in the, partly in the back of their [teachers] mind is that that they’re going to get into trouble for not doing it, or not doing the right thing, or that the school’s going to lose funding, or there is this external pressure. There is something like this cloud hanging over them, that what they do is going to have a negative impact on somewhere else, bigger than themselves, or bigger than the school. And they don’t want to do that (Margaret, Interview 1, September 7, 2018).

Margaret identified factors such as “external pressure”, “getting into trouble” and “doing the right thing” were “clouds hanging over them”. These were new burdens for school staff, underpinned by the need to maintain a certain level of funding for students with disability. Furthermore, the “negative impact on someone else, bigger themselves or bigger than school” makes visible collective pressures and responsibilities on classroom teachers that have implications beyond the school.

Jennifer, principal of HPS, also explained how policy officers contributed to maintaining the institutional ideological code, in which she described Maria (senior policy officer) talking about the NCCD, which activated sequences of actions at her school:

I think it was probably...clarifying an awareness that all principals had anyway, but I think from the, the [Education Authority] perspective, and that's what Maria [senior policy officer] was also giving, was also just making sure that we were aware of the, not the consequence, but the process and also of the significance of that funding moving forward to. I think that's, so hers was, not so much what you have to do, but that bigger picture of why (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 9, 2018).

It was evident that the issue of funding for students with disability featured prominently in the institutional discourse, however, this does not fully explain the intricate relationships between those at the frontline and how NCCD knowledge is socially organised. The principals talked about an early morning breakfast meeting attended by regional school principals, held at the beginning of the school year, and the NCCD was on the agenda. This immediately signalled, to these principals, that their colleagues gave the NCCD a high priority. Agenda items for these meetings are mostly urgent matters, and even more so for meetings at the beginning of the school year, as Jennifer explained:

usually our [senior manager] picks up and sets an agenda, certainly principals can add to an item that goes on the agenda if it's something that's, you know, specific to that term, I'm not sure who put it on the agenda, I just know that it was one of ours (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 9, 2018).

At this breakfast meeting, the senior policy officer briefed principals about the NCCD requirements. This was another opportunity for the Education Authority to make sure principals understood the importance of collecting evidence of educational adjustments provided to students with disability because from 2018 these data were to be used to

determine funding. The 2018 collection was the first time the Australian Government used the NCCD census submission to determine funding for students with disability in 2019. The NCCD is a retrospective payment of adjustments provided, and the data collection was now high stakes.

Principals and senior policy officers received an email communique from the Education Authority executive directing them to participate in NCCD professional learning. In this same communication concerns about student funding were raised, and the negative impact that reduced funding would have if the NCCD requirements were not adequately implemented:

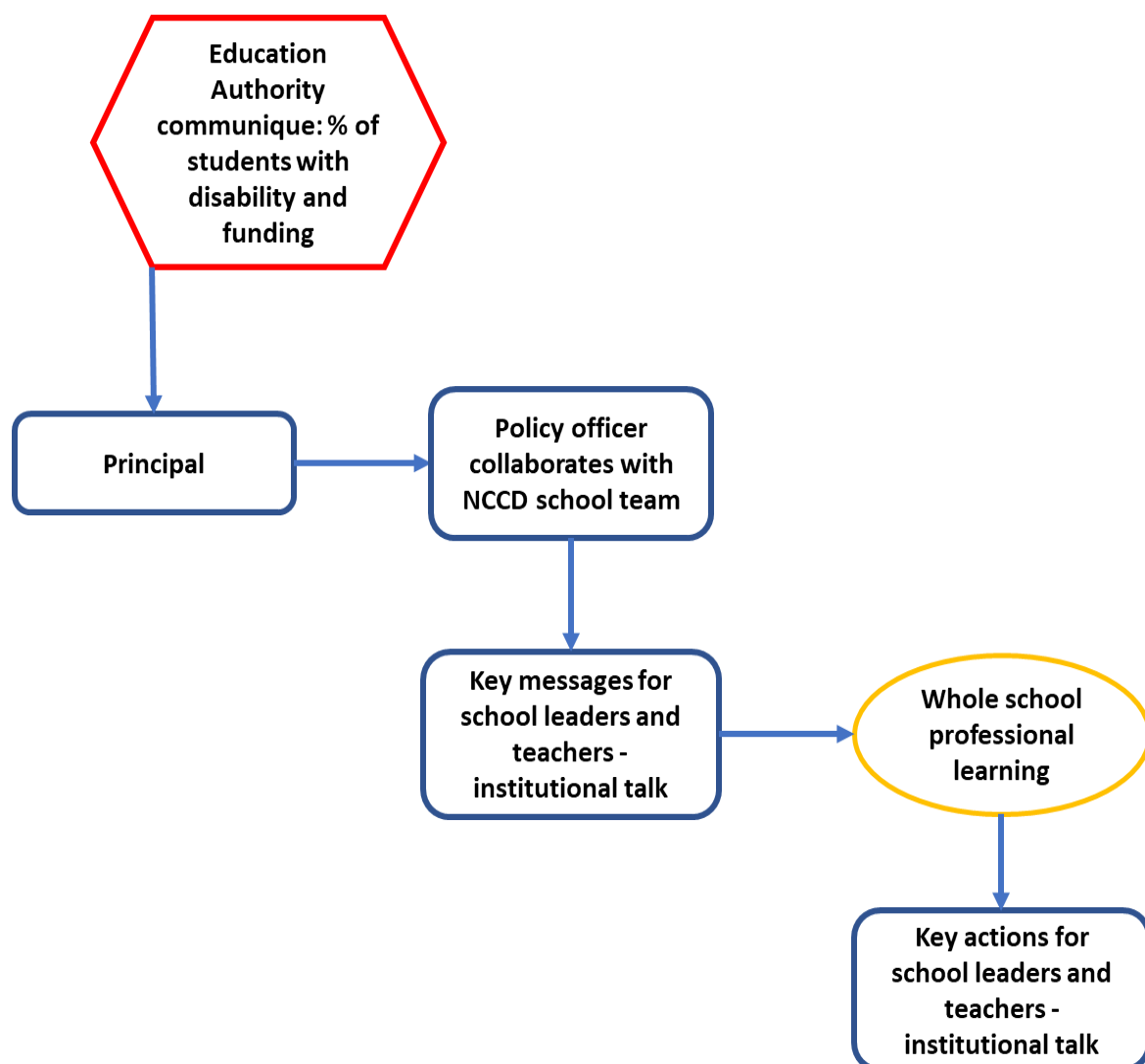
NCCD count is likely to have significant consequences on our level of funding as the proportion of students identified in our schools is markedly lower than other sectors. States and the national average (18%). Lower levels of funding will mean we will not be able to provide the support these students' needs to actively engage in their learning (Education Authority, 2018, p. 1) (see Appendix I: Education Authority communique).

The crux of the communication was about proportionate numbers of students with disability and funding. This institutional discourse established a target to be achieved, 18% of students with disability was the national average, and in so doing focussed all NCCD activities on funding (not teacher planning). However, what was not clear in the communication, was if there was an expectation that each school should have a proportionate enrolment of 18% of students with disability. For example, were targets being set for schools to either increase or decrease the proportion of students with disability enrolled to achieve the 18%; either by enrolling or identifying more students with disability or identifying fewer students as having disability.

In this communication there was no mention of teacher planning for adjustments, instead, schools with “anomalies based on this comparison [percentage of students with

disability]” will be contacted by a senior policy officer “to discuss and consider any support needed to quality assure data for your school” (Education Authority, 2018, p. 1) (see Appendix I: Education Authority communique).

**Figure 5.2** *Mapping the workflow*



The sequence of actions from this communication to professional learning for schools is presented as a map in Figure 5.2, commencing with student funding, and ending with actions for teachers about ensuring students’ information is correct.

Fiona, the newly appointed learning support teacher at HPS explained how she came to know the importance of getting the student data right:

I arrived at [HPS], operating at a very low base, in Term One, the way I actually experienced it was as a series of rumblings, you know, it was mentioned at our [learning] support teacher induction day<sup>2</sup>, it was mentioned again, at our [learning] support teacher day<sup>3</sup>, I think it may have been Peter [policy officer] ... Well, they, they did cover a lot of ground. It was an incredibly very useful day. The main reference that was made to NCCD, there was, it's very very important that you get it right, more information will follow, that was the key take home, this has implications for your funding. And I suppose, and it's one thing that I really appreciate about Peter, he's really clear about what he does and what he's in charge of, and it really is about numbers, it's about numbers and data...so, there's that message, don't put the wrong students into your list, don't put your students in the wrong category, think really carefully about this (Fiona, Interview 1, September 12, 2018).

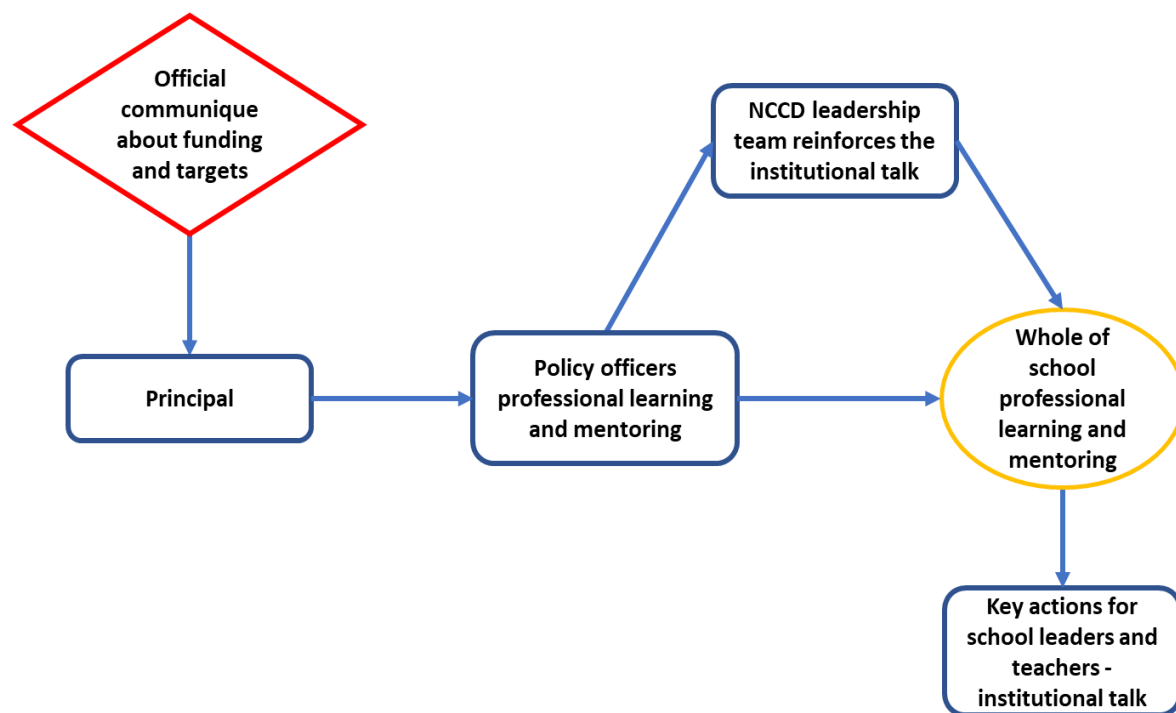
The necessity to “get it right” and “don't put the wrong students into your list” was communicated by the Education Authority and actioned by principals at the local level. The institutional demand to “get it right”, reinforced by language like “anomalies” and “quality assurance”, led the principals to focus their attention on ensuring a list of students would be produced for the purposes of meeting accountability demands. The communicate, an email, had textual power to coordinate the actions of the principal and the NCCD SLT, as well as the policy officers to deliver the key messages as presented in Figure 5.3 below.

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<sup>2</sup> Induction is a professional learning day for newly appointed learning support teachers facilitated by the Education Authority.

<sup>3</sup> The support teacher day is a professional learning held every school term for all learning support teachers in the region.

**Figure 5.3** *Institutional circuit mediated by language*



The institutional discourse about funding and targets of 18% in the official communeque is powerfully translocal; chains of actions were activated showing how peoples' daily work was being socially organised in similar ways across multiple sites (Turner, 2006). The institutional discourse about student data was established, people were using similar language to describe their own work, and were having similar kinds of conversations with classroom teachers.

Consequent to this institutional discourse, principals, Jennifer (HPS) and Margaret (PPS) considered their own next steps. While entirely separate to each other, the way they each actioned the new institutional demands of anomaly checks, quality assurance and getting the data right was remarkably similar. Their actions made visible, the translocal power of the communeque from the Education Authority beyond any of the official NCCD texts provided by the Australian Government to guide implementation.

### 5.3 SUPPORTING TEACHER WITH THE WORK OF THE NCCD

As the NCCD SLTs at both schools came to understand the requirements of the NCCD, the realisation this new work had the potential to increase the work of classroom teachers was significant. The requirement to “get it [data] right” was potentially overwhelming for classroom teachers and the NCCD SLT alike. Interestingly both schools responded similarly to concerns about work intensification in the same two ways. First, to immediately generate a list of students to be counted in the NCCD at the AG School Census in August. This text, *The List*, was quite literally a list of students with disability. The List identified students for whom teachers had to record and collect evidence of educational adjustments they provided. Second, both principals found ways to internally reorganise school resources to assist classroom teachers with the administrative work of the NCCD.

As the school year had already commenced, this meant their school budgets were already set, however, both schools reconsidered priorities and funding to accommodate the new work of the NCCD of recording detailed adjustments and collating evidence of these adjustments. Consequently, they reorganised school resources (e.g., staff allocations, professional learning budgets and so on) to enable the new work of the NCCD to happen, with the intention of managing the increased workload on teachers. Jodie, the curriculum lead teacher from PPS poignantly described her reaction when she and fellow members of the NCCD SLT realised the work of the NCCD:

We had Carol [policy officer] come out a couple of times. We had, is it Mary? Maria [senior policy officer], oh my goodness, she was amazing. So, the day she came out, I felt like I could’ve physically been sick, when she put up everything that we needed to have. And I just thought how do I, how do we, take this to the staff. It was pretty huge (Jodie, Interview 1, August 29, 2018).

Jodie had a visceral response to the overwhelming nature of the directions from the Education Authority, as it was told to her by Maria, a senior policy officer, “I could’ve physically been sick”. It was in this moment that she realised that the teachers’ workload was going to be “pretty huge” despite several earlier sessions with Carol. The opportunity to go over the key messages a few times to really understand the enormity of work ahead was significant because this activated a sequence of actions. It became evident to the members of the NCCD SLT that there was an emergent and urgent need to find practical and constructive ways to provide support to classroom teachers to undertake this new work. How these two schools provided this support was different, but with the same intent, of assisting classroom teachers to manage the workload.

### **5.3.1 Students are on The List**

The textual power of The List, an unofficial NCCD text, was immediately evident. During multiple conversations there was frequent reference made to The List. As a text, The List transcended locations, it held the same meaning across sites and across multiple role holders, which was, these are the students that were included in the NCCD count and for whom teachers were required to have detailed evidence of adjustments. The List was produced and maintained by the NCCD SLT. At the time of the inquiry, the NCCD had been operating for several years, which enabled a turnover of The List from one year to the next. With the new school year, the new list became an amalgamation of The List from the previous year, and newly identified students with disability. Students on The List either had an EAP verification (see Chapter Four) or were students who were not making educational gains in literacy and/or numeracy at the same rate as their peers.

The List’s textual power directed classroom teachers’ attention to students on it, with expectations of what needed to happen - record and collect evidence of educational



adjustments. The List informed classroom teachers of which students in their class required educational adjustment and the level of educational support required for each student.

At the beginning of the school year, classroom teachers were given The List with pre-allocated levels of adjustment and categories of disability. For example, student A is supplementary and cognitive; student B is substantial and sensory (see Appendix F, Table F1 for more information about CoD, see Chapter Four for more information about the LoA). The LoA on The List then directed teachers to the types of educational adjustments they were expected to make and what types of evidence they needed to collate, as explained by Olivia (classroom teacher), “these are the children, this is the level, you need to collect the data” (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018). The NCCD SLT also provided instructions about data storage and maintenance of the evidence. It was through these experiential accounts of the informants that the act-text-act sequence of The List was revealed (Campbell, 2006), the actions to produce The List, and then what happens because of it. The textual power of The List was translocal, meaning it was replicated across sites.

Although the production of The List was a localised school action there was oversight from the Education Authority. Advice (direction) from an Education Authority policy officer given to the school included which students should be on The List and in some instances what level of adjustment the student should be allocated:

it was really our judgement to make based on the data, our knowledge of students and also some directions from Peter [policy officer] that I don’t necessarily agree with professionally, but will willingly work as directed, not being so, for example, every [EAP] verified student has to be listed as at least supplementary...with respect to our little guy with [complex medical needs and a physical disability], Peter [policy officer] sent an email when he approved his verification for physical impairment...this little guy needs direct individual supervision each time he eats and

drinks, because of the small but still very significant risk of choking. He said I'm also assuming that you're going to add him to your NCCD data as extensive (Fiona, Interview 1, September 12, 2018).

As a "verified student", this student was also eligible for EAP funding from the state government (see Chapter Four, section 4.5), the direction provided by the policy officer, based on the EAP verification, was a blurring of two funding mechanisms. The expectation was that schools were to manage both systems concurrently (and still are). The general direction from the Education Authority displaced local discretion and was located in the ideological code presented during the professional learning; students with an EAP verification should be at least supplementary level (a funded level of the NCCD, see Chapter Four). The directive, from the policy officer, was given without knowing the student or being part of the any planning for educational adjustments, regardless, the student with "complex medical needs and a physical disability" should be placed at the extensive level. The policy officer had the capacity to shape how the NCCD work was activated translocally. Fiona explained how she complied with the direction:

Fiona: Yeah, and I think am still very, wary of that, I don't feel comfortable with it. I think the appropriate level of adjustment for that child is substantial.

Jeanine: So, what did you end up putting in?

Fiona: Extensive because I was directed to, and Jennifer's my line manager, and Jennifer said it's come from Peter, that's how we're going to do it, and if we're queried, it goes back to Peter (Fiona, Interview 1, September 12, 2018).

The process of placing a student on The List, was work that happened translocally and, at times, away from the school. The oversight of The List by the Education Authority mediated the actualities of the NCCD work across locations. Fiona's words, "because I was directed to" and her explanation of the chains of authority from her line manager and beyond illustrate

the emerging relations of rule in which teachers' everyday work was coordinated from beyond the local.

### ***How else do students get on The List?***

The initial question of how students got on The List was met with ambiguous responses. No-one really seemed to know how it happened, only that it existed. The List had textual power to coordinate significant translocal and ongoing actions of the informants. Upon a few moments of reflection (and some gentle nudging), the informants confidently identified students with an EAP verification were on The List. But beyond that, they were less confident. As Debra, the curriculum lead teacher, explained the sequence of actions for how students were placed on The List:

Ok, so, first of all we started with a list of children who had verifications who were already receiving funding and we looked at, the level of adjustments which the children were receiving and required, we then also looked at, children who, we knew were also receiving considerable adjustments but not necessarily with any kind of a verification some of them have a diagnosis around other things but not verifiable...and the level of adjustment for those children (Debra, Interview 1, August 28, 2018).

When a student with an EAP verification (see section 4.5) was included on The List, this was done without the need for further investigation into the actual provision of educational adjustments. But for those students without an EAP verification, they “looked at, children who, were also receiving considerable adjustments”. Debra’s response puts teachers’ work into the frame, understanding how this happened was the next thread to follow.

How did the school team decide which students were receiving “considerable adjustments”? These students were not known to the Education Authority by any other means other than The List that was assembled by local school processes. Although Debra described

how The List was assembled, it was through participant observation which is “grounded in actual events [curriculum planning at both schools] from which descriptions and stories are derived” that revealed the complexity of this work (Diamond, 2006, p. 58). I attended curriculum planning sessions led by the curriculum lead teacher in both schools, Jodie (PPS) and Debra (HPS) in September and October, respectively.

As each of these curriculum planning sessions commenced, I noted that teachers in both schools were extremely focused on transcribing student results onto a large wall chart that was the length of the wall (approximately five metres wide) and at least one metre in height, the school *data wall* (Harris et al., 2018, p. 18). At HPS, the source of this information being transcribed was an online repository of student results that was located within the Education Authority’s student data centre or business intelligence tool (BI tool). At PPS, teachers had their own excel spreadsheet that was either printed or on their computer. When I inquired as to what they were doing, the teachers explained that they were putting the student results from the Progressive Achievement Test in Reading (PAT-R), and the Progressive Achievement Test in Mathematics (PAT-M) that were recorded in the school repository onto the data wall. The PAT-R and the PAT-M are standardised assessment tools that were prescribed by the Education Authority as part of the annual educational testing regime.

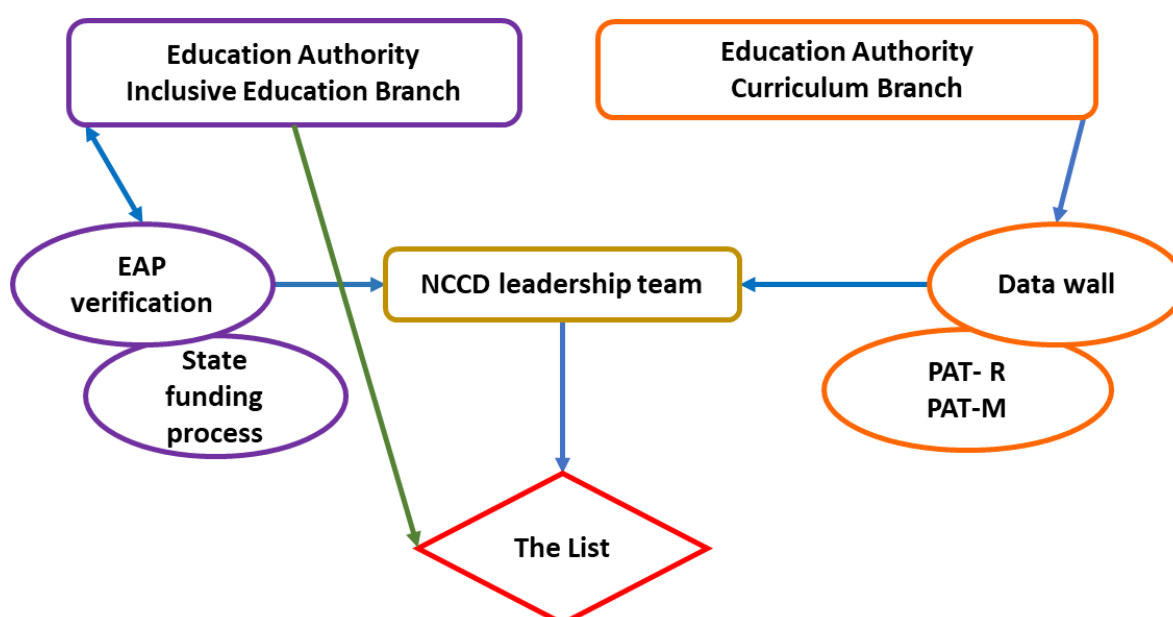
The purpose of the data wall was to plot the PAT-R and PAT-M results of every student in the class, to track and monitor their test results over time (Field Note 1, September 19, 2018; Field Note 2, October 17, 2018). As the curriculum lead teachers described this work, undertaken by themselves and classroom teachers, the textual power of these literacy and numeracy standardised test results were revealed. Students with low test scores were students requiring “considerable adjustments”. That is, literacy and numeracy data gathered through in-class standardised assessments became a key text in the creation of The List.

Students requiring “considerable adjustments” were included on The List as a student with disability.

To summarise, The List was assembled first with students with an EAP verification. They were included automatically, no questions asked, for which there was a level of oversight or surveillance from the Education Authority to ensure these students were on The List at the “right level”. Second, students placed below year level expectations on the school data wall were added to The List. The textual power of The List was significant, it mediated actions at the local school level, the Education Authority, and beyond, as these students were included in national reporting data about students with disability and funded by the Australian Government. The textual power of The List was far reaching.

The NCCD SLT used The List to coordinate their work and that of teachers. This sequence mapped in Figure 5.4 reveals the “processing interchange(s)” that occurred to assemble The List (Pence, 2001, p. 204). Students can, theoretically, be in either stream - EAP or data wall, or both. For example, a student with a “verified disability” (EAP stream) and not progressing with literacy or numeracy, can technically be in both streams. However, this was not the practice.

**Figure 5.4** *Assembling The List*



Students with an EAP were automatically included in the EAP stream regardless of their results on the standardised assessments. To have an EAP verification, means the student had a medical diagnosis of disability; a verification is determined by the submission of medical reports and detailed information about educational needs to the Education Authority to be “verified” by a disability expert. This means there was detailed information about a student with an EAP verification within the organisation, but more importantly, a verified student was given the institutional status of meeting all the accountability requirements for the NCCD (Queensland Department of Education, 2019b). The Education Authority maintains a database of every student with an EAP verification, detailing the verification status and retains all supporting records for the verification application. Data about students not achieving year level expectations via the prescribed assessment tools was used to build the school data wall. Student results from these tests were maintained on the Education Authority’s data management system. The List was submitted to the Education Authority in preparation for the August census, which afforded the Education Authority a level of data surveillance and high-level data reporting, which could be potentially used to predict proportionate numbers of students with disability in schools.

To assemble The List, students with an EAP verification or had test results below expectation (displayed on the data wall) were on it. The List was authored by the NCCD SLT, with oversight from the Education Authority (note the green arrow in Figure 5.4). Notably absent in Figure 5.4 were the actions of parents/carers/guardians (parents/carers) of the students who were included in the NCCD count. In 2018, the parent/carer of students with disability were not required to give permission for their child to be included in the NCCD count. However, schools were obligated to inform the parent/carer community that the NCCD count was occurring (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice

on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). Also absent in this textual sequence are teachers. They had no role in managing The List.

The interconnections of this complex sequence, the processing interchanges schematically represented in Figure 5.4, are “the organisational occasions of action in which one practitioner receives from another a document” (DeVault & McCoy, 2006, p. 30). As The List was assembled, whether it was part of a directive from the Education Authority about students with an EAP verification, or students being tracked on the school data wall, each of these interchanges were connected to a whole process. As the discussion above illustrates, these interchanges were components of a broader “sequence of institutional actions” that produced The List which then coordinated further actions for teachers, school leaders and policy officers (Wilson & Pence, 2006, p. 204). The production of texts at each of the “process interchanges” were designed to assist practitioners to produce the next text in the sequence (Pence, 2001). For example, there is a data system managed by the Education Authority for students with an EAP verification, policy officers from the Education Authority used this text to communicate with school leaders about including specific students on the NCCD count, and at what level. It was these texts that coordinated the actions of school staff in relation to The List, the social organisation of knowledge (D. E. Smith, 1990a), which meant the textual sequence of getting on The List was able to be mapped.

### ***How do students get off The List?***

The institutional chains of action to get a student on The List were embedded into the ideological code. Students with EAP verifications were automatically on The List. Students who were in the process of being EAP verified were added once this was completed. Students who were on The List in previous year were automatically rolled into the current list and students with low test scores on the PAT-R or PAT-M, as recorded on the data wall, were on The List because they required “significant adjustments”. Getting on The List seemed to be

an organised process, so how might students get off The List? It was established very early in conversations the authority and responsibility for The List was with the NCCD SLT. Despite probing about how a student might get off The List with a member of the NCCD SLT, this question was overlooked, and even when asked more directly, the conversation shifted back to how to maintain evidence for a student who was already on The List. As Jodie described, it was the capacity to produce physical evidence that was the priority for their attention:

And it's really important. The heartbreaking thing that we found when we were going through the process with everybody over the three, two or three days, was that what about this child, and what about this one, and you, what evidence do you have (Jodie, Interview 1, August 29, 2018).

Jodie recalled discussions with teachers about which students were The List, being driven by “what evidence do you have”. Without physical evidence of educational adjustments students were not included in the NCCD count. During the process of checking evidence, teachers raised concerns about students in their class that had not met any of the authorised ways of being on The List, this was “heartbreaking” for Jodie, because without evidence they could not be on The List. However, what was missed in this exchange, was whether teachers were raising concerns about student learning or whether there was no evidence of educational adjustments. Meeting the evidentiary requirements for the NCCD mediated ruling relations, there was no space for other conversations, it was all about getting on The List and maintaining The List. There was little institutional attention given to getting students off The List, once on, or exploring other ways students could get on The List.

### ***The disjuncture of The List***

The sequences of actions used to assemble The List presents a disjuncture between the everyday lived experiences of frontline workers and the official account of how the NCCD model was to be implemented, and how students are included in the NCCD count

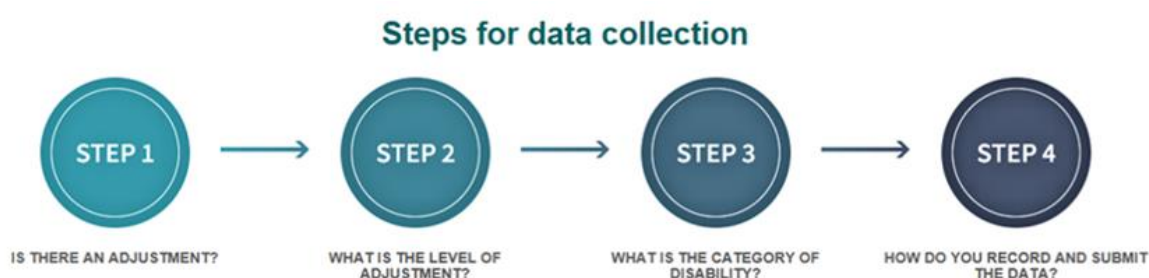


(DeVault, 2009; DeVault & McCoy, 2006). The dissonance between the embodied lived experience of those at the frontline and the official account of how students were included in the NCCD is significant. The official NCCD process for identifying students with disability begins with the provision of educational adjustments:

School teams assess their student population to determine which students are being provided with adjustments to access education because of disability, consistent with definitions and obligations under the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 and the Standards (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018, p. 10).

Commencing with students receiving educational adjustments, as the official first step, which is counter to the instruction of what evidence needs to be collected. The NCCD model is a four-step process, (see Figure 5.5); first, determine if the student is receiving an adjustment due to disability. In this model the adjustments are provided first by the teacher as part of their day-to-day teaching, not because the student was on a list. Second, the official sequence is to determine the LoA. The decision about LoA is intended to come from the adjustments provided, it is not intended that adjustments are provided to a specified level. The third step in the official sequence is to decide the CoD, and finally step four is to record and submit the data (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018; Education Services Australia, 2018).

**Figure 5.5** 2017 NCCD steps for data collection



The disjuncture between this official account, and the everyday experiences as described by the informants changed how the NCCD model was implemented; and in this change of implementation there was a change of effect for students with disability and the role of the teacher. This disjuncture commenced with the assembly of The List, which organised work in a different way to the official account contained in the NCCD model, bringing into focus the accountability work of ensuring students were included in the NCCD count, including the focus on collecting sufficient evidence (Pence, 2001; Smith, 1999; Smith et al., 2006). The NCCD model was not used to guide the decision-making process of the NCCD SLT, from the perspective of classroom teachers, which is discussed in more detail in Chapter Five.

The List powerfully regulated chains of actions by coordinating the work of the NCCD SLT. They were keen to provide practical support and guidance to classroom teachers to guarantee they had collected evidence for the right students. The production of evidence of adjustments became new work for teachers and members of the NCCD SLT (Ball, 2000). The NCCD SLT designed local solutions for the production and storage of evidence, to “be accountable” to the Education Authority (Ball, 2000). The production of evidence templates by the NCCD SLT, a performative output for accountability purposes, became the NCCD work rather than teachers drawing on current practices of planning and recording evidence of adjustments for students with disability (Ball, 2000). The NCCD SLT were instrumental in reorganising the internal school structures, including the redeployment of staff, to make sure of the collection and the safe storage of evidence.

### **5.3.2 Beyond The List; managing the new work and workload of the NCCD**

The textual power of The List, as an organising text, was evident in both schools. The List directed focused work on specific students, which included planning adjustments but also meant there were school planning meetings about these students and meetings with policy officers and so on (Goodman Rigby et al., 2017; Honig & Hatch, 2004). When Jodie

realised the intensity of the (new) work required to meet these institutional demands of the NCCD, she described it as making her feel “physically sick”. To manage the perceived work intensification, both principals undertook a process of “bridging or buffering” (Honig & Hatch, 2004, p. 17) by which deliberate decisions were made about how to accommodate new institutional policy demands by discerning what aspects of the NCCD requirements were to be prioritised and then reorganising school structures to make it happen (Honig & Hatch, 2004; Rutledge et al., 2010). When principals buffer new policy demands from the Education Authority, the intention is to reduce the perceived burden of new or additional work.

### ***Providing support to manage the NCCD workload – production and storage of evidence***

As the NCCD SLT grappled with the NCCD requirements, they sought ways of providing practical support to teachers. For example, the PPS NCCD SLT designed a data collection tool for teachers. This tool was shared at a professional learning session facilitated by a policy officer, which added a level of Education Authority endorsement for the tool. Rebecca, the learning support teacher, explained how the data collection tool was made available and then how it was used:

So, after we had our Mary PD [policy officer], which was like, PD [professional development] week Term One, before school started... So then at one of the planning days at the first couple of weeks of term, Jodie [curriculum lead teacher] and the year two teachers were talking about how we were going to record adjustments... Mary had given us an example of OOO School, what they do, like a tick and flick. It was decided by Jodie that they would make up an A3 book... You should have a look at one of them. A laminated green cover. On the inside was that levels of adjustments one sheet, and then there was 30 pages of the same page... OOO School, a high school, they took off the name, so it was that. I did express my concerns because some of the check points... wasn't relevant for our school and what was presented to

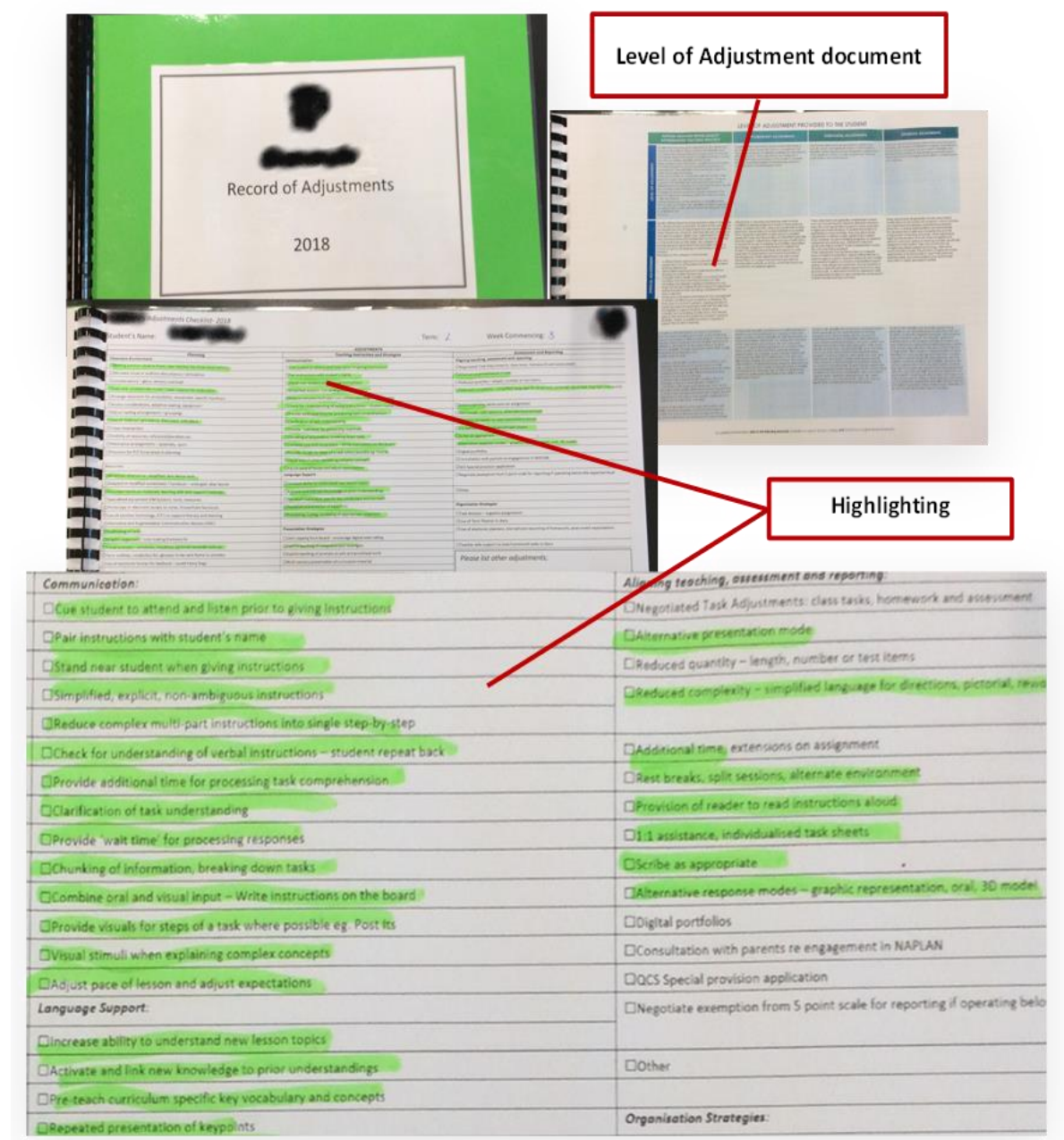
the staff that tomorrow onwards if you have a child that is verified, or you have a concern for you're going to have big green book...some teachers had like four big A3 books. Then everyone was saying too much...Teachers were expected every week to fill it out. So, you ticked what adjustments you were making that week and dated it. And then you're at Week Two, and you do the same thing...teachers have these big green books, the year 6 teachers were going home with the big green books on the weekend and ticking it and writing notes in it. And she had like piles of green books (Rebecca, Interview 1, August 28, 2018).

The green cover was laminated, the next page was the Level of Adjustment document (LoA document), an official NCCD text, and subsequent pages were the same page thirty times, where teachers could tick to record adjustments provided to the student (see Figure 5.6). New language was emerging, the “big green book” had meaning at PPS, it was a term used by all staff. The “big green book” listed a series of generic educational adjustments, for which the origin was not known. The A3 sheet had three columns, under the following broad headings - planning, teaching instructions and strategies, and assessment and reporting. When teachers were provided with The List, they were also given a “big green book” for every “child that is verified or you have a concern for” (yet students of concern could not be added to The List). The production and distribution of this resource was the work of the learning support teacher.

The learning support teacher worked with teachers to show them how to use the ‘big green book’. For 10-weeks, teachers were expected to highlight adjustments provided. Each page had a box at the bottom right hand corner that allowed for recording unlisted adjustments provided (there was no evidence this function was used). At the top of each page was the student’s name, the week, and the school term. To include a student in the NCCD count there is a minimum requirement of at least 10-weeks of adjustments (see section 4.5),

this means for every student, there were enough pages in the “big green book” to meet this accountability requirement.

**Figure 5.6** The “big green book”



Solutions to manage the workload were translocal, the “big green book” was originally sourced from another school and shared with PPS by the policy officer. The policy officer, the learning support teacher and curriculum leader reviewed the menu of the adjustments teachers could choose, thereby making the documents relevant to their primary

school setting before book production began. The translocal nature of the data collection for NCCD was evident, as was the responsabilisation of teachers' everyday work with new accountabilities (Gallagher & Spina, 2019; Kerr, 2014). However, the “big green book” failed to deliver the expected scaffolds for teachers (teachers' work is discussed in detail in Chapter Six). It was onerous to complete, and it did not allow for documenting any actual evidence of the adjustments as required by the NCCD policy in any of the following four areas, see Table 5.2 below:

**Table 5.2** *Four areas of evidence for the NCCD*

| Four areas of evidence required for the NCCD                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• the assessed individual needs of the student</li> <li>• consultation and collaboration with the parent/carer and/or student,</li> <li>• planning adjustments,</li> <li>• tracking, monitoring, and reviewing adjustments</li> </ul> |

(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018).

The PPS NCCD SLT received additional advice from the Education Authority about recording and documenting evidence of adjustments, which led to the “big green book” being discarded in favour of a new system. Jodie, curriculum lead teacher, explained:

I think we're definitely working towards a school-wide process. We have on, we've got, we began a folder last term, and we asked anyone who had had a modified assessment, any adjustments, please pop them download them into the folder...we had staff coming in and out of that room, it was crazy. Rebecca [learning support teacher] and I just coming in with people, explaining it. Everybody was learning together. So, I think everybody very quickly understood what we need to collect from now on. So, Rebecca, after Maria [senior policy officer] came, she had the four titles

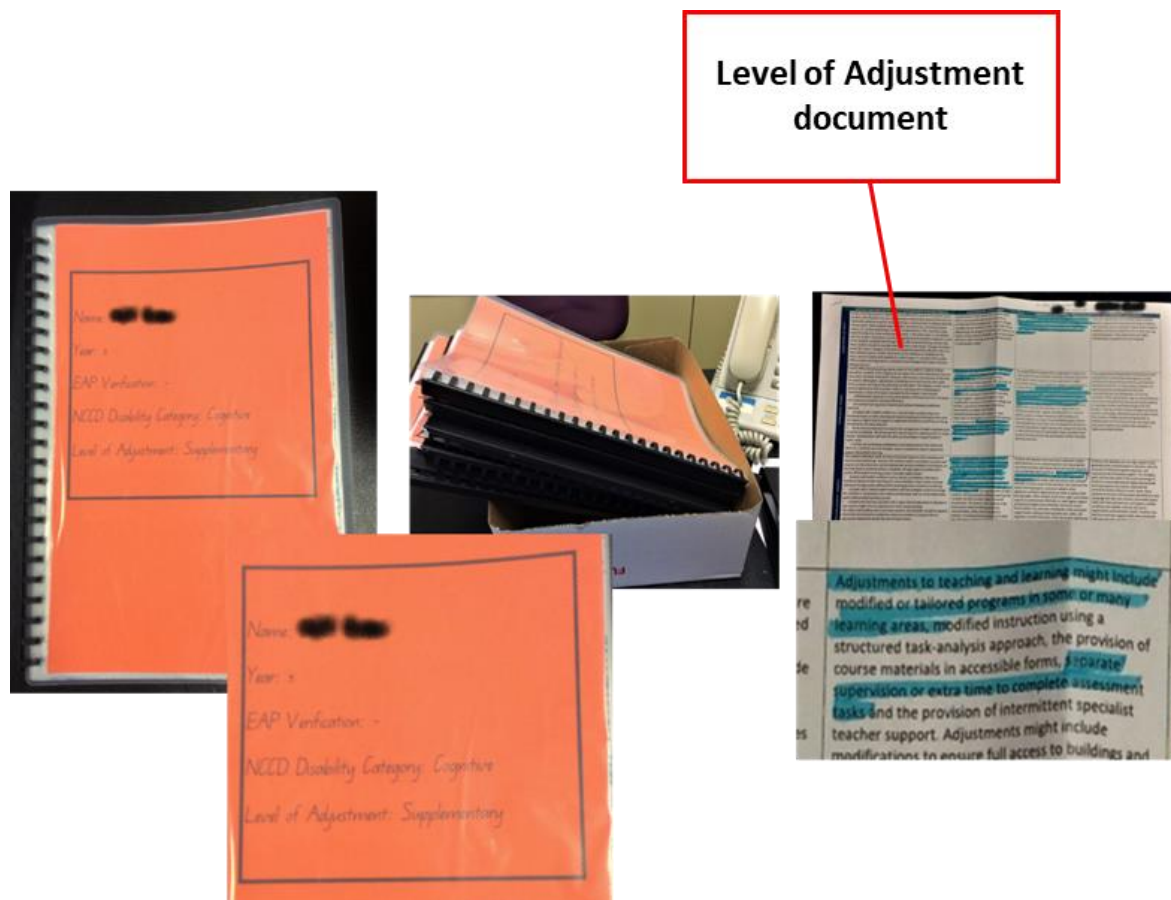
on the board that we need to have evidence for. And so that's how we had our folders (Jodie, Interview 1, August 29, 2018).

Maria, a senior policy officer, provided direction and guidance as to what evidence was required against “four titles”, the prescribed areas of evidence from the NCCD requirements (see Table 5.2 above). These student folders were created by the learning support teacher and issued to teachers at the beginning of Term Two (April) replacing the “big green book”. Teachers were required to use this new system of data collection.

The preparation and distribution of these folders, one for every student on The List, was a considerable time commitment for the curriculum lead teacher and learning support teacher. These folders served as a storage management system for evidence of adjustments provided to each student on The List, new folders were created for the next school semester, which commenced in July. Similarly, to the first set of folders, the second student folders were divided into four evidence sections for teachers to add their data.

The front cover of the folder detailed the student, the LoA and the CoD. Teachers were released from their regular duties to meet with members of the NCCD SLT, during two or three days, where teachers were “coming in and out of the room”, to complete the evidence collection prior to the August census. Teachers were given extra time to curate their evidence, in consultation with NCCD SLT. This provided certainty or assurance that the evidence provided corresponded with the pre-determined LoA specified on The List (see Figure 5.7). The principal supported this activity by funding replacement teachers to release classroom teachers from their regular teaching duties as per the pre-organised meeting schedule; this was a significant redeployment of school resources.

**Figure 5.7** Boxes of folders



This additional work of documenting and collecting evidence of educational adjustments was significant, as noted by the principal of PPS, Margaret. She was looking to provide practical support:

Exponential jump, what I think it's the fact that teachers have been doing their planning, but it's not recorded. Or they have not realised what they're doing actually is meeting all those 4 steps, the 4 levels of that, the NCCD. Yeah, it required time, effort, people knew what they were doing. But they also had to have evidence of it. For example, a photo of somebody doing whatever, a short video showing where this child is being supported that is more than classroom expectation. It's just the recording, it's the time that's needed and know what to be looking for. So, yes there has been exponential; absolute exponential, and I think the catalyst has been the



cutting, the possible cutting of funding or reduction in funding. That's been the catalyst for people get their finger out and do a heck of lot more in terms of the recording. It's not that they're not doing it, it's the recording of the doing (Margaret, Interview 1, 4 September 2018).

This description of work by Margaret, "it's not that they're not doing it, it's the recording of the doing" exemplifies how New Public Management (NPM) has transformed public services such as education. As a school, Margaret now found herself spending significant amounts of time working with a preponderance of documents that would meet government demands for standardised evidence. As Margaret makes clear, teachers and principals were not being supported to do a better job of providing adjustments for students; rather, their time was being redirected towards documenting and reporting evidence. Margaret explained there was an "exponential jump...to have evidence", beyond what teachers had done previously for the NCCD or recording planning for students with disability generally. The evidence produced represented objectified versions of teachers' work. Until this point, teachers' experience of this work was notably absent. However, Margaret "bridged" the NCCD requirements and the associated workload through an internal budget reallocation to buy time for teachers to undertake the additional administrative load:

Good, ok, what happened was, last year, I had a bit of extra, some of the G2G [Good to Great, government funding for teacher development] money that I didn't expend, adding that from last year to this year's amount...I had money from last year and I carried it over, I had to get approval to carry it over, I carried it over and that has provided extra planning time [which was time given over to administrative duties]. Which has enabled a little bit more looking at it. But I don't think, that's not going happen next year because of the reduction in G2G money (Margaret, Interview 1, 4 September 2018).

Although Margaret “needed to get approval [from the Education Authority] to carry it over [the unexpended funds]”, these funds were prioritised for the data collection requirements of the NCCD. The approval of the Education Authority to reorganise the school budget was a significant endorsement. While this was a successful strategy in 2018, Margaret was concerned about the sustainability of this option going forward into the following school year, which was five months away from when we talked. Margaret was already expending time and energy on managing the NCCD for the following year.

Similarly, the principal of HPS, Jennifer, sought practical options to help the learning support teachers with the administrative demands of the NCCD requirements. Jennifer redeployed Chloe, a teacher assistant to work directly with teachers to discern which evidence should be uploaded to the school-based student file management system. Chloe was responsible for the administrative tasks of data management and uploading student information onto the school intranet, which had been done by the learning support teachers previously. To facilitate this support Jennifer needed to consider the broad complexities of school operations, decide who would be best placed to take on this new work and then explain to the whole staff the changes to work allocations. Pulling Chloe away from her usual duties meant this work was reallocated or left unattended. Jennifer’s rationale for approaching Chloe was because of her competent computer skills, knowledge of students on The List, previous working relationships with teachers and most importantly her capacity to self-organise:

So, look I think everyone knows that Fiona and Karen did a good job, but if they’d been able to get the information that they needed as far as classroom teachers I could see that they were getting themselves a little bit stressed again, so that’s where I put Chloe in place as someone as an additional support person to be able to just do the photocopying and getting the information that they needed, that was just that time

consuming admin stuff that teachers found difficult...because I think it's valuable, to be able to do that and it, it wasn't a really long time and it wasn't that expensive, we just, we just picked, you know a time in the week that she could devote to different teachers and they've let her know when they were available, when they needed her. So that, that, and there was a consistency too I think of the collections...I know the teachers liked it, they were very appreciative, they made mention of that. And not that you'd want to keep spoon feeding everybody and doing everything for them, but at the moment there is lots going on, so, and so some of those classes had multiple children in there and the teachers were already struggling with things anyway, so, so it was to help them. I think there was a lot more....hype about it this year. That there was...a lot of, seemed like a fair bit of stress that people had that we really have to make sure this is done and done well, because there is, the funding attached to it (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 7, 2018).

Having the teacher assistant, Chloe, support teachers with their collation of evidence was well received, "I know the teachers liked it, they were very appreciative". Jennifer described increased stress for teachers associated with the work, some of the time-consuming tasks that were undertaken and how important it was to alleviate the additional administrative burden that the NCCD policy requirements placed on teachers.

Jennifer, also talked about her increased workload and that of the other members of the NCCD SLT associated with administering the Education Authority prescribed range of assessment tools used to inform the school data wall:

[Education Authority] was going to be screening, and that we had to make sure that we had, you know, clearly looked at where we were actually putting children as well, it was a fair bit of discussion about that, but I also think it's like anything, the first time you do it you don't know, you think you're going a bit blind here. The second

time, you know, there's certainly was a bit of fine tuning this year with taking some children out that were on last year, and a fair bit, it's good to have a group, a fair bit, of discussion about where those needs are for some children, and particularly when you are supporting a child well, to realise that if you didn't have that support, how would they actually be managing, it's good to have those discussions...And what I see as good practice in teachers, I can honestly say, I know that is very different depending on the capabilities of each teacher as well (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 7, 2018).

Jennifer described the value of having a “discussion about where those needs are for some children”, and the support for teachers as being valuable. However, Jennifer also talked about how differences in teacher experiences and capacities to plan adjustments for students had consequences for her planning for the following year:

So, I suppose to give an example, there is that, I can have a verified student who's high needs and put them into one class and they've kept, you know, the teacher can make adjustments and that child can cope relatively well and I've put them in another classroom and that teacher is going to need a lot more support because their general capabilities are very different, they're experience and coping with children with different needs is very different so therefore I actually am going to need more specific adjustments to be made in that classroom and I'm actually going to need the funding and support for that child, so if I've lost it from the year before because the teacher was a capable teacher, you do the next year the teacher is not as capable (Jennifer, Interview 1, September 7, 2018).

Jennifer and Margaret, in their roles of principals, talked about teacher capacity to “make adjustments” and “cope” with students with disability, but there was no mention of release time to plan for these adjustments, only to collate evidence.

Both principals were alert to the impact that a reduction of funding could have on their schools. Like Margaret, Jennifer was already thinking about, and planning for, the following year, as students moved to new teachers. Margaret's concerns included students on The List moving to an early career teacher, as well managing disruptions to staffing and that NCCD funding is not responsive to such issues:

it [the NCCD] doesn't take into consideration, in one way when teachers change year levels, also, we've had like, about five changes in staff, probably a third of our teachers changed, so we've got, this year we've got three graduates. So, they don't do any of this at teachers, you know at uni, we've got now, well we had up until yesterday, we had two teachers off on sick leave or long service leave. Ones been off since Term One, during Term One....no, the beginning of Term Two, sorry. So therefore, we've got a relief teacher coming in, doesn't, isn't up to speed. And the relief teachers aren't up to speed on a lot of this. So, it becomes very difficult that you're expending not only your PD [professional development] money for current staff but also then trying to upskill relief teachers and who are in and out...And when you're looking at teachers with a change of school, you're thinking like, do I want to take that person because you want to find out what the PD that they've had, before you want to take them on. Because you start from scratch again. You think, you've got some who are proficient, very proficient, and you've got some that are not bad and then you've got some that are, and then you've got some with none (Margaret, Interview 1, September 4, 2018).

Although both Jennifer and Margaret saw the need to ensure there was school-wide consistent approach to data collection, Margaret's description of her embodied experience as the principal revealed the disjuncture between the objectified view of the policy (documenting adjustments) and managing the everyday realities of staffing. Margaret talked

about the need to upskill relief teachers, because “the relief teachers aren’t up to speed on a lot of this” and the impost this has on the professional development program and budget to ensure consistent practices across all teachers. While this work was important at the school level, it was invisible in The List or official accounts of teachers’ work.

Furthermore, as Jennifer and Margaret described their work, they revealed how they were crafting policy coherence, a process by which they were negotiating the goals of their respective schools and the requirements of the Education Authority about the NCCD (Goodman Rigby et al., 2017; Honig & Hatch, 2004). A cornerstone of this negotiation was the use of standardised assessment tools. Using standardised assessment tools or the Education Authority assessment tools was seen to be more reliable than teacher judgement, and therefore a safer option. Margaret’s preference for “quantitative results” was also a dilemma, a disjuncture:

Margaret: Some children can come up with quantitative results, we go, so therefore it’s questionable, some time if, and that just puts you in two minds, do you just rely on the data, but then you often need that data to really take the blinkers off to how you’re perceiving something. Is this rose-coloured glasses? Is it just your sole perception or is it that you have a personal interest in something? So, the quantitative data is important but not at the expense of seeing how that child relates in this situation. Whereas pen and paper and results can be quite distant. So, it’s a bit of a mix.

Jeanine: What do you think is the most important?

Margaret: Well, it needs to be quantitative in lots of ways because when somebody comes and challenges you, you’ve got evidence, that is, it can be backed up. So, you can be backed up, while it’s lovely to say yes,

because we're very much into an empirical society, that can be measured, sometimes people just can't be measured

Jeanine: In making a decision to impute a particular disability, the documentation says that we can use teacher judgement, but the reality is the YARC<sup>4</sup> or a Probe<sup>5</sup> or a PAT-M<sup>6</sup> or a PAT-R<sup>7</sup>, rather than even a teacher-generated assessment tool seems to have more carriage, more weight or more value, do you think

Margaret: That the YARC and all those things have more value, yes, they do

Jeanine: Than a teacher-generated test?

Margaret: Yes, they do, because some of those teacher-generated tests really can be, personal and can...can be swayed or weighted towards what they want to find, and that's, that's dangerous. I know what, you know, it's almost between a rock and a hard place (Margaret, Interview 2, November 20, 2018).

Margaret's dissonance as she talked was evident, "the quantitative data is important but not at the expense of seeing how that child relates in this situation...the YARC and all those things have more value...between a rock and a hard place". In this conversation, Margaret revealed a bifurcation of consciousness, in which she shared there are different ways of knowing students, there are "two distinctive, and often contradictory ways - as real people...and as text based objects" (Campbell, 2006, p. 95). She even explains these distinctive ways of knowing in describing this line of fault, "while it's lovely to say yes, because we're very much into an empirical society, that can be measured, sometimes people

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<sup>4</sup> York Assessment of Reading Comprehension

<sup>5</sup> Probe 2 Reading Comprehension Assessment

<sup>6</sup> Progressive Achievement Test - Mathematics

<sup>7</sup> Progressive Achievement Test - Reading

just can't be measured". This knowing was understanding the child and how they might navigate learning, and knowledge of the objectified data (text) which is the outcome of the standardised assessments, the child's results.

### ***Students as text-based objects***

The value placed on the reliability of standardised assessment test scores was beyond the embodied experiences of teachers working with students who required adjustments to accommodate additional learning needs. This objectified knowing of students was discussed by school counsellor, Linda from PPS as she explained the process commenced when the classroom teacher completed a lengthy document to "refer" a student for review by the school counsellor, the learning support teacher, and the principal, the SST. The SST meeting was scheduled to convene each fortnight to review new referral forms and to decide next steps, such as whether to investigate the student's learning needs. However, Linda explained that there were difficulties maintaining the meeting schedule due to numerous disruptions (e.g., staff absences, school timetable changes and so on). Linda explained how she came to know students:

Linda: Well, it probably starts with a referral to the team...And so then the team, as a team, we meet and discuss what kind of, you know what, what reports we already have that might indicate what kind of adjustments or supports they need. Or if there is no assessments that have been done by professionals in the community we might talk about, how, doing some observations to see what is going on for this student, and then, and then consult with the parent about what we might, either offer as assessments in the school or external, or you know recommend they seek external assessments



Jeanine: In the referral, the referral process that goes to the learning enhancement team...And then you talked about assessments, what kind of assessments would kids come with?

Linda: So they come with a speech language assessment or an auditory processing assessment, or an OT assessment, psychoeducational, some of them already had a cognitive assessment, just varies, learning assessments that might explore what might be going on to explain the, some of their difficulties that they're experiencing at school, they might also have an assessment of their phonological awareness, a reading assessment, literacy, well all sorts, ah vision, you know hearing assessment.

Jeanine: How many of the kids come with that swag of assessments?

Linda: Well by the time they're reached the, you know, whether we can include them in NCCD we already started a process earlier where we've identified that they're starting to struggle early on, so it might mean, they've been flagged to the team early on and we've recommended, or we've explored, some assessments. That doesn't explain the whole picture so then we might get something else done, there is, another assessment done, but by the time they've reached the decision on, when we're deciding on who to include or who not to include, they've usually finished that process and have quite a few, whatever assessments they needed to understand what's going on (Linda, Interview 1, August 28, 2018).

As Linda explained the series of assessments and testing that occur, and how this happens, to decide "whether we can include them in NCCD...they've usually finished that process and have quite a few, whatever assessments", attention is directed towards the assessment results and reports that ensue. The description of the process was removed from the embodied

experiences as it happened, in the everyday. For example, it does not depict how the school counsellor engaged with the child, their parents, or their classroom teacher. This inscription of the student in this process was reinforced by Natalie, the school counsellor at HPS:

Centre A is basically provisional psychologists who do assessments for us, you know at no cost to children from the school, but already they were full from Term Two, so, I'm feeling like because they can actually diagnose there's going to be a lot pressure on them and therefore, because they're going to be full, I'm worried that we're going to have to impute learning disabilities all of the time, and we can't put it in writing but, they've got, we can't quote the DSM-5<sup>8</sup>, like they can... Well I think it's because of the funding, it's going to be a change for schools... obviously that's going to have a massive impact on how we're supporting our students. I understand purpose, but, but it's obviously the funding will be quite challenging, particularly around the learning disabilities, side of things because we don't verify those kids here, you know, but for NCCD they're counted. So, I see the future from us as being very challenging, because I know Centre A, will, given that they've already capped their referrals now from Term Two this year and they're putting on the wait lists for 2019, that's where it's headed already, my thoughts are, it's going to get worse and worse. Soon there won't be any assistance for them... Yeah, and they're getting a lot of intervention, not making progress, you've done a lot of school assessment on them, on their learning so those kinds of reasons, generally, or a lot of behaviour support, maybe we've gathered some data about the behaviour (Natalie, Interview 1, September 12, 2018).

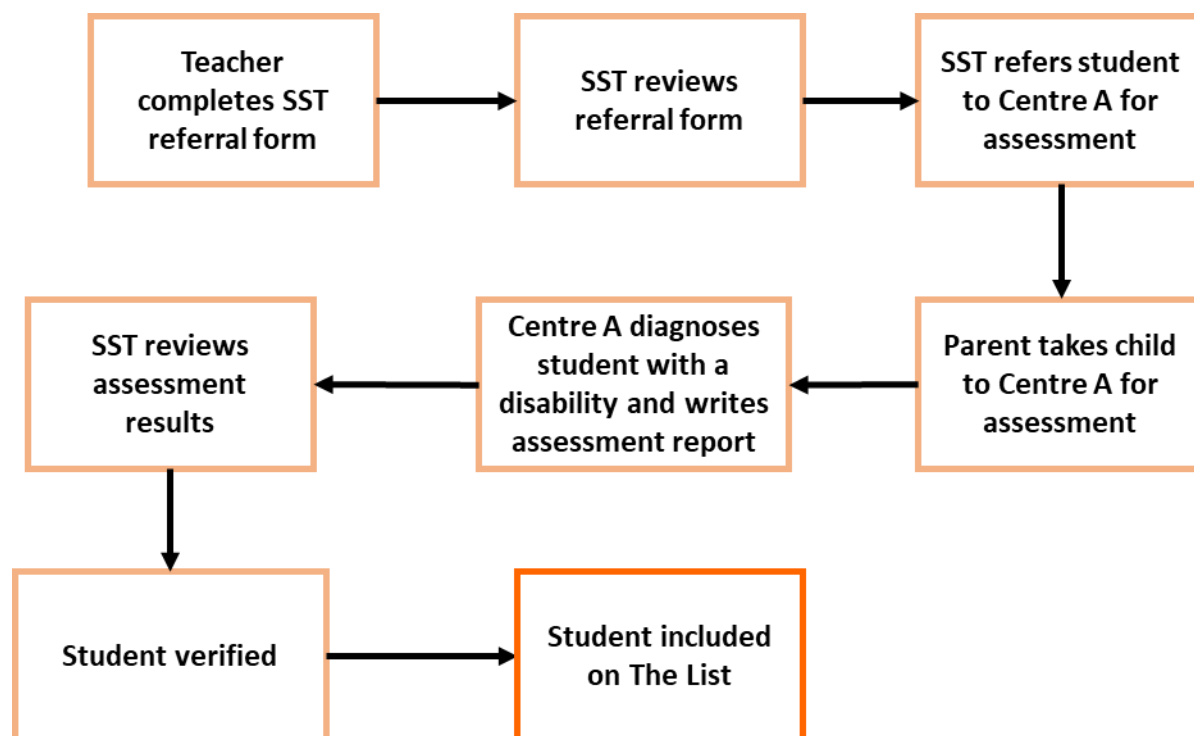
As Natalie reflected on the necessity to have students assessed, sequences of actions were revealed. Following the referral of the student to the SST, Natalie described how students

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<sup>8</sup> Diagnostic Statistical Manual – Version 5 is the manual published by the American Psychiatric Association used for the assessment and diagnosis of mental disorders.

were inscribed as data (texts) to meet the requirements of the NCCD (see Figure 5.8). The institutional talk was about test scores not children, about the assessments and data gathering.

**Figure 5.8** *The referral forms are relations of rule*



The SST referral form activated a sequence action for the purpose of an assessment of students to determine eligibility for inclusion in the NCCD count. The SST referral form, was a “textual system” in which knowledge was socially organised, the sequence was a relation of rule (D. E. Smith, 1990b, p. 213) as seen in Figure 5.8. The SST referral organised actions teachers, school counsellor, students, diagnosticians, and families in similar ways across locations. The textual power of the referral form is translocal, actions at both schools were remarkably alike, as people activated texts using these processing interchanges in similar ways.

## 5.4 CONCLUSION

This chapter has made visible lived experiences of those leading the NCCD work in schools. Their work was initially focused on buffering the policy demands being placed on teachers, this has revealed how their everyday work was hooked into institutional discourses

and relations of rule (Smith et al., 2006) and was regulated by official and unofficial NCCD texts, such as the Education Authority communique and The List. Documenting evidence of adjustments and monitoring to ensure documentation was stored using the school-wide data management system (e.g., the “big green book”, student folders or online) and was very clearly focused accountability work of the NCCD SLT. Despite not following the official process as set out in the NCCD guidelines, the key messages or ideological codes of the professional learning program was directive and institutionally were very clearly orchestrated through institutional texts. As texts or document sets moved from one person to the next, the processing interchanges created new work for the NCCD SLT in both schools. How these processing interchanges organised the work of teachers is explored and mapped in Chapter Six.

## Chapter 6: Teachers and teacher assistants

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### 6.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter reintroduces and follows the work of teacher informants from two metropolitan primary schools. From Hillside Primary School (HPS), classroom teachers Olivia and Robert, as well as teacher assistant, Chloe, and from Parkside Primary School (PPS), classroom teachers Sophie and Emily. Although my analysis of the NCCD work began with the NCCD school leadership team leading the NCCD work in the schools (see Chapter Five), the starting point of my inquiry was with the classroom teachers.

The inquiry started with individual conversations with four classroom teachers, two from each school to learn about their everyday/everynight NCCD work, in other words, the embodied actualities of these frontline workers (Griffith & Smith, 2005; Prior et al., 2018; D. E. Smith, 1990a; Smith, 2008). As is expected with snowball sampling, each person identifies the next person, and the researcher keeps following this thread until saturation is reached (Creswell, 2020). This chapter presents an analysis of how the NCCD work was experienced by four classroom teachers and a teacher assistant (see Table 6.1). The table below identifies each of the informants, their role and in which school they were located.

**Table 6.1** *Teacher and teacher assistant informants*

|                   | <b>Hillside Primary School<br/>(HPS)</b> | <b>Parkside Primary School<br/>(PPS)</b> |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Teacher           | Robert<br>Olivia                         | Sophie<br>Emily                          |
| Teacher assistant | Chloe                                    |                                          |

The next chapter draws on conversations with policy officers from two education authorities.

## **6.2 THE FRONTLINE WORK OF THE NCCD**

Each conversation commenced in the same way, with an outline of the research project, and an explanation about my interest in understanding their experience of the NCCD. Early in each conversation, I asked about how they came to know about the NCCD. Each informant responded by saying it was the professional learning provided at the beginning of the school year, which occurred prior to starting any of their official NCCD work. As Robert, Olivia, Chloe, Sophie and Emily began to describe their everyday work several lines of inquiry were revealed; threads to be pulled (Campbell, 2006). These threads had similarities that were not connected to the years of teaching experience or their role. Through careful analytic processes that followed these threads, sequences of actions were revealed.

### **6.2.1 Preparing to do the work beginning with professional learning**

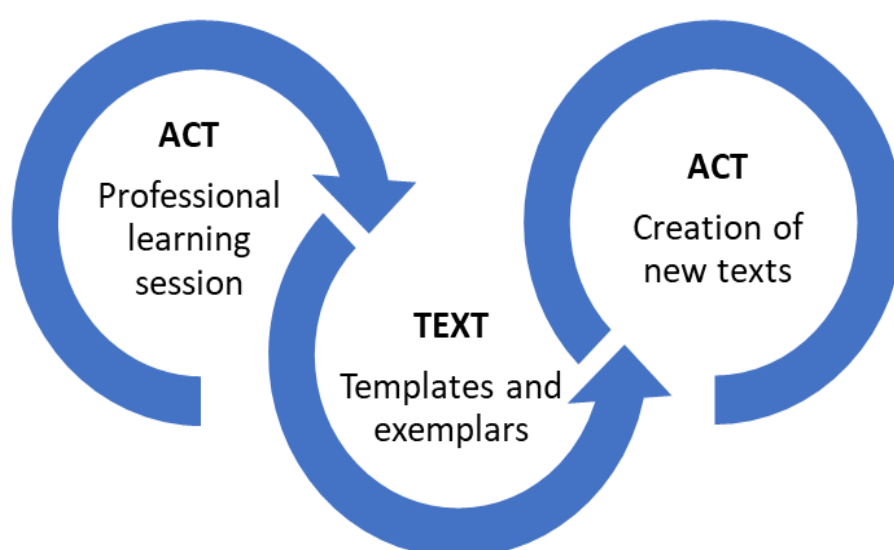
The teachers described the professional learning sessions at the beginning of the school year as being their first real introduction to the NCCD and its requirements. However, it was through the informal connections with colleagues and friends at other schools that they started to think more carefully about the work of the NCCD. The professional learning had been rolled out to all schools at the beginning of the year and continued, shaping discourse at work and during social events. The teachers described the NCCD professional learning sessions as being extremely focused on ensuring they understood the requirement to document and collect evidence of the educational adjustments they were making for students with disability in their class. Robert from HPS explained that following this professional learning session, the curriculum lead teacher gave classroom teachers a range of record-keeping templates and exemplars, which he discussed with colleagues and ways to document evidence of adjustments:

Well, what happened was, we had, we had an initial staff meeting to explain the process, then we received lots of stuff via email from our [curriculum lead teacher],

also from Karen [learning support teacher]...they sent a lot of stuff out with here are some ideas of how you might record the adjustments you're making...but also one of the other teachers you are going to talk to today she came up with a plan, and way to do her planning and she shared with a few of us. And so, mine is, is sort of a modification of all of these things (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

Robert's description of "texts in action" activated by the professional learning, is an act-text-act sequence, meaning it was temporal, occurring over time (Smith, 2006, p. 67). Following the professional learning sessions, exemplars and templates were sent out, which Robert and his colleagues recontextualised to create new templates, "she [teaching colleague] came up with a plan". Verbal communication, or dialogues, whether formal (e.g., a presentation) or informal (e.g., conversation with a colleague) are texts. These texts operated translocally, across locations to organise teachers' actions in similar ways (Smith, 2005). The act-text-act sequence of producing "stuff" and "plans" demonstrates how texts can organise actions in a social context (see Figure 6.1) (Smith, 2006). Understanding how texts coordinate workflow - in other words, how work comes, what happens because of it and then where does go, means that texts are not analysed in abstraction. Rather the analytic focus is on how texts contribute to the organisation of work (Smith, 2006). Informants were reassured that texts they shared were not going to be evaluated as part of the research. Once it was clear the analytic focus was to be on understanding the work that occurs because of the texts, the informants welcomed the opportunity, and were very willing to talk about and share a number of documents.

**Figure 6.1** Professional learning activates an act-text-act sequence



The act-text-act sequence activated by the NCCD professional learning was notable for Sophie, classroom teacher at PPS, because “at the beginning of the year, it was something that was coming in and I’d already used it [NCCD templates], I was used to using it. And we shared it [NCCD templates] with the staff” (Sophie, Interview 1, August 23, 2018). The creation of new record-keeping templates was collaborative, Sophie and her colleagues were sharing their work with each other. In both school sites, the professional learning session activated new work for teachers in similar ways, textually coordinated actions were translocal and hooked up teachers’ work with institutional accountability demands of having enough evidence for each student in the NCCD count to protect funding.

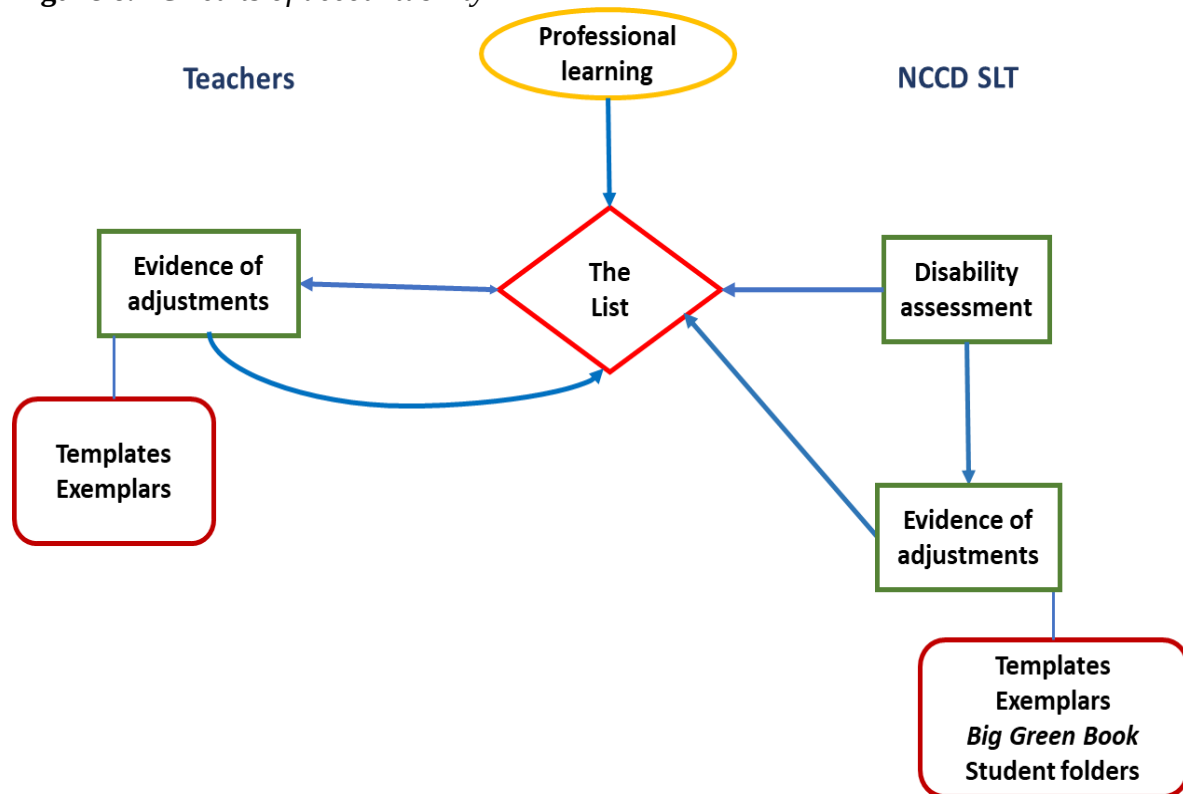
### ***Learning to collect evidence***

Shortly after the NCCD professional learning teachers began to collect evidence of adjustments they provided for students on The List. While the professional learning sessions activated new work for the teachers and the NCCD SLT, the focus of their work differed. As discussed in Chapter Five, the NCCD SLT had collaborated with the Education Authority about the content of the professional learning which was focused on ensuring there was enough evidence for the “right students” to maintain funding. The significance of this was not



lost on the teachers, but their takeaway message from the professional learning was the necessity to document and collect evidence of adjustments for students on The List. The teachers were not concerned about who were the “right students”. Although connected, the embodied actualities of the professional learning at the beginning of the year led to two different, but connected, institutional circuits (DeVault et al., 2014) (see Figure 6.2).

**Figure 6.2** *Circuits of accountability*



Teachers were focused on the eligibility work of the NCCD requirements, whereas the NCCD SLT were concerned with accountability work, including ensuring the “right students” were on The List. Teachers checked and aligned documented adjustments with LoA document of students on The List (see Figure 6.3). The List was similar in both schools; and contained the same details about the students.

**Figure 6.3** *The List*

| Student, class, disability information  | NCCD category and level                  | Forms of evidence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Location                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prep Blue<br>ASD                        | Social/Emotional<br><b>Supplementary</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Personalised visual timetable</li> <li>* Alert/student profile</li> <li>* Class teacher's weekly program</li> <li>* Checklist for social/emotional adjustments</li> <li>* Verification document</li> <li>* EASP/transition documentation from [redacted], AQ and Lady Gowrie Childcare Centre</li> <li>* Educational Support Plan</li> <li>* Wrap Meeting Notes</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Portal:<br>* Students for NCCD in 200s<br>* [redacted]'s file in 800s                                                                |
| Prep Gold<br>Tourette Syndrome;<br>ADHD | Social/Emotional<br><b>Supplementary</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Teacher checklist</li> <li>* Photographs of personalised supports: indoor and outdoor quiet spaces for "tic breaks"</li> <li>* Checklist for social/emotional adjustments</li> <li>* STIE notes from parent meeting</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Portal:<br>* Students for NCCD in 200s<br>* [redacted]'s file in 800s                                                                |
| Prep Gold<br>PI                         | Physical<br><b>Extensive</b>             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Class teacher's weekly program</li> <li>* Medical alert/student profile</li> <li>* Photo of [redacted]'s floor chair</li> <li>* Photo of [redacted]'s eating table with full individual school officer supervision</li> <li>* Feeding profile</li> <li>* Choking risk management plan</li> <li>* Lunchtime supervision timetable</li> <li>* Adjustment checklist</li> <li>* Photograph showing adjustments and additional support for PE</li> <li>* EASP notes – including meeting with PI AVT at beginning of school year</li> <li>* Record of email correspondence regarding adjustments and [redacted]'s needs with [redacted] (PI AVT)</li> <li>* SBH school request for service</li> <li>* SBH school visit report</li> <li>* Medical reports from Lady Cilento Children's</li> <li>* Educational Support Plan</li> <li>* Wrap meeting notes</li> <li>* Student profile for relief and specialist teachers, and copy of medical information for relief teachers</li> <li>* Email from [redacted] confirming verification and suggesting that [redacted]'s NCCD level be submitted at Extensive level</li> <li>* APS application with supporting documentation</li> <li>* Speech therapy program hard copy and email correspondence re:</li> </ul> | Portal:<br>* Students for NCCD in 200s<br>Hard copy:<br>* [redacted]'s paper file in Penola<br>* STIE laptop<br>* STIE email records |

The purpose of The List was to ensure the evidence matched the types of adjustments expected for a specific LoA. The NCCD SLT checked the data about students with a diagnosed/assessed disability to ensure evidence collection tasks were undertaken correctly and in accordance with the NCCD requirements (DeVault et al., 2014; Power, 1999). The production and auditing of evidentiary documentation was focused on maintaining funding, not mapping student learning progress.

#### *NCCD texts organising teacher work*

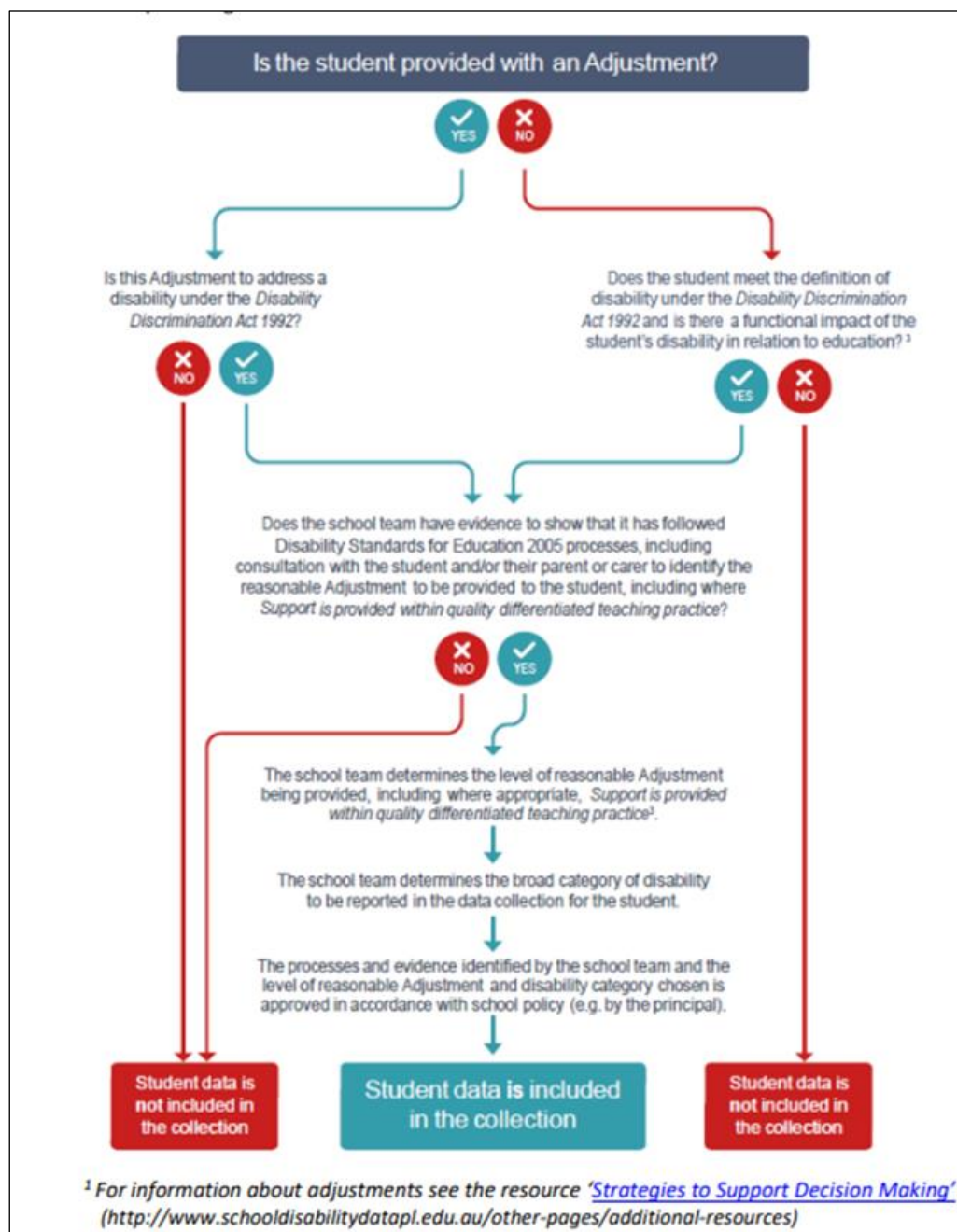
To further understand the knowledge teachers were drawing on to organise their work, a series of official NCCD texts were presented to each informant at the end of each conversation. While something of a departure from the bulk of the interview where teachers were invited to share the texts that were used in their work, this decision was intended to check if and how teachers used the texts in their everyday work, and finally to learn if they

used other texts and how. These official texts are published on the Australian Government NCCD website and are freely available to the public. My insider knowledge of the NCCD requirements helped in the selection of two official NCCD texts and one text produced by the Education Authority.

The first official text was *The National Data Collection Model Diagram* (2016 – 2018) (NCCD Model Diagram) (see Figure 6.4 below, or Appendix H: NCCD model diagram 2016 - 2018) (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). The NCCD Model Diagram is a visual scaffold of the decision-making process mandated to include a student in the NCCD count (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). Additionally, this text was identified as an essential text (see Appendix J: 2017 NCCD text categories); the NCCD Guidelines recommend school staff have a high degree of familiarity with all essential texts (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). The NCCD Model Diagram, in the format shared with the teachers (minor modifications were made in 2019) was first published as part of the trial materials, which commenced in 2011. In other words, despite being a long-standing official text, no one at the school was familiar with it. No one could ever recall seeing it before, and certainly none of them had used it to inform their everyday work. As Olivia from HPS stated:

it would've really helped to sort of, to decide, so, this is not included [reading the document] yeah, ok. Anything like, look anything like this would have been really, I'm a visual person, so, yeah, anything like this would have been really helpful (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

**Figure 6.4** NCCD model diagram (2016 – 2018)



Olivia's stated preference for visual information suggests the NCCD Model Diagram has the potential to help teachers to organise their work, and as it would seem to be, a welcomed resource. Furthermore, given that no one could recall seeing the text, this suggests that this essential official text was not included in the professional learning that was rolled out to all schools.

The second essential NCCD text shared was the *Level of Adjustment Provided to the Student 2016 – 2018* (LoA document) (see Appendix K: Level of adjustment provided to the student (LoA – A3 sheet) or Appendix L: LoA – word version). The LoA document is a detailed table with descriptors about the four levels of adjustments. An excerpt of the LoA document is captured below in Figure 6.5 Level of Adjustment Provided to the Student; the layout of this text requires it to be on an A3 sheet to be readable.

**Figure 6.5** *Level of Adjustment Provided to the Student*

|                         | Support Provided with Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Supplementary | Substantial                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Extensive |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Level of Adjustment     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |           |
| Typical Adjustments     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |           |
| Student Characteristics |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |           |
|                         | SUPPORT PROVIDED WITHIN QUALITY DIFFERENTIATED TEACHING PRACTICE                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |               | SUPPLEMENTARY ADJUSTMENTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |           |
| LEVEL OF ADJUSTMENT     | <p>Quality teaching practice is responsive to the differential needs of all students. Some students with disability may not need educational adjustments beyond those that are reasonably expected as part of quality teaching or school practice to address disability related needs. These students may have been considered for some level of active support (i.e. active monitoring or provision of adjustments). Their identified needs would be subject to close monitoring and review.</p> <p>If the school team, in consultation with the student, their parent or carer, has agreed that the student's needs as a result of the disability are being met through quality differentiated teaching practice then these students should be counted under this level of adjustment.</p> <p>Changes to student needs that require changes to the level of adjustment would be reflected in the next data collection period.</p> <p>Further information on the definition of disability for the NCCD, and on students with disability for whom support is provided within quality differentiated teaching practice, is available in the <i>Strategies that Support Decision Making</i> resource.</p> |               | <p>Supplementary adjustments are provided when there is an assessed need at specific times to complement the strategies and resources already available (for all students) within the school. These adjustments are designed to address the nature and impact of the student's disability and any associated barriers to their learning, physical, communication or participatory needs.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |           |
| ADJUSTMENT              | <p>Quality differentiated teaching practice caters to the needs of a diverse student population. Students in this category do not require the sorts of adjustments that are captured in the other three levels. However, their teachers are conscious of the need for explicit, albeit minor, adjustments to teaching and school practice that enable them to access learning on the same basis as their peers. This category would include general adjustments that have been made in a school as part of developing or maintaining a culture of inclusion.</p> <p>Examples for this category could include:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a differentiated approach to curriculum delivery and assessment that anticipates and responds to students' learning differences</li> <li>personalised learning that is implemented without</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |               | <p>Adjustments to teaching and learning might include modified or tailored programs in some or many learning areas, modified instruction using a structured task-analysis approach, the provision of course materials in accessible forms, separate supervision or extra time to complete assessment tasks and the provision of intermittent specialist teacher support. Adjustments might include modifications to ensure full access to buildings and facilities, specialised technology, programs or interventions to address the student's social/emotional needs and support or close supervision to participate in out-of-school activities or the playground. These adjustments may also include the provision of a support service that is provided by the education authority or sector, or that the school has sourced from an external agency.</p> |           |

It has four columns and three rows. The four columns correspond with the four levels of adjustment - Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice (QDTP), supplementary, substantial, and extensive. The three rows are descriptors about each of the levels of adjustment under

these headings – level of adjustment, typical adjustment, and student characteristics. The text has characteristic shading. All the teachers immediately recognised this text and knew it as the level of adjustment document. As soon as they saw the distinctive layout and the distinguishing colours of the text, they all recalled it being shared during the professional learning sessions earlier in the year and indicated a level of familiarity, as noted by Emily from PPS:

Jeanine: I'm just wondering if you have seen them and if you have used them, and if so, how. This is one that would have been highlighted – it is the levels of educational adjustment.

Emily: I've seen this

Jeanine: Have you used it

Emily: Yeah (Emily, Interview 1, August 24, 2018).

The LoA document was presented at the professional learning at the beginning of the year; it was prioritised in the professional learning package by the Education Authority over other essential texts such as the NCCD Model Diagram. Teachers were able to describe ways in which they had used the LoA document, for example, Emily shared how she used this text to organise work. She described how the LoA document regulated and coordinated her everyday actualities with planning and recording educational adjustments (Smith, 1999, 2005). Emily aligned educational adjustments with LoA document for students on The List, and what evidence might be required as proof of this work:

Emily: Yeah, so, with this, I use it [LoA document] to make my plans up, to see where the child is, what sort of adjustments I am making, and get some ideas on how I can support the child. Yeah

Jeanine: Who gave you this document, or did you just find it?

Emily: We had an in-service at the beginning of the year, and I saw this document, and I thought it would be great to support my planning

Jeanine: Have you used it, used it one per child or?

Emily: Yep, well I looked at that and then I drew up my plan

Jeanine: Great, did you share that information with anyone?

Emily: Yes, well all of us were shown this and then...when we were talking about what's the best way, I said this would be great to start, a great place to start  
(Emily, Interview 1, August 24, 2018)

Teachers were using the LoA document to create new texts to organise their collection of evidence of adjustments, and as Emily pointed out having a list or a menu of educational supports is a “great place to start” (see Chapter Five) (Ritzer, 2013). Hence one of the earlier resources provided the “big green book” with a menu of adjustments. The purpose of the LoA document is to determine the level of educational support a student with disability has received to inform funding for the following year. Given the focus on funding concerns, it is not surprising the high degree of familiarity with the text that in many ways provides the gateway to this funding.

While the LoA document coordinated teacher work, there was a disjuncture between the official account of expectations of how the LoA document is to be used and the actualities of the teachers’ lived experiences. The official flowchart/account of the NCCD Model Diagram states that educational adjustments occur first, then the teacher uses their professional judgement to decide which of the four levels of adjustment best describes the educational support that has been provided which determines the level of adjustment (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). In this official account, the LoA document is used as a reference to support the teachers’ decision-making process as they discern a level of

adjustment. When teachers were told of the students in their class on The List, they were told the level of support that they needed to provide, and then turned to the LoA document into a checklist of adjustments. Each level of adjustment has a descriptor row “typical adjustments” that described what kind of support students with different levels of educational need would typically require; some teachers used these descriptors as type of menu of support.

The final text shared with the teachers was the *NCCD Record of Evidence* (see Figure 6.6 below). This text was an official record-keeping document created by the Education Authority. The purpose of this text is to assist schools to confirm the LoA and CoD, it was intended to be used when moderating the student records. This text outlines evidence of personalised adjustments, with a column to record what evidence is currently available and then what evidence needed to be collected. The next section provides space for checking off the four forms of evidence and the final section records the LoA and CoD (Education Authority, 2015).

As a recording document the order of the text prioritises evidence of educational adjustments, and within those first few rows are questions about standardised assessments used to determine the educational needs. There was little familiarity with this text amongst teachers, however, Robert had a vague recollection of its existence, “Yeah, yes I have, in our staff meeting”, but when asked to elaborate he returned to explain he had “ten kids on his list” (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018). This meant that he was recording evidence of adjustments for more than a third of his class.



**Figure 6.6** *NCCD Evidence Record*

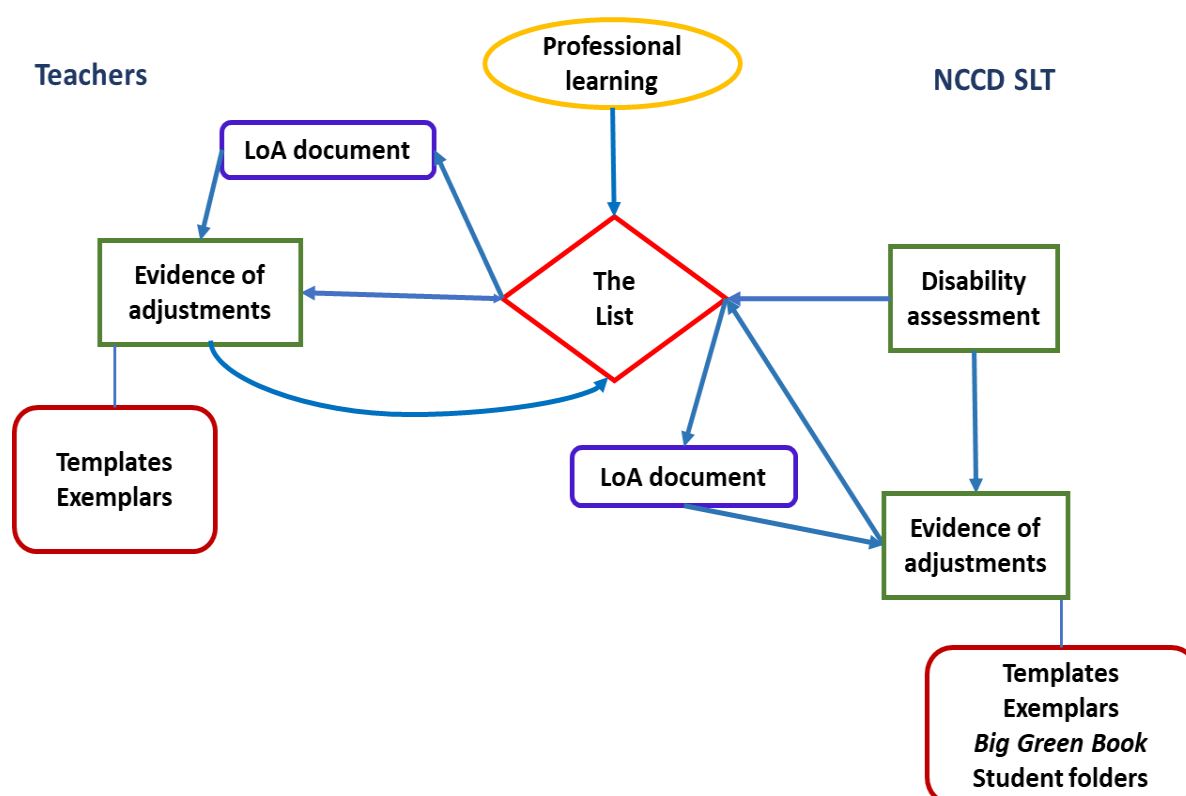
| NCCD Evidence Record                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                  |                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Student:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Year Level:                                                      | Date:                           |
| <p>Evidence of personalized adjustments being provided to meet the learning and support needs of students with disability are reflected in a range of activities, records and documents in schools. This may include but is not limited to the following:</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                  |                                 |
| <b>Evidence of Personalised Adjustments</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Current Evidence</b>                                          | <b>Evidence to be Collected</b> |
| Documentation that reflects classroom curriculum-based assessments, <i>other school or classroom assessments, system-wide assessments<sup>1</sup></i> and extra-curricular activity assessments.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                  |                                 |
| Documentation from a recognised medical professional/s if available.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                  |                                 |
| Documentation from <i>clinicians<sup>2</sup></i> , therapists or paraprofessionals.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                  |                                 |
| Evidence of school engagement and collaborative planning with the student, parents/carers or associate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                  |                                 |
| Documentation of the student's individual learning and support provisions, including access issues and adjustments required.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                  |                                 |
| Evidence that adjustments have been provided to the student.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                  |                                 |
| Records showing that the impact of adjustments has been regularly monitored and adapted where needed.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                  |                                 |
| Reports that detail adjustments being made for the student in areas such as health or personal care and social development, including adjustments to the environment and infrastructure.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                  |                                 |
| Any other relevant supporting documents e.g. staff timetables, professional learning and support for staff.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                  |                                 |
| <p>For a student to be included in the national data collection on students with a disability, the school should have evidence that adjustments have been provided for a minimum of one school term (or at least 10 weeks) in the 12 months preceding the census date.</p> <p>Evidence reflects a wide range of practices of teachers and schools in meeting the educational needs of their students consistent with obligations under the <i>Disability Discrimination Act 1992</i>, the <i>Disability Standards for Education 2005</i> and best teaching practice. This includes evidence in four general areas:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li><input type="checkbox"/> the assessed individual needs of the student;</li> <li><input type="checkbox"/> adjustments being provided to the student to address the disability – this includes support provided within quality differentiated practice;</li> <li><input type="checkbox"/> ongoing monitoring and review of the adjustments<sup>2</sup>; and</li> <li><input type="checkbox"/> consultation and collaboration with the student and/or parents and carers or associates.</li> </ul> |                                                                  |                                 |
| <b>Category of Disability</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Level of Adjustment</b>                                       |                                 |
| Physical                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Support provided within quality differentiated teaching practice |                                 |
| Cognitive                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Supplementary Adjustments                                        |                                 |
| Sensory                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Substantial Adjustments                                          |                                 |
| Social/Emotional                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Extensive Adjustments                                            |                                 |
| <p><sup>1</sup> ‘... other school or classroom assessments, system-wide assessments ...’ and ‘... clinicians ...’ is additional to Commonwealth suggested evidence documentation to provide schools with further clarity, particularly for the inclusion of students whose learning needs and adjustments are consistent with learning disabilities</p> <p><sup>2</sup>Monitoring and review assume that the implementation of adjustments has occurred.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                  |                                 |
| <div style="display: flex; justify-content: space-between;"> <span>Updated April 2015</span> <span>Page 1 of 1</span> </div>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                  |                                 |

(Education Authority, 2015)

The List, a boss text had the capacity to “bind the frontline work and workers into higher-level textual media of governing” (Griffith & Smith, 2014a, p. 342). The List

connected the work of teachers to regulatory and accountability institutional processes beyond their everyday work of teaching students (see Figure 6.7). The List was a notable text for its consistent use and application across school sites and the Education Authority. What was also notable was how The List and the LoA interacted, a type of textual hierarchy above all other texts. The List and LoA together textually mediated how evidence of adjustments was documented, curated, and stored.

**Figure 6.7** *Professional learning activates a sequence of actions*



Teachers described the sequence or flow of their NCCD work as a natural outcome of the professional learning at the beginning of the school year, as mapped in Figure 6.7. As described by the teachers, the professional learning session focused on deconstructing the LoA document to understand what each of the levels would mean in terms of recording adjustments for students in their class that were on The List. This ensured that the documentation of educational supports for specific students matched the LoA descriptions. Within this sequence of actions, The List, as a boss text, was not the starting point, but rather

this sequence of actions makes visible the complex and intensive work that was activated by the professional learning.

### **6.2.2 Evidence is textually organised**

Following on from the professional learning sessions the teachers described a series of informal collaborative exchanges of ideas and processes about how to tackle the new work of the NCCD. This cooperative alliance involved sharing newly created templates and getting feedback about them, either produced by themselves or gathered from friends and colleagues in other schools, to review and discuss their utility. As this new work evolved some teachers sought further clarity and direction from the NCCD SLT, and in some instances requested school-wide standardised templates. What was common across the school sites and within each classroom, was the work of designing and maintaining the record-keeping texts, it was time consuming and demanding; “all the documentation that and the evidence that we have to provide, so that has increased our workload immensely” (Emily, Interview 1, 24 August 2018). This new work of the NCCD happened alongside all their usual teaching duties.

The textual power of The List coordinated a series of evolving actions is evident, from the time of receiving The List early in Term One, The List maintained teachers ‘attention until the federal School Census in August. Olivia explained how The List (see Figure 6.3) organised which students got her attention in terms of tracking educational adjustments, not learning progress:

it was explained to us a few times in a staff meeting, in planning time, we were, this [level of adjustment document] was shown to us and explained to us, and then we were pretty much just told these are the children that you’re tracking, and this is the level that they’re in (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

Olivia described the emphasis that was placed on tracking and monitoring adjustments for students on The List, which directly impacted her record-keeping and therefore how she

organised her planning work. Furthermore, as noted in Figure 6.8, The List excerpt below also included a list of expected actions for the teachers, a menu of adjustments provided.

**Figure 6.8** *The List excerpt of adjustments*

|                                                                               |                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div> <div></div> <div>Prep Blue<br/>ASD</div> </div>                         | <div> <div>Social/Emotional</div> <div>Supplementary</div> </div> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Personalised visual timetable</li> <li>* Alert/student profile</li> <li>* Class teacher's weekly program</li> <li>* Checklist for social/emotional adjustments</li> <li>* Verification document</li> <li>* EASP/transition documentation from <div></div>, AQ and Lady Gowrie Childcare Centre</li> <li>* Educational Support Plan</li> <li>* Wrap Meeting Notes</li> </ul> | <div>Portal:</div> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Students for NCCD in 200s</li> <li>* <div></div>'s file in 800s</li> </ul> |
| <div> <div></div> <div>Prep Gold<br/>Tourette Syndrome;<br/>ADHD</div> </div> | <div> <div>Social/Emotional</div> <div>Supplementary</div> </div> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Teacher checklist</li> <li>* Photographs of personalised supports: indoor and outdoor quiet spaces for "tic breaks"</li> <li>* Checklist for social/emotional adjustments</li> <li>* STIE notes from parent meeting</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                              | <div>Portal:</div> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>* Students for NCCD in 200s</li> <li>* <div></div>'s file in 800s</li> </ul> |

Most teachers have their own student record-keeping system, it is often private work that is located within their teacher planning notebooks, yet this new work was organised as a translocal approach. The List was a text that was replicated across schools and within each school in a similar way. It had a standardised textual representation, as seen in Figure 6.8 (Griffith & Smith, 2014b). In the first column there is the student's name, and a diagnosed condition (not a NCCD disability category), the second column provided the already decided NCCD CoD and LoA. The final two columns of concentrate on the curation of the evidence. The flow of the information provided in this text seems to replicate what was prioritised in the professional learning and reinforced through school practices. The List was authored by the NCCD SLT; a diagnosis offered the team confidence a disability was present (see section 5.3.2), by providing the level of educational support and the evidentiary requirements, and where to store evidence, The List focused (or directed) teachers work with the intention of managing the new workload (see section 5.3). This next section explains some of the evidence management systems that teachers used.

## ***Recording evidence***

The new accountability work which required detailed tracking of educational adjustments and collecting evidence of these adjustments guided teachers to create new texts.

Being accountable underpinned Olivia's actions:

And then what I did was I collected photo evidence So, I had, what I had, so this girl here often had a completely separate task, I would take a photo of it next to what the other children were doing so there was evidence to show that, you know, this is what the rest of the class is doing, this is what she's doing. So, it's a completely separate activity. I even collected photo evidence of supports around the classroom. So, it might be, you know, I had specific places where children sit who have these adjustments facing the board directly, on the end of the row, so they have access to the teacher. You know all those sorts of adjustments. So, I took photos of that, or visuals on their desk, anything like that, that we put in place to support them we took photos of that (Olivia, Interview 1, 16 August 2018).

Olivia was recording educational adjustments, and then making sure there was photographic evidence of the adjustment, managing the burden of proof. She also identified some of the practical issues and difficulties she had experienced in maintaining the tracking the records of adjustments:

So, I can see here, this is literacy, I didn't make as many in maths, so I need to make more adjustments in my literacy. So, it is, was a way to kind of track the level of adjustments. It was, it sometimes it was hard to remember, like you, kind of, you're constantly making adjustments and then at the end of the session it's ahhh I didn't record it. So, that was the hardest thing, remembering to do it. Some days I was better than others, but often, you, I'd go back to remember what I'd done because you'd so

the same things in every single lesson. Because, yeah, that's sort of how I ran it. So, and that seemed to work quite well (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

**Figure 6.9** Olivia's record of adjustments

| WEDNESDAY 13th June                                                                                                                                         |   |   |   |   | THURSDAY 14th June                                                                                                                                                   |   |   |   |   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| K                                                                                                                                                           | H | J | M | N | K                                                                                                                                                                    | H | J | M | N |
| <b>9.00 – 9.45 YEAR 3 ASSEMBLY PREPARATION</b><br>- With 3 Red- finish posters, craft and practise song.                                                    |   |   |   |   | <b>MORNING SESSION</b><br><b>9.00 – 9.45 Spelling</b><br>- Sight word sentences.<br>A: to work one-on-one with Mrs [redacted] testing simple sentences.              |   |   |   |   |
| <b>9.45 – 10.00 Munch and Crunch</b>                                                                                                                        |   |   |   |   | <b>9.30 – 9.40 Munch and Crunch</b><br><b>9.45 – 10.45</b>                                                                                                           |   |   |   |   |
| <b>10.00 – 10.45 MATHS ROTATIONS</b><br>- Continue angles and area<br>K: To access Year 1 Soundwaves app on the iPad                                        |   |   |   |   | <b>CHINESE LESSON</b><br><b>MATHS</b>                                                                                                                                |   |   |   |   |
| <b>MIDDLE SESSION</b><br><b>Silent Reading</b><br><b>HANDWRITING</b><br>- 1-2 pages as a whole class<br>A: to complete pages from a Year 1 Handwriting book |   |   |   |   | <b>Silent Reading</b><br><b>Science-lesson</b> Literacy: Sentence writing<br>K: Alternative activities (Let's make a sentence)                                       |   |   |   |   |
| <b>Literacy- Writing</b><br>- Continue writing their stories and begin editing<br>A: K, H, J, M, N to work on their narratives with Mrs Parr                |   |   |   |   | <b>Math's Rotations</b><br>- Area and angles<br>A: to join with Mrs [redacted] to do a length worksheet<br>Writing & finish narratives (to work with Mrs [redacted]) |   |   |   |   |
| <b>AFTERNOON SESSION</b><br><b>HISTORY LESSON</b><br>- Finish off art work lesson<br>- Design a boomerang to depict our local area.                         |   |   |   |   | <b>10.00 – 10.30 Religion History</b><br>- finish off boomerangs<br>- Gchudna roluwing in meditation →                                                               |   |   |   |   |

Handwritten notes and arrows: 'CHINESE' with an arrow pointing to 'CHINESE LESSON'; 'MATHS' with an arrow pointing to 'MATHS'; 'finish off math's addition sheet' written on the right margin; '13' written at the bottom right.

Olivia took numerous photographs of different situations as additional evidence or proof of the adjustments that were provided, to be more accountable. The “manufacture” of this additional evidence due to perceived accountability is ascribed to a culture of performativity (Ball, 2000). However, the issue of being accountable in the event of an audit, was raised by Emily as the reason that she strove to produce the required evidence. She questioned the veracity of such practices:

all the documentation that and the evidence that we have to provide...[wonder]  
 whether if it's beneficial to the student or, and the teachers, I don't think so...there has  
 to be a way of doing things that doesn't take time away from our teaching and our

planning, and really giving that time to the kids. Rather than photocopying evidence and keeping this folder of things that we have been doing... This year there's been a big increase in what we have to do because of the NCCD audit, I understand... But it's a lot about providing this evidence to NCCD (Emily, Interview 1, August 24, 2018).

Emily also made comparisons with her previous experiences with the NCCD:

This year there's been a big increase in what we have to do because of the NCCD audit, I understand. And all the documentation that, and the evidence that we have to provide, so that has increased our workload immensely from what we had to provide last year (Emily, Interview 1, August 24, 2018).

Emily attributed this increased workload to “the NCCD audit”. The increasing responsibilisation of teachers’ work was underpinned by a growing culture of audit and verification of teachers’ work, which permeated the emerging institutional talk and was a new form of management of teachers’ work (Darville, 2014; Gallagher & Spina, 2019; Grace et al., 2014). This discourse was being directed by the NCCD SLT (see Chapter Five).

While Olivia noted the benefits of planning and recording the adjustments, the demands on her to maintain the evidence templates became burdensome particular in the “heavy hour” (Beck, 2018, p. 617) of her teaching day where there were often competing and important demands. Olivia also self-evaluated her performance, “some days I was better than others”, internalising and taking the responsibility for the time demands and pressure of this additional work (Beck, 2018). On the days when she was too busy with teaching duties to record the adjustments she was “constantly making” the additional demands of trying to remember, “was the hardest thing”. Olivia’s reflection touches on the emotional labour of teacher’s work as well as issues of work intensification as she sought new ways of working that were more efficient (Hargreaves, 2000). Work intensification seemed to be an unexpected and unintended consequence of the NCCD.



And I guess some of my planning documents from last year I made mental adjustments in my head for kids that I know are going to be involved in here, I haven't made it specific enough. Nowhere near as specific as this [holds up page from book; see Figure 6.10] ...But then to sort of change your ways into it and sort of, oh God, I've got to back up and back track here because I haven't been keeping a good enough record, then I think that's a bit of a pain in the neck (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

[illegible]

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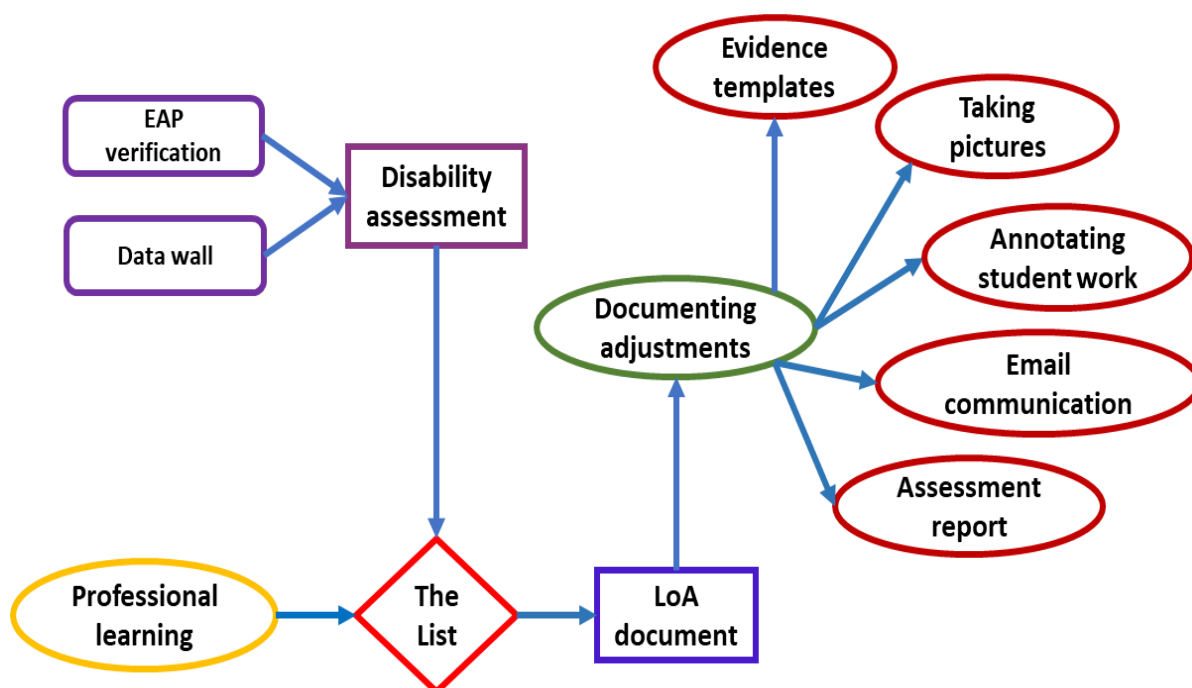
Chapter 6: Teachers and teacher assistants



were not rejecting or avoiding additional work but were looking for ways to do it more efficiently.

Institutional work is textually coordinated and aligned with people's embodied actualities (Nichols & Griffith, 2009). Teachers were provided with the LoA document at the professional learning session, which was used as a source document to create templates and exemplars for evidence collection, in which adjustments implemented were checked off many ways acted as a checklist for the evidence templates. A map of this sequence (see Figure 6.11) shows how the LoA document was connected to The List and evidence templates (Griffith & Smith, 2014b). As each teacher talked about this work, they discussed their accountability and the requirement to maintain the evidence templates as well as curating an array of evidentiary documents.

**Figure 6.11** Mapping a sequence of actions to curate evidence of adjustments



Students on The List were identified firstly as having disability and then the level of adjustment for which evidence was required, the LoA document then mediated what evidence was collated and therefore the detail that was included in the evidence templates. This sequence describes how the work came to the teachers and what happened next. Initially, the

teachers developed their own systems for record management and data storage, but these were quickly superseded by a centralised school-based file management system, which is discussed in this next section

### ***Storing the evidence***

Maintaining records of evidence of adjustments were textually authorised sequences of actions. Documenting adjustments coordinated and organised teachers' everyday work as they filled in evidence templates, annotated student work samples, photographs of adjustments in action were annotated and filed, all these new types of texts were now part of a new student record. To manage these new records both schools introduced a new school-wide data management system to centrally store these records. However, teachers continued to maintain their own individual systems to organise their own everyday actualities of this addition to the new NCCD work. Robert seemed to be keeping everything about all "ten kids" that were on The List, as there was no clarity as to what was relevant:

I've kept, I have folders for those kids, and I've kept some emails if they're pertinent to the adjustments I'm making, I've kept emails, I've kept any reports that I've received from external consultants about them, IEP [individualised education plan] documents, but I also, this year kept, in my, over a, over the NCCD period, that 10-week period, I've kept a checklist in my planning...the checklist has got students' names down the side (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

These evidentiary texts were hitched to the LoA document and The List, and were accountability texts, proof of their ongoing work (Griffith & Smith, 2014b). Retaining a variety of texts, such as emails, reports from external consultants and the IEP were important, as they meant he was being accountable. The work of documenting and collecting evidence of adjustments occurring took precedence over evaluating the effectiveness or relevance of an adjustment to meet the additional learning needs of the student. This made Emily question the

purpose, while Robert positioned this new work as what a good teacher would do, he also raised questions about clarity of purpose:

I would expect a good teacher to be doing most of this stuff anyway right from the start. However, there is, like, what am I trying to say, if, if you want, if you want to gather it all together in the one place and hand it on for someone to look at, you need to know in advance that it's going to happen. So, when you are doing your planning, you're not doing it just so that you're the only one that knows what's going on there, you've made it clear what you are doing (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

Robert talked about the textual sequence of “hand[ing] it on for someone to look at”; a “processing interchange”, whereby once he had made his contribution, the record was moved to the next step and he had little knowledge of what that was (Pence, 2001, p. 215). Sophie, explained the processing interchange from PPS, reiterating the workflow of handing documents on:

we did it in the staff meeting and then we passed it back on to them [learning support teacher and school counsellor], and they obviously went through had a look as well (Sophie, Interview 1, September 4, 2018).

What is unique about processing interchanges is that they rely on texts to both organise and produce information (Pence, 2001). Robert (HPS) and Sophie (PPS) talked about organisational occasions in which the texts they produced were moved from themselves to another professional for processing and action, which was analysing the document set for adequate evidence or audit purposes. These interchanges were connected by procedural instructions and institutional talk as they moved away from individually managed data storage to a top-down solution that was standardised within each school site.

At both schools, the NCCD SLT developed a data management and storage system specific to each location. However, these were created with remarkable similarities and for

the same outcome, to hand the records on to the Education Authority for checking. HPS used an online platform, the school intranet to create a digital file for each student on The List. In PPS, a physical file/folder was created for each student on The List, the folder was locked in a filing cabinet in the learning support teacher's room. The accountability for the student records had now moved from the teachers' domain of private work to the school level, as the NCCD SLT were now responsible for the security of the record as well as ensuring the student file/folder was adequately replete with evidentiary documents.

In both schools, teacher assistants were allocated to the task of evidence collection for the ten weeks of Term Two (April – June). At HPS, Jennifer, reallocated the usual duties for teacher assistant, Chloe, so that she was available to help the teachers with the curation of the evidence (see Chapter Five for a more discussion about how the principals buffered the teachers to complete this work). As an artefact, the production of the student file/folder involved other actors with new responsibilities, as explained, first by Olivia, and then Chloe from HPS:

And we had someone, a teacher assistant, in the school, who was responsible for uploading this all into the NCCD folders. So, she would come to my classroom once week, she'd get these [record sheets] she'd scan them for me, I even forwarded any emails that I had received, because a lot of my, I contact my parents very regularly through email. So, if I had talked about an adjustment I was making for their child, with an excursion, or it was with a literacy task I would forward that to this teacher assistant, and she would upload it to the portal (Olivia, Interview, 16 August 2018).

As Olivia described, this processing interchange in which documented adjustments would then be uploaded to the student file/folder was a significant step in the local implementation of the NCCD requirements. For Chloe, this work was quite intensive through Term Two and required her to reorganise her daily work. Olivia shared how their work was arranged:

She [Chloe, teacher assistant] was really good at helping, that made the process much more manageable, having someone to support you with that. And she went around the room, and I said, and said what do you want me to take photos of, I just went that that, that, that, that. She'd go around take the photos, upload it. [clapped hands], done (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

A subtle but significant power shift occurred; Olivia described her conversation with Chloe where she asked Chloe what photos were needed to meet the evidentiary requirements for students she was teaching. Effectively, this query from Olivia about what evidence should be curated, she had asked Chloe to decide what needed to be included. Chloe decided what photos were needed, Olivia took the pictures and then Chloe completed the administrative tasks of curating the evidence. This sequence of actions was activated by The List for the purpose of production of evidence to meet accountability requirements (Grant et al., 2017). Once the evidence was finalised Chloe turned to the administrative tasks of dividing the document set into subcategories ready to upload on the school intranet, which also included working through Olivia's email correspondence to discern relevance and therefore inclusion in the digital student files, as Olivia explained:

So, she was really good at the technology side of things, which was a great help 'cause doing this alone was a pretty big job. So that was really handy to have her to do that, 'cause I had a lot of emails, cause especially for the girl that I have with II [intellectual impairment]. It's very, you know I'm in constant contact with mum and dad. So, it's good to have that kind of up there as well, as evidence of adjustments they had made for her. So yeah (Olivia, Interview, 16 August 2018).

Chloe met with the teacher of every student on The List and replicated this process:

Ok, Jennifer contacted me, our principal, to say that we needed to show evidence for what the teachers were doing in their classrooms in terms of curriculum adjustments,

signage in the classroom and any other kind of adjustments they're making in their classroom for the children who do have a verification through that NCCD. So, I spoke with each of the teachers individually, and I spoke with Fiona [learning support teacher] who set me up with [digital] folders...so with Fiona's advice I went to the teachers and said this is what we need, these are the kinds of things I'm looking for, and then I spent four to five days going into their classrooms when they had time and taking pictures of posters and things in the room, scanning documents in regards to the adjustments they'd made to their ahh programs for their classrooms and then just putting that all in folders for each individual class and each individual verified child within that class, onto our portal (Chloe, Interview 1, September 9, 2018).

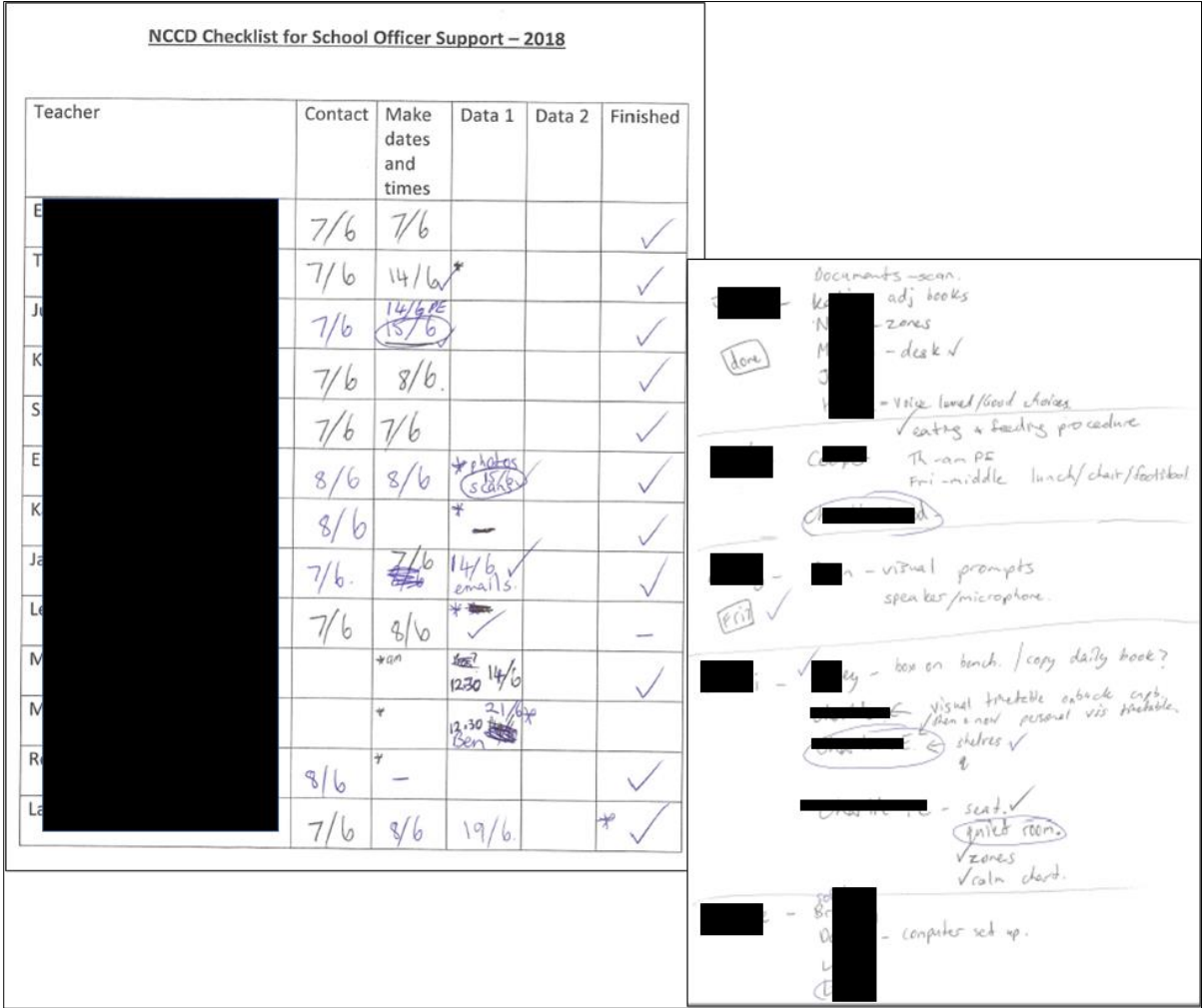
As Chloe talked about her experience of this new work, her acceptance of the responsibility for curating the evidence was reiterated, "this is what we need, these are the kinds of things I'm looking for", and explained the process:

Fiona set up all the [digital] folders telling me which children from which classes we needed to collect information on and for some of those children it was just posters in the room. So, I took the photos and then they went into several of those children's folders, ahh, for other children it was specific things, like furniture adjustments, format time and that sort of thing...She [Fiona] gave me some advice and I talked with the teachers as well, and between the three of us we'd worked out what we needed to take picture or get evidence to support. (Chloe, Interview 1, September 9, 2018).

Chloe maintained a record of her interactions with teachers about the data collection, and in so doing produced a detailed account of the sequence of actions (see Figure 6.12). Teachers are identified in the first column, followed by actions required and when they were completed, on the flipside of the page were handwritten notes of evidence to be collected

against student names from The List (see Figures 6.3 and 6.8). Chloe’s daily actions were organised and regulated by The List (Smith, 1999).

**Figure 6.12** *Collecting evidence is textually coordinated*

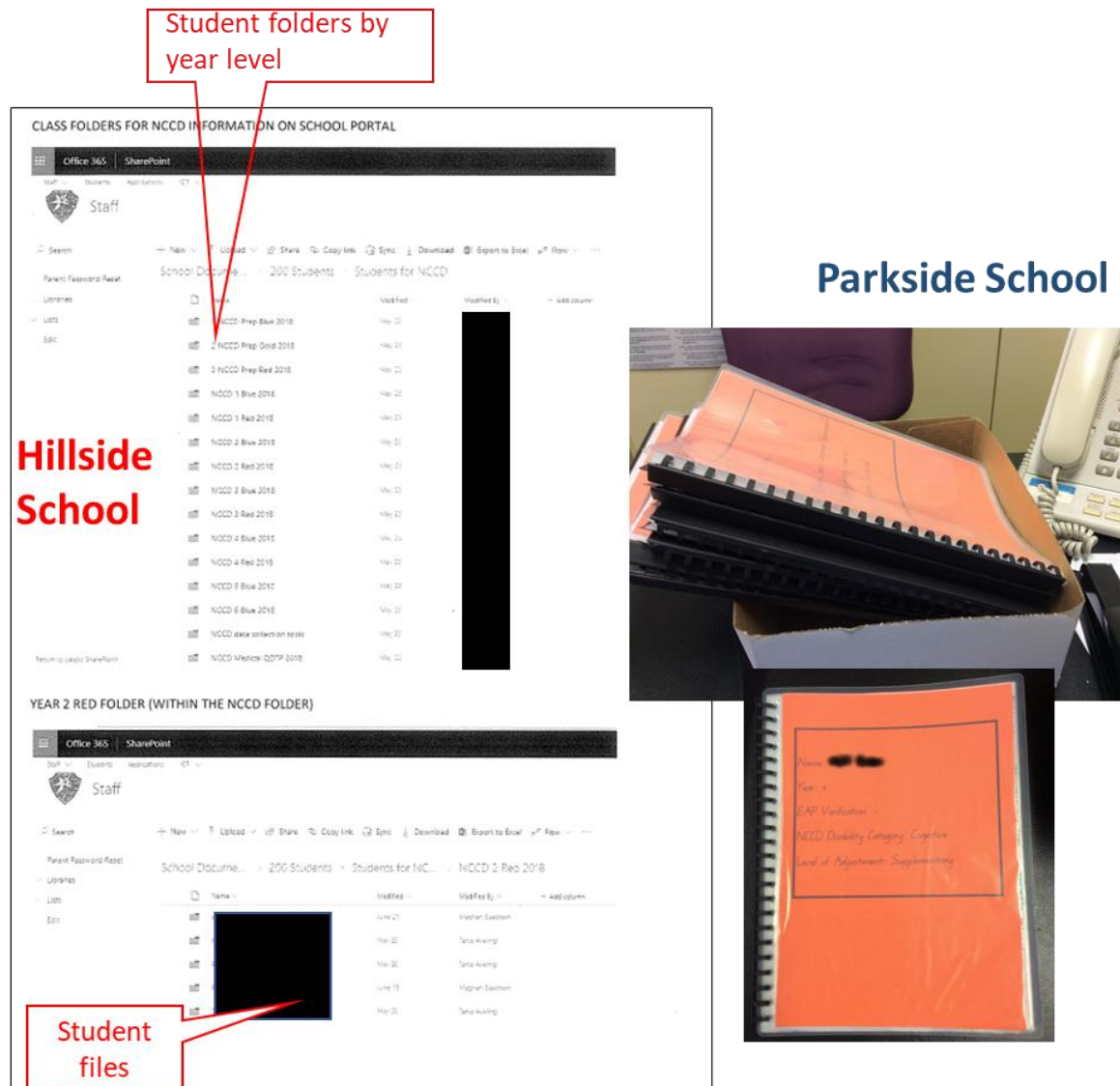


As Chloe checked off completed actions, she added additional adjustments and evidence to the collection list (menu). What was not recorded in these notes was evidence of impact, success or otherwise of specific adjustments or other reflections for improving learning access.

The record storage system at PPS was a locked filing cabinet in the learning support room that was maintained by a teacher assistant. Even though HPS had a digital system and PPS paper based, the actual file management structures were remarkably similar, in other

words textually translocal (see Figure 6.13). The data management system transcended physical locations and storage platforms.

**Figure 6.13** Student files/folders are evidence



Each student file was divided into four sections equating four areas of evidence as per the NCCD requirements listed on the *NCCD Evidence Record* (see Figure 6.6). In both schools, the teacher assistant worked with classroom teachers to maintain student records, by scanning documents and uploading them into the student folder on the school intranet or placing pieces of documentation into the student folder. Having a system in place was important because:

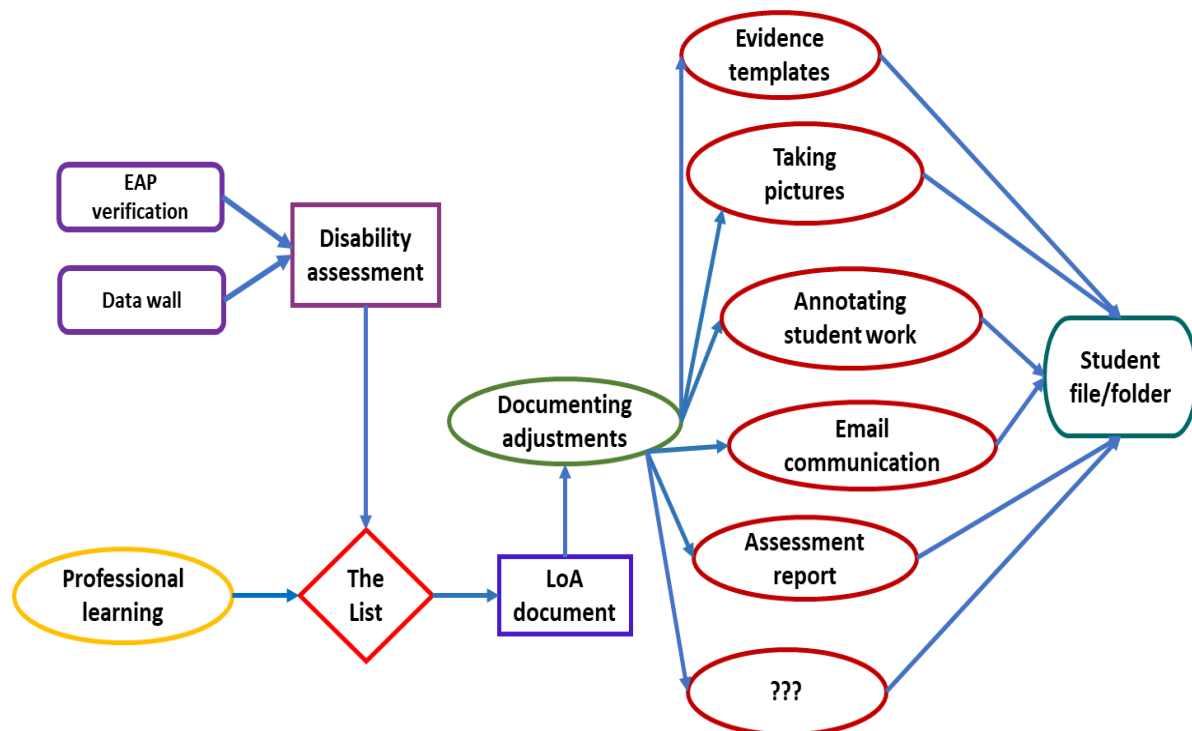


we need to be able to find it very quickly if we're audited, in a matter of minutes...if we are audited, we're going to need to rely on a bunch of resources, but she [teacher assistant] had access to a file in the curriculum documents where she could just upload everything (Fiona, Interview 1, September 12, 2018).

The collaboration between teacher assistant, classroom teachers and the learning support teacher was significant because it did not contribute to implementing educational adjustments (which was usual) but rather, the sole purpose of their work together was a performative measure, to maintain student records for accountability purposes (Ball, 2000; Grant et al., 2017). Managing the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD came at a considerable cost, the redeployment of staff, and the provision of resources to support the collection (e.g., iPads to take photos, stationery items – printing, folders, laminating, binding and so on). Yet, it was accepted as something that needed to happen, and therefore those at the frontline, the teachers and the teacher assistants, worked together to meet the institutional demands, making visible how this frontline work of the NCCD was textually mediated relations of rule (Nichols & Griffith, 2009) (see Figure 6.14).

The arrows on Figure 6.14 show the textual sequences; which texts were moved from one informant to the next for action to be ultimately stored in preparation for a potential audit (Nichols & Griffith, 2009; Wilson & Pence, 2006). Texts presented in Figure 6.14 actively contributed to the social organisation of how the NCCD was maintained by teachers and teacher assistants, each sequence with a specific purpose.

**Figure 6.14** *Evidence for NCCD is textually mediated*



The shape with the questions marks is a deliberate nod to the other forms of documentation that teachers did not mention in the conversation, but then thought about it afterwards and wished they had. As Robert, Olivia, Emily, and Sophie reflected, they all said remembering to write the adjustment down was sometimes the biggest challenge for the day.

## 6.3 PROCESSING THE NCCD COLLECTION

### 6.3.1 Teacher judgement

The official NCCD texts describe a four-step process to determine which students are eligible to be included in the NCCD collection, their LoA and CoD (see Chapter Four). This thesis has shown the disjuncture between the official process and the lived realities of teachers as being somewhat different. The first step in the official process is to provide the educational adjustments. Teachers were given The List with the LoA for each student they taught, they understood the expectation was that adjustments would be provided to match the specified level, and they would have proof of this work. The NCCD Guidelines, state an

expectation that teachers have an integral role in deciding the LoA, in fact they were the only role holders named:

Teachers determine the level of adjustments provided to students with disability to access and participate in education on the same basis as other students (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018, p. 7)

Yet, when the teachers were asked about their contribution to LoA decision, it quickly became apparent this work occurred at distance to them. The teachers were not involved, as stated by Robert:

Jeanine: Were you involved in making decision around the levels of adjustment?

Robert: No, no, I haven't made any decisions around levels of adjustment

Jeanine: So, who made the decisions around the levels of adjustment?

Robert: I can't answer that question. (Robert, Interview 1, 16 August 2018).

Olivia had the same experience:

I was basically told what category they fell into...and then we were pretty much just told these are the children that you're tracking, and this is the level that they're in. So, we weren't involved in the process of deciding the children and deciding the level, that was sort of just given to us, in a way (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018).

Teachers were not involved in the decision-making about the LoA or CoD, and even less so for which students would be included in the NCCD collection.

The composition of The List also occurred away from the teachers, and when probed about how students were placed on The List, it was not clear to them how this occurred, as explained by Olivia, "we weren't really involved in this, it was more, these are the children,

this is the level, you need to collect the data” (Olivia, Interview 1, August 16, 2018). But nor did anyone really know how to get students onto The List or off The List.

### **6.3.2 Teachers have always provided adjustments, so what is new?**

Teachers have drawn upon their professional judgement, knowledge of students and knowledge of the curriculum to provide education adjustments for students with disability for years. So, the question of how are the requirements of the NCCD different? Emily had strong views about professional trust, and performative hoop jumping (Grant et al., 2016), as she explained in a very long monologue:

No, we need to prove ourselves, and prove ourselves, you know. Yeah, so that’s the difficulty I find that we’re not trusted with, you know, what we’re saying. So, ok, what’s the test showing, but that doesn’t give us the whole picture...all that collecting of evidence, and you know and recording everything is, actually is taking my planning and teaching time away from the kids. I, I’m, you know, consciously thinking of I need to photocopy this page and write notes about this rather than having, that time, could be better spent just having a conversation and taking to the next level on a word or a sentence. So, it is really impacting on our teaching and students’ learning, it’s not beneficial for them...Yes, yep, I need to go and record this rather, look, you now, being present in that moment, yes, exactly that, and using every minute, you know, every opportunity we can, to further their learning. Yeah, it’s taken a lot of time away from that, we are just so worried about having all these records, that it actually takes it away, our time of being in that moment with the kids, and really having those deep conversations (Emily, Interview 2, November 20, 2018)

Emily raised deep concerns about how this new data regime was changing her teaching practices in ways that she found professionally challenging and dissatisfying. This raises questions about how this burden of institutional processes can be managed better. Issues of

work intensification, dissatisfaction and how this affects teacher self-identity are not new in education (Beck, 2018). Understanding people's experiences has the capacity to change how things can happen, as discussed by Sophie. She made frequent comparisons of her experiences with the NCCD across two schools in different education sectors:

Sophie: I've just come from XXX school, for 4 years and then come here, it's very different.

Jeanine: How is it different?

Sophie Just, I found that this process that we're doing is a lot more involved than what I've done in the past. So, it was a school-wide thing where we did, just a, what's it called, a specific adjustment form, for your class. And then, that was it, that's what you had to do. And then, obviously, you had your adjustment form. We have a [special education facility] attached to the school [previous school], so they kind of took care of that side, I'm assuming they took care of this side of things. So, it wasn't on the teacher (Sophie, Interview 1, August 23, 2018).

Sophie also noted that while the documenting was made onerous, there were also some benefits to her teaching practices:

Because it wasn't something in your, like in the forefront of your mind. So, this semester I'm kind of like making sure on all of my planning documents and all that, I've got everything written down. Because as a teacher, you kind of, just do it rather than writing it down. And then people go, what are you doing for this kid. And you can go boom, boom, boom. And they're like, OK so where is that documented. Well, I don't, I just do it, what I do is just

naturally. You know it's changing that mindset, I guess, of documenting it  
(Sophie, Interview 1, August 23, 2018).

As Sophie talked about her work as a teacher, and having adjustments at the “forefront”, she was visibly pleased, but even more so when described how she could just go “boom, boom, boom” if asked about a particular student. Sophie spoke with confidence about her capacity to quickly respond to requests for information, and her existing practices in differentiating for students with disability. Sophie appeared to have teacher agency, and commitment and purpose about how and why she was making adjustments for students; important attributes that contribute to educational equity for students with disability (Pantić & Florian, 2015). Yet she also readily accepted that documentation was needed, beyond the expectation of engaging in the practice with students. This is evidence of the concerning reach of the policy text reaching beyond practice and deeply into the beliefs of teachers. Despite the increased work of recording adjustments, Sophie accepted the necessity and was absorbing the requirements into her own professional practices.

## **6.4 CONCLUSION**

This chapter has provided insights into the institutional layers of this complex policy implementation from the standpoint of teachers and teacher assistants. The increased workload associated with the detailed documentation of educational adjustments was significant. The teachers' descriptions of how their everyday work was textually organised and regulated by The List revealed the translocal power of an unofficial NCCD text. Their accounts of how The List socially organised their work had remarkable similarities across school sites. The NCCD work of teachers was hooked up into the ideological codes of the Education Authority that was shared through the professional learning program. Despite the challenges of this new work, these teachers persisted and collaborated with colleagues to find

solutions and to make their work less onerous. Chapter Seven provides an analysis of how the NCCD is experienced by policy officers and senior Education Authority staff.

## Chapter 7: Regional and head office

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### 7.1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter returns to the work of informants from two education authorities who were initially introduced in Chapter Three. In total, there were 12 informants from two education authorities, ten from one Education Authority located at either head or regional office. The remaining two were based at head office (see Table 7.1 below). The education authorities had collaborated to develop the professional learning content.

**Table 7.1** *Education Authority informants*

|                 | Regional office | Head office |
|-----------------|-----------------|-------------|
| Senior managers | Sandra          | Julie       |
|                 | John            | Sharon      |
|                 | Joanne          | Wendy       |
| Policy officers | Maria           | Robyn       |
|                 | David           |             |
|                 | Michelle        |             |
|                 | Judith          |             |
|                 | Donna           |             |

Each informant, policy officer or senior manager, had some responsibility and/or oversight of policy implementation in schools, school governance and/or professional support for school-based role holders. Snowball sampling was used to identify each informant (Creswell, 2020).

Senior managers, Sandra, and John, each worked with a cluster of school principals and prior to moving to this senior role, had been school principals. Their experiences as senior managers working with principals and as a principal implementing the NCCD meant



they were able to provide valuable insights about leadership of the NCCD. The other senior managers, Sharon, Julie, Wendy, and Joanne were experienced educators and had, over time, moved into roles that were focused on educational governance with responsibilities associated with policy development and implementation. Policy officer, Robyn, was based at head office, with a direct role focused on NCCD implementation. She worked very closely with regionally based policy officers. Regional policy officers and senior policy officers Maria, Donna, Judith, Michelle, and David also worked with principals; however, their work was mostly with the learning support teacher and/or school counsellor. These policy officers were viewed as experts in their fields of students with disability or student wellbeing. Their roles were to mentor and advise school-based staff, for which they had no line management responsibilities.

This analytic chapter shows the everyday work of policy officers often involved interpreting and recontextualising NCCD policy texts on behalf of school staff (Ball et al., 2012). As the informants talked about how their work evolved, it became apparent that much of the newly created work they talked about was in part due to the change they had to make to previously negotiated activities in the schools before being directed to work with specified schools. At the beginning of the school year, the Education Authority executive communicated with principals and policy officers prioritising NCCD professional learning with a focus on ensuring all eligible students were funded. This had a direct impact on how the policy officers viewed the priorities for their daily work.

## **7.2 CHANGING THE WAY WORK HAPPENS**

This analysis commences by exploring the work of policy officers, Maria, Donna, Judith, Michelle, and David. During my conversations with these informants what became quickly evident was the institutional talk or discourse they used to describe their everyday actualities, an institutional account was being produced rather than an experiential account

(Smith, 2005; Stanley, 2018). The informants tended to employ institutional talk, using the objectified language present in organisational texts such as “building capacity”, “networking”, “school teams” and the like. This talk revealed the social organisation that was present in their everyday, even as they described how they had to unexpectedly pivot from what they had planned for 2018 to incorporate new demands that were placed on them in relation to their NCCD work with schools (Smith, 1987). For example, although they were already working with schools to implement the policy requirements of the NCCD, there was increased engagement in the NCCD work which meant they were working with more teachers and this work has happening with increased frequency across all their schools. This shift was significant and had cascading consequences. First, the policy officers had to prioritise and consider how to reorganise their work schedules, and then renegotiate their schedules with each school in the cluster to add this new work and undertake the already planned work.

As the informants talked about how this happened, they produced an “organisation’s organisational account” (Smith, 2005, p. 156) of their work with schools that was steeped in institutional discourse. Encouraging them to move beyond “work knowledges” in our conversation was difficult. Despite my efforts to encourage the informants to provide additional meaning or clarity to their accounts, institutional talk permeated our conversations (Smith, 2005). As the informants described their work, and because of my insider knowledge and therefore my ability to engage in the institutional talk, I was challenged to avoid or at least minimise the risk of benign descriptions of their work. Smith (2005) describes this as institutional capture, in which the informant provides an institutional account of their experience that is “descriptively empty” (p. 156). For example, I returned frequently to questions such as, “can you tell me a bit more about what you do”, and “what does that look like in your day/work?”

Despite these attempts, there were times when the informants did not move beyond the institutional language. It was apparent in interviews that institutional language had “subsume[d] people’s actual speech and what they [had] to tell about themselves (D. E. Smith, 1990a, p. 31). I made use of Corman (2021) suggestion that “composite accounts” (p.466) are a useful tool in institutional ethnography as they are based on accounts given by informants, while also making use of researcher observations and textual artefacts. The purpose of drawing together various data sources was to keep the institution and people in view while describing complex work (Corman, 2021). To do so, I have drawn on people’s accounts of their work, as well as texts gathered during data collection and field notes to reveal a sequence of actions connected to their NCCD work (Smith, 2005). Field notes were made after each conversation, observation (a planning meeting staff meeting and curriculum planning sessions) and about the documents that were collected. School staff gave richer accounts of the work than the policy officers, in which they described how they came to be at the school daily or weekly for periods of time, the professional development they facilitated and how planning and schedules were reorganised.

The most immediately identified change for the policy officers was how their work had shifted to include other school-based personnel, more than the learning support teacher, when it was announced that the NCCD count was going to inform funding for students with disability. Prior to 2018, the policy officers had worked predominantly with learning support teachers and/or school counsellors. But early in the 2018 school year the Education Authority increased its focus on NCCD policy implementation, prioritising this work alongside other system initiatives. This focus on the NCCD put a spotlight on the work the policy officers were already doing in schools in relation to the NCCD. This created an opportunity for the policy officers to engage with an increased number of school staff at each school. The whole staff professional learning sessions at the beginning of the school year is one such example,

but in many schools, this was extended to include other professional learning sessions about students with disability. This opportunity to have regular access to the school staff was not something that had happened before, and was an opportunity that was embraced, as Judith shared:

the other thing that's good from this office perspective is, it also allows the school teams that we support, the NCCD teams, which is, a wider group of people than I probably would have had contact with, within schools, it's stretched that out (Judith, Interview 1, September 25, 2018).

As Judith continued to reflect on how her work included more than the learning support teacher it was increasingly apparent that this provided a strong sense of job satisfaction for her, moreover, this sentiment was also echoed by the other informants. While this was very satisfying for Judith and her colleagues it was difficult to gain further insights into what this meant for her everyday actualities. From the outset, institutional talk dominated the informants' accounts, their narratives were steeped in a professional discourse that was specific to their professional work (DeVault & McCoy, 2006). Judith explained:

Yeah, so it's, I'm, I really want to build capacity, you know, but a sustainable, sort of capacity so that, the networking is happening, not just me run in and help and do everything and go away and then it all falls over but for things to become set in the school, and in most cases I really felt that happened. Yeah, when I had gone back for reflections [formal process to review the application of the NCCD at the school level], in a lot of my schools, I've just sat there and felt so, happy with how they, as a team, have continued the conversations, but they still say that they would like some support next year...but they're not sitting on their hands waiting for me to come (Judith, Interview 1, September 25, 2018).

When I asked Judith to explain what she meant by “building capacity”, her response continued to be focused on the schools she supported and that they were working independently of her. She offered no specific examples of what this actual work was and continued to tell me her work was now extended beyond just working with the learning support teacher. When nudged for more specific detail about how her work was happening Judith reiterated how pleased she was that her school teams had “continued the conversations...they’re not sitting on their hands”. However, it was not clear how these conversations continued or what these conversations were about, yet Judith was confident these conversations were ongoing in the schools. What was not visible in Judith’s explanation of her work, was how her embodied realities and that of her colleagues at schools was being organised.

Each of the policy officers talked about how their work shifted, Michelle described this change to include an increased demand on her time in schools, she said:

Big things this year...have been more school development and training for school teams. Initially my work would mainly involve working with the learning support teacher, whereas the development of school moderation teams has occurred and there’s been a lot of training for those personnel as well, but it’s been delivered as a whole system and also individually with school teams, as well (Michelle, Interview 1, September 25, 2018).

Note how she started the description of her work, “big things this year”, she was talking about the increased work for her, which included more training of school staff about the NCCD requirements. Michelle attributed this change to the inception of “school moderation teams”.

The school moderation team was responsible for reviewing documentation concerning a student the NCCD SLT had intended to include on the NCCD. The moderation team was

this same NCCD SLT plus a policy officer. The policy officer facilitated the moderation, who checked and verified the documented records of educational adjustments provided for students who were going to be included on the NCCD. This meant making decisions based on classrooms and children they did not know aside from the quantified versions provided for the purpose of ensuring perceived data accuracy. Michelle, and her fellow policy officers, were therefore taking on the role of auditors, in which there were formal processes for checking teachers' work and confirming its veracity, making an account of student data in preparation for the AG School Census (Power, 1999). This was a communal investment into realising organisational objectives. The standardised approach to auditing the documentary evidence about students who were on The List was the backdrop to the moderation team training.

This process of moderation “permeated organisational life” (Power, 1999, p. 4), as the policy officers were part of moderation teams in all the schools they supported. The moderation work was translocal, meaning the policy officers worked across schools to standardise evaluations of evidence of educational adjustments which enabled comparisons across school sites (Griffith & Smith, 2014b; Smith, 2005). This new work for policy officers, directed by the Education Authority and welcomed by the schools, was textually mediated by the AG School Census. The AG School Census produced technical forms (texts) which required schools to collect and collate student data in a specified format to complete the online census data entry. These texts organised and mediated the everyday actions the policy officers and the moderation teams (Smith et al., 2006). School census data is high stakes because it informs Australian Government school funding for the following school year. The year this data was collected, was the first year that funding was attached to the census, this was a source of anxiety for policy officers. An explanation of the NCCD and the schools census can be found in section 4.5.

Michelle talked about how her involvement in whole school training about the NCCD had increased, whereas previously most of her school contact had been the learning support teacher only. She was now talking with teachers and other members of the NCCD school leadership team. Other informants also noted this shift of work for the policy officers which is discussed in Chapters Five and Six, specifically the policy officer involvement in the professional learning and staff meeting sessions at the beginning of the school year. Although policy officers designed and facilitated the professional learning and staff meeting sessions, the actual labour involved in this work was not discussed. In their descriptions of this work, the policy officers talked about the institutional processes, making sure key messages were shared with school staff, and that they understood their requirements in terms of data collection and data quality. Michelle provided little detail about how this professional learning was organised in her description of the work.

Despite my attempts to encourage the informants to provide a detailed account of their everyday actualities, particularly how the additional work of the moderation teams, the professional learning and meeting with more school people, their descriptions do not delve deeply into how things happened in their own work. The embodied ways in which they each attended to and accommodated the additional work of the moderation teams, reorganising their schedules and facilitating adult learning sessions at each school about NCCD, this was not forthcoming. The discourse was instead steeped in institutional jargon that was descriptively minimal. However, there was enough to follow a thread which revealed the mediating capacity of the AG School Census to coordinate and organise this embodied work.

### **7.2.1 The annual Australian Government (AG) School Census**

As the informants described the new work with school moderation teams and professional learning demands, alongside the unexpected increased frequency of school visits which meant increased demands on their time. This abrupt change to their schedules required

them to renegotiate schedules of previously planned work, however, this work intensification was accepted, as Donna said, “our work had started to ramp up” (Donna, Interview 1, September 25, 2018). Although their work had “ramped up” the intensity of their workflow was not evident in their descriptions of how they went about renegotiating their work, the service plans with each of their schools. In Chapter Five, the NCCD SLT of PPS described the sudden urgency of ensuring all eligible students were included in NCCD. This emphasis on ensuring all eligible students were included in the NCCD was additional work for the policy officers and school teams, and the additional work came in over the top of the school service plan that had been negotiated in the previous year. No one talked of removing any of the pre-negotiated work from the school service plan, therefore, the new NCCD work was just added to their work schedule.

The policy officer’s accounts were dominated by the imprimatur of the Education Authority to engage with schools identified as being at risk of losing student funding. The impact of this new work as directed by the Education Authority (see Appendix I: Education Authority communique), meant that policy officers renegotiated service plans with all schools; the Education Authority executive did not acknowledge this additional workload. The new service plans also meant the policy officers were now charged with the responsibility of monitoring school data collection for quality assurance purposes. This quality assurance was twofold, the policy officer ensured all eligible students were included in NCCD count and second, for those students in the count there was evidence of adjustments that supported the Level of Adjustment (LoA) claimed (see Chapter Four for a more detailed explanation of the LoA).

The new work of data quality assurance was prioritised because it was directed by head office, as described by Donna:



at the start of the year, we were, working in a space where we thought we knew what was going to happen, but until we actually had confirmation from [head office] that this is what we needed to do...it, that confirmation really, just affirmed what we had planned what we would need to do for the year. But, I think, it's still, there was still a frenzy of activity and, very intense work in schools for Term Two (Donna, Interview 1, September 25, 2018).

When the policy officers received “confirmation from [head office] that is what we needed to do” it was accepted without question and this new work was incorporated into their everyday. Despite the work plans Donna had already made with her schools in relation to the NCCD, the requirement from head office to prioritise data quality now provided additional leverage for engaging with schools more frequently. As Donna went on to explain, the explicit link of the NCCD to student funding meant other policy actors became involved:

based on the, the suggestion that there was, that there was to be a link with [student] funding and that, the, processes around ensuring that the [student] data be clean be much clearer and tidied up...there was going to be a greater emphasis put on the NCCD...from a higher leadership level, so rather than it be driven by...policy officers working in schools that we need to do this well, that it was actually going to come from above. But that really probably didn't start to happen until Term Two, and so our work, became easier because, because each school was, more aware of the importance and urgency around, around improving the consistency of the data, enhancing the knowledge of what NCCD is, what the nationally consistent collection of data is all about, what it means to support children with disability. And it, really became work that I found myself doing with large teams of people at schools, whereas prior to this year, it was really my work, as a learning support teacher or as a policy officer supporting the learning support teachers, and sometimes school

counsellors but, but largely learning support teachers (Donna, Interview 1, September 25, 2018).

Head office had raised the “importance and urgency” of the NCCD count with schools, and the necessity of “improving the consistency of the data” as this impacted student funding. This drive from head office and the “higher leadership level” as described by Donna, made her work in Term Two easier because her work with school teams was now formally endorsed, which meant it was easier for her to work with large school teams more regularly. The emphasis on adherence to quality assurance of the NCCD, ensuring all eligible students were counted and that there was adequate evidence of adjustments was now being driven by the senior managers who had responsibility for principal supervision. The everyday work of the policy officers and the NCCD SLT was being organised by the student data for the NCCD count (Spina, 2020). The NCCD had effectively textualized students with disability; student information was hooked up into the census funding machine.

### **7.2.2 Funding and the Australian Government School Census**

Maria, a senior policy officer, discussed how preparation for the AG School Census came to organise their everyday actions:

Maria:            Alright, so, we already had NCCD as a priority as part of the [policy officer team] big rocks, that was already outlined for 2018, what we didn't expect was, the huge emphasis that would be placed upon it and the changing, the way the organisation would view our work and that happened when [head office] contacted the director, to say that they were concerned that our organisation was going to lose significant funding. So, from that point in time, NCCD, the NCCD census, became, a priority for the organisation and the assistant, the deputy director contacted schools, and explained that it was a priority, and

they were expected to work with us towards the [school] census, so that the most accurate data was collected. So that really gave us, opportunities that we hadn't had before, openings, and we were able to work really consistently with schools on a very regular basis, from that time which was Term One up until the census collection on August 3<sup>rd</sup>, and then moving forward, so really NCCD became the vehicle for the work that we'd always prioritised and needed to do. It got us into the schools.

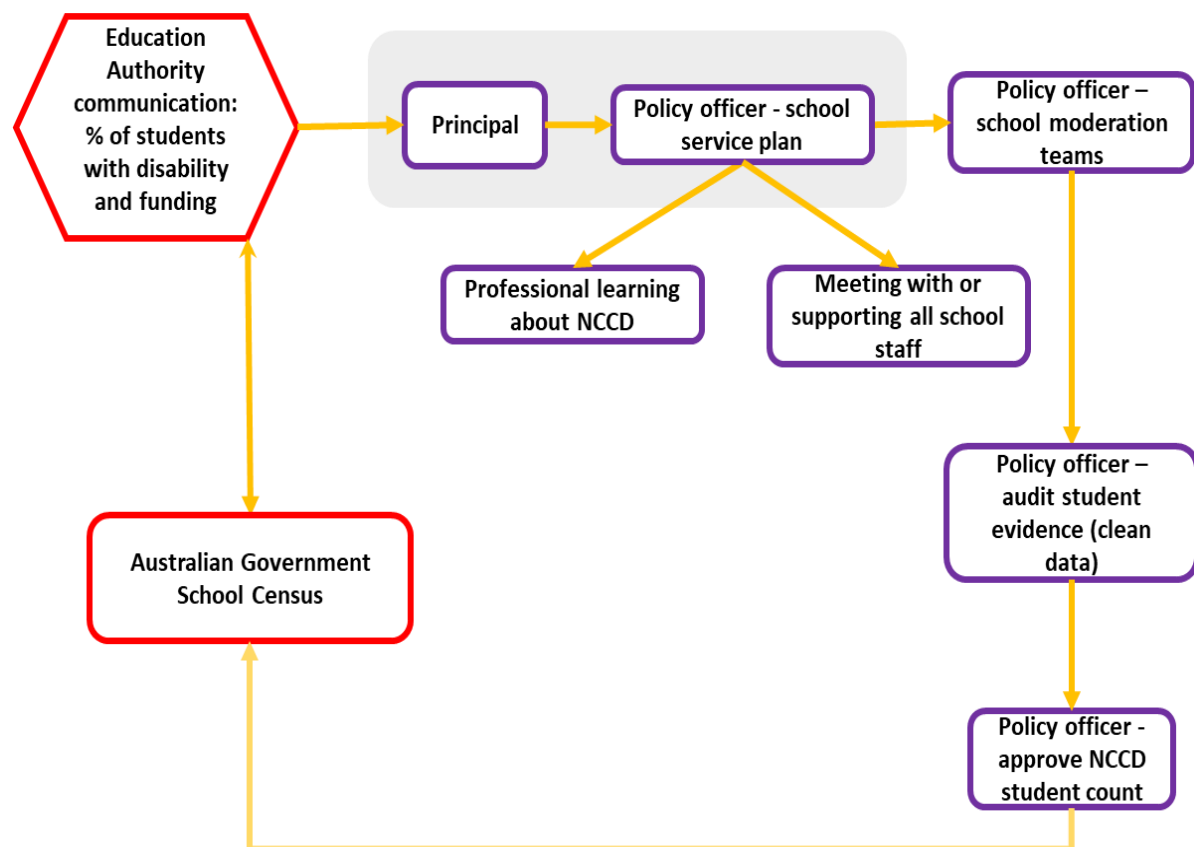
Jeanine: How did that change specifically, can you give me some specific examples about how that changed, what that change looked like?

Maria: What our changed interactions with schools looked like. So instead of dealing with an individual role holder on a staff who was trying to manage, who would have discussions with us around best practice, instead of that, we had the opportunity to work with whole teams, with multiple role holders. I think for the first time, principals prioritised their time with NCCD, we were able to get principals to professional development opportunities and be available for subsequent conversations, moderation was prioritised as an action, as a way of “depthing” knowledge. And we had principals participating in that, with their school teams, and previously I hadn't had that experience (Maria, Interview 1, October 9, 2018).

As Maria also talked about the increased time in schools, working with more school staff (beyond the learning support teacher) and principals were engaged in professional learning. Maria also identified funding as the lever that organised this work in schools. Their work was mediated by the AG School Census timelines and requirements because there was

“concern[ed] that our organisation was going to lose significant funding. So, from that point in time...it was a priority, and they [principals] were expected to work with us towards the census”. The AG School Census occurs annually on the first Friday of August. In Term One the informants began working towards the August collection date; this timeline coordinated decisions, actions, policies and plans.

**Figure 7.1** *School Census mediated the work*



The textual chain maps how the informants worked towards the census data collection is provided in Figure 7.1. This chain or sequence of actions was made visible through conversations with policy officers, who were working to ensure schools met the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD, and data was of sufficient quality, which was aptly summarised by senior manager, Wendy, “because they know census means audit” (Wendy, Interview 1, October 23, 2018).

The textual chain in Figure 7.1 begins with the red shapes which indicates ruling texts that organised replicated actions translocally (across multiple sites) (Smith, 1999). The shaded block represents the usual work of the policy officer, everything outside of the shading was work introduced because of the NCCD. In piecing this map together, it became apparent that funding for students with disability was a key apparatus that reorganised and regulated how peoples' everyday actualities happened, and that associated actions (and chains of actions) were unleashed by this mechanism (Smith, 1987). New institutional practices and arrangements were implemented, such as the policy officers working with the school moderation teams. The provision of professional learning that was orchestrated from the regional office was ultimately mediated by the AG School Census. These textual chains were not always visible to the informants (Griffith & Smith, 2005). School moderation teams were entrenched in the laborious process carefully checking student records.

### **7.2.3 Moderation or auditing - checking for evidence of adjustments**

Moderation is a quality assurance mechanism and is a core component of the teaching, learning and assessment cycle (Beutel et al., 2017). It involves teachers discussing and debating their interpretations of the quality of the work they are reviewing, professional learning is an intended outcome of this social activity (Adie & Klenowski, 2016). Through the process of professional discussion, moderation is intentionally a socio-cultural activity that is designed to achieve consistency of teacher judgement about the merit or quality of student work (Koh, 2014). Traditionally teacher moderation has focused on student achievement.

NCCD moderation is the quality assurance measure, to ensure the reliability and accuracy of students included in the NCCD count (Chaney et al., 2020). The official text, *Nationally Consistent Collection of Data – School Students with Disability: Moderation Resource for Schools Version 2* explains NCCD moderation:

NCCD moderation process, staff review all evidence and build a shared understanding of:

- the **level of adjustment** being provided for each student to meet the identified educational needs arising from their disability,
- and the **broad category of disability** for which support is provided.

The NCCD captures the ongoing work undertaken by teachers and school staff throughout the year in providing personalised learning and support for students with disability. It reflects the valuable knowledge teachers acquire about students' educational needs, and decisions they make about how these needs can be best supported. Implementing quality learning and support practices places schools in a strong position to complete the NCCD (Sharma et al., 2019, p. 5).

As the informants shared their embodied experience of moderation, reference to class teacher presence was notably absent. The moderation team was the NCCD SLT and a policy officer, teacher participation and therefore teacher judgement was not evident. As Robyn, policy officer, talked about her work with schools, a strong desire for accurate data as a quality assurance measure was foregrounded. She explained:

No, I can't be any more clearer...what is wanted at a national level, and nothing more and nothing less, is accurate data. So, your data is going to change from year to year, it's contextual, it's based on what adjustments are you providing currently for that student, and by currently, I mean in the preceding 12 months to the last data collection. So, from August to August, it needs to be reviewed every year and individually for every student. So, no one wants you to have to second guess what someone might want. That's not what the data collection is about. If you provide high quality accurate and consistent data, you're going to be fine. Quality assurance, for me, which is why I push

and we're going to continue to push nationally...in every presentation that I do, is moderation, because moderation is going to not only address the quality issues around individual school decision-making, it's going to decrease the variability across schools, across regions, across dioceses, across state jurisdictions. So, moderation is going to be a key emphasis, I believe. And in moderating, your school teams are talking, they're discussing, moderation is based on evidence, because another panel looking at your evidence, so in comes the importance of evidence, and it's going to contextualise your data. And in moderating, your school teams are talking, they're discussing, moderation is based on evidence, because another panel looking at your evidence, so in comes the importance of evidence, and it's going to contextualise your data. If you've got students receiving extensive adjustments, your evidence is going to show it, you know what's happening, it's defensible (Robyn, Interview 1, October 3, 2018).

Robyn's focus on the moderation team or moderation panel did not mention the inclusion of classroom teachers, this notable absence which was replicated across policy officer informants' explanations of moderation. Robyn shared that through professional learning, "in every presentation I do", that she was very focused on moderation as a tool for quality assurance to "provide high quality and consistent data" so that "you're going to be fine", which suggests there was a concern that you might not "be fine". This thread or idea of not being fine with the data was also picked up in my conversation with Wendy, a senior manager, when she explained:

census means audit...in the paper this morning, there was an article from Chris Riley of The Streets, complaining that he's got to give back \$630, 000 to the federal government...they've seen their funding collapse...That's not by

far the biggest amount I've heard of, in terms of the difference and when you look at it, because of the weighting of NCCD we have that volatility of numbers that has certainly caused some significant angst (Wendy, Interview 1 October 23, 2018).

The situation Wendy was referring to was about a school for young people with social emotional needs, which was playing out in the media at the time. The principal of the school, Father Chris Riley, directly attributed the substantial decrease in funding for students with disability to the evidence requirements of the NCCD. Father Riley was quoted as saying the evidentiary requirements of NCCD were onerous and had impacted the number of students who could be included in the NCCD census count (Markson, 2018). Wendy also talked about the “funding collapse” in schools and that it had “caused significant angst”.

These accounts about data quality reinforces the translocal power of the annual AG School Census which was coordinating actions in schools throughout Australia. The institutional arrangements mediated by the AG School Census led to an increased focus on evidence, not just of educational adjustments for students with disability for quality assurance purposes, but also evidence of school engagement with the professional learning agenda and the formation of moderation teams as a type of insurance against a potential “funding collapse”.

#### **7.2.4 Quality assurance or surveillance**

To curtail the potential funding issues in schools the Education Authority instigated measures that prioritised the work of the policy officers, with minimal foresight of the impact this might have on their everyday work. Sharon, a senior manager shared:

I mean we knew that we'd have work to do, we didn't realise probably the intensity of it, and then I think there was another period of intensity which we hadn't foreseen,



just the way the timelines align in our system around budget processes (Sharon, Interview 1, October 19, 2018).

My second conversation with, policy officer, Donna was some months after the initial conversation in 2018, and early in the new school year, yet she continued to reflect on the very busy workload of the previous year:

it was unexpected, and responsive to the [Education Authority] requirements that were being passed on...Unexpected, but we all just, we all rolled with it, because we didn't have a choice and it needed to be done. We had a particularly busy year really (Donna, Interview 2, February 14, 2019).

Donna emphasised that she did not feel she and her colleagues had any option other than to comply with the new requirements of the Education Authority. She said that “we all [the policy officers] rolled with it, because we didn't have a choice”. Work intensification for school staff, particularly classroom teachers, was also an issue as identified by the school-based informants (see Chapter Six). However, unlike the teacher informants, who had their school principals working to buffer this additional workload, the policy officers did not seem to have someone taking on this same role as they moved from being service orientated to being more performance focused (Omari & Paull, 2015). Donna explained the detailed record-keeping that was required by the organisation:

Donna:           The first one [record of work] was the feedback that was being given from every cluster around our work in Term Two [2018]...I can't, so the purpose of the Term Two work was reporting anything at all that we were doing in a school connected with NCCD. So, it, it was a single heading, I think

Jeanine:          So, who wanted to know that?

Donna: Philip [executive leader] wanted to know that. It, it was interesting though, because, all the clusters were represented across the bottom, and then you'd open the cluster, and the schools were there, and you'd put in your information. But for anybody to, to actually use that information effectively was a bit, curious, because you can't

Jeanine: In what way?

Donna: Well, you could go to the school and look at what is going on, but to generate a report from the document, I don't think that would ever have had happened. So, it would only be that someone said we've got a problem at MM school, let's see what's going on there. Or what's the, you know, what's Liza [policy officer] been doing to support them. I think it would have been information that went in and went nowhere. That's what I think, because I, I don't know how they would have extracted something useful from it. It's all different language, it was all, maybe, I think it was just responsive to the system putting something in place where we're all accountable in our work.

Jeanine: Do you think?

Donna: But I don't know then if they actually used the information to anybody's benefit, they might have (Donna, Interview 2, February 15, 2019).

Donna described the record-keeping working in Term Two about each school visited as being problematic. The organisation's directive was to record "anything at all that we were doing in a school connected with NCCD" on a template they were given. Ultimately, recording every detail of all interactions with schools was onerous and time demanding, in a very busy schedule.

Donna described the process of opening the excel spreadsheet, each geographical cluster of schools had their own tab (page) at the bottom, opening the cluster record and updating the “running record” of her actions in a specific school. This excel spreadsheet was a digital record maintained on the organisation’s intranet which was accessible to the senior managers, the executive leadership, and the policy officers.

The daily actions undertaken by the policy officers illustrated how their everyday doings was as part of an effort to be “responsive to the particularities of the people they were working with, while at the same time being accountable to managerially standardising frames” (Smith & Griffith, 2022, p. 100). In this way, their work represented something of an interface, or frontline, with schools. As Donna described it, this focus, and the *institutional* demands that they record their actions and interactions in each school contributed to the very “busy year”. Unlike the frontline workers in schools, there was no talk of how institutional demands were buffered for the policy officers. Being “responsive to the system putting something in place where we’re all accountable in our work” was both accepted and accommodated by the policy officers as they reorganised their everyday work. Although the policy officers felt more “accountable” for their work, it was not clear to the informants what steps the organisation took beyond record-keeping. Donna queried the functional use of the information other than “it would only be that someone said we’ve got a problem at MM school, let’s see what’s going on there” however, there was no follow up or discussion about how their work would be used, nor was there any coherent planning for next steps. Sharon, a senior manager, provided additional insights when she said:

started fairly broad, are there any schools who aren’t sending people to workshops, that was a pretty clear signal, so we, and we sort of tried to make sure that happened, and as we saw people were enrolled or not enrolled, we tried to get them there (Sharon, Interview 1, October 19, 2018).

Sharon talked about how the school records were reviewed to ensure staff in all schools attended NCCD workshops. This focused attention in schools, textually mediated by the potential “funding collapse”, continued throughout the year in more than one form.

***Avoiding a “funding collapse” or managing an audit?***

The senior managers were very focused on the fallout of funding shortfalls for schools. Wendy described the urgency of this work:

Once funding came in, business managers started to pay much closer attention, and now that audits are coming in because it’s now part of the census, school leadership is starting to pay attention (Wendy, Interview 1, October 23, 2018).

It was at this frontline, between policy and school that, this urgency was translated into actualities, as Donna described:

The instruction [from the Education Authority executive] was to, to focus on two schools, that, you work out the rationale, what you’ve chosen those schools, but this is work you are doing in Term Four in those schools. Or this the work moving forward. So, in the two schools that I chose, for example, was around a deficit of funds being expected in 2020, and so what would we be planning in order to address that...So, in both situations in Term Two and Term Four, it was unexpected, and responsive to [Education Authority] requirements that were being passed on to [regional office]...So, you know, so suddenly principals were on board with engaging with inclusive education personnel, because, their money was going to change, depend on it. (Donna, Interview 2, February 15, 2019).

Donna targeted two schools due to a predicted “deficit of funds” in 2020. She had to provide a rationale for her choice, as directed by the Education Authority. Furthermore, the “principals were on board....because their money was going to change, depend on it”, in other words there was a perception that funding was going to depend on the work that was

being undertaken to quality assure the student data. The policy officers maintained records of their own actions and interactions in schools (see Figure 7.2). The first thing you notice on this official record provided by the Education Authority are the red numbers, which represent the predicted funding shortfall for 2020, and the justification for targeting these schools.

**Figure 7.2** Evidence of actions

|    | School     | Funding for 2018 | Expected funding for 2020 | 2020 funding difference to 2018 | Notes about the work                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----|------------|------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 50 | [Redacted] | 224,913          | 207,531                   | -17,382                         | Partner with NCCD school team in changes needed to develop staff understanding of new funding model. Support XXX consolidating whole school processes for evidence collection and storage. Support XXX in building whole school understanding of DDA/DSE/NCCD. Support XXX and XX in building |
| 51 | [Redacted] | 257,049          | 194,647                   | -62,402                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 52 | [Redacted] | 193,634          | 193,634                   | 15989                           | There is not a dedicated position at the school - role holder has dual roles of                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 30 | [Redacted] | 208,572          | 147,913                   | -60,659                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|    |            |                  |                           | -17,382                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|    |            |                  |                           | -62,402                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|    |            |                  |                           | 15989                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|    |            |                  |                           | -60,659                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

Policy officers were directed to contact schools that required support to maintain funding, and to maintain records of their work and support in schools. This was recorded on a spreadsheet as a digital record for the Education Authority. This process increased the level of accountability and visibility of the policy officers' work. There was a distinctive shift from a service oriented role of mentoring the learning support teacher in schools, to being performance focussed, with increased organisational activity directed toward the minimisation of a "funding collapse" (Omari & Paull, 2015).

What is most interesting in these accounts from the policy officer informants, Michelle, Judith, Donna, and David was the shift in how this work came to them. In some accounts, the

NCCD SLT initiated the contact and therefore contracted the work. However, it was most commonly a consequence of the Education Authority's finance department's surveillance of school funding data that determined which schools the policy officers targeted and how they would engage with the school. Their work was about compliance for funding purposes, to shore up student numbers in specific levels of adjustments, supported by enough evidence should there be an audit. A notable absence in the conversations was a student-centred approach to educational adjustments. Although these conversations were driven by accountability and compliance, the policy officers suggested there were benefits for students from the improved school processes and planning that was occurring, as Donna indicated:

It's been a great thing, a great thing, and the schools who have perhaps been less inclined to engage in support at a system level, at the office, you know, from people like myself or other inclusive ed support staff, at an office level, schools engaged a lot more in what's available to them in order to support them to support students with disability. So, it has been excellent in that regard (Donna, Interview 1, 25 September 2018).

Donna linked improved school processes as having a direct correlation to better support for students with disability. However, Biesta (2015) challenges assumptions about educational processes that lead to improved outcomes for students, particularly in the absence of a visible presence of the teacher.

### **7.3 ANOMALY CHECKS BUT NO TARGETS**

As Donna and Wendy talked about how concerns about student funding reshaped their work, but they were now also working with other role holders, Wendy said:

we have done individual school visits and actually, you know, personalised emails to principals to say you need to come along to this, your data is significantly different

from the national average. We work quite closely with the data people and the funding people (Wendy, Interview 1, October 23, 2018).

Wendy worked with the “data and funding people” to identify schools because the “data is significantly different from the national average”. As Wendy described this additional nuance to this work, she also revealed how the work of the “data and funding people” was also being reshaped by the potential “funding collapse” associated with census. Their work was also being organised by the census timeline. Michelle explained how the “query that came from the data analysis was something that hadn’t been picked up previously” (Michelle, Interview 1, September 25, 2018). There was a chain of actions that included an external person doing data analysis (anomaly checks) and in so doing querying the student data, all before the August census deadline. Julie explained how workers from head office were involved in the data anomaly checks:

We saw a change in the understanding of funding implications, because that black and white piece there, for all that we’d done predicting, analysis, that piece wasn’t there until we started to cover school...by school...look at the data...And, and we, we would look at shifts right up until the census point (Julie, Interview 1, October 4, 2018).

Policy officers at head office were engaged in “predicting, analysis...by school” and this continued until the “census point”. This new analytical work for the “data and funding people” continued through the lead up to the August census. When Julie talked about “shifts” in the data, it was students moving on The List in terms of the LoA. The LoA was important because of the explicit connection to funding. Students placed in the Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice (QDPT) were not funded, students given a level at either Supplementary, Substantial or Extensive meant the school received a graduated funding amount for each student in each of these three levels.

### 7.3.1 National percentages are generated

The distribution of funding for students with disability was complicated. Senior manager, John explained:

Jeanine: That's great because that's what my questions are about the ways things have happened this year

John: Ok, so, just so from 2018 the disability loading, the funding is tied to the students identified in the three adjustment levels

Jeanine: So how do you see that happening?

John: I see that systems need to change...And even though and I can tell you what's occurred, in fact I will, as far as the information is concerned so the [Education Authority executive] sent a communication to all the principals. And now remember all principals got that, not the learning support teachers [the person who is generally managing the NCCD implementation]. At my particular cluster of 14 principals...I had Maria [senior policy officer], speak to all of the principals and do a Q & A, and that was really effective...So, there's been discussions, there's been the regional office and head office about NCCD workshops...discussions between myself and the policy officer [for] identified schools, we had lots of conversations in relation to that secondary school that I was just talking about, and then there was a follow up meeting between, them and the secondary school...got to be careful there, in a high SWD [students with disability] school, with a new way of working, put too much pressure on a certain person they may go, and that school, that particular school's got challenges in maintaining that consistency of staff. So, it's got to be walking with,



and it's got to be very clearly stepped out and regular, the meetings have got to be regular...to follow the conversations, schools that didn't attend the NCCD workshop were followed up by, staff down here, either the policy officer or the senior manager. (John, Interview 1, September 24, 2018).

John reiterated the increased workload for the policy officers, and that the work came to them as direct consequence of the communication from the executive leader. However, as John began to describe how things happened in 2018, he started with the matter of student funding, "from 2018 the disability loading, the funding". Funding was clearly coordinating the everyday actions of multiple informants, from very senior levels in the organisation down.

John continued:

John: schools with specific apparent data anomalies were identified for, direct follow up, and, and of course our executive leader was very much on to that because he is concerned about the, the NCCD data as far as percentage and we need to be conscious of resourcing, because the resourcing levels if they drop dramatically, then the kids can't be cared for as they are...In my cluster of 14 schools, there was one primary and one secondary school highlighted through, requiring additional support.

Jeanine: How did that happen, who highlighted that?

John: Well, it was the early NCCD data was showing that there were no, there were schools without evidence, and the principal at the secondary, he's brand new and certainly a detailed person who dots the 'i's and crosses the t's and used to system and government requirements, so it was very quick to draw my attention to that,

whereas previous principals at that school had relied on, I think the staff underneath him and, there's a mixture of messages there...so the director of this centre was also informed about that, and even now, I mean, in total aggregate sort of data, the [Education Authority] had 10% NCCD data and now it's moved to 14%, with the state average being 18. Well, you know the [Education Authority] is no different to any other educational organisation. If the state's 18 then we should be in that ballpark, 14 really does really change the game because, in one of my schools \$3.4 million is attracted in SWD [student with disability] money, and you want it to be astutely and accurately used for the benefit of every kid. So, every kid gets an opportunity (John, Interview 1, September 24, 2018).

John declared, "schools with specific apparent data anomalies were identified for direct follow up, there were data anomalies in schools". I was curious to understand what these data anomalies were. John clarified that it was a percentage of total enrolment, the Education Authority was working towards 18% of students to be included in the NCCD count in the AG School Census. Anything less than 18% of students was an anomaly, which over time was being addressed as the Education Authority had moved "from 10% NCCD data...to 14%".

In trying to understand where the 18% came from, senior manager, Julie provided this clarification:

so it was, the norm was being set by averages across Australia...not targets, no I think this is, in non-technical terms, self-levelling, self-standardising process, a bit like the price of petrol going up and down, I hope gradually the forces bring a much, I've never had, any, notion that there were targets, and there's never been any policy position there were targets. There are figures that begin to become apparent when you

do analysis across a big level of data, and probably what we're beginning to see and as yet put to 2018, we have all of the [education sector] data, we haven't seen anything from any other state or territory, but what we're probably beginning to see a bit of a balance out (Julie, Interview 1, October 4, 2018).

Julie was confident in her description of the metadata that there were no targets being set for schools, however, this was not evident in the accounts of frontline workers (both in schools and at the Education Authority) who talked about their attention to meeting targets. This talk reveals the disjuncture or fault line, between the institutional processes and the embodied experiences of those in the frontline of the NCCD policy implementation (Campbell & Gregor, 2004; Smith et al., 2006). Julie's description of the process used institutional language which reflected the official texts (such as government reports) of the NCCD, yet frontline staff were being deployed to work in specific schools based on percentages. In addition to staffing changes, this focus on targets has implications for the support for students who do not fit within the average range, students whose learning needs are more complex. In this way the goals of the NCCD of providing additional support for these students may be being undermined by the use of targets to manage the process.

Data percentages were first noted through the work of PwC, a multinational professional services company contracted by the Australian Government to provide guidance and advice through the development phase of the NCCD and to ensure data quality through the implementation phase (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, 2013, 2017). The PricewaterhouseCoopers (2017) Continuous Quality Improvement Project reported public data that was emerging in relation to the levels of adjustment and categories of disability. However, it was not until 2017, that the Australian national average for students with disability of 18.8% was publicly available (Australian Education Council, 2017a). This figure

was close to the percentage that was being used by the Education Authority to benchmark schools to determine if there was a need for direct support from a policy officer.

## **7.4 CONCLUSION**

This final analytic chapter provided an analysis of the NCCD work undertaken by Education Authority informants. Conversations with policy officers and senior managers, coupled with field notes and documents collected provided insights into how their work was textually mediated and hooked up into the AG School Census. The textual power of the School Census shifted the focus of policy officer's work from one of mentoring and service to performative activities such as quality assurance and data surveillance. Their work was translocal and textually coordinated by the School Census and the Education Authority's concern about student funding that was being mediated by the national percentage of students with disability on the NCCD, that became a benchmark for schools.

The final chapters, bring together the analysis to demonstrate the national significance of the NCCD's introduction across the field of education. Chapter Eight presents a discussion of the findings, pulling all the threads together. While the NCCD has met the goals of funding students with disability and collecting national data, there are questions to explore in terms of how this has improved educational opportunities for students with disability. As shown in in Chapters Five, Six and Seven; this thesis draws on the accounts of teachers and school leaders in two schools, and the policy officers who support them. However, many of the school-based informants drew on their experiences in other schools to inform their work, and the policy officers worked across numerous schools. Their work was truly translocal; which contributes to the relevance and applicability of the findings and discussion offered in this next chapter. Chapter Nine, the closing chapter, offers concluding remarks and some considerations for next steps.

# Chapter 8: Findings and discussion

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## 8.1 INTRODUCTION

A complex system of interwoven processes and governance is evident in the NCCD implementation. New managerial processes have been imposed and are operating as the work of those at the frontline, in schools and regional education offices, and is coordinated and organised by NCCD texts (Griffith & Smith, 2014b). This work occurs in similar ways across different locations, activated by the same institutional processes.

The NCCD was developed and implemented via a public-private partnership (PPP), between the Australian Government and PwC. The paradigm of PPPs to develop education policy is a global phenomenon that continues to gain momentum in the Australian policy context, as a new form of educational governance (Lingard et al., 2013). This inquiry shows how PPPs are also shaping funding for students with disability given their key role in NCCD policy development and deliver.

These next sections are a discussion of how the NCCD has had far-reaching effects beyond the original purposes and has reshaped education priorities, policies and the everyday practices of teachers and school leaders, in schools, and the work of Education Authority policy officers. The NCCD has met its goals of funding and data collection, but in so doing, it has introduced the burden of new audits to schools and evidence production to ensure student funding is maintained (see section 8.2). This focus on the collation of evidence rather than pedagogy has meant teacher judgements about the learners in their class was superseded by standardised assessments to manage “getting the data right” (see section 8.3). Teachers make formal and informal assessment decisions about learning and teaching sequences everyday and throughout the day, however, moderating the work of colleagues to determine the level of educational adjustment is new assessment work that is under-theorised (see section 8.4). The

far reaching national and transnational effects of the NCCD of are discussed in sections 8.5, 8.6 and 8.7. The textual power of the new educational policies and more broadly, social policies about people with disability, which are connected to the NCCD were not immediately obvious. However, a forensic investigation of national policy texts (see sections 8.5 and 8.6) and transnational texts (see sections 8.6 and 8.7) showed how the NCCD is hooked into broader national agendas and a global educational reform that is being orchestrated by the OECD.

## **8.2 THE PURPOSES OF THE NCCD**

The NCCD was initially described by policymakers as a policy with dual purposes:

1. improving teacher practices with planning and implementing educational adjustments and
2. allocating funding for students with disability

(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2016; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). A third policy purpose, to report on national data was added in 2018 (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). The evidence presented in this thesis indicates that the substantial institutional focus on funding that has oriented teachers' attention more towards documentation and the collection of evidence of educational adjustments. In other words, the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD have had the effect of coordinating the daily actions of informants across sites towards documentation with little evidence that it has changed teaching practice. The similar stories told by teachers, school leaders and support staff at both schools, alongside the informants working in regional offices demonstrate the translocal (Smith, 2005) nature of the NCCD as a ruling text.

Although there was minimal evidence of changed classroom practices, the teachers in this study talked extensively about the new requirement to record evidence of the educational

adjustments they were providing; this was new work and time consuming. Even though teachers have provided educational adjustments for students with disability for many years (Poed, 2015), the requirements of the NCCD to record them in such detail was new (Davies et al., 2016). Robert, a classroom teacher at HPS, described this change in the work from the perspective that he was “already...planning, not anywhere near as detailed” (Robert, Interview 1, August 16, 2018). The teachers talked about how they met the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD, which seemed to take precedence over planning educational adjustments and their practices in relation to educational support for students with disability. When describing their everyday work, teachers talked about recording adjustments in minute detail but even when prompted they did not mention whether these adjustments improved learning outcomes for the students. It can be hypothesised that the accountability pressures meant teachers prioritised their attention and time on the planning and collating of evidence of educational adjustments, this spotlight had the effect of directing time and attention to only part of the NCCD purpose, with the result that the pedagogic focus of improving student learning was left in the shadows.

Teachers were focused on collating evidence of educational adjustments as proof of their work, the provision of educational adjustments for students who were included in the NCCD. The new work of recording educational adjustments in minute detail was done for the purposes of meeting the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD. Teachers talked in detail about how this process was time consuming and necessitated new processes for managing the increased workload. They were looking for time efficient ways to cope with the increased expectations around documentation. This led to the creation of evidence templates and other types of checklists which are described in Chapters Five and Six.

Teacher time is limited and work intensification across many fronts is recognised as an urgent area for action (see Fitzgerald et al 2019; Beck, 2018). The demands of NCCD places

pressure on teachers' already scarce time, the administrative burden of NCCD adds to the burgeoning paperwork for teachers (Gallagher & Spina, 2019). As a classroom teacher, Sophie explained "it's been on my mind, because, I've had lots of jobs...[NCCD evidence] it's an extra job...it's extra work" (Sophie, Interview 2, November 20, 2018). Sophie went on to list these jobs, finishing report cards, updating the NCCD evidence folders and so on. Recording adjustments did not lead Sophie or her colleagues to talk about how these adjustments improved the learning outcomes for the specific students, even when prompted. Their focus was primarily related to the documentation of educational adjustments as additional work they were now expected to undertake. Adding NCCD related tasks to teachers' everyday actions increased their workload (see Chapter Six). The requirement to gather data has the potential to interfere with the very work teachers do – teach students (Davies et al., 2016; Parkinson & Stooke, 2012). It was distracting from teaching as they needed to remember to record adjustments that were made in situ.

The institutional texts listed by Sophie as she talked about "the jobs" organised her work; her actions were intentional and tethered to a temporal sequence for completion. The texts were situated within an act-text-act sequence, for example, evidentiary samples were curated (act), documents recorded (a new text produced) and evidence was stored/placed in the NCCD folder (act). These act-text-act sequences organised Sophie's work in such a way that maintained the institutional status quo (Griffith & Smith, 2014a). Sophie's work was hooked up into actions that were beyond her frontline work, the NCCD folder was part of the act-text-act sequence of the accountability process that was conducted by the Education Authority in readiness for an audit from the Australian Government (Smith, 2005). As Sophie completed her work, this was taken up by the NCCD SLT for moderation and finally audited by the Education Authority (see Chapter Seven, section 7.2). These act-text-act sequences



relied on each person completing their work before moving it on, the relational pressure of ensuring the work was completed because someone needed it

Whether this extra evidentiary work improves learning outcomes for students with disability is not clear at this date. What is evident, is that teachers are preoccupied by the evidentiary requirements and have less time to capitalise on the teachable moments as they arise, as Emily explained, “we are just so worried about having all these records, that it actually takes it away, our time of being in that moment with the kids” (Emily, Interview 2, November 20, 2018) (see section 6.2.3, Chapter Six). Emily described her time with the students in her class when she was with students. Although physically present, her attention was elsewhere, she was not in the moment with the student as she was thinking about recording adjustments. The full impact of this divided attention of teachers on recording incidental educational adjustments rather than being present to the student is yet to be well understood. However, other IE investigations into teacher work has shown that a focus on documentation and recording can distract from teaching (see Darville, 2014; Grant et al., 2017; Spina, 2020). Darville (2014) found literacy teachers were challenged “to teach well and then translate the experience into the reporting discourse” (p.43); Emily was also challenged in the “teachable moment”, once the learning sequence was completed to then translate or record the exchange into educational adjustments provided.

Teachers were recording educational adjustments as proof of their work. The purpose of recording was about teacher accountability, the NCCD policy organised teachers’ daily practices, including what data was recorded in relation to specific students. Teachers became institutionally accountable when they were provided with The List, which named the students in their class for whom they were required to record educational adjustments. There was increased accountability and responsabilisation of these teachers (Gallagher & Spina, 2019; Lingard et al., 2013; Spina, 2020); they were responsible for ensuring their record-keeping

procedures adequately maintained funding for students on The List, on behalf of the Education Authority

Students with disability who were not on The List were not accounted for in the same way. Knowing how to get students onto The List was problematic for teachers. The List activated standardised sequences of actions which organised and coordinated the everyday work of teachers, school leaders and policy officers translocally (Parkinson & Stooke, 2012), as discussed in detail in Chapters Five, Six and Seven. The List was a text that entered and permeated the work of teachers, school leaders and policy officers. As a new text, it organised and coordinated their doings, which included new work beyond recording educational adjustments such as preparation for a potential audit of student information. This tension invokes Ball's (2003) description of Lyotard's *Laws Contradiction* to describe first order activities, recording adjustments as a performative action, and second order activities which is how the work is managed and monitored externally to the teacher by the Education Authority. The teacher produces texts to monitor students on The List and in so doing, these texts are used to monitor teacher work.

### **8.2.1 The worry of audits**

As well as the impacts of additional work, and less control of what gets prioritised, documenting educational adjustments introduced new worries for teachers, leaders, and policy officers. Having evidence of adjustments to support students with disability mirrors the good practice of teachers planning adjustments and evidence, so that students get the educational supports they need (Conway & Walker, 2017). However, the production of evidence for the NCCD was described as a source of anxiety for informants in schools and regional offices alike. The anxiety connected to the possibility of the school receiving reduced funding was considered likely, particularly if not all eligible students were identified. Furthermore, this anxiety was exacerbated by the possibility of the school being audited by

the Australian Government with a perceived risk that there was not enough evidence of adjustments to support school decisions. Should this be the case, student funding would be jeopardised.

As the data presented in Chapters Five and Six illustrates, the vigilance of being ready to access the evidence of adjustments in the event of an audit led to the reallocation of duties or redeployment of staff (teacher assistants and learning support teachers) to manage student records in preparation for a potential audit. The “terror of performativity”, required these teachers to organise their work to be ready for a potential audit and in so doing they “set aside personal beliefs and commitments and live an existence of calculation” (Ball, 2003, p. 215). This meant that teachers and school leaders were in a constant state of preparation, just in case they were audited, and this was sometimes at the expense of their own personal time.

The possibility of an audit shifted the attention of teachers, school leaders and policy officers towards what Ball (2003) calls the “fabrication” of evidence, which activated a sequence of actions that were replicated across locations for the purpose of accountability. The “metric of accountability” was a key driver in the development of, or in another word, the fabrication or creation of technical tools to record teacher outputs that could be counted and measured (Ball, 2003, p. 223). This included the production of data collection templates to record adjustments and the establishment of data management systems for recording and reporting practices. These tools did not capture the relational aspect of teachers’ work only what could be counted. These performative technologies enable teachers’ work to be “judged on the basis of their contribution to organisational performance” (Ball, 2003, p. 223). This works adds to the theory of performativity as the worry of the audit was as pervasive as it was multi-layered and reinforced, it was more than an individual impact. Personal anxiety about being judged, changed the institutional culture, where schools were being judged and funding was at risk, and the new systems and accounts reorganised daily work.

Every year the Australian Government conducts random audits of non-government school census data from the previous years. When NCCD was included in this audit, student NCCD records were reviewed with meticulous precision, which created fear at the school level. During my conversation with Karen, learning support teacher at HPS, she said “if audited” on at least four occasions in twenty minutes as she explained how her work was organised (Karen, Interview 1, September 7, 2018). Karen, like her colleagues, was concerned about the possibility of an audit that had not yet occurred. It was a similar level of worry for her fellow learning support teacher, Fiona, who also described the necessity of being prepared for an audit within the first five minutes of our conversation (Fiona, Interview 1, September 12, 2018). The pressure of being audited had significant ramifications for how NCCD was prioritised in non-government schools. Furthermore, the emotional labour attached to the preparation for an audit that may or may not happen, sounded exhausting. This level of heightened vigilance had an impact on what work was prioritised. However, “auditing does not necessarily mean more or better” (Power, 1999, p. 127); this is particularly salient when you consider that the audit was of educational adjustments provided to support the learning of students with disability, auditing adjustments does not equate to the provision of more or even better matched adjustments (see Chapter Six).

The anticipation of a school audit persisted across the school year. School teams and policy officers began their preparation for the Australian Government post enumeration exercises (audits) leading up to the annual August School Census. Student data was reviewed through mock audits prior to the census completion, the census was completed, and then school teams and policy officers waited to find out if a particular school has been randomly selected to be audited. When a school is selected for audit, the principal is advised at the end of the school year, around early November. But it is not until the following school year that the school is informed of the actual date of the audit, which generally occurs sometime

between March and May, well after the August census and being advised of the audit (Australian Education Council, 2017b). This requires the school team and policy officers to stay focused on the data that was submitted in the August census, whilst at the same time moving on with the new school year, which includes recording educational adjustments for the new NCCD cycle.

The worry of the audit continues until it is completed, all the while the potential of another audit, the following year, lingers. The fabrication of NCCD evidence has distorted everyday practices and the regulatory context in which teachers, school leaders and policy officers are now operating, which has social and personal elements (Ball, 2003; Singh, 2017). The ongoing and protracted timeline of accountability associated with being audited and the growing performativity agenda and school governance extends to include students with disability in new ways (see Ball, 2003; Selwyn 2016). Australian Government post enumeration exercises (audits) of school data are essentially a check and balance process and reconciliation of data submitted with school records. For example, the number of full-time teachers, the number of students, numbers of students in specific groups (i.e., English as an Additional Language/Dialect, indigenous) are all implicated in these processes. For students with disability, it is not just the number of students at the levels of adjustment, the auditor also reviews the records of adjustments for each student from supplementary level and above (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021d). This means the teachers' records must also be produced; however, this does not happen for any other component of the post enumeration exercise (audit). Some ideas for action to reduce this worry are outlined in section 9.2 of Chapter Nine.

### **8.2.2 The worry of funding**

Policy officers were required to renegotiate their work to ensure schools most at risk of a funding shortfall received their attention, which was seen as a mitigation measure for

funding loss (see Chapter Five). The act-text-act sequence was activated by a communication from the Education Authority which directed a prioritisation of NCCD to maintain levels of funding for students with disability. Chapter Five discusses how the policy officers renegotiated their work, which occurred at both the school level, as well as the regional office. Their core work was to support schools to meet the requirements of the “evidence base...and the level of educational adjustment that is being provided” (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2016, p. 1) to ensure readiness for any potential audit. This shift in their role is discussed in more detail later in this chapter.

The worry of funding loss was pervasive, consequently, policy officers inadvertently reinforced the primacy of the evidentiary requirements of the NCCD above other aspects of teacher’s everyday actions teaching students with disability. The policy officers reorganised their work schedules to ensure schools were prepared for an audit, their “work became accountable within a new framework” (McCoy, 2005, p. 174). (McCoy, 2005, p. 174). Teachers and policy officers, had different work to do, yet their work was similarly textually coordinated (McCoy, 2005) (see Chapters Five and Six). Their work was organised by the evidentiary texts of the NCCD, for the same accountability outcome, to make sure the school “passed the audit” so that the school retained funding for students on The List. Australian Government funding for students with disability is a retrospective payment for educational support provided, this means the current teacher’s records are used to determine the funding allocation for a student the following year. Effectively, this means, in any given year, the current teachers of students with disability are impacted by the actions of teachers in the previous year (see discussion about funding in Chapter Five). The processes of the NCCD, therefore, changes the temporal reach of teacher planning and documentation, including who gets to see teacher planning. Policy officers would not normally be expected to interrogate teacher records of educational adjustments about students with disability.

Accountability and compliance actions occurred translocally, across school and regional office settings and were textually activated by the AG School Census. Teacher planning was no longer “neutral record keeping”, it had “textual visibility...as a form of social control” (McCoy, 2014, p. 95). The worry of potentially losing funding organised the everyday work of teachers, school leaders and policy officers. The production and regulation of evidence led to changes to routines and workloads. New work such as moderating the records of educational adjustments emerged, adding another complex layer of accountability.

### **8.3 STANDARDISED ASSESSMENT PRIORITISED OVER TEACHER JUDGEMENT**

The NCCD is predicated on teacher professional judgement about the type of educational adjustments that are best to provide students with disability with access to education. The model assumes that teachers and school teams make professional assessment judgements, drawing on supported evidence, to determine a Level of Adjustment (LoA) that was provided to the student for the purposes of funding (Australian Education Council, 2019a, 2021; Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018; Education Services Australia, 2020). The logic of the LoA text seems to be based on expectations that teachers will apply interactive assessment principles such as Vygotsky’s zone of proximal development (ZPD) in which there is an escalating level or tiered scaffolding provided to support the student’s learning, that is based on teacher judgement about the student’s learning and their progress (Grigorenko, 2009). The chain of texts and activities in this thesis demonstrates that teacher professional judgements about which students should be included in the NCCD count were not commonly utilised or highly valued by school leaders and policy officers. Instead, standardised assessments and data were seen as authoritative, and were used to assemble The List.

The importance of standardised assessments was explained by Margaret, principal of PPS, “because when somebody comes and challenges you, you’ve got evidence” (Margaret, Interview 2, November 20, 2018). Margaret’s preference for standardised assessment over “teacher-generated tests” or other teacher observations or planning was a decision made in light of her view that teacher designed assessments might not withstand external scrutiny and therefore were “dangerous” especially as they may not support the LoA outcome (Margaret, Interview 2, November 20, 2018). In activating NCCD requirements, Margaret, like others at the schools, held the view that standardised tests would be a more reliable choice, which was important given the high stakes associated with guaranteeing NCCD funding.

This view of standardised assessments was replicated in other conversations with informants and played out using data walls as an authoritative process to guide decisions (see Chapter Five). The use of standardised assessments as the measure ratified decisions to place a student on The List, which seemed to overlook teacher judgements that were based on their own embodied experiences of working with the student everyday (see Chapter Six, section 6.3.3) (Rose, 1991). Standardised assessments were used to determine which students were recorded on The List, and therefore ultimately which students were included in the NCCD count and at what level. This had the effect of reducing confidence in teacher professional judgement.

The List also had the effect of reducing opportunities for teachers to exercise their professional judgements about evidence and which student should be on The List. This unofficial translocal text was produced and maintained by the NCCD SLT. As a translocal text, it organised people’s work in similar ways across sites (schools and regional offices). The List was a shared way of talking about the work, it carried meaning about actions that were activated across the Education Authority and was understood by all (McCoy, 2006). The talk associated with The List was consistent across sites.



A student's pre-assigned LoA and CoD was given to teachers via The List. There was no evidence that teachers had the opportunity to use their professional judgement to determine which students were on The List, or at what LoA or CoD. Results from standardised assessments were used to identify and then quantify individual students. The veracity of the student's result on a standardised test, and therefore their inclusion on The List, suggests students' learning needs were not problematised or challenged at the school level, or later through audit processes that were managed by policy officers.

As a ruling text, The List, standardised and objectified how students were viewed depending on which LoA or CoD the student was assigned. Each LoA and CoD generated descriptions of students, which were not contested by teachers, and as a result determined how people behaved. Facts about the student were produced which did not exist a priori (D. E. Smith, 1990b; Smith, 2005; Stanley, 2018). Teachers' embodied experiences of teaching the student, planning educational adjustments for the student were not visible in these textual chains. The use of standardised test results in data walls and The List mediated social relations and everyday work as part of NCCD textual chains.

### **8.3.1 Test scores, data walls and The List a circuit with consequences for students**

Stobart (2008) describes assessment as being a purposeful activity that is largely about collecting evidence to make a judgement. The evidence presented in this thesis illustrates the various ways teachers engaged in assessment activities. Teachers reported that they spent considerable time on planning and recording the educational adjustments for students in their class with an unexpected focus on student results on standardised literacy and numeracy assessments. In Chapters Five and Six, the informants shared how they used standardised assessments, such as PAT-R and PAT-M which are designed to assess student progress with literacy or numeracy. As we saw in Chapters Five and Six, some students were placed on The List at their respective schools because of their results on standardised tests. These tests were

either part of a formal diagnostic process that was external to the school, often part of a suite of assessments requested a paediatrician, or tests that are used at specific junctures of schooling, such as literacy assessments. Data from standardised assessments conducted at school were often recorded on the class data wall.

During a curriculum planning observation, I watched teachers transpose the PAT-R and PAT-M test scores of students in their class from a spreadsheet to the class data wall. As the teachers undertook this time-consuming task, I noticed there was no discussion about specific interventions or supports that were going to be put in place for specific students, the educational adjustments (see Chapters Five and Six). Maintaining a data wall is a significant workload (Spina, 2020). This was particularly evident when during the observation of the curriculum planning session, teachers were moving test scores from one text to another with painstaking diligence. Once the task was completed, which took at least one hour of their time, the test scores were used to update the data wall but were not used to inform the curriculum planning discussion. It was through participant observation that I was able to “locate the institutional in the local, at the point of contact with the actual” (Diamond, 2006, p. 61). In locating “the institutional in the local”, it was the distinctive generalised coordination of their work that was striking, the organisation and social relations that were produced because of the PAT-R and PAT-M results.

The teachers produced texts for the data wall and the data wall was produced because of texts (PAT-R and PAT-M results). Smith (2005) describes the institutional as the professional forms of organisation that is discovered in motion, with distinctive modes of generalising coordination. The institutional organisation associated with the PAT tests and the data wall construction was not controlled by the teachers nor the students. That is, the creation of data walls occurred using the institutional categories that aligned with institutional demands related to the NCCD. The textual power of PAT tests was evident in that it

generated work for teachers and school leaders, both in implementing tests in the classroom, recording data, and in transposing results onto data walls. All these tasks required a discussion about how to visualise the data. The PAT scores were thus used to reify students into institutional categories. The data obtained from the PAT tests had a secondary purpose, beyond student achievement data, it also served to inform which students were placed on The List for the NCCD. This has the potential to create perverse outcomes in relation to these data.

Beyond the data wall, this text coordinated actions by NCCD SLT, as well as policy officers. A sequence of actions activated by the PAT results meant some students with below average test scores were subsequently included on The List and were imputed with disability. This outcome of imputing students to have disability is concerning for two reasons. First, the efficacy of data walls is not well established in the research literature and second, the data wall had significant textual power despite the efficacy not being well theorised or established.

The regulatory frame established by the data wall, was maintained by subordinate texts, such as the excel spreadsheet used to transpose the data, the teachers' conversations as they transferred the data from one text to another during the curriculum planning time. These actions provided insight into how the text was activated and institutionally maintained. (Smith, 2006) reminds us that "texts don't achieve the capacity to regulate just by their existence...[the data wall] would have no *force*, that is, no capacity to effect a change...had it not an authorisation established by somebody [Education Authority]" (p.81). The intertextual relations between the data wall, The List and the NCCD categories produced a powerful dynamic, an intertextual circuit. Some students on the data wall were placed on The List. Students on The List were allocated to a NCCD LoA, and adjustments were then recorded to secure their inclusion in the NCCD count. Significantly, once on The List, no one could explain how students could get off The List (see Chapter Six).

Teachers spoke with confidence of their embodied knowledge about the students they taught and even questioned whether the use of standardised assessments really captured all that they knew of the student, as stated by Emily “what’s the test [PAT-R] showing, that doesn’t give the full picture about...[the student’s] learning in the classroom” (Emily, Interview 2, November 20, 2018). Emily’s embodied knowledge of students in her class extended beyond the textual work of transposing test results (and recording adjustments), but even when prompted her focus remained on documenting evidence.

At both schools, the data collection sites, teachers’ work was socially organised by the institution, in which they shared their everyday “work knowledge” of how the NCCD was being implemented. Smith (2005) defines “work knowledge” to be “a person’s experience of and in their own work, what they do, how they do it, including what they think and feel” (p.151). Through Emily’s description and those of her colleagues, about their work, their work knowledge, an institutional ethnographic investigation begins and is “located in the everyday world” (Smith, 1987, p. 159). While Emily stated that standardised assessments did not “give the full picture”, the textual power of these tests prevailed, to reveal a disjuncture “between the artificial realities of the institutions and the actualities of how people live (Smith, 2005, p. 187). The institutional expectation that Emily would know more about her students because of the standardised assessments was different to Emily’s actualities (Selwyn et al., 2021). Emily’s experience was that the test score did not tell the “full story” of her students.

While these standardised tests have the potential to determine an entry point for specific learning interventions, they are disconnected from the curriculum that the student is expected to be learning (Datnow & Hubbard, 2015). Test scores on standardised assessments can serve as a way to identify which students are more capable and by default, which students require additional instruction and/or resources to learn the new content (Stobart, 2008). Having

access to standardised data, alongside the student being named on The List was a reminder for the teacher to provide educational adjustments to support their learning, as Sophie explained, “we would always get a list, and for those students without a diagnosed disability...well, it’s based on our standardised tests [PAT-R and PAT-M]” (Sophie, Interview 2, November 20, 2018). The opportunity to delve into the diagnostic properties of the PAT tests to provide targeted educational supports for students was missed in this sequence of actions, with attention directed towards the NCCD.

The limitations of standardised assessments are often discussed in the literature, more specifically, these point in time tests do not adequately tell the story of a young person or their capacity to learn (Reay & Wiliam, 1999; Stobart, 2008). The datafication of students with disability using data that is visualised on data walls and is hooked into a funding mechanism, is a new addition to data culture and a continuation of the medical model of disability that is focused on diagnosis. Identifying the relationship between standardised assessment data and funding and inviting critical consideration of the effects, is a contribution of this thesis.

The use of standardised assessments to assess and determine educational pathways for students with disability is not new (see Tomlinson, 2004; Tomlinson, 2017). Standardised assessments have been used to identify people with disability, particularly those who were not learning at the planned or expected rate, which has given rise to a discourse and deficit view of some children (S. Tomlinson, 2017; Walton, 2015). Tomlinson (2004) uses the “Mobius Effect” to explain how the progression of practices such as standardised testing to identify students, and the ramifications of these practices, such as ability grouping or streaming students, feed one another, to the point where there is no beginning or end. The discourse of inclusive education practice is all about avoiding predetermined life trajectories and opportunities that are often associated with labels and deterministic views (Walton,

2015). Yet, as the data presented in this research illustrate, the NCCD has seen something of a return to the conceptualisation of students with disability using data that reifies students according to achievement categories.

Teachers and school leaders appeared to accept the practice of having student test scores publicly or semi-publicly displayed. Yet how a data wall improves the learning outcomes for students is not clear with scholars questioning the educational value and ethical consequences of this practice (Adie et al., 2020; Harris et al., 2018; Spina, 2020). Harris et al. (2018) and Spina (2020) describe how the production of a data wall, while serving school accountability, does not necessarily correlate with improved learning outcomes for students or changed teacher instructional practices. Adie et al. (2020) have discussed the ethics of public displays of student data, and the potential for emotional harm in the literature about the efficacy of data walls, concluding that “their utility to support learning and teaching, is inconclusive” (p. 14). Understanding whether visual displays of student data can improve learning opportunities for students with disability and teacher instructional, assessment and curriculum planning practices are areas for further research.

### **8.3.2 Data surveillance versus aspirations of the NCCD**

The documentation of educational adjustments should not be mistaken as a form of assessment for learning which is an everyday practice for teachers in which they seek, reflect on and respond to information to enhance a student’s ongoing learning (Klenowski, 2009). The research reported in this thesis has shown that balancing evidentiary requirements and undertaking productive assessment work that is of benefit to teachers and students in their everyday work remains a challenge. There is a risk that what is quantifiable (evidence which confirms the numbers of students) becomes the legitimatised work of the NCCD policy, at the expense of teachers providing students with educational adjustments to address the functional impact of disability, which was a core policy intention (Australian Education

Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018).

When considering the impact of a new social policy such as funding for students with disability, the potential for distortion when quantitative measures are used in social decision-making is significant (Campbell, 1979). Campbell's Law argues when quantitative measures are used to measure social change; these measures have the capacity to corrupt what is intended to be the focus of improvement (Campbell, 1979; Sidorkin, 2015). The research reported in this thesis has shown that quantitative measures have been a dominant feature of the NCCD and have coordinated the work and embodied experiences of the those at the frontline of the policy implementation (see Chapters Five, Six, Seven) as they have focused their attention and energies on the evidentiary requirements.

The requirement to provide textual evidence of actions associated with the NCCD also coordinated and organised policy officers' work. This was particularly evident when the Education Authority required the policy officers to reorganise previously scheduled work in schools so that they could be more focused on schools that were likely to lose funding, to ensure these schools would have their full attention (see Chapter Seven). This new work of data surveillance for the policy officers was focused on auditing the evidence of adjustments and inspecting what evidence the system believed would count for funding. The work involved in the production of evidence was measured and quantified. However, the sociocultural shift expected from the NCCD, building teacher capacity to plan, track and monitor appropriate educational adjustments for their students was not evident in the conversations with informants.

#### **8.4 THE NCCD: NEW ASSESSMENT WORK FOR TEACHERS**

Teachers engage in assessment as part of their everyday work; however, assessing to determine the level of educational adjustment or a category of disability could be considered

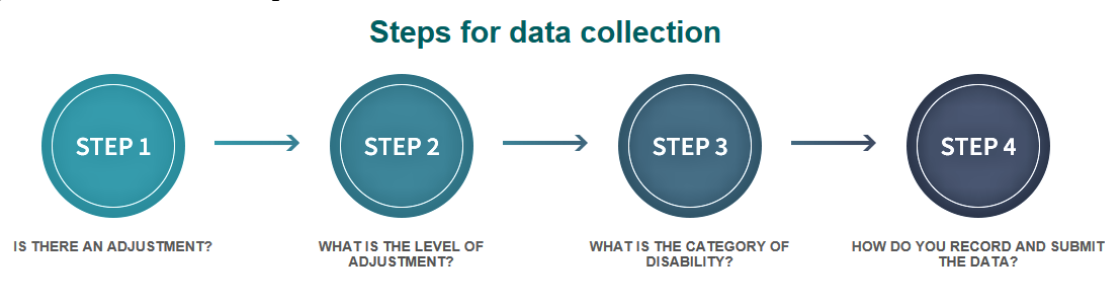
new assessment work. Often teacher assessment work is understood in terms of the teacher's collection and evaluation of evidence to judge the impact of a learning program, or to guide the direction of a learning program, and to provide certification of achievement of specified learning outcomes (Moss, 2008; Portelli & O'Sullivan, 2016). Assessment decisions are underpinned by underlying assumptions and values about assessment.

Sociocultural assessment researchers recognise assessment as a social act, they create classroom conditions for students to learn, and where productive feedback is encouraged (Elwood & Murphy, 2015; Willis & Adie, 2014; Willis & Klenowski, 2018). Sociocultural assessment work is intentional, interactive and requires time and energy (Griffith, 1998; Smith, 2005). Daily, teachers use informal observations, conversations, and experiences to inform their assessment practices, which has been unofficial work of class teachers for some time (Gipps, 2012; Pullin & Haertel, 2008; Spina, 2020). The NCCD relies on this work, making it visible and open to scrutiny, and carries greater consequences and increases teacher accountability.

The NCCD relies heavily on teachers' work. Much of the data used in NCCD decision-making is collected by teachers. The procedural requirements of the NCCD, are represented in Figure 8.1 below. This seemingly uncomplicated textual chain does not account for the complex work that is required at each step. While there has not yet been scholarly literature published on the impact of the NCCD on teachers' work, it is evident that teachers are making a multitude of decisions to follow this process. For example, they must make formative assessment decisions well before they decide an educational adjustment is needed, and then before they begin planning this adjustment to address the functional impact of disability.



**Figure 8.1** 2017 NCCD process



(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017)

Teachers are required to determine a LoA and a CoD. This involves the collation of evidence of adjustments provided to make a judgement against the NCCD LoA criterion (see Figure 8.1 step 2) and CoD descriptions (see Figure 8.1, step 3) to determine the LoA (see Figure 8.1, step 4). These judgement decisions inform funding (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). Those involved in this process need to have a thorough understanding of the DSE and the DDA, to ensure the adjustments being quantified address the functional impact of disability.

To assess for a CoD, teachers are influenced by their own personal values and beliefs about disability (Riddell, 2008). Teachers draw on their own embodied experience, and beliefs about learners, and their own teaching history to make decisions (Walton, 2015). These decisions are likely to influence their understanding and interpretation of the NCCD support materials as they allocate students to one of the four broad disability categories and assign a level of educational need (Liasidou, 2015; Walton, 2015). In complying with the NCCD requirements, teachers are required to use data from a range of sources such as teacher assessments, standardised assessments, and professional reports from educational psychologists, medical professionals, and/or allied health, to make judgements (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with

Disability, 2017). Teachers are drawing on formal and informal assessment knowledge as they evaluate student data.

Planning, implementing, and tracking educational adjustments for students is a type of assessment work. These assessments are often informal evaluations of a student's competence or success and are used to plan the next steps, and to make educational adjustments, if required (Gipps, 2012). How these decisions are made about students with disability is informed by conscious or unconscious values and beliefs about disability (Moore & Slee, 2020; Skrtic, 2016). This is shown to be an important limiter on what is offered to students with disability (see Chapter Two). However, when treated as a value free recording activity, the expectations of teachers to record adjustments renders invisible whether a medical model of disability or a human rights approach are activated. The teachers' ascertainment of levels of educational adjustment are predicated on teacher competence and confidence, their perceptions of an educational need and their capacity to meet these needs. The actions associated with data collection mean teachers are now making official accounts of what has been traditionally their private work.

The allocation of a LoA is a process of quantifying their teacher work, with high stakes, as this outcome leads to funding. Planning and recording adjustments require an understanding of the student, as well as being a reflective practitioner. For example, a teacher can only record an adjustment if they know they have implemented one. Frequently, teachers accommodate a broad range of student needs as part of their daily work, and when it occurs fluently as part of good teaching, this fluency has the potential to render the work of planning and implementing adjustments invisible. PwC identified under reporting (or recording) of educational adjustments was a challenge (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017). Through conversations with teachers, PwC policy actors noted that teachers were not necessarily aware of all that

they did to support learners (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017). To support teachers with this process PwC produced an exemplar with questions to guide the collection of evidence about adjustments provided.

Teacher assessment work for the NCCD is activated by institutional texts that are designed to quantify student data for the purpose of governance and/or funding (Comber, 2012; Kerr, 2014; Spina, 2020). The emotional labour required to sustain this new assessment work, within an already crowded space of performative tasks that organise teachers' work has challenges (Singh, 2017). The NCCD has the potential to add another layer to the increasing regulation of teacher work and datafication of students.

#### **8.4.1 NCCD is predicated on teacher assessment work**

One of the four evidentiary requirements of the NCCD is the assessed individual needs of a student (see section 4.5). This assessment is expected to inform specific personalised educational adjustments that are needed to address the “functional impact of the disability” (another evidentiary requirement of the NCCD) (Australian Education Council, 2021; Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). For a student to be included in the NCCD all four evidentiary requirements must be met, as well as a minimum of ten-weeks of actions in providing these adjustments (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). Although teachers talked about standardised assessment as an entry point for some students to the NCCD, the ongoing assessed needs of individual students were overshadowed by other textual work.

Teacher judgements about the assessed individual needs of students to plan for educational adjustments is an expected practice outlined in the NCCD official texts. However, in my data collection sites, the kinds of judgements that teachers made through

their everyday embodied experiences and knowledge about students through talking with students, observing them, and the kinds of teaching that would best suit the needs of the students were not prominent in textual chains. Yet the literature has documented how the assessment work that teachers undertake is complex and detailed. For instance, a study by Bourke et al. (2011) about teachers' assessment practices for students with disability reveals that teachers employ a vast array of assessment practices like learning stories or narrative assessment, anecdotal records and portfolios to identify the next step in a student's learning journey. In this study, the least effective assessments to plan for learning were psychometric assessments and standardised tests such as those that are commonly used for literacy and numeracy testing (Bourke et al., 2011). Here the literature provides a contrast with the assessment practices that are undertaken for the NCCD. For example, Chapter Five outlines how the use of standardised test data contributes to the NCCD count. These data are used as an indicator of which students should be included on The List and at what LoA. There was little evidence of non-standardised forms of assessment (or teacher judgement) in NCCD textual chains. Instead, the reliance on standardised assessments was institutionally endorsed and authorised through auditing and data surveillance.

The NCCD can therefore be seen as shaping teacher assessment work through an increased focus on test scores and use of standardised testing to meet the evidentiary requirements identified as part of the assessed individual needs of the students. Yet even when standardised assessments results are translated into personalised educational adjustments that are tracked, monitored, and reviewed with regularity, this sequence of actions is reliant on teachers making ongoing judgements and assessment decisions. For example, a student with low literacy results may lead the teacher to use assistive technology, such as text to speech software, to reduce the reading demand for a specific learning activity. This requires the teacher to make ongoing decisions, based on their judgement, about the

student's understanding of the language demands of the task. The teacher is making numerous assessment judgements whilst tracking and monitoring the effectiveness of the adjustment.

Rasooli et al. (2021) found where funding policy and student assessment were linked this had the potential to narrow the scope of teacher assessment practices, and the responsiveness of educational adjustments to the student's learning needs. Adherence to NCCD policy mandates has the potential to drive assessment decisions away from a student-centric approach. Teacher professional judgement in assessment was not visible in their accounts of collecting evidence of adjustments, there was a preference for other data, which is potentially further complicated and harder to accomplish with reduced time available. The complexity of the teacher evaluations in terms of adjustments was textually coordinated by the LoA document and regulated, as the adjustments provided for students were only those listed (see section 6.2). Benchmarking descriptions were provided at each of the levels. From here, teachers were expected to evaluate the adjustments they had provided to address the functional impact of a student's disability and then determine the level of adjustment (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). This evaluative process requires teachers to consider the frequency and intensity of the adjustment, as well as the level of specialist advice or intervention provided.

Teachers rely on their knowledge, skills and experiences as they make judgements about adjustments to teaching and learning sequences to accommodate the learning needs of students with disability (Rasooli et al., 2021). The documentation of this work, through institutional categories also had the effect of reifying part of the teachers' assessment work. Undertaking these processes of documentation is a new form of work in which teachers must

now evaluate the intensity and frequency of their own adjustments to teaching and the work of peers in moderation.

#### **8.4.2 New forms of teacher moderation**

In the previous section, it was established the NCCD has altered teacher assessment work in a way that teacher professional judgement has been obscured by standardised assessments. In this section, an additional alteration in teacher assessment work is noted as NCCD moderation is different to other forms of teacher moderation practices described in the literature. Maxwell (2002) describes two categories of teacher moderation work: first, moderation for improving student learning and second, moderation to certify student results through certification, which is an accountability process. Both forms of moderation work are directed towards moderating student work samples. The Australian Government named NCCD moderation as the preferred tool for quality assurance of NCCD (Chaney et al., 2020). NCCD moderation is about coming to a consensus about a LoA and a CoD for students on The List. The Australian Government expects that through moderation discussions, teacher decision-making about the LoA, and CoD quality assures that the right students are in the right levels (Chaney et al., 2020; Sharma et al., 2019). Teachers are moderating the evidence collected for NCCD by other teachers.

NCCD moderation is about reviewing teachers' work, rather than the traditional format of moderation, where students' work is the focus. While there are a few existing examples of moderation practices of teachers' work, such as the certification of *Highly Accomplished and Lead Teachers in Australia* and Teacher Performance Assessment (TPA) (Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership (AITSL), 2017), the certification processes are managed by the teaching profession and not a private accounting firm. Additionally, the moderation outcomes of NCCD determine the level of student funding provided by the Australian Government to the Education Authority for each individual student the following year. The

consequence of NCCD moderation is a financial one that is then directly impacting the school. One contribution of this thesis is to recognise that the moderation occurring in the NCCD process is a new form of moderation, which is currently under-theorised, and not recognised. As it has not been recognised that the focus is different, this misrecognition is creating tensions for teachers experiencing the moderation of their work and that of their colleagues as the moderation actions are being caught up in a chain of audit process at the Education Authority level, as well as at the state and national level.

NCCD moderation is a quality assurance measure that is expected to promote consistency of teacher judgement and a shared language in relation to the student records, prior to them being included in the NCCD count (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018). There has not been a review of whether this national moderation has improved the quality of student data or teacher work. Moderation emerged from a quality assurance project conducted by PwC whereby schools described processes they were undertaking to develop shared practices in relation to the NCCD (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017). The practice of moderation quickly moved from a common practice that teachers use to becoming a policy instrument associated with reportable actions in the Australian Government's post enumeration audit and funding processes.

Once a student is included in the NCCD count, funding from the Australian Government is activated for three of the four LoAs. The activation of funding means a level of responsibility ensues. The accountability expectations attached to this funding were negotiated within the Bilateral Agreements of each state and territory government with the Australian Government under the terms of the National School Reform Agreement (NRSA). The details of the NRSA and bilateral agreements are discussed in more detail in Chapter Four. However, what is noteworthy is that four of the eight state and territory governments

included NCCD moderation as a reportable action to the Australian Government under their respective Bilateral Agreement, despite Education Services Australia promoting moderation as a recommended action (not mandatory) (Education Services Australia, 2019; Sharma et al., 2019). Queensland is one of these four state governments. In reporting on moderation there is no guidance as to what moderation specifically entails, only that it is a cross-sectoral activity, which means teachers from government and non-government education sectors moderate together (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2018). As a nationally endorsed process, moderation is developing differentially, some state and territory governments have implemented state-wide moderation processes, education authorities within state and territory education jurisdictions have done similarly, despite not having specific guidance as to how moderation should be implemented at a systems level, other than *NCCD Moderation Resource for Schools* an official text of the NCCD that is recommended.

Moderation is “hooked into sequences of action” (Smith, 1999, p. 7) as an accountable action that is textually mediated across school sites and within regional offices as part of this policy implementation. Moderation is a recommended activity for schools (see NCCD website, *NCCD Moderation Resource for Schools*) that sits within the implementation phase of NCCD, yet four state/territory governments have made it a reportable action at a jurisdictional level to secure funding from the Australian Government. Furthermore, the Australian Government has ratified a recommendation arising from the 2019 review of funding by the National School Resourcing Board (NRSB) to invest in moderation as the preferred tool for promoting national data collection consistency. However, the stated purpose of moderation is for school teams to confirm the level of adjustment and category of disability, with this new addition of quality assurance as the purpose of moderation, the links between funding and moderation were strengthened. Recommendation 4 of the *Review of loading for students with disability: Final report* also places the Australian Government in a



role that reduces the power of the state and territory governments in relation to education policy, it states that:

The Australian Government should continue its current level of investment in comprehensive training and development to support consistency in the collection and moderation of data under the NCCD until at least 2023. This should include the Australian Government taking a leadership role in a national approach to moderation (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2020a, p. 6).

This recommendation was further explicated with an expectation that the Australian Government take a “leadership role in a national cross-sectoral approach to moderation of data” (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2020b, p. 7). The Australian Government’s response was to make recommendations to schools to embed moderation into school practices to “build capacity and quality assure the collection” (p.7). This high-level policy around moderation pushes a new type of quality assurance measure to the frontline, with assumptions of the textual coordination, and without clarification of how this is different teacher practice at the everyday classroom and school level (DeVault, 2008a). How this quality measure is to be fully implemented is yet to be understood. But what is clear is that there is increasing policy significance being given to NCCD moderation, a new type of everyday work for informants.

Expectations about NCCD moderation are increasingly more visible, as are the requirements for this new moderation work which is predicated on teacher’s collation of evidence of the educational adjustment they provide. Moderation in education previously has been focused on student work (see Adie & Klenowski, 2016; Willis & Adie, 2014), but this shift to moderation of teacher’s work, as outlined in NCCD is a change to education practices and policy. Moderation as an educational policy has been taken from one arena (moderation of student work) and applied to another (moderation of teacher records of educational

adjustments); Lingard (2010) describes this as “policy borrowing” in which the application of knowledge is borrowed and applied elsewhere and often without a thorough review of “the effects of the policy that will be borrowed” (p.132). Evidence offered in this thesis suggests the effect of policy borrowing for moderation has led to increased accountability for teachers and policy officers, and yet does seem to be connected to improving learning for students or improving teaching practices.

The emphasis on accountability and quality assurance has the potential for NCCD moderation to become high stakes in schools and education systems, particularly should moderation become a mandatory quality assurance measure that is attached to student funding. Robyn (policy officer) explained how school teams moderated the work of teachers, and how the very action of moderation contributed to evidence that may be used if the school was audited:

And in moderating...because another panel is looking at your evidence, so in comes the importance of evidence, and it's going to contextualise your data (Robyn, Interview 1, October 3, 2018).

The new work of the NCCD moderation meant a “panel is looking at your evidence” and the necessity to “contextualise your data”. This description of how texts used for moderation can meet accountability/evidentiary requirements of the NCCD, can also form part of the proof that is provided for an audit. The textual work of NCCD moderation forms an accountability circuit whereby discretionary judgements about students are presented as objective textual representations of them, and are given a status of authority as they are circulated among the NCCD school leadership team and policy officers through auditing and compliance processes (Grace et al., 2014; Griffith & Smith, 2014b; Nilsen, 2021). The moderation activities are converted into textual realities that are re-presented as a “warrantable account” of compliance (Rankin, 2017a, p. 6). A finding from this thesis is that NCCD moderation provides

professional coverage as an accountability action, in other words, moderation for accountability.

## **8.5 POLICY OFFICER WORK IS TEXTUALLY ORGANISED**

The research reported in this thesis has shown the important role policy officers have in bringing together the governing texts (the policy requirements) with the practicalities of how things happen through working with people at the frontline (Griffith & Smith, 2014b). The policy officers shared how their work had previously existed to support and mentor teachers but had been reframed by the dominant focus on documenting evidence to ensure ongoing funding. This shift of focus for their work seemed to have little or no institutional acknowledgement, the emotional impact of this rapid transition was ostensibly invisible to the institution.

The policy officers described how their roles quickly morphed from one of service and mentoring to one dominated by performative activities aimed at ensuring schools maintained student funding. The shift to reviewing predicted funding, auditing student records, and checking in with school personnel as to their progress towards documentation and evidence collation became an institutional priority. This new work was added to their everyday work, whilst they continued to keep pre-existing work schedules and commitments (see Chapter Seven). The policy officers accepted this shift and the increased workload of supporting schools to implement the NCCD requirements without question.

As policy actors in schools, the policy officers, took up a *narrator* role (Ball et al., 2011, p. 626), in which they interpreted the NCCD policy and the Education Authority policy expectations to enable meaning making for school teams. A more detailed discussion about their work was offered in Chapter Seven, but essentially these policy actors were the conduit for the NCCD policy implementation in schools and Education Authority. The significant contribution that education policy officers make in a process of change is not always visible.

Education policy reform is often discussed in terms of how policy change is managed by school leaders (see Ball et al., 2012) and/or governance and accountability practices (see Ozga, 2020). Unlike typical public servants the policy officers in this inquiry had previous roles as learning support teachers, school counsellors, or school leaders, which all require minimum qualifications for professional registration. Scholarly literature about public service reform rarely separates those who have had other professional roles from career public servants (see Newman et al., 2016; Omari & Paull, 2015). In this inquiry, these policy officers had moved through the ranks of school-based roles, which meant some had recent experience as a member of the school team working to implement the NCCD policy. The emotional labour of this new policy work was not visible to the Education Authority or the schools they supported.

The effect of educational reform on schools and how school leaders strived to buffer the direct impact of policy change on teachers was discussed in Chapter Five. There was no evidence of the Education Authority acknowledged the increased workload for policy officers or offer a similar type of support. Hargreaves (2004) described the emotional impact of mandated educational and policy change on teachers as grinding, from which resentment builds about the increased work. Rayner and Espinoza (2015) also describe the issue of work intensification in relation to change, but in so doing, describe teachers as public servants. There appears to be a gap in the research literature, with little research done specifically focused on policy officers who are public servants with professional qualifications and experience with school-based roles. These public servants have an insider standpoint of the work, they know how schools operate and have experienced educational change. They “systematically developed consciousness...that means working from that of knowing” (Smith, 1999, p. 49). These policy officers draw on ways of knowing through their embodied experience which remains with them as they narrate and interpret a new policy, offering

perspectives about daily work from a place of lived experiences. The impact of the emotional labour of this work for policy officers with qualifications and frontline embodied experiences, is an area of research that is under-theorised.

## **8.6 PUBLIC-PRIVATE PARTNERSHIPS**

Public-private partnerships (PPPs) are complex relationships between private firms and the state that have transformed public infrastructure and government services (Whiteside, 2020). These relationships exist often without clear boundaries, blurring responsibilities which can make it difficult to trace whose interests are being served (Ball & Junemann, 2012; Gerrard et al., 2017; Whiteside, 2020). Yet, despite this fuzziness, international organisations, such as the OECD, promote PPP arrangements, and in so doing, endorse the role consultancy firms have in state governance structures including educational policy reform (Ball et al., 2017; Sellar & Lingard, 2013; Whiteside, 2020). The OECD influence on global governance is achieved through the “surveillance and peer pressure rather than sanctions” (Sellar & Lingard, 2013, p. 715). Furthermore, the connectivity of member nations affords the OECD the capacity to work towards alignment of national policies that promote international comparative data, as is the case for education and schooling (Ozga, 2020; Rinne & Ozga, 2011). For example, participation in global testing has been achieved through publication of data, whereby failing to meet Program for International Student Assessment (PISA) targets becomes the source of opinion pieces in the media which places pressure on educational jurisdictions to improve results (Gerrard et al., 2017). This global shift towards PPPs to negotiate and navigate educational policy reform is often flanked by discussions about the necessity for, and value of, data-driven accountability measures (see Ozga, 2020; 2021; Sellar & Lingard, 2013). The NCCD is a PPP between PwC and the Australian Government: PwC was contracted to develop, deliver, and evaluate a significant national educational policy

reform in relation to students with disability that required educational jurisdictions across Australia to adhere to new forms of data-driven accountability measures.

A more detailed account of the development of the NCCD is provided in Chapter Four, supplemented by Appendix A. To summarise, in 2008 the Australian Government announced there would be a nationally consistent way of identifying students with disability. In 2011, PwC was contracted by the Australian Government to commence the trial of the national data collection model, the NCCD. In the interim, the 2010 review of the Disability Standards for Education, 2005 problematised the issue of inconsistencies of how students with disability were identified across state and territory educational jurisdictions. By framing the identification of students with disability as a problem to be fixed, this confirmed there was an issue, and a solution was needed (Bacchi, 2009; Whitburn et al., 2017; Whiteside, 2020). A PPP was formed and in 2011 PwC, a private consultancy firm, began trialling the national data collection model on behalf of the Australian Government. Since that time, PwC has continued to lead refinements of the model, as well as ongoing evaluations and the development of professional learning and support materials for schools. Through this process PwC policy actors have tested ideas and conducted quality assurance activities.

This research project has shown how the consequences of the institutional work in relation to the NCCD, the ruling practices, have organised the everyday life of people across two schools, a regional education office and the head office (Campbell, 2014; Rankin, 2017b). Although not a primary research purpose, this inquiry also made visible some of the frontline work of the PwC policy actors, through observations of interactions with regional policy officers and school teams. Drawing on the institutional ethnographic observational work of Diamond (2006) observational notes were made of the interactions of school teams, and my own interactions with PwC policy actors.

It was through these observations and reflections that I came to appreciate how their work was also being textually organised. The purpose and expected outcome of the school meeting was linked to contractual expectations as negotiated through the PPP. These specific conditions did not seem to be visible to the school team nor the PwC policy actor, as they held tightly to the scripted interview, as they were taught. They also used recorded responses on their laptops during PDs. The PwC school visits can be characterised as transactional interactions between PwC actors and school staff; every school visit followed the same format. Despite the differing sociocultural contexts of each school, PwC policy actors maintained the same standardised approach.

A forensic search on government and PwC websites unearthed government documents such as an outline of the 2016 contract for PwC to produce the professional learning package for schools (Australian Department of Finance, 2016) and senate (upper house of the Australian Government) questions on notice about the data reliability produced with particular reference to NCCD being used to inform school funding (Australian Senate Committee: Education and Employment, 2017). However, the specific details of the PPP remain confidential, and even responses to questions on notice are heavily redacted. What was visible in my fieldwork, was that the procedural work of the frontline PwC policy actors was textually organised by managerial texts that were focused on standardisation and accountability, as described by Margaret, principal of PPS:

PricewaterhouseCoopers people...are non-educational people...not understanding an educational context as much as you would hope...so data driven...it's all very cut and dried and its figures, facts and figures (Margaret, Interview 1, September 4, 2018).

These frontline PwC policy actors talked about their work in terms of *best practices*, *illustrations of practice* and *quality assurance measures*, a managerial discourse that was produced in official texts (see Appendix M: PwC quality practice texts). They contributed to

how things happened as “social organisation was also carried and transmitted in the talk” (DeVault, 2021, p. 24). How they talked about their work was hooked into the accountability circuits of the NCCD. Specifically, the “sequences of text and action that were designed to not only to direct the action of subordinates [educators], but also to represent them back to managers [Australian Government] so as to make compliance or non-compliance more visible” (DeVault, 2021, p. 24). Consequently, audits and data organised the work of school teams and regional officers and made compliance visible.

The ruling practices that were established by PwC policy actors have the potential to “reorient the nature of the public sector, normalising the PPP model through managerialism” (Whiteside, 2020, p. 881). This push for managerialism is being realised through new forms of record-keeping by school teams and the regional offices. Most obvious of these is the teacher records of educational adjustments. Less visible is how these records were reviewed/audited by educational officers and the use of funding data to prioritise school visits by the policy officers, as well as the detailed records that were maintained about their work in schools, notwithstanding the professional learning that was delivered on site. The List, as a boss text, had the textual power to coordinate the everyday work of teachers, school leaders and the policy officers in similar ways across locations, in other words, translocally. The List also mediated the work of PwC policy actors in that it was the first text that was consulted in any of the school visits, the LoA was of primary interest, ensuring there were specific types of evidence for each level. The consequences of policy development with its narrowed scope on data and evidence has coordinated the daily action of frontline workers in predictable and replicable way. This includes the work of teachers, policy officers *and* PwC personnel.



## 8.7 ACCOUNTING FOR STUDENTS WITH DISABILITY – REPORTING NUMBERS

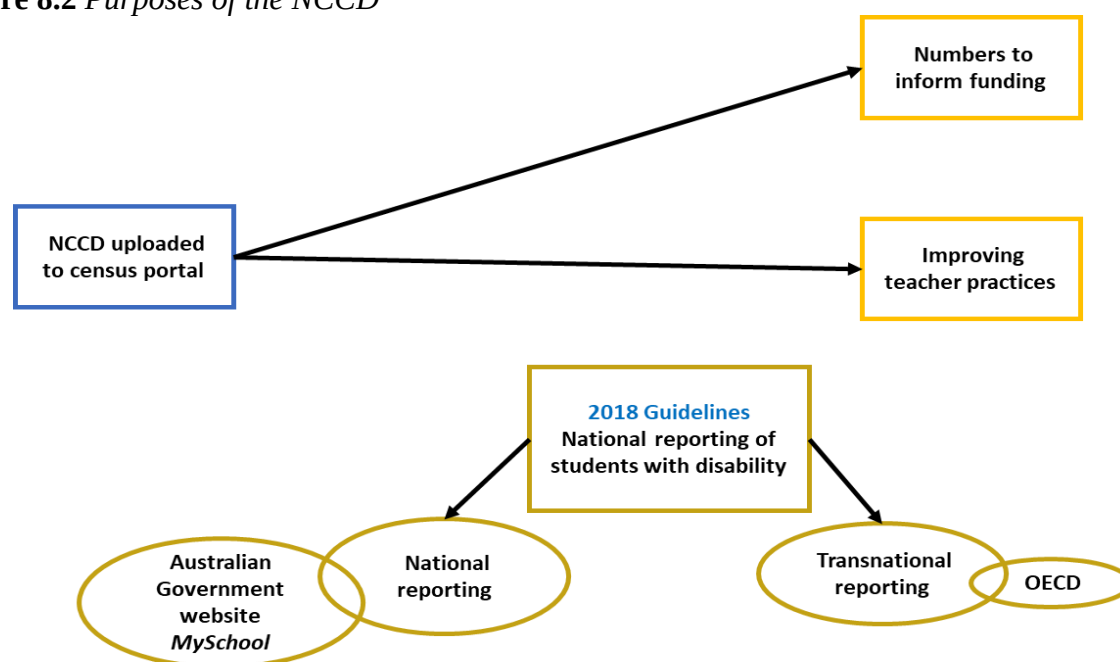
The Australian Government is committed to reporting prevalence data about students with disability. The NCCD is now the national reporting mechanism, despite persistent concerns raised about the reliability and therefore quality of the student data (see *2015 NCCD Continuous Quality improvement Project (PwC)*; *2016 NCCD Continuous Quality Improvement Project (PwC)*; *National School Resourcing Board Review of the loading for students with disability: Final report (2019)*). The most recent review, *National School Resourcing Board Review of the loading for students with disability: Final report (2019)* raised the issue of inconsistent implementation of the NCCD requirements, and the differential approach to the post enumeration exercise (audit) and data checking across the educational jurisdictions (Chaney et al., 2020). Data consistency has been an issue since the NCCD began, however, there is now a national standard for the eligibility criteria to identify students with disability.

The Australian Government is committed to reporting prevalence data on school students with disability to the OECD, to “monitor and evaluate the systems in place” (Brussina, 2020, p. 43). The NCCD fulfills this commitment, however, the secondary use of data is an extension to the original purpose, which was a means to determine additional funding of Australian school students with disability. How the NCCD facilitates the Australian Government’s engagement with international systemic evaluation and monitoring is less obvious in official texts. However, in 2005-2006, the Australian Government contributed funding to scoping work conducted by the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) to compile comparative data sets about students with disability. There was no Australian data in the last report - *2007 Students with Disabilities, Learning Difficulties and Disadvantages: Policies, Statistics and Indicators*, despite an agreement between OECD member nations to use cross-national definitions of disability,

difficulties, and disadvantage to identify specific cohorts of school students (OECD, 2008). OECD member countries have agreed on a resource-based approach to resource students with disability, who are identified using the cross-national definitions of disability OECD, 2008 (OECD, 2008). A more detailed explanation of the OECD model is included in Chapter Four. How the OECD intends to use data collected through the NCCD is not yet clear.

Nevertheless, the data set does meet the Australian Government’s commitment to providing prevalence data of students with disability to the OECD and paves the way for providing assessment and educational outcome data (Brussina, 2020). The NCCD is a policy that is located within a global system, in which shifts in global relations are transforming how national educational policies are developed (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009), which is not always transparent or visible policy actors at the frontline (Ball et al., 2017).

**Figure 8.2** *Purposes of the NCCD*



The NCCD was initially a policy with dual purposes: it was designed as a funding mechanism and to improve planning, in 2018, it was also identified as a mechanism for reporting on student numbers (see Figure 8.2 above). The NCCD, therefore, meets the obligation of providing data for transnational objectives. This secondary purpose for the

national data is often not part of institutional discourses. Since 2018, the Australian Government has used the NCCD to fund students with disability (see Chapter Four).

***NCCD is a funding model that meets transnational objectives***

A broad description of how the funding model works is provided on the landing page of the NCCD website:

It's important that schools understand which students should be included...the evidence needed...to ensure that funding will be allocated fairly...schools and school systems will have access to appropriate funding support based on the adjustments that have been provided in the previous twelve months. (Education Services Australia, 2020)

Ensuring the right students were counted in the data means “schools and school systems will have access to appropriate funding”. Institutional talk of ensuring the right students were included and that there was sufficient evidence activated actions that framed “what was [will be] recorded, observed, described and so on” (Smith, 2005, p. 191). Student data underlies the funding model of the NCCD. In other words, the evidence of adjustments leads to decisions about the LoA and CoD, which is an objectified way of knowing the student. A regulatory frame in which the “institutional realities [are produced] from the actualities of peoples’ lives” (Smith, 2005, p. 187) was activated. Students were discussed in terms of LoA and CoD and this objectified way of knowing the student can only occur when there is a body of evidence of adjustments. Schools and education authorities were focused on funding, but this data also meets the Australian Government’s commitment to the transnational objectives of the OECD of using the cross-national definitions of disability that enable a globalised approach to monitoring and evaluating educational provision.

The Australian Government has agreed to report on the number of students with disability to the OECD. The NCCD meets this reporting obligation (Hardy & Woodcock,

2015). The Australian Government website, National Assessment Program (NAP), as part of the suite of public websites connected to the Australian Curriculum, Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA), has the capacity to meet all OECD data reporting requirements about students with disability. Not only has the Australian Government agreed to provide disability prevalence data, but there is also a commitment to report on the learning outcomes for students with disability (see 2012 OECD report, *Delivering School Transparency in Australia*, Zanderigo et al., 2012). Currently, Australian school student achievement is collected through the NAP and reports on specific cohorts of students (indigenous, language background other than English), their data are disaggregated from the national data (see National Assessment Program – Literacy and Numeracy, National Reports). It is not yet known when students with disability will be included in this list of student cohorts. However, it must be noted that the national conversation about students with disability participating in the NAP has generally focused on the high rates of exemption from the assessment program as an area of concern and the provision of adequate adjustments to support participation; it has not been about precluding these students from the national assessment regimen (Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority, 2016; Cumming & Dickson, 2013; Duncan et al., 2020). The current NAP data is used to report Australian school student achievement, including the outcomes for the specific cohorts, to the OECD. Including students with disability as an identified cohort in the NAP data will meet the Australian Government’s obligations to the OECD in relation to reporting the learning outcomes for students with disability. With the introduction of the NCCD, every Australian state and territory are now using the same criteria to identify school students with disability, which means there is now national data.

### **8.7.1 Accounting for students is intensive work**

The NCCD is more than just a funding model, it is part of a suite of data sets “with a bias towards accountancy” (Hardy & Boyle, 2011, p. 220) designed to make comparisons across schools about their communities and students. This data is published on the Australian Government website, My School website, with NCCD a recent addition. Schools are being held to account through the increasing level of surveillance of data, this kind of data-based governance is complex, and requires the creation of the ‘datafied’ student (Selwyn, 2015; Selwyn et al., 2021; Spina, 2020). The NCCD contribution to data-based governance is shared on the My School website (see Appendix N: Australian school students with disability), with averages posted of each of the levels of adjustments, based on educational jurisdiction or state. These averages were a “regulatory frame” (Smith, 2005, p. 227) for the Education Authority, the average for each of the LoAs guided considerations in relation to what funding to expect and was part of the communication to schools about funding maintenance. If schools were significantly different to the average data, this had the potential to affect funding, and these schools were specifically targeted for additional support (see Chapter Seven). This had a tempering effect; school teams worked towards achieving/reporting school data that were close to the national averages published on My School website for the total number of students with disability and for the number of students in each of the LoA categories.

The focus on reporting prevalence data on students with disability potentially has a reductive outcome of the NCCD, as it possibly shifts the focus from improving learning outcomes for students (see Chapter Four) to ensuring students with disability are counted in the NAP (Hardy, 2015) and report data to the OECD (Rinne & Ozga, 2011). This thesis has highlighted how the work of school teams and regional policy officers ensured data numbers were obtained, as well as the inordinate time given over to collecting evidence of adjustments

as part of the requirements of the NCCD. Grant et al. (2017) described how teachers' work in an early years learning context was coordinated by a regulatory system to collect evidence as proof of their work, which was time taken away from teaching. The research presented in this thesis has made visible how the work of school teams and the regional policy officers was being steered, from a distance, towards accountability (Grant et al., 2017; Kickert, 1995). Holloway and Larsen Hedegaard (2021) raise questions about how standardisation and the pursuit of evidence is reshaping what happens in schools and go on further to suggest that these notions have the potential to undermine professional expertise. The necessity for student data is not in dispute, however, my experiences of talking with frontline workers in schools and regional offices has given me reason to wonder if there is a more productive and targeted approach to guaranteeing data numbers are available at the same time as ensuring the production of evidence of adjustments really becomes the by-product of the everyday work of teaching. The findings presented in this thesis suggest there is a nexus of datafication and work intensification that have the capacity to override one's sense of humanistic values.

## **8.8 CONCLUSION**

These findings, presented in the chapter, have clearly shown how the textual coordination of the NCCD happened. Beginning largely from an unofficial text, *The List*, and official texts, including Australian Government School Census. The textual power of these boss texts was far reaching, they coordinated actions in similar ways across location, they had translocal power. However, these boss texts were not included in the suite of official texts provided to guide and direct the implementation of the NCCD requirements. How these boss texts organised the work of the NCCD is visually represented as a social cartography presented in Chapter Nine, section 9.1.

The NCCD is official mechanism for Australian Government funding for school students with disability. The worry of ensuring all eligible students were included in the

NCCD count was significant, it meant new work for teachers, school leaders and policy officers. The emotional labour attached to this work was activated by concerns about student funding levels, and maintained through the emerging translocal institutional practices, whereby policy officer accounted for their work in new ways, teachers' work was audited, and students were textualized.

The deliberate decision to used standardised assessments to confirm eligibility for a student to be added to The List negated teacher judgements about the students in their class. This presented a disjuncture between the official accounts and the embodied everyday experiences of those at the frontline. There were no other options for a student to get on The List, but more importantly once on The List there was no clear path for coming off it. There appeared to be very little involvement of the class teachers in discerning which students, they taught, were eligible to be include in the NCCD count.

Moderation, a quality assurance measure for the NCCD, in many ways was an audit conducted away from the teacher to confirm the evidence required for the NCCD was sufficient. This evidence was teacher records of the educational adjustments they had provided for the student with disability in their class. Unlike more traditional forms of moderation, which is focused on student work, moderation for the NCCD is about teacher work. This thesis has discussed how this is new type of moderation, which requires further research and theorisation, especially as it is a mandatory component of the NCCD.

The shift for education policy officers from a mentoring role to one of auditing had considerable consequences. Furthermore, there is an opportunity to consider the work of public service in this arena, especially from the standpoint of public servants who have professional expertise and qualifications beyond policy. These policy officers commenced their careers as classroom educators before moving to promotional roles. How a vocational

background role influences standpoint as policy officers is an area of research that is under-theorised.

The far-reaching influence of public-private partnerships and global education movement, in particular national obligations to an external body such as the OECD is noted in the scholarly literature. However, what is not visible in this literature is the textual coordination of the frontline work of policy actors in PPPs, such as the work of the PwC officers. Their work was textually organised by contractual obligations and performance indicators that were accounted for through official reports.

My findings show that the NCCD is a multi-layered complex policy landscape, but at the heart of it is teachers providing educational adjustments for students with disability. The work of teachers is critical to the educational experiences of students with disability, I have argued that educators are motivated to be compliant with institutional requirements, even when these processes do not enhance pedagogical teacher practices for these students. The implications of this are profound, particularly given the interim findings of from the *Royal Commission into Violence, Abuse, Neglect and Exploitation of People with Disability Public Hearing 7* into education, whereby it was found that “the provision of reasonable (educational) adjustments is largely left to the judgement and discretion of educators” (Commonwealth of Australia, 2021, p. 66). Consequences of the everyday actions of those at the frontline have long lasting outcomes for students with disability. This matters because the NCCD has introduced new work for educators but not new requirements in terms of the provision of educational adjustments; the new work includes detailed record keeping of adjustments and moderation for accountability purposes.



# Chapter 9: Conclusion

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## 9.1 INTRODUCTION

This research inquiry has achieved the broad aim of understanding how the NCCD shaped the everyday work happening in schools and Education Authority offices. This detailed examination of what actually happened in schools and within an education office, where the research was conducted, makes an original contribution to knowledge about funding for students with disability, policy implementation and teachers' work to provide educational adjustments. It also sheds light on the importance of understanding the everyday work of people as a means of considering whether policy goals have been achieved, and the kinds of unintended, perverse consequences that may have emerged. The research was conducted in the Australian state of Queensland, within an Education Authority that was in the process of implementing the NCCD. Within this setting, and through mapping the textual chains and social practices, this research illustrated how an inaugural national policy for funding students with disability authorised vast amounts of work across a wide range of roles and locations. This work was textually mediated, revealing the relations of rule (DeVault & McCoy, 2006). An IE inquiry is used to discover how things happen, in a state of perpetual motion (Smith, 1999). As this research affirms, schools are busy places, and the NCCD, as a new policy, certainly added to and guided the everyday work of people across the institution of schooling.

This final chapter is a summary of the research followed by an outline of the contribution this thesis makes to applied practices and to theory. An analysis of the limitations of the inquiry are then shared. Opportunities for further research are explored, and the chapter concludes with a final statement.

## 9.2 SUMMARY OF THE RESEARCH

Although the research began with a fine-grained analysis of what happens in schools, the ultimate aim was to map the broad ruling relations coordinating work across the institution. Specific research questions guiding the study were:

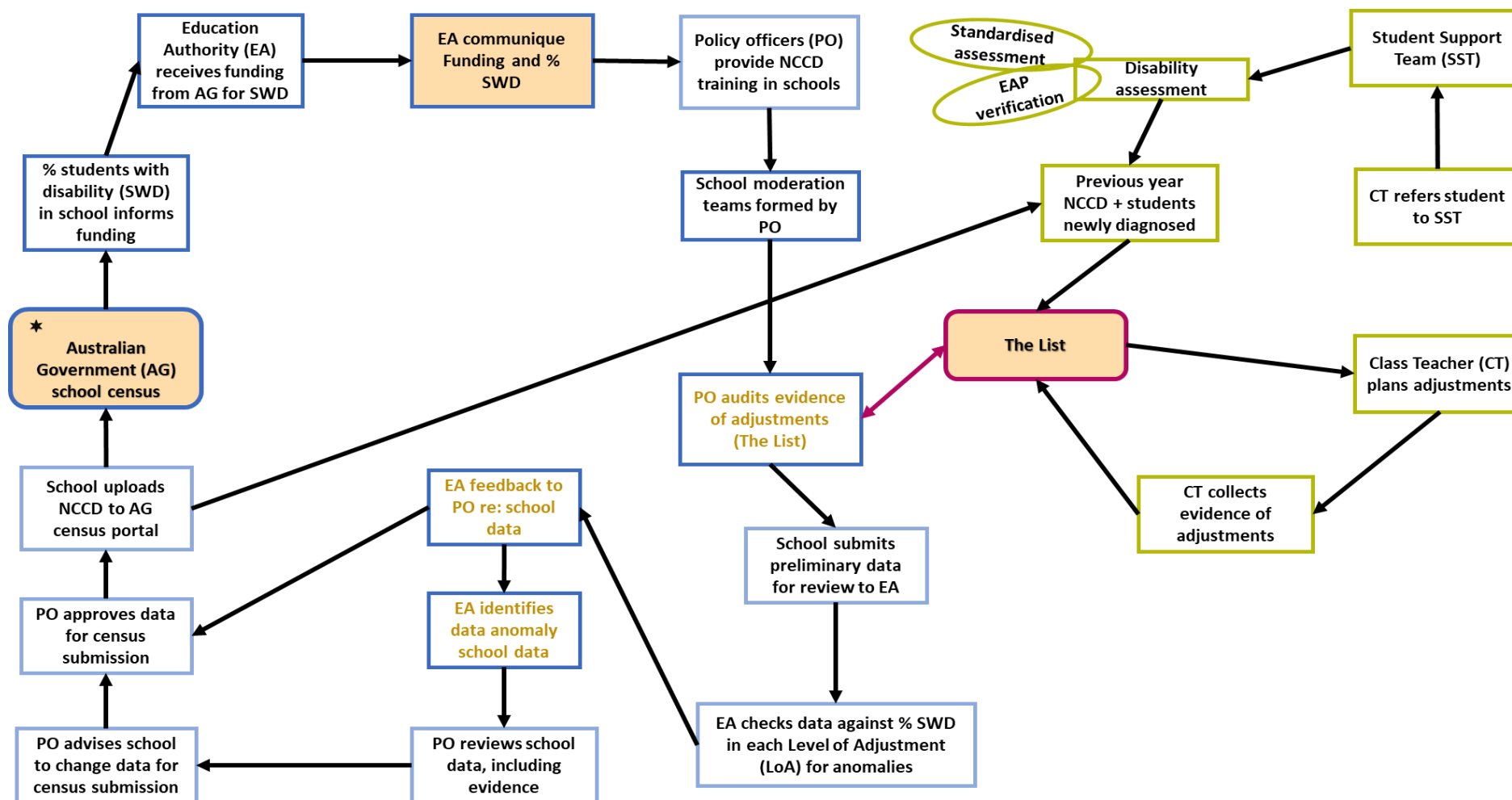
1. Whose everyday work was coordinated by the NCCD and how did this happen?
2. What activities did people attend to within the workflow processes from the Education Authority (macro) to the classroom (micro) and vice versa?
3. What institutional practices emerged (ruling relations) and how were these maintained across settings (translocally)?

In exploring these questions, the research findings were reported in three analytic chapters (Chapters Five, Six and Seven), which explored the social organisation of knowledge and explained how people's everyday work shaped, and was shaped by, institutional practices of the NCCD. Maps are presented in each chapter showing the textual organisation of work from the Education Authority to the teacher. A more detailed analytic chapter (Chapter Eight) brought together these findings in a discussion that focussed on the significant amounts of time and energy that was invested by teachers, school leaders, support staff and policy officers as they worked to meet the institutional requirements of the NCCD.

Mapping people's actualities (see Figure 9.1) revealed whose work was coordinated by the NCCD and how this happened. Mapping sequences of actions and following a line of inquiry or thread, showed how the NCCD coordinated actions of teachers and school leaders, and policy officers, it showed how the work came to them and where it went next, in other words the textual flow. It also built a picture of how their work is hooked up into broader institutional processes that are discussed in Chapter Eight.



**Figure 9.1** Mapping how the NCCD happens





Textual authority was found in unofficial NCCD texts (The List), an email communication from the Education Authority and the Australian Government School Census procedure. To interpret Figure 9.1, commence with the orange shaded shape with the star to follow the arrows. Orange shaded boxes are boss texts, they had significant textual power, and coordinated the work of teachers, school leaders and policy officers. The accountability circuit with green shapes represent work that was mostly school based, with NCCD SLTs and class teachers, and the blue accountability circuit shows work that was shared between the NCCD SLT, the policy officers, the Education Authority and less visible, the Australian Government. The blue shapes with orange writing represent the work for the anomaly check, this is relevant because despite the rhetoric of no targets, the anomaly check for targets was significant for each school. The List has its own shape, as a textual node, it was a boss text for both accountability circuits.

The new work of the NCCD changed the professional relationships between policy officers supporting school staff, moving from a mentoring role to one of auditing data (see Chapters Seven and Eight). Other new work for teachers is the requirement to record educational adjustments they provide for students with disability in detail, and the introduction of a moderation process to determine the level of support provided. This chain of actions, or accountability circuit, is attached to student funding.

Students are textualized through the NCCD. Teachers and school leaders talked about the tension or disjuncture of knowing the student which was different to how they are represented by data used to activate funding. These data were standardised assessments visually represented on data walls and records of educational adjustments. The production of evidence for NCCD is new work for

teachers, it is laborious and designed to meet accountability requirements, with no evidence offered as to how this improves teaching and planning (see Chapters Five and Six). Policy officers lamented the change of focus from supporting schools and improving teaching practices, to only having time to check the data, to make sure funding was secured, that the data was right (see Chapter Seven). The work of the NCCD is translocal, the institutional talk or ideological code filters across locations, and in so doing serves to promote, and maintain institutional processes, as does staff movement between schools (for example, The List, see Chapter Five). Understanding how things happen is only useful when it contributes to improving people's everyday lives. This next section offers practical contributions this inquiry makes to the everyday lives, followed by contributions to theory.

Official and unofficial NCCD texts coordinated peoples 'daily activities in similar ways across locations. There was evidence of an emerging ideological code, by which, people who were not known to each other used. They used the same terminology and language to describe their work.

## **9.3 PRACTICAL CONTRIBUTIONS**

### **9.3.1 Policy in practice**

The evidence presented by the informants in this research demonstrates that the actual implementation of the NCCD was different from the proposed process outlined in the NCCD model diagram, representing a significant disjuncture (Education Services Australia, 2018). An easy assumption might be that teachers or school leaders were recalcitrant or resisting expectations. However, the analysis in this research showed that textual power was hidden in multiple texts used in schools and was largely driven by concerns over the funding outcomes of the NCCD. The consequences of this meant there was a narrowing of what was prioritised in terms of

teaching and learning for students with disability, as noted by teachers and school leaders. Importantly this thesis shows how the NCCD policy implementation has not always served those for whom the policy was designed, in this case, students with disability.

The NCCD was originally framed around two key objectives, first to enable Australian Government funding to flow to schools; and second to improve planning for students with disability. The evidence presented in this thesis shows that the NCCD has oriented teacher's attention towards "getting the data right" for funding reasons, rather than meeting the educational needs of students with disability.

This research has shone a light on what is actually happening in schools and education authorities and provides insights that could be harnessed to refine policy and practice. For example, the federal government might consider how power relations have generated attention on documentation and funding ahead of schools' application of the NCCD prescribed process in which students are identified by teachers as part of their regular classroom practice.

The NCCD as a nationally consistent approach to identifying students with disability has not been fully realised. This thesis has made visible some of the inconsistencies across and within educational jurisdictions and has shown how this has given rise to increased work for teachers as they document evidence of educational adjustments for students in their classes. Working towards consistent NCCD processes informed by the official NCCD texts and the experiences of those engaged in the day-to-day application of NCCD processes and requirements across education authorities and with every educational jurisdiction is a worthwhile goal.



### 9.3.2 Teachers as producers of documents

The empirical work in this research has shown that teachers are spending considerable time producing (and worrying about) evidence for the NCCD. There was evidence of translocal rule, where two different school sites maintained a strong focus on the flow of data. As teachers, teacher assistants and school leaders activated key texts, teachers responded by producing templates and documentation. The textual objectification of students by teachers, school leaders and policy officers are a point of disjuncture, particularly for school staff. The bifurcated consciousness of knowing the students in two distinctive ways was cause for discomfort and concern; knowing students in the everyday world of a class bears little resemblance to a set of teaching adjustments submitted to comply with the pressure of funding demands.

It is questionable whether this work is an effective use of teachers' time and energy. There was certainly evidence at both schools to suggest that it was a distraction from the kinds of work that might best support students with disability. Teachers talked about the tension of divided attention when working with students. Rather than being focused on teaching and truly being *with* the student; instead, their thinking was about how and when they would record the interaction.

With this in mind, I argue that policy might consider working towards a less labour-intensive process of collecting evidence. Consideration could be given to the quantity and type of evidence required to distribute funding. As a starting point, reviewing the existing processes and their effectiveness could generate opportunities to refine the NCCD so that is more closely aligned to how teachers plan, track, and monitor learning sequences and educational adjustments for students with disability. A further issue that could be raised here relates to the positioning of such comprehensive mandatory evidence collection within the rise of neoliberal audit

cultures – cultures which emphasise administrative accountability over professional expertise, and managerialism over experience. Arguably, the collection of data thus becomes an end in itself, with operations rationalities driven by the political and the organisation, rather than the pedagogic. That is teachers’ aforementioned time and energy is primarily devoted to ‘accounting’ for themselves as opposed to (what should be) their main task of actually teaching.

### **9.3.3 Administrators as auditors**

While there is much research showing how datafication and documentation can reorient away from what matters most (e.g., Ball, 2003), less attention has been paid to staff working in regional offices and education authorities. This thesis has provided a unique contribution to knowledge, which shows how a policy such as the NCCD can shift the role and purpose of these staff. The research informants I talked with from the Education Authority described having their work reconstituted from supporting and mentoring teachers and principals to auditing and checking. As regional office staff activated texts from the federal government, and from schools, they found themselves in the middle of ruling relations, in ways that changed their work and social relations in their offices and with school staff. Policy officers found themselves managing internal audits to “get the data right”; this new work permeated every aspect of work and relations with schools, and at regional offices. Internal auditing of evidence of educational adjustments, while not an official process of the NCCD, is now an established institutional practice activated and endorsed by the Education Authority. This set of ruling relations meant that the work of policy officers shifted from an established role that targeted the mentoring leaders and teaching staff working with students with disability to auditing schools deemed most

at risk of reduced funding, which relegated the school-based mentoring work to a much lower priority.

Policy officers talked about how this shift in their work changed relationships with teachers and school leaders, as their conversations changed from being primarily about supporting teachers and students, to discussions around accountability demands. It is worth remembering that for most educators planning effective educational adjustments is underpinned by their professional values and beliefs, as well as experiences (Slee, 2011, 2018). The data in this thesis has shown how this reconstituted relationship between school leaders and teachers and policy officers has reduced opportunities for genuine professional dialogue making the work of teachers a tricky terrain to navigate. Policymakers, teachers, and leaders alike can find it challenging to contest ableist perspectives and relationships dominated by accountability requirements is a significant new development that could diminish trust and the professional capacity of those involved in delivering education to students with disability.

The internal audits were undertaken in preparation for the AG School Census and the associated possibility of a post-enumeration (external) audit. Schools are randomly selected for an external audit by an accounting firm that has successfully tendered for the contract to carry these audits out on behalf of the Australian Government. The reports from policy officers and staff at the two schools involved in this research points toward inconsistent experiences with external auditors, which led to even more anxiety to ensure there is even more evidence. Having clarity of the process and expectations of the actual audit well ahead of the event could alleviate some of this angst, for both the school staff and auditors.

Policy practices are not static. In understanding how the work of internal audits happen there is an opportunity to reposition how the NCCD requirements are met so that they might realign practices with the policy intent. Attending to how the work of policy officers has been reorganised, is an opportunity to refine how the NCCD is implemented so that teachers and school leaders are able to retain a focus on planning effective educational adjustments for students with disability as being the priority action (as described in the original policy intent) and make the need for internal audits unnecessary. This kind of refinement could enable education authorities to focus on how to best support schools in the improvement of teaching practices that remove barriers to access and participation for students with disability.

The new policy work for the Education Authority policy officers (public servants) required them to pivot from an established way of working based mentoring to new accountability work. Prior to being promoted to the policy officer roles meant that most had previously held roles in schools as teachers or school leaders and that moving into their current positions was recognition of their expertise. This thesis calls for more research about public servants with a vocational background, their work in policy roles and how new policy work is taken up. Understanding how shifts in education policy are textually mediated, what gets picked up and what is pushed aside by a public servant (education policy officer) with a vocational background is an area for further research by scholars in policy, educational leadership, and school change.

## **9.4 THEORETICAL CONTRIBUTIONS**

### **9.4.1 Importance of policy work, including those within public-private partnerships**

The importance of understanding what policymakers do, including those working in private consultancies as part of public-private partnerships (PPPs) is under researched. The decision by the Australian Government to establish a PPP, mostly with PwC, to develop an inaugural national educational reform policy placed an intermediary layer between federal government and those at the frontline of this policy implementation (schools, education authorities). There is risk of assuming that the NCCD policy frontline work only happened in schools and the offices of the Education Authority. The PwC team that led this significant national policy work, were integral to the implementation of the NCCD, they were responsible for evaluating the policy implementation and providing advice to the Australian Government about next steps. This frontline work of the PwC actors was textually mediated by the established performance indicators negotiated with the Australian Government and documented in the contractual arrangements. The PwC team produced important NCCD texts, undertook school visits and delivered professional learning to educators in schools. Their work was also quantified and measured through progress reports and agreed outputs. As frontline workers, the PwC project team were vital in maintaining relations of rule, as they worked with educational jurisdictions to trial resources and processes and reported on each phase of the project.

The PwC team had responsibility for developing resources for schools to use and providing advice to the Australian Government, with minimal authority to act on concerns. For example, despite PwC raising concerns about the accuracy of student

data, (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017), the Australian Government proceeded to attach funding to the model (which is based on the student data). The data presented in this thesis raises serious concerns about how this tension, or similar issues is considered in the new public management literature. The dilemmas faced by frontline workers of professional service companies such as PwC are under-theorised and in urgent need of further research.

#### **9.4.2 Understandings of moderation as a practice**

Moderation is the quality assurance measure for the NCCD. The moderation process in its current form means teachers are moderating teachers' work. Moderation is a sociocultural practice, designed for teachers to consider whether student work meets a specific standard to determine an agreed position about the student's achievement. Moderation is teacher assessment work. NCCD moderation borrows from this practice. The purpose of NCCD moderation is to establish whether the evidence provided by a teacher of the educational adjustments they have provided for a student firstly meets the threshold of four areas of evidence (see Appendix L: LoA – word version) and then to decide a LoA and a CoD. No part of this moderation activity is about student achievement or teacher assessment work (despite the assessed individual needs of students being one of the NCCD evidentiary requirements), but the outcome decides the level of funding for a student the following school year. NCCD moderation processes are under-theorised and require urgent attention by practitioners and researchers. The data presented in this thesis demonstrate the significant effect NCCD moderation has in shaping social relations and broader power relations (including the allocation of funding, and the relations between schools and education authorities). This thesis contributes to the moderation

research literature by raising important questions about how a process designed for student work can be theorised for teachers to moderate teachers' work.

#### **9.4.3 Funding for the education of students with disability – policy and practice**

The NCCD is essentially a funding model for students with disability. Funding allocations are decided based on the level of educational adjustments provided for a student. The funding is a retrospective payment for educational adjustments provided. At the school level, the principal signs off on the proposed level of adjustment for each student, and in so doing, validates the evidence of these adjustments. Yet, the intent of the policy to fund educational adjustments provided for a student has not been fully realised in its current form.

Since 2019, the Australian Government has selected a sample of non-government schools to undertake a post-enumeration process (audit). An auditor (from an accounting firm) physically checks student records to ensure there is sufficient documented evidence for every funded student against four areas. The audit process reinforces the focus on data collection and evidence production. In the event the evidence in all four areas is deemed to be lacking the school is required to return funding received for the student (e.g., Markson, 2018). While it is possible the school has received funding for a student where this is insufficient evidence, it is also likely that the 'correct' data was not recorded, or possibly not retained as part of the evidentiary requirements for the NCCD. This circuit of accountability is very much focussed on the production of evidence, which, as has been shown throughout this thesis, is intensive and time-consuming. This research inquiry has shown the textual power of accountability circuits, and while auditing continues to emphasise the quantity of evidence this nexus will be difficult to break.

I would like to remind the reader that in my professional view, the necessity of developing a fair and equitable funding mechanism is not in dispute. The NCCD model has the capacity to reduce confusion about which students with disability are eligible for funding and to bring a more consistent (predictable) approach to student funding. The NCCD policy promotes a human rights approach to educational provision for students with disability, and in so doing has the potential to improve the quality of education for these students through the emphasis on personalised learning and the provision of educational adjustments intended to specifically address the functional impact of disability. However, much more consideration needs to be given to how these data are collected such that accountability requirements can be met, including the requirement to provide OECD with prevalence data of students with disability (Stahl, 2020). The serious question remains as to how this can be achieved without overburdening teachers with administrative tasks that take away from their core purpose of *teaching* students with disability. Creating an overworked and overwhelmed workforce with the worry of being audited and not meeting the evidentiary requirement threshold is a serious concern (Talbot, 2020). The dilemma of ensuring students get what they need, and the funding required to support this is perennial. Listening to people at the frontlines, such as teachers, school leaders and policymakers (e.g., Education Authority and PwC) could be a good place to start to reshape ruling relations to value social relations and everyday knowledge to refine and improve NCCD processes.

## 9.5 LIMITATIONS

This research inquiry was carefully scoped to explore the experiences of those working to implement the NCCD. Consequently, the experiences and views of parents/carers of children with disability, and students themselves was not included



at this time. I return briefly to my own personal story, I bring with me a personal journey of disability and my professional work, these experiences are core to my standpoint, they cannot be divorced. The decision not to explore how the experiences of parent/carers and students, is not in any way, a reflection of how I value their experiences. This research project was designed to explicate how the work of the NCCD was being experienced by educators. While this is a limitation of this inquiry, it does, however, provide the opportunity for further research to include the important voices, of parents and students, about their experiences of the NCCD.

In this research, educators from both sites worked in primary schools located in a metropolitan area. The geographical complexity of services and specialist support to schools regional and remote schools are not within the scope of this inquiry. Additionally, many of the informants worked in mainstream primary schools, the unique issues of secondary educators and those working in special education are not represented in this inquiry. Broadening the scope to include how the NCCD is being implemented in secondary school sites and special education school sites in future research has the potential to make a valuable contribution to understanding how the NCCD is experienced in the full range of Australian school settings.

Not being able to secure informants from all education authorities is a limitation. The research application to one of the education authorities was indirectly declined, despite their high interest in the outcomes of this inquiry (see section 3.2). The NCCD space provides a real opportunity to put education back into education policy, whereby universities and education departments might benefit from working more closely together, in collaboration with other policy designers. However, what was made visible in this inquiry was the staff mobility across the education authorities; some of the informants had worked in schools and regional officers of

other education authorities. Knowledge obtained in these workplaces contributed to their embodied experiences and were informing their current practices.

Consequently, there were rich conversations or data dialogues with all the informants that in some ways cut through the boundaries of the education authorities.

## **9.6 IMPLICATIONS FOR FURTHER RESEARCH**

The NCCD has increased expectations that educational adjustments are planned, implemented, tracked, and monitored. This is a welcomed outcome.

However, the data in this thesis shows that teachers continue to seek guidance about how to plan, track and monitor educational adjustments for students with disability in their classes. There is an opportunity to refocus and address the broad intentions of the NCCD policy intentions, to improve planning for students with disability, and therefore, learning outcomes. Developing a well theorised moderation process that supports teachers to plan, track and monitor educational adjustments for students in their class, but also meets the accountability requirements for including students in the NCCD count, is a priority.

Understanding the complex and multi-layered education policy work that is now increasingly the remit of public-private partnerships is timely. Working in authentic partnerships that draw on educational research, policy development and the everyday experiences of teachers to support this policy work to make certain the best policy structures are enabled is surely better for everyone. How such contracts are negotiated, who gets to decide who are the stakeholder groups and which people are consulted are key to the success of policy development.

## **9.7 CONCLUSION**

In conclusion, the very process of undertaking this inquiry has been both cathartic and challenging. It is reassuring and joyful to talk with people motivated to

work towards the successful implementation of the NCCD. Every informant named their challenges with the NCCD, but they also countered these challenges with solutions, their ‘work arounds’. Their talk revealed an emerging ideological code that was translocal that cut across locations and professional roles.

As a funding model, the NCCD was designed to provide fair and equitable distribution of funding based on student needs. Students with the highest levels of educational need are allocated more funding than students with lower educational needs. This aspect of the policy intent is working, funding is flowing, although the current loadings are already under review; but how this has improved student learning outcomes is not apparent. Instead, the policy has focused on ensuring documentation of evidentiary requirements.

It was interesting to note the textual hierarchy of official and unofficial NCCD texts, and how these are hooked into institutional practices that were centred on accountability. These institutional practices are connected through textual chains that were revealed by following threads (Campbell & Gregor, 2004). In following this thread, it raised the visibility of a globalised education policy, not connected to the usual testing regimes that most are familiar with, but a commitment of the Australian Government to provide national data on students with disability to the OECD. However, it would not be a surprise, should over time, the agreement morph to include more than just prevalence data.

Aside from funding, it was expected the NCCD would be used for planning. But after years of data collection, is there enough data to plan? How can the data that is already collected be used? How reliable is the data? The differential approach to a policy with “nationally consistent” in the title, is at best confusing, has provided a vortex for mixed messages as teachers, school leaders and policy officers come to

understand what is actually required or expected. Non-government schools have been early adopters (which sounds more of voluntary action than it was), this sector has yielded to additional forms of accountability that are not required of colleagues in government schools, such as random annual audits from the Australian Government.

NCCD moderation is a borrowed process/policy from teachers moderating student work samples to come to an agreed level of achievement or competency against a standard, such as the achievement standard of the Australian Curriculum. In its current form, teachers are moderating teachers' work to decide a level of adjustment provided (which is not the amount of work teachers are undertaking to document adjustments), which determines if the student will be allocated funding for the following year. Funding decisions are high stakes; the moderation process has far-reaching consequences beyond the school that are connected to broader funding agreements. NCCD moderation is under-theorised.

The NCCD space has the potential to harness expertise from a variety of quarters. Through using an IE approach, this thesis has shown the motivation of people from a variety of professional roles to get the policy right, yet the lack of cooperation across institutional boundaries is a challenge. Individuals are working with each other, but their institutions are bound up. It is time to draw on expertise found in universities, as well as education departments, to collaboratively refine and improve a national implementation of the NCCD.

As a teacher, as a researcher and as a policy officer, it was necessary to take time to stand away from the research, to review the data, and check for institutional capture. Being close to the work, meant there was a risk of not seeing something to truly reveal how things are actually happening. The work to implement this policy is occurring in multiple locations or frontlines, the topic of this research is complex,

and multi-layered, and as I came to learn, potentially contentious – not everyone wants to know how this work really happens! The very purpose of an IE inquiry is to understand how things are happening, this project has done that. More importantly, Dorothy Smith reminds IEers that knowing how things happen is not enough, once you know, you need to do something with this new knowledge. My sincere hope is that the knowledge gained from this research inquiry will contribute to educational provision for students with disability; and that their teachers are well prepared and well-resourced in carrying out this work. Equitable access to educational opportunities, is a human right and is a cornerstone of democratisation. Thinking about how best to fund this work in a way that supports those at the frontlines of education has the potential to vastly improve the lives of people with disability and enrich the lives of many.

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# Appendices

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## Appendix A The development of the NCCD model

### *The NCCD from design to trial to mandatory data collection*

Designing a nationally consistent approach to funding Australian school students with disability, was a recommendation of the 2002 Senate Inquiry: *Education of students with disabilities* (Australian Senate Standing Committee on Education Employment and Workplace Relations, 2002), and further endorsed by the first review of the DSE in 2010 (Australian Disability Standards for Education Review Team, 2012). Between these reviews, in 2008, all Australian government Ministers of Education agreed to a standardised approach to collecting national data on school-age students with disability (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). This set-in motion the beginnings of a national model, facilitated by the federal government.

### *Trial phase 2011 - 2013*

The Australian Government announced the trial of a national model for identifying students with disability on 20 July 2011, yet the trial had already commenced with 143 schools (Garrett & McLucas, 2011; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, 2013). PwC was awarded the contract in 2010 to develop the new national model and supporting resources, with the support of “an expert advisory group which met in 2010” (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, p. 1). The expert advisory group, the Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability (JWG), had representation from the Australian Department of Education, each state and territory Education Authority, Independent Schools Council of Australia, the National Catholic Commission (NCEC) and Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority (ACARA) (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2013). While the

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JWG had broad stakeholder representation, what remains unknown is the expertise of these members, were they educators and/or policy officers.

The 20 July 2011 media release pulled policy threads together. For example, it was expected the national model would build on More Support for Students with Disability initiative; contribute to meeting education, training and employment goals of the National Disability Strategy 2010 – 2020 (NDS) and assist with reporting about students with disability on the My School website (Garrett & McLucas, 2011). This positioned NCCD as having the potential to produce better life outcomes for students with disability, in which education is seen to contribute to the production of “human capital” (Rizvi & Lingard, 2009, p. 18). National data about students with disability, a success measure of this policy, is reported on the My School website.

Throughout the 2011 – 2013 trial, PwC generated supporting resources for trial schools to test and provide feedback about their utility (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, 2013). This feedback was provided as advice to the JWG about emerging matters, and to inform the annual project evaluations. Through the trial phase, evaluation reports were completed, but only the 2011 and 2012 evaluations were publicly released, the 2013 report remains confidential (Australian Senate Committee: Education and Employment, 2015). Evaluation reports about the NCCD have informed the literature review due to the limited availability of scholarly literature. The absence of a full history of issues raised through the trial phase and efforts to ameliorate these concerns have the potential to lead to misgivings about the integrity of the model. For example, the issue of variance in decision-making about the LoA was raised in both the 2011 and 2012 reports, as was the issue of confusion for schools maintaining the existing

jurisdictional funding procedures for students with disability and the NCCD (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, 2013). Connected to these issues were concerns raised about teacher workloads, PwC recommended increased clarity about the LoA and CoD was needed (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011). Despite efforts to resolve these very early issues with the NCCD, they have persisted, notwithstanding the refinements and clarification of supporting resources and professional learning resources and programs. From inception, the work of PwC has shaped local practices through the resources and tools produced to support schools and education authorities, and in so doing introduced new ways to describe and talk about students with disability.

The federal Minister for Education, Peter Garrett announced on 10 May 2013 that the national model was endorsed by “all education ministers today and will start in October 2013...this significant reform will mean...consistent data will help our schools better recognise and support the needs of students with disability [and]...to implement the disability loading in 2015” (Garrett & Collins, 2013, p. 1). Until this point, government communication about the national model had been about having consistent national data, this was the first-time funding was publicly attached to the NCCD model.

Despite concerns raised by PwC about data quality and reliability the NCCD trial moved into the implementation phase, with the plan use the data to inform funding as outlined in the Gonski 1.0 Review (Australian Department of Education and Training, 2016; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2011, 2013). Advice given by PwC during the trial phase about issues such as data reliability and the maintenance of dual processes for identifying students with disability (NCCD and

existing state-based models) and they could affect teacher workload seemed to be ignored.

#### *Implementation phase 2014 - 2015*

In the implementation phase it was expected that by 2015 every Australian school participate in the NCCD (Australian Education Council, 2014). Schools were required to apply the NCCD model and maintain the existing funding arrangements for students with disability, due to concerns about the data quality, as noted in the 31 October 2014 Communique:

Although substantial progress has been made, data collected so far is not yet of sufficient quality to provide the information required to inform funding arrangements for students with disability. State and territory eligibility criteria for the distribution of Australian Government funding for students with disability will continue in 2015 while Ministers work to ensure that the NCCD is of the necessary quality to accurately inform funding, with the aim of utilising NCCD data from 2016 (Australian Education Council, 2014, p. 2).

This decision meant schools and education authorities were required to continue to manage dual processes until 2016. For example, in Queensland, the Education Adjustment Program (EAP) is the longstanding method used to resource students with disability. Eligible students are identified through a two part process, the first being a diagnosis of disability, and second, an assessment of educational need (Queensland Department of Education, 2019b). Under this program, not all students with disability are eligible for additional resourcing. For example, some students with developmental language disorder or students with learning disability are

excluded from EAP resourcing. The decision to maintain the existing method and the NCCD meant that Queensland teachers are (still) required to manage two mechanisms for students with disability, with differing disability discourses. The NCCD does not require an intensive medical investigation to access funding, it is more aligned to the social model of disability. Whereas the gateway to EAP is a medical diagnosis first, a medical view of disability. The decision to run dual systems concurrently, was made by senior government officials seemed to have little consideration for what this means for those at the frontline; despite PwC raising concerns about teacher workload in earlier reports to the Australian Government.

During this phase, PwC continued to gather feedback to refine the tools and resources for schools to use. In this early stage of implementation, school staff often relied on recontextualised generated by the Education Authority rather than the published official texts (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2016). The potential for misunderstandings about the NCCD model to be shared through formal and informal professional networks was significant.

However, the 2015 quality assurance project was the most significant undertaking in this phase. PwC staff interviewed school staff from 407 schools across Australia and reviewed 1007 student case studies to “whether the school correctly identified the student for inclusion, the appropriate level of adjustment and category of disability, and further whether there was sufficient evidence to include the student” (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2016, p. 2). School practices were audited by professionals, who were not necessarily educators, yet had authority to decide if there was “sufficient evidence” and if the student was “correctly identified”. While there were no repercussions for the school, other than feedback

in relation to the student's inclusion on the NCCD. The quality assurance project established a culture of auditing in schools, see Chapters Five, Six and Seven for more information.

*The NCCD is fully implemented (2016 and beyond)*

In 2016, the NCCD became a mandatory data collection for every Australian school. While there was confidence “the data collected in the NCCD to be of sufficient quality to inform policy at the national level” there was an added caveat that this is “one component among others” but there was no clarity or elaboration about these other components (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017, p. iv). Funding was still not attached to the NCCD, which meant all Australian governments agreed to that schools needed to maintain the existing dual processes for at least another year (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017). In other words, the continuation of the piecemeal systems, which had been one of the catalysts for the new national model. To date, the only thing that had changed with the introduction of the NCCD, was new work for teachers, principals, and education policymakers.

Persistent concerns about data quality did not prevent the publication of the data reports in 2016 and 2017. Since 2018, this data has been published on the *ACARA National Report on Schooling in Australia data portal* (which has retrospective data from 2015 onwards) and is freely available (Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority, 2020; Australian Education Council, 2016, 2017a). The national student data can be disaggregated to a state and national sector level (e.g., all Australian Catholic schools). This data has the potential to establish targets for schools to work towards, for example, 18% of Australian school students

have disability, therefore school XXX needs to have 18% of students with disability.

Quality assuring student data is a high priority for the Australian Government (AG). PwC was contracted by the AG to develop and deliver a suite of professional learning materials for school staff, designed to improve understanding of the NCCD model, and educators obligations as outlined in the DSE and DDA (Australian Department of Finance, 2016; PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017). The intent of this package, and resources to support moderation practices was to improve data quality (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017). Moderation was earmarked as a quality assurance measure that can be “externally applied through an expert panel review...to provide quality assurance controls in the moderation of variation in teachers’ judgements” (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017, pp. viii-ix). The intent and purpose of this type of “moderation” was external experts overseeing local decisions to quality control outcomes, not the socio-cultural practice that teachers might expect moderation to be.

Active engagement with the professional learning materials was “strongly recommended” for school staff (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017, p. 16). An additional direction was given that “materials...are not to be re-written” (Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017, p. 17). In other words, the professional learning materials were not to be altered to ensure key messages remain the same. The expected outcome of the professional learning package was improved understanding of the requirements of the NCCD model and therefore, having more reliable student information (PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017). The priority outcomes of the

professional learning package designed by PwC, was data integrity, not planning educational adjustments for students with disability.

During the initial phases of the NCCD resources and supporting texts (e.g., professional learning materials, templates), policy documents and technical reports were published on the same Australian Government website (Australian Education Council, 2017b). Leading up to the official launch of the dedicated NCCD portal 2019, the original website was decommissioned, and all materials moved; technical reports and policy documents to another Australian Government website and the NCCD resources to a dedicated NCCD portal (Education Services Australia, 2019). As new resources were developed, they were organised and categorised, the first iteration of this structure had texts classified as either essential, recommended, or optional (see Appendix J: 2017 NCCD text categories). Essential texts included documents about the data collection process, recommended texts included resources for planning learning and moderation and so on, and optional texts included documents such information for parents. This classification system has since been revised, texts are now mandatory or recommended (Education Services Australia, 2019). The categorisation of the texts organised the local work of teachers and school leaders by drawing their immediate attention to what was deemed to be most important (essential), such as data collection.

Since 2018, the NCCD has informed Australian Government funding for students with disability through *Quality Schools Package*, as recommended in 2011 *Review of School Funding* (Gonski Review) (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021f). Students with disability are funded using a base amount determined by the *Schooling Resource Standard* (SRS) with the disability loading determined by the allocated LoA (supplementary, substantial or extensive)

(Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021f). For example, in 2021, the SRS payment for a primary student was \$12,099 and \$15,204 for a secondary student, then add the disability loading for LoA, (e.g., \$17,665 for substantial level) (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021f). Ensuring the accuracy of the LoA is important because it directly impacts funding.

Quality assurance of the NCCD occurs through the annual Census Post Enumeration (PE) process; this is only for non-government schools, there is no equivalent process for government schools (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021h). Schools selected by the Australian Government for a PE process are notified at the end of school year, there is no option to refuse participation and the PE process occurs sometime between February to May following year (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021h). On the day of PE process (audit), the auditor (from an economics firm such as Bentleys, Urbis) reviews the school census submission (which includes other data such as staff numbers, student enrolment numbers and so on), and then audits the records of every student included in the NCCD (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021h). The auditor is checking to ensure the requirement of all four areas of evidence is recorded. The outcome of the audit is not discussed with the school, unless of course there is a requirement to reimburse funding back to the Australian Government (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021h). The census audit is a longstanding process in schools, however, the addition of a compliance check of student records is a new additional because of the NCCD. Significantly, external audits of student records do not occur in government schools, an inconsistency within the national model



that is tied to funding agreements; however, has little or no meaning to those at the frontline. What is visible to those being audited, is there are different requirements.

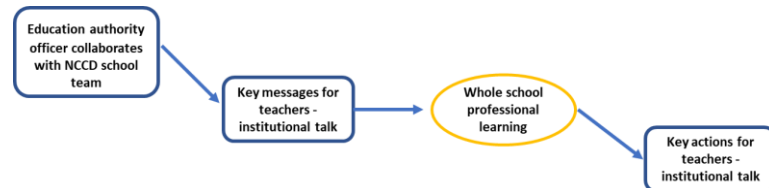
## Appendix B Maps in progress

These are examples of mapping examples that were part of the reflection, recreating and working through actions were hooked up, these examples contribute to the final map Figure 5.4

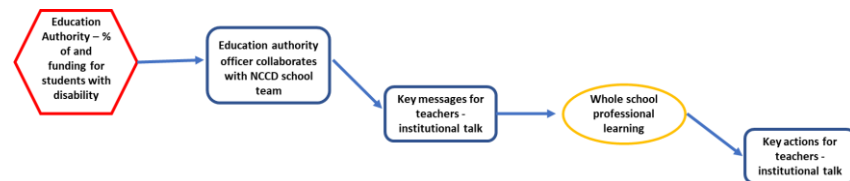
Attempt 1



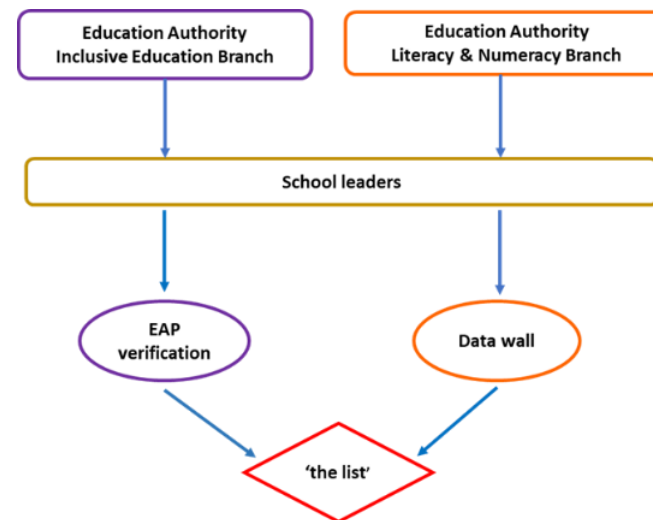
Attempt 2



Attempt 3



Attempt 4



## Appendix C Semi-structured interview scaffold

| Stages of IE                       | Alignment with research question       | Five factors of an IE inquiry                                                                                                                                                                             | Semi-structured conversation (interview) - questions                                                                                                |                                                                      |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Initial                                                                                                                                             | Probing                                                              |
| Stage 1<br>Entry Point             | Educational experiences and background |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Tell me about your school                                                                                                                           | Demographic data                                                     |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | How would you describe your preferred teaching style?                                                                                               | Teachers' experience                                                 |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | What experiences have you had with people with disability general, students with disability?                                                        | Probe for explanation of contexts                                    |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | What is your most recent experience as a class teacher of a student with disability?                                                                | Knowledge of disability, values, and beliefs about disability        |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | How have your experiences with a student with disability shaped the way you work as a teacher?                                                      | Knowledge of disability and influence on teacher practices           |
|                                    | NCCD policy                            | 1. How the text comes to this informant and where it goes after the informant is done with it.<br>2. What the informant needs to know to use the text (create it, respond to it, fill it out, and so on). | Tell me about your own experiences to date with NCCD?                                                                                               | Knowledge of NCCD                                                    |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Can you describe NCCD in your school?<br>Which students are now made visible because of NCCD, and how does this occur?                              | Use of NCCD                                                          |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Do you use any NCCD support materials? If so, can you describe how you use them, and where you got them from?                                       | Have you viewed/used other materials?                                |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | What knowledge do you draw upon when using the NCCD support materials?                                                                              | Alignment of teacher knowledge and NCCD                              |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                      |
| Stage 2<br>Institutional processes | NCCD implementation                    | 3. What the informant does with, for, and on account of the text.<br>4. Who this text intersects with and depends on other texts and textual processes as sources of information, generators of           | What documents do you used when preparing for NCCD?<br>Talk me through how you have used the NCCD materials. How does this text work with this one? | Talk through each text at a time<br>Intersection of texts.           |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | What were the key factors for the making this decision about this way of working?                                                                   | Which texts and how, what does the teacher do on account of the text |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | How has NCCD influenced or changed what happens at school? School processes?                                                                        | Conceptual frames                                                    |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Has NCCD influenced the way you record adjustments for students, if so, how?                                                                        | Conceptual schema                                                    |
|                                    |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                      |

|  |  |                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                       |                                     |
|--|--|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
|  |  | <p>conceptual frames, authorising texts and so on?</p> <p>5. The conceptual schema that organises the text and its competent reading.</p> | <p>How has NCCD changed funding for students with disability in your class?</p> <p>Does NCCD impact on other processes, such as NDIS?</p> <p>How?</p> | <p>How the texts organise work.</p> |
|--|--|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|



## Appendix D Ethics approval certificate

|                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  | University Human Research Ethics Committee (UHREC)<br><b>HUMAN RESEARCH ETHICS APPROVAL CERTIFICATE</b><br>NHMRC Registered Committee Number EC00171 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

Date of Issue: 3/7/18 (supersedes all previously issued certificates)

Dear Dr Nerida Spina

This approval certificate serves as your written notice that the proposal has met the requirements of the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* and has been approved on that basis. You are therefore authorised to commence activities as outlined in your application, subject to any specific and standard conditions detailed in this document.

|                        |                                                                                                                            |                 |                                       |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Project Details</b> |                                                                                                                            |                 |                                       |
| Category of Approval:  | Negligible-Low Risk                                                                                                        |                 |                                       |
| Approved From:         | 2/07/2018                                                                                                                  | Approved Until: | 2/07/2021 (subject to annual reports) |
| Approval Number:       | 1800000564                                                                                                                 |                 |                                       |
| Project Title:         | A national assessment model of school-age students with disability: An institutional ethnography of the practice of policy |                 |                                       |

|                             |                 |                          |
|-----------------------------|-----------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Investigator Details</b> |                 |                          |
| Chief Investigator:         | Dr Nerida Spina |                          |
| Other Staff/Students:       |                 |                          |
| Investigator Name           | Type            | Role                     |
| Mrs Jeanine Gallagher       | Student         | Doctoral (Research)      |
| Dr Jill Willis              | Internal        | QUT Associate Supervisor |
| Prof Gordon Tait            | Internal        | QUT Associate Supervisor |

|                               |
|-------------------------------|
| <b>Conditions of Approval</b> |
|-------------------------------|

**Specific Conditions of Approval:**

No special conditions placed on approval by the UHREC. Standard conditions apply.

**Standard Conditions of Approval:**

1. Conduct the project in accordance with the principles of the NHMRC National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research 2007, the Australian Code for the Responsible Conduct of Research, any additional specific conditions defined by the UHREC, any associated NHMRC guidelines and regulations, and the provisions of any legislation which is relevant to the project;
2. Obtain UHREC approval for any proposed variation to the project prior to implementation (note that major changes may require a different level of review and/or submission of a new application);
3. Obtain any additional approvals or authorisations as required (e.g. from other ethics committees, collaborating institutions, supporting organisations);
4. Maintain research records and data in accordance with MoPP D/2.8 Management of research data.
5. Respond promptly to the requests and instructions of UHREC;
6. Declare all actual, perceived or potential conflicts of interest (NS 5.4);
7. Immediately advise the Office of Research Ethics and Integrity (OREI) of any concerns, complaints or adverse events including (NS 5.5.3):
  - o if any unforeseen development or events occur that might affect the continued ethical acceptability of the project;
  - o if any complaints are made, or expressions of concern are raised, in relation to the project;
  - o if the project needs to be suspended or modified because the risks to participants now outweigh the benefits;
  - o if a participant can no longer be involved because the research may harm them.
8. Report on the progress of the project at least annually, or at intervals determined by UHREC (NS 5.5.5);
9. Participate in project monitoring activities in accordance with MoPP D/2.4 Monitoring of research approved by a University

*If any details within this Approval Certificate are incorrect please advise the Research Ethics Advisory Team immediately.*

End of Document

## Appendix E NCCD legislative and policy landscape

### *National goals for schooling*

Since the introduction of the NCCD, in the early 2000s, there have been three declarations of national schooling goals; The Adelaide Declaration on National Goals for Schooling in the Twenty-First Century 1999 (Adelaide Declaration), The Melbourne Declaration on Educational Goals for Young Australians 2008 (Melbourne Declaration) and The Alice Springs (Mparntwe) Education Declaration 2019 (Mparntwe or Alice Springs Declaration). While the Mparntwe national goals do not significantly differ significantly from the Melbourne Declaration, (see Table D1), the rearrangement of concepts provides new emphasis, and therefore importance.

**Table E1:** *National goals of schooling*

| Adelaide Declaration 1999                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Melbourne Declaration 2008                                                                                              | Mparntwe 2019                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Schooling should develop fully the talents and capacities of all students.                                                                                                                                                                         | Australian schooling promotes equity and excellence                                                                     | The Australian education system promotes excellence and equity                                                                                   |
| In terms of curriculum, students should have attained high standards of knowledge, skills and understanding through a comprehensive and balanced curriculum in the compulsory years of schooling encompassing the agreed eight key learning areas. | All young Australians become successful learners, confident and creative individuals, and active and informed citizens. | All young Australians become confident and creative individuals, successful lifelong learners, and active and informed members of the community. |
| Schooling should be socially just, so that students' outcomes from schooling are free from the effects of negative forms of discrimination based on sex, language, culture and ethnicity, religion or disability; and                              |                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                  |

or differences arising  
from the students’  
socioeconomic  
background or geographic  
location.

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Students with disability were specifically identified in the third goal of the Adelaide Declaration, about schooling being socially just (Australian Ministerial Council on Education Employment Training and Youth Affairs, 1999; Foreman, 2015). It was the Melbourne Declaration that raised expectations of equity and excellence for all students and the necessity to minimise educational disadvantage, which includes disability (Australian Ministerial Council for Education Employment Training and Youth Affairs, 2008). Mparntwe has provided additional direction about students with disability being at risk of educational disadvantage and the need to ensure improved learning outcomes for educationally disadvantaged Australian students (Australian Education Council, 2019b). The intent of the goals is to be future focused, establishing expectations for schooling yet aspirational. The national goals for schooling establish educational expectations for all students, including students with disability. How teachers record educational adjustments, actions that are designed to minimise barriers to learning and, therefore, educational disadvantage, is at the crux of NCCD.

#### *Australian Curriculum (AC)*

The AC outlines what all Australian school students should learn from the first year of formal schooling through to year ten (Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2016). The content of the AC is the responsibility of ACARA; however, state and territory educational jurisdictions each have their own agencies to provide direction and support to schools about how to implement the AC. In Queensland, the Queensland Curriculum and Assessment Authority (QCAA) has



this remit and is answerable to the Queensland Government. This means there two levels of government are engaged in school curriculum work, first, ACARA designs the content of the curriculum and then state, and territory governments work to support the implementation of the curriculum.

The AC has three dimensions; first, learning areas; second, cross curricula priority areas and finally, the general capabilities. These dimensions outline what students are expected to learn. Specific information about learning entitlement for students with disability and expectations that “each student can learn and that the needs of every student is important” is further strengthened by a human rights disability discourse and reiterating obligations of the DSE to make reasonable adjustments to curriculum, instructional practices and/or the environment (Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority, 2021). The NCCD and the AC are inextricably connected, teachers plan learning sequences from the AC and plan educational adjustments.

#### *Australian Professional Standards for Teachers (APSTs)*

The APSTs are used by each state and territory teacher accreditation authority. The APSTs were introduced by The Australian Institute for Teaching and Leadership (AITSL) in 2011, and are used to endorse licensure for teaching (Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership, 2011; Queensland College of Teachers, 2021a). Teachers are required to benchmark professional learning against the APSTs to maintain their accreditation as a registered teacher. In Queensland, this means teachers submit a dossier of their professional learning every five years to show professional currency to the teacher accreditation authority, the Queensland College of Teachers (Queensland College of Teachers, 2021b). The APSTs and teacher registration are tethered.

The structure of the APSTs is seven professional standards across four stages of professional practice – graduate, proficient, highly accomplished and lead. Each standard has subcomponents, and with expectations of professional practice relevant to each practice stage (e.g., graduate, proficient and so on). Each of the seven standards and five subcomponents relevant to teaching students with disability are listed are provide in Table D2.

**Table E2:** *Professional standards for teachers and relevant subcomponent to students with disability*

|   | <b>Standard</b>                                                          | <b>Subcomponent of standard</b>                                                                                                                                                             |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Know students and how they learn                                         | 1.5 Differentiate teaching to meet the specific learning needs of students across the full range of abilities.<br>1.6 Strategies to support full participation of students with disability. |
| 2 | Know the content and how to teach it                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 3 | Plan for and implement effective teaching and learning                   | 3.1 Establish challenging learning                                                                                                                                                          |
| 4 | Create and maintain supportive and safe learning environments            | 4.1 Support student participation                                                                                                                                                           |
| 5 | Assess, provide feedback, and report on student learning                 | 5.1 Assess student learning                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 6 | Engage in professional learning                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 7 | Engage professionally with colleagues, parents/carers, and the community |                                                                                                                                                                                             |

(Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership, 2011; Dempsey & Dally, 2014)

The APSTs describe some of the complexity of teachers' work. Teachers are navigating multiple textually authorised demands which are being made via various

agencies and levels of government that serve to organise teachers' work (e.g., APSTs, AC, DSE, QCT, Mparntwe).

#### *Australian Education Act 2013 (AEA)*

The AEA outlines funding arrangements for government and non-government schools, and accountability expectations of education authorities to the federal government (Commonwealth of Australia, 2013). The AEA came into effect on 1 January 2014, followed shortly after with the first amendment, with the most recent amendment in June 2017 legislated the funding formula for students with disability under the *Quality Schools Package*. This effectively tied funding agreements to accountability measures outlined in the National School Reform Agreement (NSRA) (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021f). More specifically, under the NSRA, each state and territory government has a separate Bilateral Agreement with the Australian Government for five years, from 2019 to 2023 outlining agreed accountabilities for funding received (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021e). The Queensland Bilateral Agreement has a commitment to cross-sector NCCD moderation, meaning government and non-government school staff will undertake NCCD moderation together for the duration of the agreement (Australian Department of Education Skills and Employment, 2021e). The AEA and associated Australian Government funding agreements are directly organising aspects of the NCCD work in schools.

#### *National Disability Strategy 2010-2020 (NDS) and Australian Disability Strategy 2021 – 2031 (ADS)*

The inaugural NDS, launched in 2010, was ratified by all states and territory governments, with the intention of promoting a community-wide shift in attitudes towards a more inclusive society. Drawing on the UN CRPD, an international human rights convention, the NDS sought to improve the lives of all Australians with

disability (Australian Department of Social Services, 2010). During the ten years of this strategy, the National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS) was introduced.

The NDIS is an Australian Government program that funds costs associated with disability for people under the age of sixty-five year. It is one of the most significant social reforms in Australia, alongside the introduction universal health care in the 1970s and compulsory superannuation in the 1980s (Bonyhady, 2016). The NDIS provides information and funding to connect people with disability (including children) to services in their community, it has the potential to be life changing (Australian National Disability Insurance Agency (NDIA), 2020). The NDIS does not fund supports for students with disability in schools (e.g., assistance with personal care, teacher assistants in the classroom), this remains the remit of educational jurisdictions.

The ADS builds on the NDS and was launched in December 2021. The ADS has seven outcome areas, of which, *Education and Learning* is one. The outcome measures for this area will be comparative data; comparing students with disability (as identified through NCCD) with all Australian school students on two criteria. First, school attendance and second, the year nine results on the National Assessment Program – Literacy and Numeracy (NAPLAN) (Australian Department of Social Services, 2021). This introduces a new purpose for NCCD, it is now contributing to accountability reporting for other government initiatives.

### ***International obligations***

#### *United Nations treaties and conventions*

United Nations (UN) treaties and conventions have an important role in the formation of Australian policy and legislation, contributing to the protection of individual rights and social expectations (Cumming & Mawdesley, 2013; Harcourt & Hägglund, 2013; Whitburn, 2015). Unlike the United States, which has a Bill of

Rights, Australia does not have constitutional protection of individual rights, and therefore individual interests are protected through statute-based rights for specific groups of people within legislation, for example, anti-discrimination laws generally and specifically the DDA for people with disability (Cumming & Mawdesley, 2013). When ratified, UN treaties and conventions contribute to the Australian policy discourse. They have introduced new concepts and ideas, and in some instances challenged longstanding values and beliefs, and social practices.

#### *Convention on the Rights of the Child 1989 (CRC)*

In 1990, the Australian Government ratified the CRC, and in so doing, agreed to always protect children's best interests (Australian Human Rights Commission, 2017; Cumming & Mawdesley, 2013). The CRC describes the rights of the child, mostly in terms of social rights, and to a lesser extent civil rights and political rights (Harcourt & Hägglund, 2013). Participatory rights to an education are covered in Article 28, which addresses the right of all children to an education on an equal basis, and Article 29 addresses values and content of the education provided (Harcourt & Hägglund, 2013; United Nations, 1989). The fundamental human right of students with disability to an education on the same basis as their peers is reinforced by the CRC.

#### *Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities 2006 (UN CRPD)*

The UN CRPD marked a global shift in the conceptualisation of disability and consequently the disability discourse through the adoption of a human rights approach (Harpur, 2012; Whitburn, 2015). The UN CRPD promotes equitable and active participation for people with disability and the protection of legal rights to have active choice and control about services, employment, and life opportunities, including education (Harpur, 2012; Series, 2020). As a signatory to the UN CRPD, the Australian Government agreed to moving away from a medicalised view of

disability to a human rights approach (see Table 4.1) to inform government policies and services (Dempsey, 2003; Harpur, 2012). As shown in this chapter the UN CRPD is used to inform policies and underpins the recently launched Australian Disability Strategy 2021-2031.

General comment 4, Article 24 of the UN CRPD outlines obligations and expectations of all member states about the rights of people with disability to an inclusive education (United Nations Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, 2016). This follows on from the 1994 the Salamanca Statement and Framework for Action on Special Needs Education (Salamanca Statement); in which 90 countries, including Australia, endorsed the principles of an inclusive education for students with disability (Forlin et al., 2013; Moss, 2003; Slee, 2011). The Salamanca Statement highlighted the need to transition from special education services to inclusive education, the UN CRPD declared inclusive education as a human right (Foreman, 2015; Forlin, 2006; Moore & Slee, 2020; Moss, 2003). As already established, education for students with disability occurs in special schools and in regular schools, despite being a signatory to UN CRPD.

## Appendix F Definition of disability

This appendix has 2 parts:

1. Definition of disability, Disability Discrimination Act 1992
2. Table E1: NCCD categories of disability defined

### F1 The Disability Discrimination Act 1992

Disability is defined as:

- (a) total or partial loss of the person's bodily or mental functions; or
- (b) total or partial loss of a part of the body; or
- (c) the presence in the body of organisms causing disease or illness; or
- (d) the presence in the body of organisms capable of causing disease or illness; or
- (e) the malfunction, malformation, or disfigurement of a part of the person's body; or
- (f) a disorder or malfunction that results in the person learning differently from a person without the disorder or malfunction; or
- (g) a disorder, illness or disease that affects a person's thought processes, perception of reality, emotions or judgement or that results in disturbed behaviour;

and includes a disability that:

- (h) presently exists; or
- (i) previously existed but no longer exists; or
- (j) may exist in the future (including because of a genetic predisposition to that disability); or
- (k) is imputed to a person.

To avoid doubt, a **disability** that is otherwise covered by this definition includes behaviour that is a symptom or manifestation of the disability.

(Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (Cth) s.4)

**Table F1:** *Broad categories of disability*

| DDA definition of disability                                                                                                                                        | Australian Human Rights Commission interpretation of the DDA definition                                     | Broad categories of the NCCD |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| b) total or partial loss of a part of the body                                                                                                                      | Neurological<br>Physical<br>Physical disfigurement<br>The presence in the body of disease-causing organisms | Physical                     |
| e) the malfunction, malformation or disfigurement of a part of the person's body                                                                                    |                                                                                                             |                              |
| c) the presence in the body of organisms causing disease or illness                                                                                                 |                                                                                                             |                              |
| d) the presence in the body of organisms capable of causing disease or illness                                                                                      |                                                                                                             |                              |
| a) total or partial loss of the person's bodily or mental functions                                                                                                 | Intellectual                                                                                                | Cognitive                    |
| f) a disorder or malfunction that results in the person learning differently from a person without the disorder or malfunction                                      | Learning disabilities                                                                                       |                              |
| a) total or partial loss of the person's bodily or mental functions                                                                                                 | Sensory                                                                                                     | Sensory                      |
| f) a disorder or malfunction that results in the person learning differently from a person without the disorder or malfunction                                      |                                                                                                             |                              |
| g) a disorder, illness or disease that affects the person's thought processes, perception of reality, emotions or judgement, or that results in disturbed behaviour | Psychiatric                                                                                                 | Social/Emotional             |

(Sharma et al., 2019, p. 17)

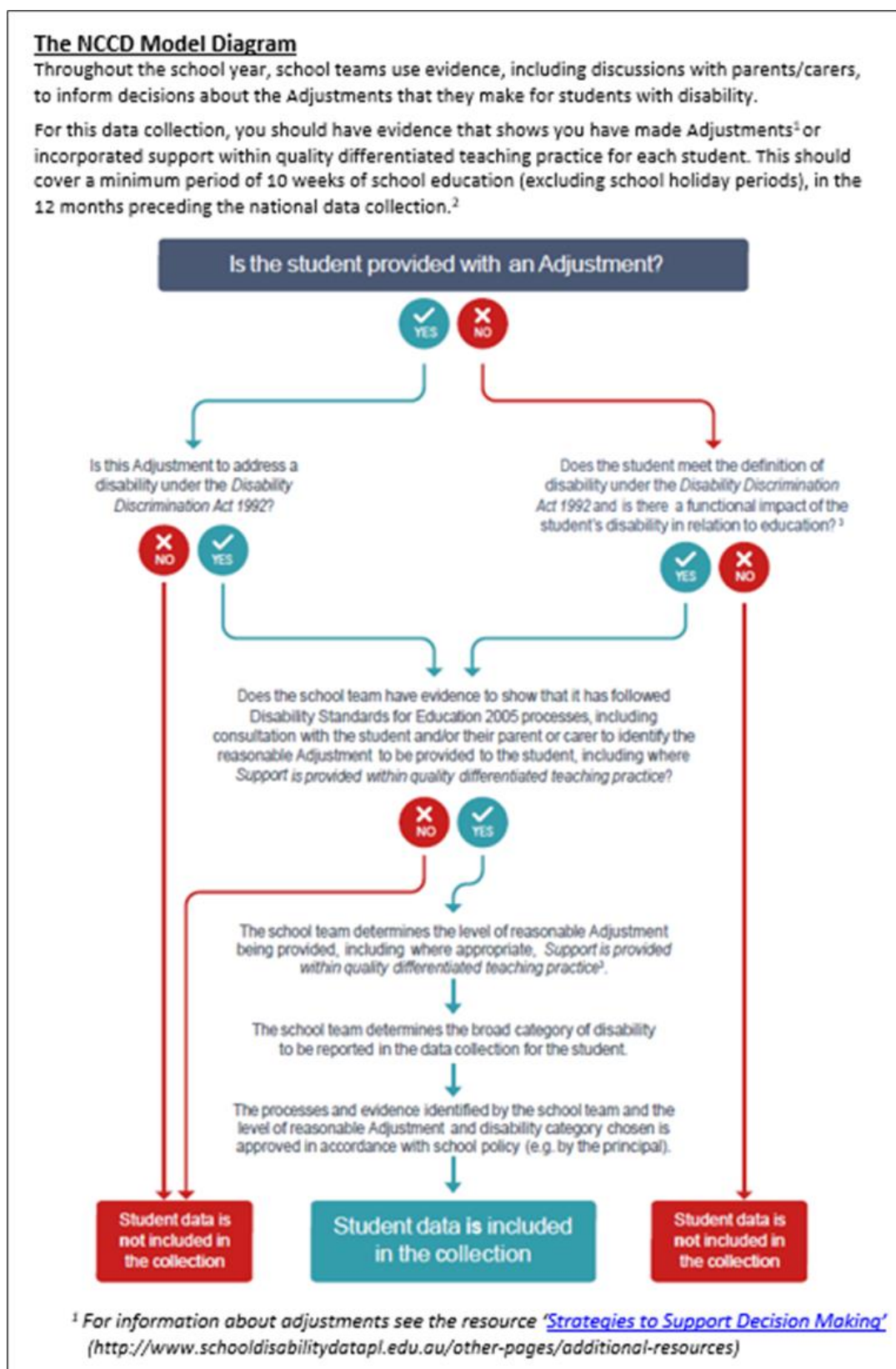


## Appendix G NCCD Levels of Adjustment descriptors

| Level of adjustment                      | Descriptor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Quality differentiated teaching practice | Quality differentiated teaching practice is responsive to the differential needs of all students. Some students with disability may not need educational adjustments beyond those that are reasonably expected as part of quality teaching or school practice to address disability related needs.                                                                                    |
| Supplementary adjustment                 | Supplementary adjustments are provided when there is an assessed need at specific times to complement the strategies and resources already available (for all students) within the school. These adjustments are designed to address the nature and impact of the student's disability and any associated barriers to their learning, physical, communication or participatory needs. |
| Substantial adjustment                   | Substantial adjustments are provided to address the specific nature and significant impact of the student's disability. These adjustments are designed to address the more significant barriers to their engagement, learning, participation, and achievement.                                                                                                                        |
| Extensive adjustment                     | Extensive adjustments are provided when essential specific measures are required at all times to address the individual nature and acute impact of the student's disability and the associated barriers to their learning and participation. These adjustments are highly individualised, comprehensive and ongoing.                                                                  |

(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2017)

## Appendix H NCCD Model Diagram 2016 – 2018



(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018, p. 11)

## Appendix I Education Authority communique – NCCD workshops

### National Consistent Collection of Data Workshops [email]

XXXXX [Executive]

Tue 24/04/2018 9.08AM

To: All Principals

Cc: Senior Policy Officer 1; Senior Policy Officer 2; Senior Policy Officer 3

Dear Principals

As you are aware, the Nationally Consistent Collection of Data (NCCD) rather than the Education Adjustment Program (EAP) data will now be used to determine the Students with Disability (SWD) from the **Commonwealth** following the 2018 Census. (State funding allocations for Students with disability continue to be based on the EAP data). Quality assurance of this is vital and the this end XXX, in collaboration with XXX staff, is currently facilitating workshops to improve understanding and application of NCCD criteria. I strongly urge the NCCD team from your school to attend these important days.

We have concerns that SWD Commonwealth Government funding based on the current [Education Authority] NCCD count is likely to have significant consequences on our level of funding as the proportion of student identified in our schools is markedly lower than in other sectors, States and the national average (18%). Lower levels of funding will mean we will not be able to provide the support these students need to actively engage in their learning.

Based on 2017 data, XXX has provided data based on each of our schools' actual NCCD count and that which might be expected statistically by comparing like schools. I have asked [Senior Policy Officers] to identify schools that appear to have anomalies based on this comparison and to contact you to discuss and consider any support needed to quality assure data for your school.

In the meantime, if you would like any further information, please contact your relevant Senior Policy Officer.

Regards

XXX

## Appendix J 2017 NCCD texts categories

| Document Category | Type                                        | Document Name                                                                                   |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Essential         | Legislation                                 | Disability Discrimination Act, 1992                                                             |
|                   |                                             | Disability Standards for Education, 2005                                                        |
|                   | Data Collection Model                       | National Model Diagram                                                                          |
|                   |                                             | Step 1 – is there an adjustment                                                                 |
|                   |                                             | Step 2 – what is the level of adjustment                                                        |
|                   |                                             | Step 3 – what is the category of disability                                                     |
|                   |                                             | Step 4 – how do you record and submit the data                                                  |
|                   |                                             | Do you have evidence?                                                                           |
|                   |                                             | Strategies to support decision-making                                                           |
|                   |                                             | Notice for schools and principals                                                               |
|                   |                                             | Nationally Consistent Collection of Data on School Students with Disability: public information |
|                   | Level of adjustment provided to the student | Quality differentiated teaching practice                                                        |
|                   |                                             | Supplementary adjustment                                                                        |
|                   |                                             | Substantial adjustment                                                                          |
|                   |                                             | Extensive adjustment                                                                            |
| Recommended       |                                             | Frequently asked questions                                                                      |
|                   |                                             | Planning for personalised learning and support                                                  |
|                   |                                             | Key activities and timeframes for 2017                                                          |
|                   |                                             | Moderation resource for schools                                                                 |
| Optional          |                                             | Introduction                                                                                    |
|                   |                                             | The Data Collection Model Diagram                                                               |
|                   |                                             | Illustrations of the steps                                                                      |
|                   |                                             | Illustrations of practice                                                                       |
|                   |                                             | Glossary                                                                                        |
|                   |                                             | Disability Discrimination Act, 1992                                                             |
|                   |                                             | Disability Standards for Education, 2005                                                        |
|                   |                                             | Guidance on adjustment level selection                                                          |
|                   |                                             | Level of adjustment by disability category                                                      |
|                   |                                             | Collaboration                                                                                   |
|                   |                                             | Consultation                                                                                    |
|                   |                                             | What is ‘consultation’ and who is involved                                                      |
|                   |                                             | Meeting obligations under the DDA/DSE                                                           |
|                   |                                             | In brief: Disability Discrimination Act, 1992                                                   |
|                   |                                             | In brief: Disability Standards for Education 2005                                               |

|  |  |                                                              |
|--|--|--------------------------------------------------------------|
|  |  | Embracing diversity                                          |
|  |  | Talking about people with disability                         |
|  |  | Student wellbeing hub                                        |
|  |  | Positive Partnerships                                        |
|  |  | Reflection tool                                              |
|  |  | Consolidated case studies                                    |
|  |  | Fact sheets for parents/carers                               |
|  |  | Australian Government's fact sheet on Parental Engagement    |
|  |  | Australian Government's fact sheet on Effective Consultation |
|  |  | A Practical Guide for Individuals, Families, and Communities |

Note:

1. As April 2018, the Education Council website was decommissioned, and replaced by the NCCD portal
2. Many of the original texts on the Education Council website were moved over to the NCCD portal without change; however, essential texts are now called mandatory texts.

## Appendix K Level of adjustment provided to the student (LoA - A3 sheet)

| LEVEL OF ADJUSTMENT PROVIDED TO THE STUDENT                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
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| SUPPORT PROVIDED WITHIN QUALITY DIFFERENTIATED TEACHING PRACTICE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | SUPPLEMENTARY ADJUSTMENTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | SUBSTANTIAL ADJUSTMENTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | EXTENSIVE ADJUSTMENTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| LIVE OF ADJUSTMENT                                               | <p>Quality teaching practice is responsive to the differential needs of all students. Some students with disability may not need additional adjustments beyond those that are reasonably expected as part of quality teaching or school practice to address disability related needs. These students may have been considered for some level of active support (i.e. active monitoring or provision of adjustment). Their identified needs would be subject to close monitoring and review.</p> <p>If the school team, in consultation with the student, their parent or carer, has agreed that the student's needs as a result of the disability are being met through quality differentiated teaching practice then these students should be counted under this level of adjustment.</p> <p>Changes to student needs that require changes to the level of adjustment would be reflected in the next data collection period.</p> <p>Further information on the definition of disability for the HCOG, and on students with disability for whom support is provided within quality differentiated teaching practice, is available in the <a href="#">Strategies that Support Diverse Learning</a> resource.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <p>Supplementary adjustments are provided when there is an assessed need of specific times to complement the strategies and resources already available (for all students) within the school. These adjustments are designed to address the nature and impact of the student's disability and any associated barriers to their learning, physical, communication or participatory needs.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <p>Substantial adjustments are provided to address the specific nature and significant impact of the student's disability. These adjustments are designed to address the more significant barriers to their engagement, learning, participation and achievement.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <p>Extensive adjustments are provided when essential specific measures are required of all times to address the individual nature and/or impact of the student's disability and the associated barriers to their learning and participation. These adjustments are highly individualised, comprehensive and ongoing.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| TYPICAL ADJUSTMENT                                               | <p>Quality differentiated teaching practice caters to the needs of a diverse student population. Students in this category do not require the sorts of adjustments that are captured in the other three levels. However, their teachers are conscious of the need for explicit, albeit minor, adjustments to teaching and school practice that enable them to access learning on the same basis as their peers. This category would include general needs that have been made in a school as part of developing or maintaining a culture of inclusion.</p> <p>Examples for this category could include:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a differentiated approach to curriculum delivery and assessment that anticipates and responds to students' learning differences;</li> <li>personalised learning that is implemented without drawing on additional resources;</li> <li>a student with a health condition or a mental health condition that has a functional impact on their schooling and requires ongoing monitoring but who does not require a higher level of support or adjustment during the period they are being considered for the data collection;</li> <li>whole school professional learning for the management of health conditions such as asthma or diabetes. This forms part of a school's general ongoing practice to equip teachers and education staff with the skills and knowledge to support students' health needs;</li> <li>a facility such as building modifications, that already exist in the school and cater for a student's physical disability, where no additional action is required to support the student's learning.</li> </ul> | <p>Adjustments to teaching and learning might include modified or tailored programs in some or many learning areas, modified instruction using a structured task-analysis approach, the provision of course materials in accessible forms, separate supervision or extra time to complete assessment tasks and the provision of individualised specialist teacher support. Adjustments might include modifications to ensure full access to buildings and facilities, specialised technology, programs or interventions to address the student's social/emotional needs and support or close supervision to participate in out-of-school activities or the playground. These adjustments may also include the provision of a support service that is provided by the education authority or sector, or that the school has sourced from an external agency.</p>       | <p>These adjustments are generally considerable in extent and may include frequent (teacher directed) individual instruction and regular direct support or close supervision in highly structured situations, to enable the students to participate in school activities. They may also include adjustments to delivery modes, significantly modified study materials, access to bridging programs, or adapted assessment procedures (e.g., assessment tasks that significantly adjust content, mode of presentation and/or the outcomes being assessed).</p> <p>Other adjustments may be the provision on a regular basis of additional supervision, regular visiting teacher or external agency support, frequent assistance with mobility and personal hygiene, or access to a specialised support setting. Close playground supervision may be required at all times or essential specialised support services for using technical aids, or alternative formats for assessment tasks, to enable these students to demonstrate the achievement of their intended learning outcomes.</p> | <p>These adjustments will generally include personalised modifications to all course and programs, school activities and assessment procedures, and intensive individual instruction, to ensure these students can demonstrate the development of skills and competencies and the achievement of learning outcomes. Other adjustments might be the provision of much more accessible and relevant curriculum options or learning activities specifically designed for the student. They may involve the use of highly specialised assistive technology, alternative communication modes, the provision of highly structured approaches or technical aids to meet their particular learning needs, and some students may receive their education in highly specialised facilities.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| STUDENT CHARACTERISTICS                                          | <p>The student's identified needs do have a functional impact on their schooling and require active monitoring. However, the student is able to participate in courses and programs at the school and use the facilities and services available to all students, on the same basis as students without a disability, through support provided within quality differentiated teaching practice.</p> <p>Examples might include:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>students with health conditions such as asthma and diabetes, that have a functional impact on their schooling, but whose disability related needs are being addressed through quality differentiated teaching practice and active monitoring;</li> <li>a student with a mental health condition who has strategies in place to manage the condition in consultation with medical professionals, that can be provided within quality differentiated teaching practice;</li> <li>a student who has been provided with a higher level of adjustment in the past or may require a higher level of adjustment in their future schooling.</li> </ul> <p>The needs of all students, but in particular students with disability, should be regularly monitored and reviewed to enable the school and teachers to respond with an appropriate adjustment should the level of need change.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | <p>Students with disability and lower level additional support needs access and participate in schooling on the same basis as students without disability through the provision of some personalised adjustments. Accessing the curriculum of the appropriate year level (i.e. the outcomes and content of regular learning programs or courses) is often where students of this level have particular learning support needs. For example, many of these students will have particular difficulty acquiring new concepts and skills outside a highly structured environment. The needs of other students of this level may be related to their personal care, communication, safety, social interaction or mobility, or to physical access issues, any of which may limit their capacity to participate effectively in the full life of their mainstream school.</p> | <p>Students with disability who have more substantial support needs generally access and participate in learning programs and school activities with the provision of essential measures and considerable adult assistance. Some students of this level require curriculum content of a different year level to their same-age peers, while others will only acquire new concepts and skills, or access some of the outcomes and content of the regular learning programs, courses or subjects, when significant curriculum adjustments are made to address their learning needs. Other students of this level might have limited capacity to communicate effectively, or need regular support with personal hygiene and movement around the school. These students may also have considerable, often associated support needs, relating to their personal care, safety, self-regulation or social interaction, which also impact significantly on their participation and learning.</p>                                                                                                   | <p>Students with disability and very high support needs generally access and participate in education with the provision of extensive targeted measures, and sustained levels of intensive support. The strengths, goals and learning needs of this small percentage of students are best addressed by highly individualised learning programs and courses using selected curriculum content tailored to their needs. Many students of this level will have been identified at a very young age and may have complex, associated support needs with their personal care and hygiene, medical conditions and mobility, and may also use an augmentative communication system. Students may also have particular support needs when presented with new concepts and skills and may be dependent on adult support to participate effectively in most aspects of their school programs. Without highly intensive intervention, such as extensive support from specialist staff or constant and vigilant supervision, these students may otherwise not access or participate effectively in schooling.</p> |

For additional information, refer to the following resources: [Strategies to support decision making](#), and [Guidance on adjustment level selection](#)



## **Appendix L LoA – word version**

### ***Support provided within quality differentiated teaching practice (QDTP)***

#### **Description**

Quality teaching practice is responsive to the differential needs of all students. Some students with disability may not need educational adjustments beyond those that are reasonably expected as part of quality teaching or school practice to address disability related needs.

These students may have been considered for some level of active support (that is, active monitoring or provision of adjustments). Their identified needs have a functional impact on their schooling and would be subject to close monitoring and review. If the school team, in consultation with the student, their parent or carer, has agreed that the student's needs as a result of the disability are being met through quality differentiated teaching practice then these students should be counted under this level of adjustment. Changes to student needs that require changes to the level of adjustment would be reflected in the next data collection period.

#### **Typical adjustments**

Quality differentiated teaching practice caters to the needs of a diverse student population. Students in this category do not require the sorts of adjustments that are captured in the other three levels. However, their teachers are conscious of the need for explicit, albeit minor, adjustments to teaching and school practice that enable them to access learning “on the same basis” as their peers. This category would include general adjustments that have been made in a school as part of developing or maintaining a culture of inclusion.

Examples for this category could include:



a differentiated approach to curriculum delivery and assessment that anticipates and responds to students' learning differences

personalised learning that is implemented without drawing on additional resources

a student with a health condition or a mental health condition that has a functional impact on their schooling and requires ongoing monitoring but who does not require a higher level of support or adjustment during the period they are being considered for the data collection

whole school professional learning for the management of health conditions such as asthma or diabetes. This forms part of a school's general, ongoing practice to equip teachers and education staff with the skills and knowledge to support students' health needs

a facility such as building modifications, which already exists in the school and caters for a student's physical disability, where no additional action is required to support the student's learning.

### **Student characteristics**

The student's identified needs do have a functional impact on his or her schooling and require active monitoring. However, the student is able to participate in courses and programs at the school and use the facilities and services available to all students, "on the same basis" as students without a disability, through support provided within quality differentiated teaching practice.

Examples might include:

students with health conditions such as asthma and diabetes, that have a functional impact on his or her schooling, but whose disability related needs are being addressed through quality differentiated teaching practice and active monitoring

a student with a mental health condition who has strategies in place to manage the condition in consultation with medical professionals, that can be provided within quality differentiated teaching practice

a student who has been provided with a higher level of adjustment in the past or may require a higher level of adjustment in their future schooling. The needs of all students, but in particular students with disability, should be regularly monitored and reviewed to enable the school and teachers to respond with an appropriate adjustment should the level of need change.

### ***Supplementary adjustments***

#### **Description**

Supplementary adjustments are provided when there is an assessed need at specific times to complement the strategies and resources already available (for all students) within the school. These adjustments are designed to address the nature and impact of the student's disability and any associated barriers to their learning, physical, communication or participatory needs.

#### **Typical adjustments**

Adjustments to teaching and learning might include modified or tailored programs in some or many learning areas, modified instruction using a structured task-analysis approach, the provision of course materials in accessible forms, separate supervision or extra time to complete assessment tasks and the provision of intermittent specialist teacher support. Adjustments might include modifications to ensure full access to buildings and facilities, specialised technology, programs or interventions to address the student's social/emotional needs and support or close supervision to participate in out-of-school activities or the playground. These adjustments may also include the

provision of a support service that is provided by the Education Authority or sector, or that the school has sourced from an external agency.

### **Student characteristics**

Students with disability and lower-level additional support needs access and participate in schooling “on the same basis” as students without disability through the provision of some personalised adjustments. Accessing the curriculum at the appropriate year level (that is, the outcomes and content of regular learning programs or courses) is often where students at this level have particular learning support needs. For example, many of these students will have particular difficulty acquiring new concepts and skills outside a highly structured environment. The needs of other students at this level may be related to their personal care, communication, safety, social interaction or mobility, or to physical access issues, any of which may limit their capacity to participate effectively in the full life of their mainstream school.

### ***Substantial adjustments***

#### **Description**

Substantial adjustments are provided to address the specific nature and significant impact of the student’s disability. These adjustments are designed to address the more significant barriers to their engagement, learning, participation and achievement.

#### **Typical adjustments**

These adjustments are generally considerable in extent and may include frequent (teacher directed) individual instruction and regular direct support or close supervision in highly structured situations, to enable the students to participate in school activities. They may also include adjustments to delivery modes, significantly modified study materials, access to bridging programs, or adapted assessment

procedures (for example, assessment tasks that significantly adjust content, mode of presentation and/or the outcomes being assessed).

Other adjustments may be the provision on a regular basis of additional supervision, regular visiting teacher or external agency support, frequent assistance with mobility and personal hygiene, or access to a specialised support setting. Close playground supervision may be required at all times or essential specialised support services for using technical aids, or alternative formats for assessment tasks, to enable these students to demonstrate the achievement of their intended learning outcomes.

### **Student characteristics**

Students with disability who have more substantial support needs generally access and participate in learning programs and school activities with the provision of essential measures and considerable adult assistance. Some students at this level require curriculum content at a different year level to their same-age peers, while others will only acquire new concepts and skills, or access some of the outcomes and content of the regular learning program, courses or subjects, when significant curriculum adjustments are made to address their learning needs. Other students at this level might have limited capacity to communicate effectively or need regular support with personal hygiene and movement around the school. These students may also have considerable, often associated support needs, relating to their personal care, safety, self-regulation or social interaction, which also impact significantly on their participation and learning.

### ***Extensive adjustments***

#### **Description**

Extensive adjustments are provided when essential specific measures are required at all times to address the individual nature and acute impact of the student's disability

and the associated barriers to their learning and participation. These adjustments are highly individualised, comprehensive and ongoing.

### **Typical adjustments**

These adjustments will generally include personalised modifications to all courses and programs, school activities and assessment procedures, and intensive individual instruction, to ensure these students can demonstrate the development of skills and competencies and the achievement of learning outcomes. Other adjustments might be the provision of much more accessible and relevant curriculum options or learning activities specifically designed for the student. They may involve the use of highly specialised assistive technology, alternative communication modes, the provision of highly structured approaches or technical aids to meet their particular learning needs, and some students may receive their education in highly specialised facilities.

### **Student characteristics**

Students with disability and very high support needs generally access and participate in education with the provision of extensive targeted measures, and sustained levels of intensive support. The strengths, goals and learning needs of this small percentage of students are best addressed by highly individualised learning programs and courses using selected curriculum content tailored to their needs. Many students at this level will have been identified at a very young age and may have complex, associated support needs with their personal care and hygiene, medical conditions and mobility, and may also use an augmentative communication system. Students may also have particular support needs when presented with new concepts and skills and may be dependent on adult support to participate effectively in most aspects of their school program. Without highly intensive intervention, such as extensive

support from specialist staff or constant and vigilant supervision, these students may otherwise not access or participate effectively in schooling.

**General note**

Approved authorities and schools must ensure that they carefully consider which of the above levels of adjustment appropriately and reasonably apply to each student.

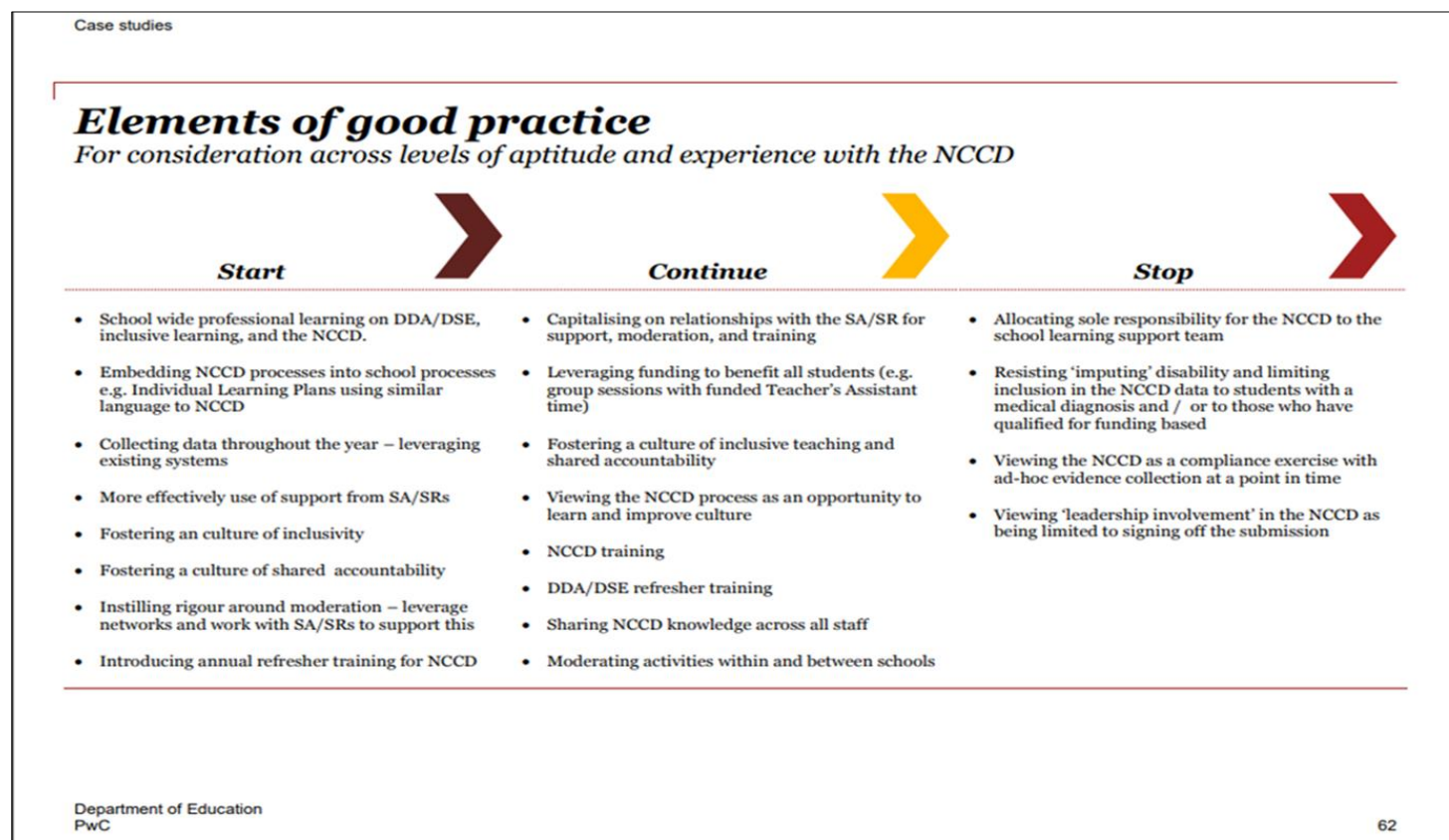
The department will be actively monitoring the data reported in the NCCD each year, including comparing student numbers and characteristics by level of adjustment reported across multiple years.

(Australian Education Council Joint Working Group to Provide Advice on Reform for Students with Disability, 2018, pp. 30-33)



## Appendix M NCCD quality practice texts

**Figure M1:** *Elements of good practice*





**Figure M2** What does best practice look like



(PricewaterhouseCoopers, 2017, p. 63)

**Appendix N Australian students with disability counted in the NCCD 2015 - 2021**

**Table N1** *Total number of Australian school students and students with disability*

|      | Australian total number of school students in the NCCD | Total number of Australian school students | Percentage of school students with disability of total enrolment |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2015 | 674,323                                                | 3,750,973                                  | 18.0                                                             |
| 2016 | 685,911                                                | 3,798,226                                  | 18.1                                                             |
| 2017 | 724,624                                                | 3,849,225                                  | 18.8                                                             |
| 2018 | 753,232                                                | 3,893,834                                  | 19.3                                                             |
| 2019 | 786,678                                                | 3,948,811                                  | 19.9                                                             |
| 2020 | 814,767                                                | 4,006,974                                  | 20.3                                                             |
| 2021 | 878,242                                                | Not available                              | 21.8                                                             |

**Table N2** *Percentage of total Australian student population distribution by Level of Adjustment*

|      | Quality Differentiated Teaching Practice (QDTP) | Supplementary | Substantial | Extensive |
|------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------|-------------|-----------|
| 2015 | 5.5                                             | 8.2           | 2.8         | 1.5       |
| 2016 | 5.7                                             | 8.0           | 2.9         | 1.5       |
| 2017 | 6.2                                             | 8.2           | 3.0         | 1.5       |
| 2018 | 6.4                                             | 8.3           | 3.1         | 1.5       |
| 2019 | 6.8                                             | 8.3           | 3.2         | 1.6       |
| 2020 | 6.8                                             | 8.5           | 3.4         | 1.6       |
| 2021 | 7.1                                             | 9.2           | 3.7         | 1.8       |

(Australian Curriculum and Reporting Authority, 2020)